Untitled Rich Catra Story

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Untitled Rich Catra Story

by motherofchimeras

Summary

Untitled Rich Catra Story is the love story of what happens when one driven and incredibly successful CEO walks into her regular coffeeshop and meets eyes with the most beautiful, dorky barista in the world.

Since graduating high school and launching her company, Catra has worked tirelessly to make Darla Industries the success it is today. She loves her job and works hard to take care of her employees, but has taken little time to have fun and be like any other 20 something. Enter Adora with her puns, smug smiles, and kind heart to help her slow down and enjoy life. Meanwhile, the barista can't believe it when the woman she's been falling for turns out to be a multi-millionaire. The idea of being taken care of and spoiled for once in her life takes some getting used to, but Catra is more than happy to help her get there.

Notes

This started out as my attempt at lending my own take to sugar daddy AU trend for our sweet Catradora. While the others are fantastic, I thought Catra needed more chances to be the rich one. Thus, this fic was born. But honestly, it’s more of a love story about two people where one is rich.

Brewing

Chapter Notes

I got some fabulous art commissioned from the amazing doodlefox2:



See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was Adora's first day on the actual floor at Starbucks, and she couldn't be more thrilled to be done with all of the ridiculous computer-based training finally. Glimmer, her best friend, now turned shift supervisor, had planted her on the front register but promised some actual bar training later. Ringing customers up had been easy enough once she started to untangle the jargon for all of the various drinks and customizations, and she did like the routine of keeping all of the coffees fresh upfront. She was in the middle of making her five-thousandth batch of drip coffee just before her life changed forever. She stood by the incredibly loud coffee grinder, wondering how many baristas ended up losing their hearing when Glimmer broke her inner thoughts.

"Hey, a customer is coming to the counter," she heard on the headset, "It's one of our regulars, Catra."

"I don't know if she likes us, but we *love* her," Bow came on and treated them both to the sounds of the blender he was running, "She's like, kind of snarky, but in a nice way. Plus, she always tips."

Adora looked back over her shoulder to let the customer know she'd be there in a moment. She hoped that her face didn't betray how her heart and mind both leapt with the thought, *I am so gay.* Her whole world paused as she processed the sight in front of her. The young woman looked incredibly sharp in a black button-up and a dark red suit jacket that fit her perfectly. Her brown hair was short and just the right amount of messy instead of perfectly polished. Her golden brown skin was dotted with the cutest freckles around her nose and eyes. Those eyes... she had never seen someone with more captivating eyes -- one blue and the other a honeyed brown.

"AND she totally shut up this asshole who was yelling at us one day. It was super hot," Glimmer had continued her rambling in the headset and was followed by Bow.

"Yeah, I thought Glimmer was going to leave me then and there and--"

Adora pulled the headset off her ear and quickly finished getting her coffee brewing. She took a calming breath before turning around and addressing said, super hot woman. "Hi, thank you for choosing Starbucks. What can I set started for you?"

Catra smirked at the canned greeting. "Hey, could I have a grande nitro cold brew and a croissant?"

"Absolutely," she said cheerily as she started pressing buttons, "And that's, Catra? Right?"

"Yep, how'd you know," she joked. Bow had already popped up by the register with her drink ready before Adora even sent it through, "Clearly, I come here too much."

"You're a bit of a legend, I'm afraid," Adora teased as she finished all of her register wranglings and went to pick up the croissant, "I'm told you defend us against mean customers."

"It's the only reason I come here. Someone's gotta stand up for Bow," she winked as she took the food.

"I guess I'll be seeing a lot of you," Adora tried to contain her enthusiasm but felt it was a losing cause. "It's really nice to meet you. I'm Adora," she held out a hand that Catra took.

"Same, Adora. See you tomorrow." She dropped some cash in the tip jar before grabbing her things and heading out.

Adora slid her headset back on and was immediately berated. "Oh my gosh, Adora," Glimmer leaned out from the nook of the drive-thru window, "Flirting on the job *already*!"

"What? No. I mean, she's hot," she pressed to reply.

"Yeah, you just totally said that over the drive-thru speaker," Bow noted as he looked over at her and gestured at where she had pressed the wrong button. "Annnnd... I think Catra *just* got in her car, so she might have heard that in the parking lot."

"Kill me," Adora whined as she buried her face in her hands.

"After the rush," Glimmer winked before slipping back into her spot, "Also, wash your hands after touching your face and hot girls, please."

Sure enough, Catra came around the same time the next day. This time Adora had her order keyed in for her before she got to the register. She was dressed down by comparison to the previous outfit, but

somehow she looked every bit as polished in a fitted t-shirt, black jeans, and very adorably nerdy black-framed glasses.

"Hey, Adora. They didn't scare you off?"

God, that voice. "Nope! Not yet. You want your regular?" The other woman nodded, and she sent it through. "No work today?"

"Ah, there's always work," the other woman mused and then tapped the laptop bag she had slung around her shoulder. "Just not going to the office. Not in a seeing a bunch of people mood today."

"I'm touched you decided to work with us instead." She slipped away to grab the croissant and then handed it over.

"Nothing helps my focus more than listening to Sparkles yell." The blank look the other woman gave her back caused her to laugh. "Sorry, Glimmer."

"Nitro for Catra," another voice called out from the corner.

"Thanks, by the way," she dropped in her tip then headed to grab the drink. She posted up in the corner of the small coffee shop and opened up her laptop to start working.

Adora went through her daily tasks and tried to stay focused despite her head swirling with thoughts about the other woman. When she was out "sweeping" the front, she noticed that her laptop had a lesbian flag sticker on it. *Yes!* Only, in her daze of celebration, she managed to accidentally knock down a whole row of coffee beans that she had to clean up. Catra had watched with a bemused look on her face before turning back to her laptop.

When she was finally sent on her lunch break, she was both excited and terrified that the other woman was still there. She grabbed her backpack from the back and decided that if she was rebuffed, at least she could bury her embarrassment in homework. After receiving her food and drink, she sat down at a table on the other side of Catra and laid out a textbook as well. The other woman looked over at her and took her AirPods out.

"How's it going," Catra asked casually.

"Fine! I haven't screwed up yet today. I think anyway." She looked over at Catra's computer screen; it was some kind of program she didn't recognize at all. "You?"

"I've undoubtedly screwed up by now, but fuck it. That's the nature of the work," she shrugged and looked at the book. "What are you studying?"

"Latin," Adora groaned as she looked at the textbook. "I'm wanting to go into physical therapy, and I thought this would be helpful because of all the medical terminology that comes from it. It's *so* hard, though."

"Ah," Catra nodded thoughtfully, "Ad Astra Per Aspera." Adora looked at her with confusion. "Through hardships to the stars. I took Latin in high school. Can't say I've had to use it a ton, but I liked it well enough. Reminds me of programing languages. Lots of rules and patterns."

"Maybe you can tutor me," Adora laughed. "Are you in college too?"

"Nope. I decided I was done with school when I graduated. Started working instead," she saved what she was doing on her laptop and closed it up. "Can't say I regret it. Though, messing with bodies...

yeah, you need a degree to do that. I mean, you seem smart enough, but if you don't even know your Latin, who knows what muscles you'll be mixing up."

"Hey! I have an A in anatomy, I'll have you know," Adora quipped back before she started to eat her lunch finally. They continued chit-chatting as Adora filled her in on her post-graduate plans and her various gripes about declensions and conjugations. Once she finished lunch, Catra decided she was done for the day too, and headed out.

After a few days of trying to get a sense of whether or not the cheerful barista was interested, Catra couldn't help herself from asking someone. Still, she knew it was a tricky situation. There's a severe imbalance of power when you're a customer inquiring about a worker, and that didn't even take into account their economic differences. She didn't want to put Adora in a weird position and make her uncomfortable at her job. Then Catra would have to find a new coffee shop and get used to new people... no thanks.

"What's Blondie's deal," Catra kept her voice low, though the sounds of Adora's accidentally screeching milk made it unnecessary.

"Adora? She's a part of our best friend squad," Bow said cheerily, "She needed a job, and so of course, we recommended her. She's, uh, still learning, but I'm sure she'll be great."

She closed her eyes for a moment and breathed out a frustrated sigh. After small talking with the young woman over the last few days, she knew that much already. "That's not really what I meant." she glanced over at Adora, still stumbling her way through making a latte. No one had ever been this cute while doing a terrible job.

Before she could elaborate further, Glimmer appeared by the register, somehow covered in milk. "Bow," she growled, "You have to take over training. I just can't anymore—" she realized that a customer was still in front of them. "Oh, hi, Catra. Did you need something else? Adora should have your drink in a minute." She made eyes at Bow, and he rushed over to the bar.

Damn. She looked over at Adora again briefly before shaking her head, "I'm good, thanks, Sparkles." She dropped some bills in the tip jar, and as she walked away to wait on her drink, she could barely hear Glimmer talking on the headset to Bow. Giggles and shrieks followed next. This was a huge mistake.

At least Adora wasn't wearing a headset today. Probably for the best, as all of her focus was on trying to get this steaming routine down. Her current milk sounded much less like a banshee. She finished the latte finally and was looking so smug and excited about it as she handed it back to Bow for the drive thru. She pulled Catra's sticker next and smiled as she glanced over to her, "Catra, hi! Sorry for your wait. At least I can't mess this one up."

"No problem," Catra said casually. Oh god, Sparkles was staring at them.

"Any big plans for the day," she asked as she started filling the cup from the nitro tap.

"Nothing but work today," Catra shrugged, "Mostly boring meetings. Hence the nitro. Gotta stay awake somehow."

Adora laughed and the sweet sound alone brought a smile back onto Catra's face. "Hopefully, we can get you caffeinated enough so you don't get fired!"

"Yeah, gotta watch out for that, my boss is a real asshole," Catra joked. It wasn't a lie, really; no one was more critical of her work than herself. She took a break from staring at those beautiful eyes long enough to notice the drink overflowing, "Hey, Adora. You might want to—"

"Oh, fuck," she said to herself then looked panicked as she flipped the lever up. Her whole face had turned red by the time she had cleaned up and delivered the drink. "I'm so sorry that I said that. It was really unprofessional. You're always so patient with me. "

"Frankly, I've never heard such foul language in my whole fucking life," she winked as she picked up the drink. "Thanks. Good luck with the milk."

As she walked out to her car she felt no less or more sure that the other woman was interested. From what she had seen over the last few days, she was very friendly with everyone. Still, whether it was imagined or not, she thought perhaps there was something special about their banter. And, she *had* heard the confused new barista declaring someone was hot over the loudspeaker of the drive thru after they just met. Adora had caught her eye enough for Catra to be satisfied with playing the long game and seeing if she made a move.

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Another week went by with pleasant banter and more than one day of Catra deciding to “work from home” aka in the cafe where she could count on little moments with Adora. She was impressed to see that she had really improved her barring skills in such a short time.

While Catra was waiting on her own beverage one morning, Adora proudly showed her the flat white she had just made. “Look! I even got the little dot right,” she said, practically beaming

“It’s a great dot. Maybe I’ll start trusting you with my hot drinks now,” she had teased back. Though, truly, she preferred cold drinks because it always felt like she needed to get caffeinated in a hurry. Like this particular morning, when she had arrived early enough that only the drive thru was open and the sun was just beginning to think about rising.

“Good morning, thank you for choosing Starbucks,” that very familiar voice had said over the speaker.

“Hey, Adora,” she answered back.

“CATRA! Good morning! Sorry, I’m not at the register so I couldn’t see you on the camera. Do you want your regular?”

“Yep, I am very predictable like that.Though, you better make me a doppio too, it’s going to be a long day.”

“It’ll be shorter when your heart stops from all that caffeine,” Adora chided her.

“Okay, doctor dummy,” she laughed to herself, “I’ll take some water instead.”

“Good choice! Did you know it’s triple filtered? I’ll see you at the window!”

When she pulled up to the window, Adora was already halfway out of it waiting for her. “Hey, Catra,” she handed over the water first, “What are you doing up so early?”

“Gotta catch a flight,” she groaned and then drank some of the water. It was really refreshing, “There’s a conference I have to go to for work. Maybe I should just have that heart attack instead…”

“Aw, come on, it can’t be that bad,” Adora teased as she scanned her phone for the payment. “I mean, I’m sure you’ll miss.. um, you know, all of us here.” Her face turned red and she ducked back inside to grab her croissant.

“Yeah, I’m not really sure how I’m going to start my day without your ridiculous level of energy and enthusiasm at these ungodly hours,” Catra added as she took the food. Adora made a face at the comment and hurriedly turned away from her again. In that moment, Catra would have paid no less than a million dollars to save herself from the embarrassment she felt. *Why did she have to get a crush on her barista?*

Adora appeared back and handed over her cold brew that she had put a cardboard sleeve on like they would normally do a hot drink. “What, cold brew too cold today,” she joked as she took it.

“No, it’s, um,” Adora leaned on her elbow at the ledge and pointed with her other hand. Her face was still red but she was clearly trying to be play it as cool as possible. “I put my number on there… you know, if you miss my superhuman morning energy and want a little pick me up… free of charge, and all!”

“I will definitely be taking you up on that,” Catra smiled back at her and loved the way the other woman lit up at the response. “See you in a couple days. Keep notes on if anyone’s rude to you, I’ll deal with them when I get back.”

“Will do. Safe travels,” Adora smiled, “And.. you could text me to let me know when you land or whenever, it doesn’t have to be in the morning.”

Catra had to make herself nod and drive off after that one. Sitting here and chatting with Adora sounded much more fun than going to this probably very boring conference. In a world where she wasn’t the keynote speaker, she would skip it. At least now she had something to look forward to when the plane landed.

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She texted Adora when she landed, and was excited to see that she immediately replied back. It wasn’t much, just a glad you made it safe and all, but it was a nice change. It had been a long time since anyone other than her business partners seemed invested in her well being.

Today was technically the pre-conference, full of networking events and attempts at fun social gatherings. She normally attended the first because the business woman in her wouldn’t pass up the opportunity, even if they were far past their scrappy first days as a start-up. It never hurts to know new players and spot talent worth investing in that others might miss. Social events, however, those she normally avoided. Only this one was unfortunately in the bar of her hotel, and she had already set her mind on posting up for a drink or two to relax.

Thankfully, it seemed that her reputation for being anti-social was helping her this evening. Most people had left her alone at her high table for two aside from some polite hellos and one fangirl who was practically about to pass out as she asked to take a selfie with her. She thought it was weird, but obliged. Is this how stalkers were made, she wondered after the young woman ran away back to her friends. Speaking of, she met eyes with a woman whom she felt tempted to bestow the title on.

“Catra,” she said as she hopped up onto the stool across from her, “Surprised to see you down here. I don’t think I’ve seen you socializing since our first year at this thing.”

“Valerie,” she narrowed her eyes at the woman. She was around the same age, early twenties, with long red hair and green eyes. Conventionally attractive enough, but everything else about her made her stomach turn. “I was enjoying a drink by myself until you decided to ruin that for me.” She grabbed her phone and shot off a quick text.

The redhead rolled her eyes. “Oh, please. You wouldn’t be sitting here if you didn’t want *some* kind of attention, darling. Look at you and your smart little suit. I think you’ll go down as the sexiest keynote speaker this conference has ever seen.”

“Fuck off,” she mumbled as she downed the rest of her cocktail. “I’ve told you a thousand times I’m not interested.”

“Ah, such a shame,” she pouted. “You know, we could be quite the power couple, you and I.”

“Seeing as I’m the one with all the power, I think I’m doing just fine on my own.” She wanted to storm off, but she knew that lurking in this mix of industry people were journalists waiting for something more exciting than revenue to tweet and live stream. It was bad enough that she had entertained the other woman sitting with her this long. Finally, her phone rang. “As unpleasant as this has been, I’ve got to take this.” She got up from her seat and answered the phone, “Go for Catra.”

“Oh my gosh, you sound so businessy,” a much sweeter, more welcomed voice said on the other end. “Did I call in time? Are you escaping?”

“Yes, thanks for checking in. Give me one second,” she noted flatly as she hustled towards the elevator. Once she was alone, she dipped into her regular way of speaking. “Thank you. You’re my hero.”

“Who were you running away from again?”

Catra slid her card and set the elevator to the penthouse. “Ugh, it’s this awful woman. She’s been hitting on me at this thing since I started coming here.”

“Oh, can’t she take a hint then?”

“It’s complicated,” she groaned as she recalled the memory, “The first time, she didn’t seem that bad. We were dancing and that was before I knew she just wanted me for—“ her voice dropped off, she didn’t feel like getting into this ‘Hey, by the way, I’m really fucking rich’ moment.

“Sex?” Adora provided sheepishly on the other line.

“Yep, that’s it. I turned her down and she still chases me,” she complained. The doors opened up and she was in her room finally.

“I’m trying to wrap my head around you dancing,” Adora admitted. “I can’t imagine it.”

“Hey, fuck you, I’m a very good dancer,” she took off her suit jacket and hung it up. She was looking at herself in a mirror as she started to loosen her tie.

“Well, we’ll just have to go dancing when you get back then. I have to see it to believe it.” Adora laughed. Catra liked this relaxed non-work version of her even more.

“It’s a date. You pick a place, I’m lousy for spots in our area,” she mused as she crossed the gigantic space and collapsed onto her bed. Normally she would spend at least a few minutes dreamily staring out at the lights of the city, but she couldn’t be bothered tonight. Fucking Valerie.

“So, how’s the hotel,” Adora asked after the lull in conversation.

“It’s fine,” Catra noted as she looked around. “Nothing’s like home though, you know.”

“Oh sure, but I *love* hotels. My family was pretty broke growing up. We never went on a trip we couldn’t just drive back home from the same day,” Adora admitted softly before getting enthused again. “But now I’ve stayed in them a couple of times with Glimmer and Bow, and I love it. Everything’s so neat, and they make your bed for you.”

“It does have its perks.” Hearing that Adora came from humble beginnings too made her feel all the more attracted to her. She was a self-made entrepreneur in a sea of others who were simply there on their parents’ dimes and connections.

“I think the only thing I don’t like is that they charge so much for all those little drinks and snacks,” Adora complained. “I didn’t know the first time and I had to put it all on my credit card. Ugh! They should label it better. Who would pay that much for a soda?”

The thought occurred to Catra that she could continue her drinking and relaxation. She popped up from the bed to check the situation in the fridge. “What if you were rich though,” Catra mused as she looked at her selection, “Would it be worth it to drop a hundred bucks on some tiny things of soda and whiskey?”

Adora hummed aloud to herself on the other line before following up, “I think if I did, I’d have to make at least a couple thousand dollar donation to a legit charity in penance.”

“Seems fair,” she agreed as she pulled out the overly priced beverages. To tell the truth, she wasn’t even exactly sure if she got charged by the line item on such things when staying in this level of luxury. Someone else did all of the billing for her these days. “What exactly qualifies as a legit charity?”

“Oh! Well, you know, they actually help people, for one,” Adora noted, “There’s so many that make themselves rich. There’s this charity back where I grew up, Backpack Helpers, they would be my pick.”

Catra took a break from being her own mixologist to jot down the name on one of the hotel pads. “Uh huh, and what do they do? Give out school supplies?”

“Yes, but way more. This is kind of embarrassing,” she stalled in talking for a second, and Catra gave her space. “When I was in elementary school, my mom was between jobs and I got signed up for it through my social worker at school. Every Friday or vacations, they’d send me home with a backpack full of food and things to help fill the gap between school meals.”

Catra’s heart started to melt even more. “That’s not embarrassing at all, and if anyone said so I hope they’re fucking poor someday so they get it,” she mellowed herself back out, “Sorry, it.. uh, strikes a cord with me. I get what that’s like. I’m sure it was a relief for your mom not to have to worry about keeping you fed.”

“Yeah. I know she appreciated it,” Adora sighed. “I saw on their social media they might be having to cut back the number of schools they serve. That’s what I mean — places like this, no money. Places that sell cutesy shirts and wristbands or whatever, fully funded. It doesn’t make any sense.”

“No argument there,” Catra walked over to her laptop and searched the name. “So, how was the rest of your day at work?”

“Not too bad. My list of people for you to yell at is only half a page long,” Adora teased. “Oh, shit. I really ought to be getting to bed though. I’ve got to be there at 5 AM again tomorrow. Are you going to be alright?”

“Yeah, I should be going too. Have to give a little speech tomorrow. Thanks again for saving me,” Catra started to fill out the donation form. “Goodnight.”

“Good luck! Let me know how it goes. Night!” Adora chirped and then was gone.

After making her anonymous penance donation of $500,000 dollars, she let herself drink the cocktail and wrote up a note to her accountant to explain the impending withdrawal. She always did donations anonymously; she felt anything else was somehow disgeniune. She’d rather look like a cold heartless person to the press than look like she was doing good simply to reap the benefits for her public image. She shut down her laptop and headed over towards her bed when her phone pinged with a text.

“Just remember, I’m brewing for you!” Adora had sent along with the dorkiest photo anyone has ever taken while wearing a Starbucks apron that she had clearly thrown on over her pajamas. “Get it, it’s like, rooting.” She had followed up in case it wasn’t clear.

“Oh my god, you are such a dork and that doesn’t even make sense,” she texted back immediately. “Thanks.”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! Comments are always well-loved and appreciated :)

Big Tech's Bad Girl

Chapter Summary

Catra makes a big splash at the conference but has an even more interesting time back home.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra woke up the following day to the light of the sunrise coming in through the windows of the penthouse. She sat up in bed and smiled at the beautiful sight. Having gone to bed with Adora's voice being the last thing she heard, it was much easier to find herself back in that place where she felt wonder about this being her life again. When she grabbed her phone, sure enough, the early-rising barista had already texted her.

Adora: Good morning! Hope your speech goes well today. Don't worry; I'm too sleepy to think of another good pun.

Adora: [Picture of Sunrise taken through the drive-thru window]

Adora: Working this early isn't too bad!

Catra: Morning. Thank god, I don't think I'd recover before I needed to speak. The sun just started rising here. I hope you have a good day at work. Don't burn the place down while I'm gone.

Catra thought about sending a picture in return, but honestly, nothing she took was going to outdo the charm of Adora's. She crawled out of bed and went about getting herself ready for the day. She had brought double the number of outfits than she had public appearances planned. What kind of vibe did she want to give off speaking to a couple of thousand people? Most of them were older than her. Something about that gave her two very contradictory feelings -- dressing up to the maximum so that they take her seriously or dressing however the fuck she wanted because she's the one on the god damn stage for a reason. She landed somewhere between the two conflicting ideas with a step up from tech casual.

She took a selfie in the mirror, angling it so that it didn't give away that she was in a bathroom bigger than the bedroom she had growing up.

Catra: [selfie]

Catra: Thoughts? Would you listen to me ramble about tech stuff?

Adora: [fire emoji] I would be happy to, but I might get distracted. You look amazing. I want your whole wardrobe.

Catra: Pants would be a little short on you...

Adora: I'll say they're capris.

Catra: Aren't you working? Sparkles is going to write you up.

Adora: But I'm making the moment right with my favorite customer.

Adora: I mean you if that wasn't clear

Catra: Ha. I'm going to stop aiding you in getting fired now. Going to go get some coffee. Sorry in advance for the infidelity

Adora: How dare you

When she was out of town and already a known quantity, Catra let herself go to a more snobby local coffeehouse. It wasn't that she thought Starbucks was the best coffee or anything, but she liked how normally she could sneak in there without having to see someone who recognized her. Here though. Fuck it. She was already getting hassled. She sat down with her drink and read over her notes for the speech. There were still a couple of hours to kill before the opening pomp and circumstance. She was midway through her one-thousandth reread when she had to pay the price of not making drip coffee in her hotel room.

"Excuse me, Catra?" A soft and shaking voice called from above her.

She took out the one airpod she had in and sighed. The young man was a lithe blonde with a press credential badge on display. He looked harmless enough.

"Yes, how can I help you?" She put her phone away and crossed her arms defensively.

"Hi, I'm Kyle. I'm with The Times, and I was wondering if I could ask you a few questions, please." His voice was shaking.

Catra wondered if this was the first time he had ever interviewed someone in his life or if she was that intimidating. "Sure, fine. I can do a couple of questions."

"Oh! Great," he sat down in the empty chair beside her and pulled out his phone, "Is it okay if I record this? I can't write that fast. I don't want to misquote you on anything." She nodded. "Great! Okay, so. Before we get started, what is your last name? I couldn't find it anywhere."

"I don't use one. Next question."

"That's so cool. Alright, let's see." He was swiping around on his phone until he pulled up a notes app with his questions. He started reading verbatim: "The world wants to know what to make of two up-and-coming women in tech seen drinking together last night at the industry's biggest event?" He turned his phone and showed her a picture of her and Valerie. Someone managed to take one where Catra must have been in the middle of saying something sarcastic because she was actually smiling.

"Are you fucking kidding me right now?" Catra said before she remembered she was being recorded.

"No, ma'am," he said sheepishly. "The photos were going viral last night on Twitter. A lot of people think that you two are cute, and they're rooting--"

"Okay, let me make a few things clear." She took a deep breath and let her mind process before she spoke without a filter. "One, I consider Ms. Harper an acquaintance at best. She sat with me for a

minute before I had to take care of a business matter. Two, my personal life isn't a news story. Three, I'm not up and coming. I'm already here."

"That's a really super line. Thanks, ma'am. Um, I guess I don't have any other questions. They really wanted me to ask about that." He scratched behind his neck and looked pitiful.

"Sure, there's nothing else to ask the youngest person to ever keynote at this event. Nothing interesting about how I'm also the only woman of color to do so...or how I don't even have a college degree. All of that's boring." Catra wanted to scold him some more, but she could already hear her PR head back home lecturing her. "So, thanks. Hopefully, this clears some things up." She made eyes at him, and he had enough common sense to leave now. Ugh, Valerie would fucking love this if it was as big a story as he said. She pulled her phone back out and was happy to see that Adora had texted her in the meantime.

Adora: Glimmer made us all undertows! Have you had one? They're so good! I've had three already! I could run a marathon right now.

Catra: Now whose heart is going to stop from caffeine?

Adora: It was nice knowing you.

The keynote speech went as well as Catra hoped it would, if not even better. She thought being centerstage would make her anxious, but it hit her that they were all there to listen to her. The more the speech went on, her natural swagger and bravado kicked in. The audience was hers as she detailed the story of the company she and Entrapta had built, from high school dreams to today's reality. She passionately spoke about what it meant to her as a young woman of color in an industry dominated by old white men. She hoped, perhaps fruitlessly, that it would become the story of the day rather than silly gossip. When she finished, the crowd roared with applause. She was simultaneously proud and relieved to be done.

She texted Adora as soon as she got off stage and finished with all of the rig amoral of returning sound equipment and saying polite thank yous.

Catra: Done! It went pretty well I think.

Adora: Awesome! Do they record these things? I wanna watch it.

Catra stared at that for a moment. Of course, they recorded it. God, there were probably already clips up right now. Thankfully, she knew that Adora wasn't into social media from their small talk. Still, she probably should come clean with this whole thing soon.

Catra: It's just boring stuff. I'll see if they post it somewhere after the conference is over.

Adora: When are you coming back?

Adora: Not to sound needy. It's really Bow that wants to know...

Adora: But also, I do.

The texts had fired off in rapid succession, making Catra laugh to herself as she navigated the crowd.

Catra: Still pretty hyped up on that caffeine, huh? Maybe drink some water. I'm supposed to be here like two more days, but I might dip out early.

Adora: Good!

Adora: I mean, good that you might be back early.

Catra: Yeah, I figured, dummy.

On her way to her room, she stopped politely to answer some more press questions before deciding she was done after the second time the rumor came up. She changed back down to loungewear, made herself another drink along with a note to ask Adora about another charity, and called Entrapta.

"Catra! How's it going? The metadata on social media seems to say you have knocked it out of the field."

"It's out of the park. Maybe stay away from the sports metaphors." She laughed and shook her head. No doubt their PR people had been trying again to get Entrapta to speak down in a relatable way to those without her vast intellect.

"Input received. All's well over here! Emily and I are keeping everything running optimally."

"Wouldn't expect anything less. Hey, listen, do you think I have to stay for this whole thing?"

"You don't have to do anything, Catra. You have full autonomy."

"I just didn't know if you cared or not. We're in this together, you know."

"Let me run a quick risk and benefits analysis." The phone line went silent for a minute aside from rapid-fire typing and clicking in the background. Catra had been on the end of this many times before --- whether it was a big business decision or what they should order for lunch.

"Okay, I'm back. It appears that your staying or leaving has no net negative or positive impact on our brand. In my professional opinion, do whatever you want."

Catra silently pumped her fist in celebration. "Perfect. Press here is annoying. If I stay, there will definitely be some negative impact."

"You mean the Valerie situation? There was the picture last night, and now she was front row and center at your speech this afternoon. I thought you hated her. Very unusual."

"I do. Fucking hell. This is why I'm leaving." Her mind was beyond made up now. She was glad to already be in the clothes she'd be comfortable flying in. "Hey, can you ask my assistant to go ahead and book me the next flight home?"

"Absolutely! Ooh, before you leave, can you--"

"I already packed away all of the tiny things for you."

After another minute of coordinating plans, she was off the phone with her partner and started packing in earnest. She was so relieved that Entrapta didn't think she needed to stay for this whole thing. The first couple of times had been invigorating and inspiring, but she was not in the mood for it this year. Plus, no matter what she told Adora, they *did* record everything. If she wanted the experience, she could put it on while she worked later.

She was back home before dinner and couldn't be happier. Her cat, a beautiful Russian blue she had adopted named Melog, was waiting for her as soon as she walked in. After she gave him a sufficient amount of hugs and scratches, she let her pet sitter know that she no longer needed their service, but she paid them in full anyway.

"Did you miss me, buddy," she asked as Melog followed her around her spacious, modern penthouse. It was not all too unlike the one she had been staying in temporarily, but it had a lot more character and heart to it. She laid back on her couch, and the cuddly cat jumped up on her chest. "Should I tell her I'm home already," she asked as though he'd reply while rubbing behind his ears, "Or does that seem too desperate? Treat for your thoughts?"

At the word treat, he did meow at her, and she managed to balance them both while reaching over to grab the bag from her coffee table. While he munched, she decided that if anyone would *not* find it pathetic, it would probably be Adora. She took a snapshot of the fuzzy happy animal lying across her and texted it to her crush.

Catra: [Melog picture]

Catra: My son said he missed me, so I came home early.

Adora: OH.

Adora: MY.

Adora: GOD.

Adora: He's so cute! I want to pet him. Bring him through the drive-thru tomorrow.

Adora: Also, welcome home!

Catra: Will do. He doesn't like car rides too much, but he does like pretty girls petting him.

Adora: Who doesn't? [rainbow emoji]

God, she liked this girl.

While they were working on opening tasks, Adora caught Glimmer and Bow up on how things had been going with her flirtmance. "She's bringing her cat today," she reported excitedly.

"Oh my gosh, that's so cute," Bow cooed through the headset as he worked on restocking.

"Now that you're meeting the family when are you two going on an actual date?" Glimmer asked while she was busy putting money in the tills.

"Um, well. We talked about going dancing. I don't know if that was serious or not." Adora said, and she could hear Glimmer laughing already from the other side of the small coffee shop.

"I hope it was a joke. Adora, you know you can't dance," she noted and was affirmed by Bow immediately, "You're going to scare her away!"

Adora came around the corner to be with Glimmer and made the most pitiful face at her. "Please, you have to tell me somewhere cool for us to go, she wanted me to choose. Maybe I can fake it."

Glimmer tapped her chin as she thought this through. "I don't know about cool, but if we send you somewhere popular enough, you'll be crammed in and won't be able to pull some of your worst moves." Once she closed up the till, she grabbed her phone from her apron pocket, "I'll send you some names."

"My hero," Adora cried as she wrapped her arms around her friend in a tight hug.

"Aw, I missed the group hug," Bow whined as he looked through the door.

Adora survived a boring but busy morning in the drive-thru. Finally, nearing the end of their rush, Adora saw the face she had been waiting for on the register's tiny camera.

"Good morning. Thank you for choosing Meowbucks," she joked.

"Hey, Adora," Catra laughed, "I'll take my regular and a short of cold water. Thanks."

"Of course, see you two at the window!" She happily keyed everything in and added Melog's name to the water cup.

"This is sickeningly cute," Glimmer noted on the headset from back at the oven.

After several painstaking minutes of taking care of the customers ahead of her, Catra finally pulled up to the window. Adora, benefiting from her long legs, was leaned out and waiting for her. She carefully took the gray cat from his carrier and held him close enough that Adora could reach out and touch him.

"Adora, meet Melog," she said as Adora scratched under his chin and earned the beginning of a purr.

"I love him already," she cooed, then dipped back in to grab his water cup. "Look, it's your own little kittycino," she tilted it slightly and he tentatively took a lick before deciding he wasn't thirsty.

"This is the cutest thing that's ever happened here," Bow yelled from the cold bar. "Hi, Melog!"

"Alright, let's put this little guy away before his ego gets too big," she let Adora give him one more pet before tucking him back away in his carrier.

"Oh! I forgot, here's your stuff," Adora quickly handed out the food and drink.

"Second to my cat, what a shame," she laughed as she put the things away. While Adora was scanning her phone, she brought up what was most on her mind, "So, when do I get to prove what a good dancer I am?"

"I'm free tonight. I know that's kind of soon, but I'm off in the morning, and I don't have class till noon…"

"Sounds perfect. Can I treat you to dinner and drinks too?" Adora nodded excitedly. "Text me a time and your address, and I'll pick you up then. We better get going before the lady behind me pops a blood vessel." She quickly held up her phone again, "Run me through for her order too, for the wait."

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Once Adora was home from school and work, she and Catra solidified their plans for the evening. On Glimmer's advice, she had picked a club near their college strip that she assured would be busy even on a Wednesday night. In turn, her date had chosen a local pizza place not far from there that had rave reviews. Now, all there was to do was decide on an outfit and manage not to pass out from excitement.

It wasn't that she hadn't dated since being in college; she had more than a couple of disappointing flings to her name. In all those, she had never felt a spark like this before. To say she felt butterflies when she thought about Catra would be a vast understatement. Birds... no, more like dragons, that would be befitting of the feelings that were flying around in her.

This was going to be the first time that Catra saw her outside of her work uniform, and she knew the other woman was going to be dressed to impress. Adora's small wardrobe left her with much fewer options to do the same. Ultimately, she decided on a crop top that she paired with her 'dressy' jeans and some matching trendy sneakers. At the very least, she hoped the sight of abs and toned arms could do some of the work for her.

Before she could change her mind again, there was a knock at her door. She smiled as she opened it and saw Catra waiting on the other side. She looked at Adora with wide eyes, and she didn't know if she should feel complimented or self-conscious.

"Damn," was all Catra said for a moment. "The uniform doesn't do you justice."

"Thanks," she blushed. "You look… really, really hot." She had hoped for something more eloquent to say, but the words didn't come.

The other woman was wearing a tight dark red shirt with a cutout over her chest and black pants that left little to the imagination about her curves. She blushed the same as Adora and laughed, "You know, I think I heard my barista say that about me once."

"Shit," Adora whined, "You heard that?"

"Uh-huh," she had a wicked grin on her face. "You ready to go?" They headed downstairs after locking up, chatting away comfortably. Catra reached for her hand, and Adora happily accepted. Everything between them felt natural already.

When they got to Catra's car, the barista realized she had never really paid attention to it before. She was constantly distracted by the woman behind the wheel when she used the drive-thru. The car was some kind of electric brand she wasn't familiar with, and everything about it seemed futuristic beyond what she had ever driven or even ridden in.

"Wow," she noted once Catra climbed in beside her. "This is like a spaceship."

"I don't think she's rated for space travel yet. Maybe someday," Catra winked as she activated the push to start.

Adora wondered what her actual job must be. To afford a car payment on something like this, it paid a hell of a lot more than Starbucks. Of course, it's impolite to ask about something like that, so she let it go. Instead, the drive to the pizza place was filled with more questions and answers about her new best friend, Melog.

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After thoroughly stuffing themselves on what they mutually agreed was the best pizza ever, they headed over to the club that Glimmer had suggested. Once they were inside, it was all flashing lights in the darkness, sweaty bodies, and loud music pounding in their ears.

"I forgot going out dancing involved so many other people," Catra mused as she surveyed the scene. She grabbed for Adora's hand and held it tight, "Drinks?"

"Definitely," she followed along after Catra, who, despite her smaller stature, cut her way through the crowd with authority. They finally got to the one open spot at the bar, and Adora stood behind Catra, wrapping an arm around her waist to stay close. It wasn't *at all* motivated by the fact that she had caught another woman making eyes at her sexy date.

When Adora pulled her close with those strong arms, Catra could feel her heart beating stronger than the bass of the music. She thought about turning and kissing her then and there, but, alas, the bartender turned her attention to them. "What do you want," she yelled back at Adora.

"Normally, we just get whatever the special is," she provided unhelpfully.

Catra ordered a pitcher of the unnamed special, which turned out to be some kind of questionable blue liquid. As she and Adora sat down at a small table to try it, she grimaced.

"You drink stuff like this," she asked with a raised eyebrow and then ventured a sip of the glass she poured for herself, "It tastes like Kool-Aid and bad decisions."

"You're getting the full college experience tonight," Adora winked as she raised her glass and tried it. She looked much more satisfied. "I like it! You can't even taste the alcohol."

"Famous last words," Catra said as they clinked their plastic cups and downed the first round of whatever blue ruin this would turn out to be.

After finishing half the pitcher between them, Catra felt good and silly but still smart enough to realize that they had no business drinking the rest. She gifted the remainder to another larger group and dragged Adora out to the crowded dance floor.

"Okay, let's see who is the better dancer here," The thumping music picked up and she was already moving her body in time, loosening up in preparation.

"Um, I'm really sorry but," Adora shook her head and looked entirely too emotional for the confession. "I'm the worst dancer."

Catra grinned smugly as she looked the helpless woman up and down. Even with the admission, she was going to make sure that Adora would regret saying she couldn't imagine her dancing. As much as she had skipped the wild party college lifestyle, she had more than a few nights of blowing off steam or celebrating a new milestone at the company. When the beat was about to drop on the song, she decided she might as well follow suit. She spun around and placed Adora's hands on her hips before dropping low against her.

"It's okay," she said as she rose back up slowly and looked back at the Adora over her shoulder, "Stay right there and look pretty, I'll do the rest."

"Gladly," Adora's entire body was on fire now between the heat of the room and the feeling of the other woman's body against hers. It took all of her focus to keep on the beat as Catra danced circles

around her. After noticing just how much attention her date was getting from jealous onlookers, the competitive edge in her took over. All she wanted to do was claim Catra as hers.

In between a song, Catra had turned back around to her with flushed cheeks giving her sultry eyes and another one of those mischievous smiles. Adora seized the moment and brought her close with one arm. She lifted the other woman's chin with her other hand and seeing only the same want looking back at her, she brought them together in a passionate and deep kiss.

When they parted, Catra smirked, "Mmm, I was wondering what was taking so long." She kissed her once more quickly, "Worth it though."

"I was hoping for somewhere more romantic," Adora let her hands drop down to her hips again.

"What, like the bathroom?" She started laughing and feeling dizzy from all the dancing and the mounting heat between them.

"It's not too late for that," Adora teased as she leaned in and spoke in her ear.

The feeling of her breath against her and the alcoholic concoction running through her body made this sound like the best idea Catra had ever heard. She grabbed Adora's hand and started pulling them back towards the women's restroom. "You promised me the full college experience," she yelled back at her as they passed the sound system. Once they were in the bathroom, she pounced on Adora and tangled her hands in her hair before being pressed up against the wall. Adora giggled between kisses.

"You good now?" she asked after they parted.

"Off the fuck-it list," Catra started cackling, "Bucket, bucket list."

"Maybe we should head somewhere a lil cleaner," Adora suggested as she leaned into her for one last sweet kiss.

"Mmkay," Catra pulled out her phone and squinted at it, "I'll order us a car."

Adora led the way so that Catra could focus on her phone. Being back out in the fresh air did them both a ton of good, and they snuggled up against the wall while waiting for the car she had ordered.

"You *are* a good dancer," Adora kissed the top of her head.

"Damn right I am," Catra smirked and started wiggling her hips again. "I'll dance for you any time."

"Ooh, Can't wait to make you dance at Starbucks," she started giggling again, imagining it, "I'll give you a discount!"

"Oh, sweet dummy, I don't need--" she cut herself. Stay sharp, drunk Catra, she thought to herself.

Of course, drunk Catra had already betrayed her. She didn't know this until Adora started pointing and laughing as a limousine pulled up and put its hazards on in the street.

"Oh my gosh, is it prom night," she nudged Catra to make her look, "This is a 21 and up club!"

Catra looked down at her phone and realized she had used the entirely wrong car service. She swallowed hard and tried to think of what to say. Mercifully, the driver rolled down his window and called over to them, "Ms. Catra! Pleasure to see you," he said cheerily.

Fuuuuck . "Ha, yeah," she looked at Adora, "We're doing it all tonight, prom too. Let's go." She grabbed her hand and they headed over to the limo. Whether it was due to her tipsy state or pure enthusiasm, Adora didn't question it any further. Once they were inside, she gave the driver her address and then closed up the privacy window.

"This is amazing," she declared as she made her way back to Catra, "How did you know I didn't get to go to prom?"

"Um, lucky guess," Catra laughed nervously. She opened the limo's mini-fridge and pulled out a couple of water bottles.

After rehydrating and catching their breaths, they cuddled in the back seat with Catra's arm around Adora as she rested her head on her shoulder. When they pulled up to her apartment building, Catra shook her awake. "Hey, we're here. Listen-- I had a *really* fun time tonight and-"

Adora put her fingers on her lips, "What if you came up for cuddles?"

She stuck her tongue out and licked Adora's fingers to make her pull them away.

"I just don't want to say bye yet. I wanna hold you and wake up with you. I'll take you to your car in the mornin' if you want to stay."

Catra narrowed her eyes at her as her date combated her with big sad blue ones. "I don't really want to say goodbye yet either," she admitted.

After tipping the driver and thanking him for coming out to such an unusual request, Catra followed Adora back up to her apartment. Adora let them in and flipped the lights on in her living room/kitchen combination that was the front of her modest home. "Welcome," she said as she swung her arms around, "to Casa Adora," she looked really pleased with the pun, "Get it? It's like Casa Amor on Love Island. Except, my name."

"Dummy, the more you have to explain jokes, the less funny they are," Catra giggled all the same as she corrected her.

"You always laugh though," Adora smiled smugly as she headed over into the kitchen to pour them two more glasses of water. "So," she said over the running water, "I know it's not fancy, but I bought all this." She gestured to the various mismatched pieces of furniture. It had the charm of a very selective, eclectic thrift store. Catra hadn't looked around much earlier, but now that she did... she loved everything about it. From the bright blue couch that was clearly from the 60s to the kitchen table with four different style chairs.

"I love it," Catra said sincerely as she accepted her water glass.

"Thanks," Adora beamed as she sipped on her own water and started walking towards the only other spaces -- her bedroom and the bathroom. When she opened the door to the bedroom, she did another grand arm gesture, "And this is where the magic happens. You know--"

"Cribs. God, of course, you'd make that dated reference," Catra shook her head and took in the new room. Sure, it wasn't the grand space she was used to these days, but her full-sized bed looked awfully cozy at this moment.

Adora went over to her wardrobe and grabbed a couple of shirts for them. She handed over an old high school athletics shirt to Catra. "For you, my lady," she said dramatically.

She slipped over into the bathroom to change, and Catra was left alone in her room to do the same. After she was down to the shirt and her underwear, she looked at herself in the mirror. Adora's old t was soft from years of loving care and delicate laundering. It was easily her favorite thing she had worn in a long time; thousand-dollar suits be damned.

When Adora finished changing, they curled up together in bed. After some light kissing, neither wanting to push past their limits, they fell asleep intertwined and happy.

Bright and early, they were woken up by Catra's phone going off. She grabbed to silence it and whispered apologies to her sleeping partner. She rubbed her eyes and tried to focus as she stared at the phone. Fuck, she realized she left her contacts in all night. One was so dry, it popped right off on its own accord, but somehow the other was glued on until she finally freed it. She couldn't remember the last time she had fallen asleep with her contacts in. Yep, the real college experience alright. At least she had her glasses in her car. Once her eyes recovered, she saw she had a series of work-related messages. Entrapta wanted to know if she was coming in. The head of PR scheduled a meeting first thing, then rescheduled the meeting after she slept through it, and finally sent a passive-aggressive email about her seeing them as soon as she decided to rejoin the working world.

"Fuck," she groaned as she read over everything, "Hey, Adora?"

Adora mumbled something against her neck.

"I forgot they're expecting me at work today," she ran a hand through Adora's mess of hair, "I can call a car to take me to mine if you need to sleep in more."

"No, no," Adora said with a yawn and kissed her neck before sitting up in bed, "I'm a woman of my word. Don't go ordering another limo."

"Ha, yeah, that was ridiculous," she laughed at herself and thought about how to explain it to her accountant later.

When Catra got out of bed, she pulled her pants back on but left the t-shirt. "Can I borrow this?"

"Of course," Adora looked very pleased with the ask. "I like seeing you in it. Plus, then I'll have something to wear when I stay over at your place."

"I wasn't giving it back anyway, but now I have an excuse. Thanks," Catra couldn't help but daydream for a moment about Adora sprawled out across her giant bed. It was going to feel awfully lonely when she went back to it tonight.

She raced over to her work in record time after Adora dropped her off. She didn't bother stopping by home to change, as the messages she was getting were becoming less passive and more just plain aggressive. After scanning her way through the multiple security checks, she practically jogged into the PR department and the lead's office.

"Kitten," they said disapprovingly as soon as she closed the door behind her. "What about SOS, threat level midnight meeting do you not understand?"

"Sorry, DT, I forgot I said I was coming in this morning," she lied as she took a seat across from them. Despite the fact that she was the one who hired them, she felt like she had been called to the

principal's office. "Listen, I'm sorry I dipped out on the conference. It was bor--"

"Nope, shush. You listen. I have a story to tell you," they hit a button that dimmed the lights in the office and lit up a projection behind their desk. "It's a love story in three acts. Very riveting." The first images appeared on the screen behind them --- the photo that some journalist had landed of her and Valerie accompanied by various screenshots of articles and tweets. "Monday, the Internet falls in love with the sight of one Valerie Harper and, you guessed it, our sweet CEO."

"That's--" she was cut off again.

"I told you, listen. It doesn't matter what's true or not. I'm telling you what people perceive. That's my job, right?" She nodded. "Now, you tried to put out this fire on your own with Kyle and the Times? Didn't go over so well. Though, I did like your quote on being there already. I might put that on a t-shirt. Unfortunately, your words couldn't put out what Ms. Harper decided to pour gasoline on." They swapped over to the next images. Valerie sitting front row and center like Entrapta had reported, and looking positively adoringly up at Catra as she owned the stage. God, the angle even looked like Catra was speaking towards her with passion in her eyes. Next, an interview snippet played:

"Catra means so much to young women in our industry. I can't even begin to say what she means to me. She and I have had a very special relationship since we shared our first year here. And now just look where we are," she gave a sly smile.

Catra watched in obedient silence but still mouthed a "what the fuck" to express her disbelief.

"When I say people fell in love, I mean it. A couple of hot lesbians at the top of their respective companies? You've got a trending topic and a couple hashtag: Valtra." Her eyes went wide at that one. "I know, shame. Couldn't even get you top billing! Now, I know you don't even like that little clout chaser, but she certainly is working your image right now."

"This is fucked up, DT, but I don't see how it impacts the company," she said defiantly as she crossed her arms. "It'll pass. Slow news week."

"Smart, that would have been my thinking too, but, as I promised. Three acts," they clicked over to a tweet of a mirror selfie paired with the text 'Let's go Lesbians.' The image was of a top of a woman's head where above her was the reflection of Adora, mercifully unidentifiable, pressing Catra against the dingy bathroom wall.

Next, headlines started popping up with the image. DT read aloud one of their favorites, "Big Tech's Bad Girl Catra Leaves Conference Early to Network with a New Partner: Where does that leave Valtra? Is the young CEO losing her focus?"

"Fuck me," Catra collapsed down into the chair briefly before leaping to her feet and getting angry. "This is bullshit, DT! I don't...why the fuck does anyone care about this?! Big Tech's Bad Girl, really?!"

"I thought that was kind of cute actually. Should I cancel your new business cards?" One of Catra's eyes started twitching. "Kidding, darling, breathe. People care, because now all of a sudden there's Team Blondie and Team Valtra. Personally, I'm Team Blondie. Look at those arms. Stunning specimen, dear, good for you."

"People can fuck off with their opinions about my personal life. It doesn't affect my work. This is some sexist bullshit," she clenched one of her hands into a fist and squeezed for a moment before relaxing again. "Can we pay that person to take the picture down?"

"See, I tried that this morning while you were... I don't want to presume, dear, but that is not your shirt." They emphasized the accusation with a dirty look before continuing. "She said the followers she's getting are the only payment she wants. I think she's angling for influencer status. People these days." They sighed and moved on to the last bit. "Of course, little miss Valerie has already issued a vague enough statement on her Twitter via some sad-ass Taylor Swift song lyrics. You're looking to be quite the heartbreaker."

"People really can't care this much about this, can they," Catra whined as she finally sat back down.

"Oh, sweetie, I haven't even shown you the fan art," they clicked again. "I like this one personally," they gestured at a recreation of Adora and her in the bathroom that put them in some kind of fantasy world setting. "They gave you cat ears and a tail as an homage to your name. How cute is that?" She was not amused. DT sighed and became very serious. "Like you said in your fantastic speech, you're showing up for about 5 different drastically underrepresented demographics in this industry. You mean something to people. And they care about your personal life, whether you like it or not. What they feel affects what our current and future investors see in you and our whole company."

"Fine, whatever, I get your point. Just tell me how I fix this. Isn't *that* what I pay you for?" She rubbed her temples and wondered if this ridiculous story was going to reach anywhere near Adora's world. "Sorry, I know you're looking out for all of us."

"Of course. The way I see it is you have two options. Tuck your tail between your legs and go give Ms. Harper a chance to appease the people." Catra gagged at the notion, and they moved quickly beyond it. "I know, not happening. Well, option two. We're going to need to go public with blondie. What's her name? You're coming first in this hashtag, I stake my reputation on it."

"Fuck, no," she groaned. "I don't want to drag her into this."

"Aw, you really like her, that's adorable," DT pulled up a document and started typing notes. "Now spill."

"You don't get it. She doesn't even know this is what she signed up for."

"Oooh, she doesn't know you're rich, does she?" Catra shook her head while keeping her eyes cast downward. "The plot thickens! Suddenly the multi-millionaire making out in the bathroom of a college bar is making more sense. Tell me how you lovebirds met."

"She works at the Starbucks I go to," she admitted low enough that DT had to strain to hear.

When DT processed what she said, they started cackling, "Fantastic hook. A rags to riches love story! Valtra won't have anything on this. Still going to need that name, though."

"I have to tell her myself first. She should get to choose what she wants," she sighed, pulling out her phone and looking over the various sweet messages they had exchanged. "I really, really like this girl, DT. I don't want to mess this up." This was the most vulnerable she had felt in front of another person in a very long time.

"Catra, speaking as a friend, I want you to be happy," DT said very sincerely as they got up from their chair and walked over to the other side of the desk. They patted her shoulder, "I also *need* you to be smart. I won't run anything without your say so, but you need to get ahead of this. Barista Barbie is going to find out either way, and it's not a good look if it's not you who tells her."

"Fine, I'll see if she can meet me this afternoon," she relented and stood up to look them in the eyes. She knew that DT was right, whether she liked it or not. "But, if she agrees to this, I'm bringing her back here. You're not running anything about her without her approving it too."

"Works for me," they smiled smugly, satisfied with winning the battle. They held out a hand and the two shook on the agreement. "Now about that name? I swear on my job I won't do anything with it until I have the all-clear, but I need to strategize."

"Adora," Catra said quietly. "I guess I don't know her last name."

"Doesn't go on the nametag and all," DT said with a wink. "Adora, cute. I can work with that."

With that, the frustrated CEO headed out of the office and felt like punching a wall. That, of course, was the old Catra talking, and she died in high school after she started therapy. Instead, she headed to their tranquility garden, something the lead architect had insisted on that she half-heartedly agreed to. Surprisingly, it had become one of her favorite places. She sat on the edge of the central fountain and tried to calm her thoughts. Surely, Adora would be happy to find out her potential girlfriend was loaded, right? Most people would be. Still... there was this whole three-ring media circus now. And what if she read too far into Catra not telling her earlier...

Deep breaths. Closed eyes. Listening to the water.

After her heart rate finally started to settle, she pulled out her phone and called up Adora. It was still 45 minutes until her class was supposed to start.

"Hey, Adora," she said as soon as the phone picked up.

"Hey, Catra," she parroted back, "Miss me already?"

"Of course." It was the truth. "Haven't heard a bad pun in over an hour. But, I was wondering if I could talk you into skipping class for lunch instead? I really need to talk to you about something."

"Hmm," Adora hummed over the phone, "Well, my next class is Latin. You do make a hotter teacher than my professor."

"Gratias tibi ago," she replied.

"Yeah, I don't know what that means. Maybe I *should* go to class." She started laughing. "Just kidding. Lunch sounds much better. Meet me back over here?"

"On my way," Catra was tempted to reply back in Latin again, but her still partially dehydrated brain cells didn't provide a good response.

Chapter End Notes

Promise this isn't leading to any major angst! Just a bit of a plot point to keep things exciting! Are you Team Blondie or Team Valtra*? Next chapter... Adora finds out the truth, and Catra can really start to show her a good time.

Comments and feedback are good for my image according to my PR person.

Things I know a lot about: Starbucks (I worked there)
Things I have no experience with: Being rich
Undertows are where you pull shots of espresso over a spoon into a tiny cup of milk/a pump of syrup. If you do it just right, when you drink the shots the hot espresso hits your mouth first and then is followed by the cold "undertow" of the milk. My team used to drink them together before opening/post-rush. (please don't try to order one, I don't need secret menu guilt on my conscience because by the way there is no secret menu. And also, be good like Catra and tip when you can.)

*all team Valtra's will be blocked and reported, I don't make the rules.

Where the Magic Happens

Chapter Summary

Adora finds out the truth about Catra.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora was on the sidewalk waiting for Catra when she pulled into her apartment's parking lot. She hopped up and down, waving as though somehow Catra might have missed her standing there. Once she pulled to a stop, Adora climbed in and leaned across to steal a kiss that she happily returned.

"I missed you already too for the record." She buckled herself in and couldn't stop smiling. "What's the plan? I'm so excited, I've never actually skipped class before."

Catra's mood was already improving being back together with Adora. "I thought we could get some takeout and go eat at my place. Does that sound okay? Gotta check in on Melog and all." This was the plan. Bring Adora to her home, and let the sight of her penthouse start the conversation. She was shocked she hadn't inquired about the car already.

"A chance to see our son *and* where the magic happens for you? Of course," Adora smirked.

"Wow, we're at our son already after one date? Did we get married last night, and I forgot?" Catra felt like had they finished that pitcher of "the special," they probably would be lawfully wedded wives at this rate.

"Mmhm, he took water from me, which means that I'm his second caregiver," she declared matter-of-factly.

"Fine, but I get to be the cool mom. I mean, you're obviously the dorky mom."

"I'm not so sure about that. You're the one with cute nerdy glasses who speaks to people about tech stuff."

"Yeah, well, you should know that some people call me the bad girl of big tech," Catra joked proudly.

Adora began laughing so hard that Catra couldn't help but feel slightly offended. They were at a stoplight, so she took a chance to look over at Adora and scowl at her.

Adora dropped into the voice of a concerned adult comforting a child, "I'm sorry, I'm sure you're the baddest in the bunch, but all I see is the sweet nerd doing newspaper crossword puzzles in Starbucks."

"It helps me think!" She protested petulantly. "I… fine, whatever. You win. You can be the cool mom. Now, what do you want to eat?"

"Hangover food sounds good-- burgers, fries, milkshakes? There's a place a few minutes from here that I love. It's a walk-up only though."

Greasy salvation retrieved, Catra was mostly quiet and stuck in her head as she drove home. Thankfully, Adora was happy to amuse them both by singing along poorly to the radio and feeding them fries.

She took a break from giving her best attempt at a throwback Britney Spears song. "Wow, you live downtown? That's awesome."

"Yep, moved into my place a couple of years ago," Catra tried to look casual about it. "Grew up in the middle of nowhere, so it was a nice change."

Catra pulled up in front of a massive building with a unique, modern architectural feature of having a slight inward curve. She shifted the car into park and unbuckled herself.

"This is some apartment building!" Adora was enthused but still not quite grasping the situation.

"I've got to hand off my key to the valet and I'll be back to help with the food," she explained quickly and hopped out before giving Adora a chance to question her.

Adora watched as the other woman talked with a uniformed man waiting at the bottom of the building. After an exchange of a friendly handshake followed by keys and some currency, Catra was on her way back over. She opened the car door for Adora and took from her the tray of milkshakes she was precariously balancing.

"Watch your step," she warned as Adora made her way out of the car and onto the sidewalk. She led her into the building and politely acknowledged the various staff that greeted her on their way towards the elevator.

Adora marveled at the lobby, having no idea what she was really in for. The open atrium was a far cry from the sad little apartment office that she had signed her lease in. It was all sleek, clean, and, despite it being *just* a lobby, she felt underdressed somehow. At least Catra was still wearing her big t-shirt and looking just as casual as she was in her athletic shorts and horse pun shirt.

When they entered the elevator, Catra slid a card, punched in a code on the interface, and then pressed the last button the panel-- a red one labeled C. Adora's mystified expression was hard to continue to ignore, but Catra did her best to look casual while the elevator rose.

Adora finally asked in confusion. "Is this actually your company's office or something?"

"Oh no," Catra gave a small laugh and looked away from her for a second. "Our complex is actually in a more rural area. Kind of inconvenient for commuting, but we wanted space to grow... and we needed it, turns out."

"Uh-huh," Adora watched as the floors continued to fly by. "You *really* live here?"

"Yeah, remember how I told you I wanted to talk to you about something?" she looked up at her and gave a self-conscious smile. "When you said 'your company,' you meant like... the company I work for right?" Adora nodded. "But, it's actually *my* company. I'm the CEO."

"Wow. That's really cool," she said cheerily, still not grasping the gravity of the admission. She had forgotten all about the pretense of "something to talk about," and when first hearing it brought up again she found herself worried it was a very early break-up talk.

As nervous as she was, Catra found herself laughing at her reaction thus far, "I like to think so, yeah. Helped me buy this place anyway." Finally, the elevator came to a stop and the doors opened.

Catra stepped in and reached her free arm back to hold the door to the elevator while Adora stood staring, wide-eyed and silent. Sunlight poured in from floor-to-ceiling windows that lined the outer walls offering a beautiful view of downtown. To her immediate left was a spiral staircase where a familiar fuzzy face was laying halfway up and looking down at her. Melog meowed and started down the stairs. The noise snapped Adora back into reality and she finally stepped in so the elevator could start its descent down.

“Hey buddy,” Catra called to the cat as he began circling the couple. She looked over to the barista who was still dumbfounded, “We'll give you the grand tour after lunch.” She started further into the condo and Adora followed along carefully.

The style was very modern with an open concept floorplan and a theme of white and gray that allowed pops of vibrant colors and interesting art pieces to soak up the attention. Catra brought them to a square table set for four that was by one of the windowed walls. She put the milkshakes on coasters, and then turned to Adora as she said nervously, “Gonna go grab some plates for us.” She nodded back. All this silence was killing her, especially considering how out of character it was for Adora. In the privacy of her kitchen, Catra made herself pause and do a breathing exercise before grabbing the plates and hurrying back. When she rejoined Adora at the table, she had at least taken a seat and was stroking Melog who was in her lap. Catra served up their food, tossed out the trash, and finally sat down.

Adora hugged the cat to her chest as she started to speak, “I made you stay in my dumb tiny apartment when you could’ve gone back here.“ She was tearing up in embarrassment, and Melog rubbed his head against her. She remembered how proud she had been of the things she had managed to buy for herself. It felt so silly now.

“What? No, don’t say that.” Catra wanted to hop up from her seat and cross the small distance to hug her, but knew she needed to give her space. “I loved it. I felt lucky that you asked me to stay. I’d go back there right now if you wanted.”

“I’m sorry, I don’t know why I’m so embarrassed,” Adora sniffled and then took a big drink of her chocolate milkshake. “I’m really happy for you. This is amazing. I just, oh man, I told you all that stuff about how I grew up…”

“From what you’ve said, it sounds like we grew up in pretty similar ways. It made me like you even more,” she started picking at her food, nervously tearing fries in half. “Only Entrapta, my co-founder, really knows this, but I was moved around in a couple different foster homes starting in elementary school. The family I ended up with at the end, they were nice, treated me well and all, but money was always tight. When I graduated high school, I was out on my own. I wasn’t trying to mislead you or...,” her voice started cracking. Fuck this is pathetic, she admonished herself internally.

Adora reached across the table and placed a hand onto hers to pause her greasy destruction, “Let’s eat and then talk more, okay? I’m not upset. I’m shocked is all. It's a lot to process when you find out your date is secretly rich,” she gave one of her silly smiles in another push to comfort her, “Plus if we wait any longer I think Melog is going to steal our food, and I’ll have to let him because I’m the cool mom.”

“As the nerdy mom, I have to remind you both French fries aren’t in his approved diet,” She was genuinely starting to relax now and actually began to eat. It felt like a weight was off her shoulders. Well, maybe *one* shoulder. Adora still didn’t know she was in the middle of a social media war.

After finishing up lunch, Adora helped Catra clean up and followed her into the kitchen. In the theme of the rest of the house, it was all sleek and pristine. “I don’t cook much these days,” Catra explained as the blonde looked around. “Or else it probably would look a little more used.”

“I can’t cook worth anything but if I lived here I think I’d learn,” Adora dreamed as she glided her hand on the cool marble of the counter.

“You’re welcome to practice here anytime,” Catra smirked as she closed up the dishwasher. “However, I reserve the right to order food if you make something inedible.”

“That’s more than fair I think,” Adora propped up against the island and stared out at the expanse of the city below them. From what she could tell, this was the tallest building in the area. Everything looked like ants busying about their days. “The view is gorgeous.”

“You should see it at night. That’s my favorite. I still haven't gotten over it," The idea of having someone... not someone, *Adora*, to spend her evenings with made her heart flutter. When had she gotten to be such a sap?

“Invitation accepted,” she winked. “Now about that tour?”

Catra reached for her hand and walked her through the bottom floor. She paused to explain some of her favorite art pieces, including one that she had done of Melog in space with a surrealistic style. “I like to find artists that aren’t a big name yet but I think should be. I commissioned this one from someone that was working part-time at our regular pet store after getting their BFA. I tweeted about it, tagged them, and bam. Now they’re in demand.”

“They deserve it,” Adora looked from the art over to Catra with such sincere adoration. “Being able to help people like that must be amazing."

“Yeah. It's hard to make it any industry really if you don’t have connections or you’re not the right ‘fit’ in their stupid fucking minds.” she explained. “Entrapta and I were lucky we found investors that were willing to take a chance on us, and our ideas actually worked. Don’t get me wrong, we worked our asses off and earned it, but there are a lot of deserving people that don’t get the opportunity to even try. That was a big part of my speech on Tuesday.”

“The speech!” Adora laughed to herself. “You know, I imagined you in a little conference room presenting a PowerPoint to like ten people. That’s probably not true, huh?”

Catra smirked and shook her head no. “It’s a little bigger deal than that.” She started towards another corner of the floor that was her living room area. The maroon sectional was eyecatching against the dark gray decor around it. However, it appeared as though it was directed to simply look at the view. Catra pulled out her phone and with a few taps, shades slowly covered the windows in the area and a massive screen lowered from the ceiling. She took her hand and led her around to get cozy on the couch. “Probably be easier to show you.”

With another swipe, the screen lit up and it was a still of Catra from behind looking out into a packed sea of people. “I was actually the keynote for the conference,” she explained before a thought occurred to her. “Why don’t you watch it, and I’ll go take a shower and change. I can’t stand listening to myself.”

“I wanted to even when I thought it was going to be a PowerPoint I wouldn’t understand,” Adora kissed her on the cheek. “And I was impressed with you then too.”

After calling for Melog to keep his new mother company, Catra turned on the video and left to head upstairs. She gave herself plenty of time to relax in the hot water of the shower so that she wouldn't have to go back downstairs before she knew the video was done. She really did hate listening to herself. DT always relistened to her various podcast and media appearances to provide her notes for the future instead. That was much preferable to cringing at her voice, as sexy as other people had told her it was (including one particularly complimentary barista she knew).

After cleaning up and brushing her teeth, she decided she wasn't done wearing Adora's shirt. It still smelled like her and being wrapped in it felt like a big hug from the blonde. She threw it back on with a pair of jeans, knotted the bottom to make it more stylishly fitted, and added a leather jacket to tie it together. She figured if the press was going to say she was a bad girl, she might as well look the part. Though, she did keep her 'nerdy' glasses on. Her eyes needed a break after the tortuous night.

She managed to time everything perfectly, because when she reached the main floor again there was the sound of applause as the video wrapped up. She quickly grabbed her phone to stop the autoplay. Knowing her luck it was going to be that stupid clip of Valerie. The screen and curtains lifted, inviting the light of the afternoon back in. Adora looked back at her over the top of the couch, Melog's head resting on her shoulder. Her face was wet from crying again.

"That was beautiful," she sniffled. "Catra, I'm just so proud of you."

"Thanks. I've not been told that in a while… it's nice." She said as she made her way over to join them. She leaned over the edge of the couch to kiss her upside down. "Do you want to know anything else about it?"

"Why didn't you want to tell me?" Adora spoke with a small voice, somewhere between hurt and confused.

Of course, Catra had anticipated this was going to be the question most at the center of the conversation. She sighed and pressed her forehead down against the cushion. "You get money, and suddenly everyone's so damn fake and in your business. I hated it. That's why I go to your Starbucks, I've never been recognized there. It's mostly college kids, I blend in better." She tilted her head so she was peeking out over at her. "Me not telling you? That wasn't because of you at all. I *never* thought you would be that kind of person. My mind says some pretty awful shit to me. I got burned once, and it made me think no one actually would want to be with me for anything but the money. Then, you came along… and I started to believe that wasn't true."

"I really, really like the real you," Adora assured her, reaching over to run her fingers through her partially damp hair, "I'd still want to date you if you were broke tomorrow. You and Melog could come live in Casa Adora."

Anyone else making such a declaration would probably sound fake, and she'd never take them seriously. Not Adora though. "Good to know my boy and I won't be on the streets," she turned her head away briefly to wipe her teary eyes before Adora noticed. "How about I show you my favorite part of this place now?"

"Absolutely," Adora gave the cat one last hug and then placed him carefully onto the couch before getting up.

Catra led her up the winding staircase into the master bedroom. Much like downstairs, it featured the same grand windows and view. Only instead of being a second floor, it was actually an addition built onto the roof. Outside the glass was a pool, a small garden, lounging areas, and a tropical-themed bar.

“I kind of have a thing for being up high,” she explained as she opened a door and led her out onto the roof.

“Oh, I see why you like me now. You need a tall girl like me to lift you up, hmm?” She smiled smugly before returning to the same doe-eyed wonder she had since entering her home.

“Yes, why else would I like you, dummy? It's not like you check every box on my list or anything,” Catra watched with lust in her eyes as the wind whipped through Adora’s hair and the sun glowed on her exposed, toned arms and legs. To tell the truth, she checked boxes Catra didn't even know she had until she saw those abs the night before. She shook her head and scolded herself that she needed to focus. “I want to make this official, whatever it is we’re doing here.”

“I think it’s called falling in love, but I’m a romantic,” Adora teased and gave a wink before getting serious. “Of course, I want to be your girlfriend. I’ve wanted to since the moment I saw you.”

“Same,” Catra tried not to panic too hard at the initial joke. Focus. “There’s something else we need to talk about, but we have to go back inside. I can’t think with you out here looking like a goddess.”

“That’s so embarrassing for you,” she teased while striking a pose that showed her muscles and caused her shirt to lift up slightly.

After Catra managed to drag herself away from the sight, they snuggled up in her bed and she hit a command that brought a screen down as it had downstairs. “Remember that woman you saved me from?”

“Yes, we hate her,” Adora confirmed.

Catra sent up the article from The Times that had detailed the initial fascination with the two. “One stupid minute and someone managed to get a shot that makes it look like we’re a thing,” she explained. “And, for reasons beyond me, people loved it. It was trending, and there’s tons of these articles. Then, Valerie, because she’s a desperate leech, decided to keep up the act.” She swapped over to the follow-up articles with the pictures from her keynote, and Valerie’s interview snippet.

“What the fuck,” Adora growled after the video stopped. “Who does that?! She’s a trash person. That’s what Glimmer would say.”

“I agree,” Catra smirked and then sighed. “Apparently by the time I got home, everyone thought this was the lesbian love story of our generation. There’s a whole hashtag.” She showed twitter next with Valtra searched. She shuddered when she noticed that included in the media section was some fanart of the two of them in rather compromising positions.

“Oh gross!!” Adora averted her eyes. “What is wrong with people?!”

“Thank you for your horror. My PR person tried to make it sound like this was a normal thing for people to do,” she shook her head. “So, here’s where it gets even more complicated.” She swapped to the ‘Bad Girl’ article DT was so amused by.

“Wait, what? That’s us,” Adora’s eyes got big at the mirror selfie that revealed the two of them against the wall. Adora’s hand that wasn't in Catra's hair was low and out of frame. She knew it was just on her hip, but… god, it looked much more scandalous. “Why would someone post a picture of people they don’t even know?! This is why I don’t do social media!”

“The girl took the picture as a joke, but someone who follows her must have recognized me. Then it was everywhere. If it makes you feel better, you have your own hashtag too,” she swapped to the Team Blondie twitter feed. “DT, that’s my PR head, said this is why I can’t ignore it. Valerie’s making it look like I ditched her and the conference to go fool around in a club bathroom with you… which, I guess is half true.”

“The Bad Girl of Big Tech, it makes sense now.” She had hopped off the bed and was standing closer to the screen to examine the images as Catra scrolled through. “I like my team. They clearly have taste. Oh, stop! Look!” She pointed at an image. Of course, it was the one of Catra as a catgirl with magical muscles Adora. “This one’s really cute. I wanna heart it.” She tried uselessly to touch the nontouch screen.

“Ugh, okay, whatever,” Catra mumbled as she liked the tweet on Adora’s behalf from her account. “I can’t wait for all the cat pun articles that are going to come from this. Anyway, I thought you should know. It turns out this is the price of admission if you want to be with me. It's a lot of ridiculous shit all of a sudden and it might be a while til this whole thing blows over. My PR people aren’t going to involve you at all if you want to opt-out.”

Adora turned back around and climbed into the gigantic fluffy bed with her. “No, I’m all in. I’m your girlfriend, and this is hurting you. If she wants a war…” she furrowed her brow and did her best attempt at looking rather intimidating. “Team Blondie will answer.”

“How can that be so stupid and hot at the same time?" Catra should have been starting to come down off of her anxiety with everything finally revealed and accepted, but instead, her heart was racing for entirely new reasons.

Adora noticed the shift in her demeanor as Catra’s face covered in a blush and her breathing picked up. She seized the opportunity to climb on top of her new girlfriend. “Maybe that can be my brand," she had dropped into a low and sultry voice as she leaned down and brushed her lips against her neck.

As though summoned by the mere mention of a brand, Catra’s phone started going off and it was DT’s ringtone. “What timing,” she mumbled to herself. “It's my PR lead. As much as I'd rather continue this conversation, I’ve got to take this.”

“Oooh, good, we need a battle plan,” Adora rolled off of her again and propped up beside her.

Catra answered, “Hey, DT.”

“I assume you and Blondie had the talk," they said knowingly on the other end.

“Yes, she said she's in," Catra looked over at Adora whose eyes lit with determination.

“I WANT TO DESTROY HER,” she yelled.

“Loving the energy,” DT laughed, “Okay, swap to video. I need to share my screen.” Catra did as told and DT’s computer was now projected onto the big screen. “Aw, look at you two,” they said as now they saw in return Adora pushed in next to Catra on the bed. “Our bad girl and barista homewrecker. Precious.”

They showed a page that was a draft of an article that included paparazzi photos of Catra going into work in Adora’s shirt looking hungover and disheveled, the two of them grabbing burgers, and Catra helping her out of the car. “This was shared to me before publishing as a courtesy slash bargaining

chip. We've got two alternative takes here. The one they're prepared to run is continuing the cheating, party girl angle. I'm sure little miss Valerie has already given some choice quotes. They are *also* amenable to running an exclusive about the truth. Apparently, they're the only ones with someone in town following you, kitten. No one else has these photos."

"Kitten," Adora repeated and giggled before putting her game face back on. "We'll do it."

"Well aren't you easy to work with. I knew I was Team Blondie for a reason." DT laughed. They directed their attention to Catra who was amused to watch the two interact. "Get down here as soon as you can so we can chat strategy, and I'll set up an interview before the end of the news day. Adora, darling, I love an ironic shirt as much as anybody, but we're going to need something different. Get my number and text me your sizes and I'll have one of my assistants round up a few options for you. Okay? Okay. Bye, lovebirds."

"Bye," the barista replied back for the two of them.

"Oh, and I pulled the kill switch on your Twitter for now. It's for your own good. Val Pal's little fans are not loving that like, and she's having her own moment right now retweeting some bullshit," DT remarked just before hanging up.

Sure enough, when Catra pulled up her social media accounts she realized she had been logged out of not just Twitter but everything. "Fucking hell," she grumbled, breaking her last few minutes of silence, "We literally just did that. How did that happen so fast?"

"Team Blondie will not be muzzled," Adora proclaimed. "How do I Twitter?"

Chapter End Notes

This version of these two goofs is really fun to write. Finally, next chapter we'll get a more in-depth look at Catra and Entrapta's business. And more importantly... what will Adora tweet? Will anyone see it? Has she already ordered a t-shirt with the Catra catgirl art?

Comments give me life. Thank you!

Adjust Your Clocks

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora tackle their first public appearance and set the record straight on their relationship.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra covered her face in disbelief as she chuckled to herself. "Seriously, Adora?"

"Yes," she declared as she began an attempt to locate her phone in her bag. "As soon as I figure this out, I will out hashtag her!"

"I have an idea," Catra deflected, trying to give herself time to let DT intervene in the other woman's attempt. It was too cute to see Adora all fired up like this on her behalf, and she couldn't be the person to tell her no. "Why don't you drive us over to the complex, and I'll set up your Twitter for you on the way?"

Adora's whole face suddenly lit up like a kid in a candy store. "I can drive the spaceship? Are you sure? I'm not exactly known for being a great driver."

"If you'd like to." Catra shrugged and tried to play off her pride in the next statement. "Darla's smart enough to keep you from crashing, and if you somehow manage it... well, we've got a whole garage of new models on-site."

"Oh, that's right. I forgot already, ha," she turned Catra's chin to look her in the eyes as she dropped her playful tone, "My sexy CEO," she purred.

Catra knew that they were under strict orders to leave but staring back into those blue eyes and letting cloying tone wash over her, she was done for. Why should she let something as insignificant as Valerie keep her from enjoying the first time seeing Adora in her bed anyway? Catra closed the distance between them, drawing their lips together into a kiss charged with the fire of hearing Adora claim her as her own. She slid a hand under her ridiculous horse shirt to ghost her fingertips along the ridges of her abs.

Adora returned the kiss, lips parting as they explored each other, teeth pausing to nibble. The feeling of Catra's hands on her stomach made her shiver, and all she wanted was to feel her touch everywhere. Adora brought one of her hands up and clawed her fingers through her hair to bring forward and eliminate every bit of space that was separating them. The other hand found its way under Catra's shirt, *her* shirt, holding her by the small of her back.

Eventually, they were brought back into reality via Catra's phone going off again. She groaned as she finally broke away from the kiss to grab it.

Text from DT: You know, I can tell you haven't left yet.

"Of course. I forgot I share my location with them," Catra complained as she relayed the message.

The two finally got up from the bed, sent off the required information to DT, and made their way downstairs. Before leaving, Adora insisted that they check in on their son, and they found Melog snoozing on a window seat. The barista mews'd over how a cat had a better view of downtown than all the humans who lived there (get it? mused?). Satisfied with the contentment of their child, they called up the elevator and entered, holding hands.

"Wait," Adora thought aloud, "Do you think whoever is taking pictures of us is still out there?"

"Ugh, probably," Catra complained. "I could ask the building people to do something about it, but I'm sure they're using a zoom lens somewhere."

"If we can't beat them, we better give them a show then," Adora tapped her chin and thought.

The lobby was only a few stops away at this point. "And what exactly does that --" Catra got out as the blonde slipped one arm behind her back and the other at her knees. Before she knew it, she had her arms wrapped around Adora's neck as she was hoisted into the air. "I'm not sure this is good for the rumors," she laughed, snuggling into her closer. "Now, I'm a day drunk who has to be carried around by her sidepiece."

"I'm not worried about the rumors. I want *her* to have to see this," Adora kissed her on the cheek, and the doors finally opened.

They got a few looks from the various staff in the lobby, but they casually waved as though it wasn't unusual. Catra made Adora put her down by the desk so that she could ask them to make a keycard for her, you know, for emergencies or whatever. As soon as that was settled, she was captured by strong arms again. Adora carried her all the way outside to wait on the valet.

"You're really not putting me down until the car comes," Catra asked incredulously as she swung her legs slightly in amusement. "Aren't your arms tired?"

"I've been training for this moment all my life," Adora teased. "What are muscles for, if not carrying beautiful women?"

Finally, the valet brought the car around, and Adora let the other woman down on her feet gently. She opened the door for her and then slipped over to the other side. The seat automatically adjusted to her, which was needed relief from Catra's short-legged settings. The blonde analyzed the complicated interface in confusion.

"How do I do this?" She felt too scared that she might accidentally hit a button that meant self-destruct.

"Technically speaking, you don't have to do much of anything. She'll drive herself," Catra reached over and, with a few taps on the screen, had the navigation programmed for her work address.

"But it looked like you were driving," Adora noted, recalling their ride earlier.

"Yeah, I was, but *I* have a bit of a thing about control," Catra admitted.

"Is that so," Adora asked cheekily. "Maybe I do too. This could be a problem for us."

"I'm sure we can come to some kind of arrangement." Focus, Catra, focus, she reminded herself. Something about this woman made her logical mind slip away. She bit back her desire and instead

made a few updates on the screen. "Autopilot's off. Just drive like usual. Now give me your phone, and I'll get to work on this whole Twitter thing."

Adora handed it over, carefully shifted into drive, and they were off.

"How do you use this," Catra complained as she tried to pull up the app store on Adora's phone. The screen had a spiderweb of cracks, and the model was several years behind. "You're going to slice up your fingers."

"Hey, rude," Adora whined as she took her eyes off the road for a second. The car yelled at her, and so she focused forward again. "I've still got a couple of months on my plan before I can upgrade. I cracked it, gosh, a month into owning it, I think. I'm pretty used to it."

Catra immediately felt guilty for making fun of the phone. Before launching Darla, she had been using the same busted up phone for years too. She decided to move past it quickly and not belabor the topic. "Okay, the app is downloaded. What do you want your username to be?"

"Oh, gosh, it can be whatever you want?"

"Yeah, as long as it's available. Before you ask, Adora is not," she had already tried that one.

"Shoot! That was my best idea," she laughed as she turned onto a road heading out of town. "Hmm... what do you think?" Before Catra got a chance to answer, she gasped. "I've got it! Try IAdoraCatra. Get it? Cause I *adore* you, and that's why I'm twittering."

"That is so dumb," Catra scoffed, trying to play it cool. As stupid as it was, her heart did jump at the statement. "Of course, it's available. Are you sure?"

"That's the one," Adora confirmed happily. "Okay, what next?"

"You need a profile picture if you want," Catra noted. "Can I look through your pictures?"

"Sure, if you promise not to make fun of all my selfies. Pick whatever you want."

Going through Adora's photos, she found herself wishing she could see all of the cute pictures without jagged lines across them. "Hey, Adora?" Adora answered her with a hum. "What's your favorite color?"

"Ooh, you get to set the color? Yellow." She enjoyed driving even more now that they were beyond the relentless stoplights of downtown. Everything about the vehicle was so smooth, something she had never experienced in her history of used cars. She owned a car once that overheated at stoplights. That made for some tricky maneuvers.

"Good to know," Catra noted and finally landed on a photo that she wanted to set as the woman's main photo, if only so she could see it whenever she wanted. It was a selfie she had taken on some sunny day, her hair aglow and the smile on her face genuine and warm. "Okay, I think you're good to get into your first social media war now." She slid the phone away into Adora's bag and picked her own back up to take care of a few things.

As they drove down the country road, Adora had rolled the windows down to enjoy the wind whipping around them. After some persistent pleading, she even got Catra to sing along with her to some oldies station she found on the satellite radio. When they finally pulled up to the complex, the woman in the guard station looked at her unfamiliar face in confusion. Catra leaned up and waved from the passenger side, and they were quickly ushered through with apologies. "I'll have to get you a

permanent visitor badge," Catra shot off a quick email to the appropriate person. "Of course, you'll have to pledge to keep all our secrets. We maintain pretty tight security around here."

"Hmm. I *suppose* I can agree to do that. You aren't secretly creating machines to take over the world, are you?"

"I can't confirm or deny that until you sign," Catra winked.

The pair held hands after exiting the car and headed into the main building of the large complex. As they walked through the atrium, Adora noticed people in the glass-walled offices staring at them in amusement as they exchanged whispers. She found herself feeling a mixture of embarrassment and pride as she wondered if Catra had brought any previous dates or partners else here. She sincerely hoped not, as unlikely as it seemed.

"If it isn't miss Blondie herself," a female voice called from down another corridor.

They turned in unison to look over at the other woman. She had her brown locs pulled back in a ponytail and was wearing protective coveralls halfway unzipped and wrapped around her waist revealing a gray button-up underneath.

"Adora, this is Lonnie," Catra gestured to the woman. "She's our lead engineer and union steward."

"Nice to meet you, Adora," Lonnie said as they shook hands. "Union's my favorite part, personally. I have the honor of telling this one when she's fucking up."

"Someone's gotta keep this bad girl in line," Adora joked. Lonnie burst into laughter, and the CEO sighed.

"I approve, boss." Lonnie winked, and she patted Catra on the shoulder before started back off along her way. "You better get down to PR. DT's preparing for the end of the world."

Adora couldn't imagine having such a comfortable relationship with her immediate boss, much less a CEO. "She seems really cool. Are you friends with everyone who works here?"

"Not everybody, but Lonnie's the first person we brought in. We're pretty close," Catra explained, opening a door for Adora as she reached the PR department finally. "Entrapta and I knew what we were doing with the programming and AI aspects, but our initial car designs weren't anything special. Lonnie fixed that."

When they opened the door to DT's office, they were surprised to find the space already very occupied. "Finally," DT looked up from the top that one of their assistants was showing them. "Alright, everybody out. I'll call you back in before curtain call."

Once the crowd dispersed, Catra realized that Entrapta was sitting behind DT's desk. "Catra! Greetings." She said happily as she got up and went to join them. "My apologies, it seems my risk benefits analysis was inaccurate. I did not take into account your social life."

"That's because kitten normally doesn't have a social life," DT noted offhandedly, continuing to pick through the various outfits. Catra made a grumbling noise in response, she couldn't defend herself against the accurate read.

"Yes, this is correct," Entrapta nodded. She turned her attention to Adora. "Hello, Blondie is not your real name, is it? I ask because my name is Entrapta and everyone wants to know if it is my real name. And *it is* !"

"Adora, nice to meet you," she tightened her grip on Catra's hand. "I'm so sorry for causing all these problems. I had no idea."

"Hey, you did nothing wrong," Catra assured her and squeezed her hand back.

"It's true. Based on my calculations, the amount of blame you share is minuscule." She assured her in her uniquely Entrapta way. "Good luck with the press! DT walked me through the data, and I do believe it will have a good outcome."

This evaluation honestly did lower Catra's mounting nerves about the interview. "Thanks," she said as she held out her hand, and the two co-founders exchanged a complicated handshake that made Adora smirk.

Once Entrapta had closed the door behind her, they sat down in front of DT's desk. They had already pulled up a new presentation of images on the large screen behind them. "Catra, dear, what a relief to see you can walk," they noted as a few spy shots appeared of Adora carrying Catra out of the building. "Quite the display! It's almost as though you weren't alerted by your amazing PR lead that you were being followed." They made eyes at Catra. "Talk about job security for me, at least! Alright, Adora, I have heard a bit of this from our mutual friend. Tell me the story of, wait for it," they swapped over to a screen of large text, "Catradora."

"Oh that's perfect," Adora cheered. "It sounds so cool. Right?" She looked at Catra with a big smile on her face, expecting enthusiastic approval.

"Um, yeah, it's great," Catra honestly would prefer no hashtag name, but there was no way she was going to say no when she saw how excited Adora was. "Anything's better than Valtra."

"Exactly. Now, woo me with the tales of your young love forged in caffeine and yearning," DT brought up a document to take notes.

Adora looked to Catra, who gave her a nod. "I met Catra on my first day being on the floor. My friends were gushing about her on the headset, how she's a good regular, and I turned, and there she was." She detailed to DT all of how the two had been finding little moments throughout her days at work: the crosswords that Adora always had an answer or two for, Catra's help with her Latin homework, the CEO taste-testing some of her experimental beverages while pretending to like them. Finally, she arrived on the morning of the conference when Adora got the courage to give her her number.

"There's plenty here to work with," DT nodded approvingly, looking back over what they had written. "We've got a lot of options to establish that you two were well into whatever this meet-cute situation was before that one minute with Valerie. Do you mind sharing your texts if they came up? Nothing too scandalous yet?"

Catra smirked. "Scandalous? No. Stupid? Yes." She already had her phone out and was looking through them. "I dunno, Adora, you've got some pretty bad jokes in here. I'm not sure if you want to share that with everyone."

"Pfft, I'm proud of my puns," Adora nudged her shoulder and started giggling, "They're very punny."

"I can't wait to unleash you on the world," Catra let out a few raspy laughs.

"I like this chemistry," DT looked over while typing furiously. "Okay, they are going to have some tough questions, I'm sure. One, they'll want to test you on if you knew the truth about our cash kitten

here. You never searched for her name?"

"I'm not a big techie person; searching for her didn't even cross my mind, honestly." Adora looked at DT then at the other woman to confirm. "My friends that work there have no idea too. She doesn't... what's the word? Flaunt it."

"I can believe that," DT laughed to themselves. "I think this is why the press is eating this up. She's been so boringly responsible with her money and life. Finally, they have something of a scandal."

"Just talk about me like I'm not here," Catra complained, mostly to herself.

"Sorry, calling it as I see it. Any objections?" DT looked over Catra, who shook her head no. "Perfect. Next, Adora, they'll probably want to know how you feel now that you know? Are you going to be claws in now that you've bagged yourself a multi-millionaire? Ready to quit Starbucks and school for the good life?"

Catra found herself getting defensive with this line of questioning. It felt delicate and private. Of course, if Adora wanted her to take care of her, she'd be more than happy to. The fantasies she'd already had about spoiling her were too many to count. The only problem was this was all happening at once. She never planned for it to be like this. To keep herself from obviously spiraling, she got up from her seat and went over to the rack of potential outfits. She started flipping through them as though she was unbothered by the topic at hand.

"I really like my job, and I'm passionate about what I'm in school for," Adora answered quickly. "We just started dating, you know. I'm not expecting anything." She laughed. "I'm excited that she's my girlfriend, period."

"You are a sincere little thing. How refreshing," DT said and then swapped their screen to show a feed of Valerie's tweets. "On the opposite end, I present little miss Valerie. I thought you both might want to know what she's been into today."

ValerieSHarper: [Youtube Video: You Belong with Me - Taylor Swift]

ValerieSHarper: If only I had a time machine. I'd go back to that first kiss, and I'd never let you go.

ValerieSHarper: If we could put our minds together, I bet we could make one. We could do anything, if only you'd let us.

[retweet]: make it work you big brain lesbians. my fave aesthetic #TeamValtra

[retweet]: how can it be wrong when you look so cute together #TeamValtra [media attachment: poorly drawn fanart]

[retweet]: she likes being a cat? we can do it better #TeamValtra #CatgirlCatra #myqueens [media attachment: remarkably well-drawn fanart of Catra as a catgirl in a throne with Valerie sitting on her lap]

ValerieSHarper: Thank you to my sweet followers for your support during these difficult times. I'm still holding out for my happy ending to this story! [prayer hands emoji]

ValerieSHarper: Poll: Should I call? *Results:* [Yes 67%] [No: 33%]

[retweet]: Prayer Circle for #TeamValtra [gif of prayer circle from Big Brother]

Adora read over the tweets and clenched her fists in her lap. "You belong with me by Taylor Swift?! Seriously! This rich girl is trying to out underdog me," she raised one of her fists and waggled it at the screen. "She's just making all of this up. It's so pathetic."

Catra's face was hot as she looked up from the clothes she pretended to examine and read over the tweets. It wasn't all made up. "I'm done with this, DT. Do we have to go through every stupid thing?" She swung her arms at the screen. One of her eyes was twitching again. "Can't we do this god damn interview so I can go back to doing my actual job?"

"Catra," DT said in a measured voice as they eyed her, recognizing the tell-tale signs of her anxiety getting the best of her---something they hadn't seen in a long while. "Why don't you go to the garden? I'm setting up the interview there. I'll finish prepping Adora, and she'll be out in a few minutes. Okay? Okay. Now go."

"Fine," she quietly answered and felt defeated as she headed out of the room. It was for the best. She didn't like that Adora had seen her like this in the first place, no need to make it worse.

After she left Adora looked at DT with concern. "Maybe I should go talk to her," she offered, and started to get up before they stopped her.

"No, darling, you stay here. She needs few minutes alone to collect herself. She knows it, that's why she left," they explained. "It's why I insisted that the architect make a tranquility garden in the first place. She'll be fine. Cool as a cucumber under normal work stress, you know. She's worked up because she likes you and she's blaming herself for having fun for once in her life. I'm telling you, she's normally a bore in regards to gossip. She's done exactly one reckless thing since I've worked here. Has she told you about the arcade?" Adora shook her head no. "Now that's a funny true story, but the press didn't pick it up. Shame!"

Catra took up her usual spot in the tranquility garden, laying on her back on the edge of a fountain and staring up at the sky. She focused on the sound as she closed her eyes, trying to suppress unwanted thoughts that were bubbling up. Thoughts of a balcony, the cold night air, and the feeling of her first kiss. Years of pent-up desire poured out towards the exact wrong person as she crashed through the truth. How she'd closed herself off entirely after that just to have it fuck her over when she finally opened up again. It wasn't... Focus, Catra.

By the time she had finally gotten her mind settled, she was roused by a sweet voice above her. "This place is gorgeous," Adora leaned down and kissed her quickly. "I promise DT didn't torture me or tell me any secrets. Well, actually, they did tell me to ask about an arcade, but that can wait. Oh! And they said I could tweet whatever I want after the interview! I can't wait to punch that jerk technologically."

Catra sat back up on the edge and gently took Adora's hand to lead her to sit down beside her. "She has no idea what she's in for," she joked half-heartedly.

"Are you okay?" Adora cuddled in beside her, sneaking a hand underneath her jacket to run up and down her back soothingly.

"She pisses me off so much," Catra stared down at her shoes, not wanting to meet her blue eyes. She felt like crying, but she forced herself to maintain control. She wasn't going to be all red-eyed and puffy during this thing. "I'm not the bad guy here. The kiss thing? That's so fucking low. She was my first kiss, and she *knows* that."

"Oh," Adora thought about this for a moment. She hadn't considered that the pair had anything between them other than the dancing and Valerie's clear obsession. "Did you.. two.. you know, were you a couple?"

"No," Catra answered quickly, shaking her head low. "We went back to my room and kissed, but I had to step out to meet with Entrapta. I came back in time to hear her bragging to her friends about hitting the jackpot. I'd be her *pet* millionaire when she was done with me."

"If I see her in person, I really will hit her. Is it too much to ask you to cover my bail?" Adora joked, happy to see Catra's smirk returning to her face. "I vote we do this interview, I'll tweet my heart out while you drive back, we'll pick up something really delicious to eat, and the second we step inside your place we're going to forget about her. She's dead to us."

"I like this plan," Catra finally took a moment to realize that Adora had changed into one of DT's picks for her. She was wearing a long-sleeve white blouse with gold detailing and a pair of dark jeans. It was finished with matching gold-trimmed white sneakers that she knew were going to be Adora's favorite. "I see you've been upgraded from Watch me Neigh Neigh. How do you feel?"

"I think it had more personality, but I like this too. Look at these shoes," she kicked her feet out. "I'm going to have buy some like these!"

"Um, Adora," Catra chuckled. "You can have all of this. The other stuff from the racks too. Anything you want."

"Whoa," she contemplated. "But, wait, is that coming out of Darla's budget?! I can't do that, that's not right."

"Of course not, dummy. This would be on me," Catra confirmed. "If you want anyway... if not, that's okay too."

"I do," Adora said after a long time of staring at her shoes. She figured they must be worth a week of part-time work at Starbucks. "I meant what I said, though. I don't expect you to take care of me. That's not what this is about."

"I know that. But... if you want something, I'd love to give it to you."

"I'd love another kiss."

"You're such an idiot," Catra teased before her lips covered Adora's, and her hands became entangled in her recently styled hair.

"Wow! This is great!" a voice vaguely familiar to the CEO called, followed by snapping noises.

Catra tore herself away from the kiss to look over at the source of the noise. It was the kid from The Times.

"Wait, you're the one stalking me," Catra asked with a raised eyebrow.

"No, not stalking, Ms. Catra. I'm with the press, remember?" Kyle pointed at his badge. "They sent me because I was one of the only interviews you gave this week. They think we have a good rapport!"

"Why would anyone think that," Catra grumbled.

"Because sweet Kyle is willing to broadcast the truth for us," DT came up from behind the young man and patted him on the shoulder. "Alright, my love birds, I'm told we're set up and ready to go. They will air a video teaser tonight online, and the rest will be in print tomorrow. Catra, we'll need to get you in make-up--" she narrowed her eyes at them, clearly done. " *Never* , because look at that natural beauty. Who could improve it? Am I right, Blondie?"

"Right," Adora grabbed her hand, and they stood up together. "Let's do this!"

Finally, DT and Kyle led them over to the spot for the interview. They were directed to sit on a bench together in front of a selection of colorful flower bushes. While the sound team went to work mic-ing them up, Adora never let go of Catra's hand. She squeezed it from time to time as a quick check-in, her wordless promise about it almost being over.

Kyle began, reading off of cue cards to start, "We are joined here this evening by Catra, CEO of Darla Industries, and the woman everyone wants to know more about, whether you're Team Valtra or Team Blondie. So, who are you?"

"My name is Adora," she looked over to Catra with love in her eyes, "And I'm Catra's barista. She's my favorite customer."

"Yep," Catra smirked. "We've been starting our days together for weeks now."

"Oh, and I'm her girlfriend," Adora added as she turned back to Kyle with a wink.

Once again, they detailed the way that their relationship had come together. They took turns back and forth, joking about the ways they had found to flirt and how Adora had slipped her number onto the cardboard sleeve. Just like DT had imagined, Kyle asked about her intentions around her new girlfriend's money. Adora delivered her truth even more charmingly than before. DT thumbed up at her from behind Kyle. As planned, Catra found a moment to pull out her phone and showcase some of the dorky texts they had been exchanging.

"Brewing for you," Kyle repeated and laughed. "That's a good one!"

"I'm glad someone appreciates it," Adora nudged her girlfriend.

"Catra," he looked towards the brunette, who stiffened up again. "What do you make of Valerie Harper's claims of a relationship with you? Were you two an item at the same time?"

"I think that Ms. Harper is either confused or willfully misleading herself and her following. As I've already stated to you on the record, I spoke with her for less than a minute on Monday. In fact," she pointed at her phone, "You'll see me text Adora to call me because I needed an out. The time should line up with the timestamp of the photos."

"Wow," Kyle noted as he read over that bit. "What a twist! So you and Valerie never kissed? Valtra is all a lie?"

Catra should've been ready for this. Hell, it was her own damn fault she wasn't. DT tried to prepare her, and she stomped out like a child. Her face went blank as she spiraled, trying to think of a good answer.

"Valtra is old news," Adora swooped in for her without skipping a beat. "It's Catradora time now. Adjust your clocks, people!"

"Exactly," Catra giggled at the dumb joke, and everything felt lighter again. She'd been dreaming of taking care of Adora, but here she was saving her.

"Adora, what would you like to say to Valerie? When reached for comment about the photos we've obtained of you two, she had some choice words about your relationship. She said, and I quote, 'Clearly my dear Catra needs something more meaningless right now. I'm sure she is overwhelmed with work. I have faith she'll see this simple girl is in it for anything but her heart.' "

Catra almost opened her mouth, but a strong squeeze from Adora kept her silent.

"I would like to say to Ms. Harper, best wishes on finding your own Catra. This one is mine." She was so divinely calm and spoke with the polish of a well-trained politician. "Thank you, Kyle and The Times, for letting us set the record straight."

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter, we'll get to the sugar daddy of it all... oh, and check in with Glimbow, of course! Do you think Adora gave them a heads up or do they find out from a news clip?

This chapter took a little longer to write out, been a bit busy. Hope it was worth the wait! Thoughts, feedback, and all are always appreciated. Thanks for reading!

Also, is it really a Catradora tale from MotherofChimeras if I haven't found an excuse to make Adora bridal carry Catra?

Making the Moment Right

Chapter Summary

> Catradora wrap up their eventful day one of their official relationship with DT wisdom, Adora meeting the Internet, tacos for dinner, and some much needed relaxation for the CEO.

Chapter Notes

> We're officially moving into explicit territory here at the end of this chapter. I updated the rating to reflect this. There's not a ton of necessary plot info in it, so you can skip it if that's not your thing!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Kyle and his crew began packing up their equipment, and DT was hovering nearby to check in with the young journalist. No doubt using their charm to sneak some insight into his interview perception. Catra and Adora were still sitting on the bench together, even after all of their sound equipment was taken.

"You were amazing, Adora," Catra leaned in to whisper in her ear once they were alone. She kissed her on the cheek and continued, "Sorry that you have to deal with all this shit. I hope I'm worth it."

"You are." The way she looked at her as she said it, Catra believed it.

"Alright, my dear Catradora," DT said as they turned their attention to the women, "Before you start making out again, we should debrief in my office." Without waiting for a response, they spun on their impossibly high, thin heels and started off to the main building.

The couple followed along after, hustling to catch up with DT's purposeful power walk. Most of the employees had gone home at this point. Those that were still there had lingered to watch the unusual situation play out. Catra walked with her head up, confidently meeting eyes with anyone who looked her way. The last thing she needed was to lose the faith of her actual company. Thankfully, they seemed warm and bemused. Maybe they were happy for her, she imagined. She had *always* been the forever single one at various company social events. If there were negative gossip about her or incoming instability, Entrapta would inform her. It would undoubtedly be delivered with precisely zero sugar coating or twist. It was one of her favorite qualities of her co-founder.

When they entered DT's office, the various clothing selected for Adora had already been folded and bagged for her to take home. The blonde tried not to look too giddy about it. It felt wrong to be visibly excited, but is it wrong to enjoy the perks of a rich girlfriend?

"I would give that performance a standing ovation," DT informed them proudly as they all took their seats. "Personally, if I had any doubts about your situation, it would certainly have convinced me that this is the real thing."

"But," Catra raised an eyebrow. "There's always a but."

"Of course, there's a but. You lead with praise. It's called a compliment sandwich, darling," DT winked and then looked over to their computer. " *But* you need to be very aware of your image right now. I'll give you back your socials on Monday but keep it work-related for now. Adora, I know I promised you carte blanche on Twitter, but I trust that you aren't going on there to start tweeting fuck you at this woman. Given how you nailed that ending comment after her vicious excuse for one, you can handle that, yes?"

"Is calling her a dumb face off the table?" Adora asked very seriously.

"You can subtweet that. I'm sure Catra can explain that concept to you," DT winked. "We need everything to go back to business as usual. That means, madam CEO, you need to be here on campus looking like the millions of bucks you're worth. Especially since the world knows where your 'work from home' spot is."

"Got it," Catra nodded without much resistance. She *had* gotten distracted in the last couple of weeks working at Starbucks. She could look forward to seeing Adora outside of the coffee shop now, after all.

"Adora, chances are your store is going to be extra popular for a while. Remember, there's nothing wrong with a little 'no comment.' You can also defer them to me," DT handed over their business card to the barista. "I represent Catradora, which means I represent you now."

"Oh wow," Adora looked over the card. "I never thought I'd need a PR person for anything."

"Welcome to the good life," Catra teased sarcastically. "DT was the second person we hired after Lonnie."

"And I've been worth every penny, right, kitten?"

"Eh," she shrugged indifferently.

"So sweet. You can feel the love, right?" DT rested their chin on their hands as they looked at her, "I can't decide if we're best friends or basically siblings. Blondie, go ahead and pencil me into the Catradora wedding party. I can be persuaded to be on whoever's side has the better outfit."

"I hate you," Catra mumbled as she started to blush again. God, she figured she had blushed more times in the last couple of weeks than she had in her whole life combined.

"Siblings, it is!" DT winked again.

After they collected Adora's clothes and Catra's assistant dropped off another bag, the two finally were on their way out of the Darla complex. Both breathed a heavy sigh of relief once they settled into the car.

"Before we get going," Catra grabbed for the small bag her assistant gave her and pulled out a box that she handed over to Adora. "I wanted to make up for teasing you earlier about your phone."

"Wait what," Adora's eyes went wide as she looked at the box. It was a brand-new phone in yellow. "Oh my gosh, seriously? Catra, I don't know if I can take this."

"Yes, you can, dummy," the CEO laughed to herself. "You need it, I can give it to you. Why not take it? Plus, now you have the right equipment for the war you're getting yourself into for me. Unlimited

data and all that stuff; I'll take care of it. We can get your old number changed to it if you want."

"Thank you," Adora reached over and hugged her. "I promise I'll try not to always be so weird about this. I just don't want to feel like a burden."

"You will never be a burden to me. Taking care of you makes me feel good." She returned the hug before starting the car. "I have to admit I *am* getting something out of this too."

Adora had started into the box now and looked like a kid at their birthday party. "And what's that?" She gave a coy smile.

"Ah, well, now the next time you need to send me a terrible pun picture, it'll be high enough quality that I can get the dumb thing printed on a canvas. It'll be my next great conversation piece. I'll hang it with space Melog."

Adora looked very amused at this idea. "Can we host an unveiling party?"

"Absolutely," Catra smirked. It occurred to the CEO that it would be the first party she had at her home if such a thing were to happen. DT and Entrapta weren't wrong with their takes on her social life, even if she wouldn't admit that out loud.

By the time they got back into town, Adora had finished setting up her new phone and transferring the necessary logins. She was finally ready to meet the Internet head-on.

"Alright, keyboard warrior, what's your first move," Catra questioned her once she declared that she had her twitter pulled up on her new phone.

"I think… um, hmmmm," she hummed as she stared at the app. "I want to find that one picture we got in trouble about and tell them I like it." Finally, after some instruction from Catra as she tried to visualize the app in her head while driving, she got to it.

@IAdoraCatra reply to [Adorable Catgirl Catra and magical Blondie photo]: This is so cute! I'm going to buy her cat ears and make her take a picture, ssh it's a secret. Will update! #TeamBlondie #TeamCatradora

"Do you want tacos?" Catra asked, unaware that Adora was setting her up for nonsense.

"Oh yeah, that sounds good," Adora answered happily, a mischievous grin on her face that the other woman couldn't see.

[artist] reply to @IAdoraCatra : wait are you the real blondie?

"Someone wants to know if I'm real! Why wouldn't I be real?"

"There are probably already accounts pretending to be you. That's how Twitter works," Catra shrugged. "I've seen plenty of fake me accounts, even before this shit. Plus, the interview hasn't posted yet, I'm sure."

@IAdoraCatra: Yes, my name is Adora! Nice to meet you, thanks for the art! Catra likes it too!

[artist] reply to @IAdoraCatra : thanks, but prove it #teamblondie possible blondie sighting!

[teamblondieoriginalfan] reply to [artist] & @IAdoraCatra : profile pic's cute, but can't see her muscles, cannot confirm if #realblondie

[catrasmyheroandgod] #teamblondie [prayer hands] plz really be her blessing us [queen emoji] tell catra we love her [cat heart eyes emoji]

"They don't believe me!" Adora whined after receiving several more similar tweets. "How annoying. I'm me."

"Oh good, I was worried you might be a fake, and I'd never find that girl I made out with," she teased. "I have an idea. Gotta park first, though." Catra knew that she was probably going to be on the receiving end of another DT lecture, but she had already passed the point of 'do anything to make this girl smile.' After they pulled into a spot at the restaurant she had picked, she turned on the lights in the car. "Okay, pull up the thing like you're about to write something," she instructed, and Adora followed. "Click the little picture a camera, and choose to go live. This means that ---"

Before she could finish explaining, Adora had already clicked the live button. "I'm live!" She declared enthusiastically. "What's happening?"

"Well, right now, you're giving people a fantastic live show of my dashboard," Catra quietly answered as she shook her head.

"Oh, I got it!" Adora turned the phone's camera around to face herself. She already had viewers flooding in. It appeared that the people replying to her had alerted the rest of the ranks of their team. "Hi! Like I said, I'm Adora! And I'm really Blondie! No lies told by this girl. I think you all know who's the liar-liar pants on fire on here." She made a goofy face as she raised her eyebrows.

Comments started flooding her screen, and she tried to keep up. "Wow, this is fast. Yes, I can share my workout routine!" Adora continued to try to speed-read the screen. Catra was trying to keep her giggles quiet from the driver's side. "They keep asking to see you," she whispered over to her.

"Well, yeah, that's kind of the point," she explained, loud enough that the video picked up. "So they can see you're *my* blondie."

Adora worked on switching around the camera while reporting to Catra the various new comments coming in. "People are freaking out about your voice, whoa. They really like it," she noted and then finally directed the camera at Catra.

"Hey," she nodded coolly at the camera. "Yes, my dorky girlfriend here is telling the truth. Thanks, bye."

Adora turned the camera back to her. "Okay, you heard the woman! We're going to eat tacos now. Bye!"

Before she turned off the live she watched as the comments started to roll in fast and furious. She cut the feed as her eyes went wide. "Heh," she made an awkward face as she looked over at Catra. "They said some.. um.. interesting stuff there at the end."

"It's about the tacos, huh," Catra gave an exasperated sigh and shook her head.

"Mmhmm," Adora blushed. "I can correct them. That we've only kissed… you know, so far, not that I wouldn't want to, I mean I do--"

"They don't need to know anything like that. Post something else, and they'll move on, please?" Catra begged and followed it up with a quick kiss to make sure she didn't think she was mad. "I'll go grab our food while you work on a distraction. Any allergies or preferences?"

"Nope! Surprise me!"

Catra headed into the restaurant, wondering if she could offer DT A bonus to not give her shit about this. Was that unethical?

Adora busied herself with replying to some of the nicer tweets coming her way and retweeting some art she loved. This social media thing could be fun! Then, she remembered, her whole reason for doing this was to snap back at Valerie. After some searching around, she landed on her page.

ValerieSHarper: The last 24 hours have been very challenging for me, and I ask that my privacy be respected at this time.

IAdoraCatra: @ValerieSHarper I request that you respect my gf's privacy at all times, forever, instead of making stuff up!

She waited another couple of minutes, and no response. Hmph.

IAdoraCatra: Dumb. Face. [100 emoji]

By the time Catra returned to the car with their dinner, Adora had gained over one thousand followers. "How's the war going," she asked as she climbed in and buckled up.

"I told Valerie off, and she didn't even reply," she showed off the tweet proudly.

"Nice," Catra approved. "If I weren't on social media time out, I'd heart it."

"You can just heart me instead," Adora said in a sultry voice as she winked.

"Yep, sexy-stupid is your brand."

"And what does it mean if you're my key demographic, hmm," Adora teased, reaching over and tousling her hair as she put the car into reverse.

"That I'll have to thank Sparkles for getting you the job so I could meet you."

Adora was able to luxuriate in the comment for only a moment before realizing a problem. "Glimmer's going to kill me when she finds out I told the world before her."

After a few more silly tweets interacting with their various fans and blocking more than a few idiots, the two of them gave up the social media war for the night. They found new music for Adora to endearingly butcher as she sang along with incorrect lyrics and pitch.

When they walked into the penthouse for the second time together, the sight took Adora's breath away again. However, this time, she felt less shocked and more appreciative of it all. This was *her* girlfriend's insanely expensive, beautiful home. Adora belonged *here*, no matter her background or the fact that her bank account had less than forty dollars on it. That was too dizzying to think.

"You were right; the view is extra gorgeous at night," she said as she walked over to the table by the window. The electric light of the city created multicolored stars below them.

"Yeah," Catra sat the food down and then came up behind her. She wrapped her arms around her girlfriend as she peeked out with her chin on her shoulder. She had to stand on her tiptoes a bit to do so, but Adora didn't need to know that. "Second most gorgeous thing I've seen today."

"And the first?" Adora asked coyly, as though she didn't sense an oncoming compliment.

"You in that horse shirt." Catra kissed the side of her neck before dropping back down and pulling out a chair for Adora.

After eating and playing with Melog until he was tuckered out, the two women retreated up to Catra's bedroom. It felt a little like the night before, each a bit awkward in not knowing what was appropriate. At least they were sober this time.

"So, um," Catra scratched the hair on the back of her head and made an awkward popping sound with her mouth. "Did you still want to sleep in this shirt? Because now I've worn it all day and night..."

"I dunno, let me smell you," she teased, and Catra got a sour look on her face. "Kidding! Of course, I don't mind wearing it."

Catra shrugged off her jacket and went to hang it up in her walk-in closet. Adora wanted to go back and peek in, but she felt like she had already had enough rich people stuff overwhelm for the day. She didn't need to check if Catra's closet was bigger than her bedroom at her apartment. That could be confirmed another day, surely.

When the brunette came back into the room, she looked a bit sheepish for a moment but then started to pull off the top in front of its owner. Adora's heart skipped as she watched, wondering if she was supposed to look away, but Catra certainly didn't turn away or ask her to. She was wearing a simple gray bra underneath, nothing lacey or overly sexy. Even still, Adora thought she had never seen breasts that she wanted to touch more in her life.

"Your shirt, my lady," Catra mimicked Adora's ridiculous drunken line as she handed the shirt over.

She swallowed as she took it and replied, "Thanks."

"For the shirt or letting you see me without one?" Catra was relishing the change in her demeanor.

"Um, both?" She gave a cheeky grin.

"Good answer," Catra laughed as she turned back around and went into her wardrobe to retrieve something for herself. "Do you have work or class in the morning? Because I could drop you off at your place if it's just school or if it's work at 5am you could--" she stopped herself when she turned around because Adora was standing there in her underwear, the t-shirt draped casually over her arm. Time and all of her cognitive ability stopped at that moment as she took in the sight.

"You're welcome," Adora winked, satisfied with having caught her off guard as well.

Catra abandoned her quest for some sort of cool vintage t-shirt to sleep in, crossed back over to her girlfriend, and pounced on Adora with a series of hungry kisses. The feeling of their bare skin touching made her heart skip a beat. Adora ran her fingertips along her back so tenderly it sent shivers down her spine. When they landed on the clasp of her bra, the blonde pulled away from the kiss briefly to question her silently with raised eyebrows and she nodded quickly. Fuck yes, she wanted to say, but her lips were already busying themselves again with Adora's delicious-looking collarbones. She let her hands drift and explore the soft skin of her partner's hips.

Once she had freed Catra of her pesky bra, Adora cupped her breasts and squeezed them gently before rolling one of her nipples between her fingers. She slotted her leg between Catra's unfortunately still

very clothed ones and rocked against her, earning her the moan she could tell the other woman had been suppressing. "So, I know you said you have a thing about control, but," she lifted the other woman's chin to look into her eyes, "Taking care of you would make me feel good too," she copied Catra's intonation from earlier. "Can I, please?"

Catra stared up at her with a slight panic that accompanied overwhelming desire. Since the whole 'ruining her first kiss with she who shall not be named,' she hadn't let herself even consider a partner that she would ever see again, much less one she had genuine affection for. In the past few years, she had entertained a small number of one-night stands in tiny towns where no one knew who she was, and even those were few and far between. She never let herself truly be vulnerable with any of them. The idea of letting Adora *take care of her* was exciting and a little scary.

Sensing her hesitation, the blonde relaxed her hands and retreated from pressing into her center. "Oh, damn, you're right, this is kind of fast. We had our first kiss and all yesterday... I don't want to push you--"

"I mean, you can push me," Catra conjured up her bravado again, trying to put them both back at ease. "My bed is *really* soft."

"You're right," Adora smirked. She put her hands under the other woman's ass and started to lift, "How about I drop you instead?"

Catra pretended to protest with a wiggle but then hopped into the hold and clung to Adora as she walked them towards the foot of her bed. She fell back into the soft comfort of her bed as the other woman gently dropped her. She barely had a moment to recover before the blonde was crawling on top of her after she had shed her own bra and underwear.

"What could I get started for you?" Adora asked with another one of her silly grins as she sat back on her knees straddling Catra's waist.

"Did you seriously... just... Starbucks greetings me about sex," Catra cackled. Sexy stupid. On brand. "I'm going to need to see a menu."

"The menu is," Adora thought for a moment and then held out a hand in front of Catra's face as she waggled her fingers. "These, they're *very* good. Inside and outside, I have to say. And also, here's a free sample of another option," she leaned down, slotting her lips into Catra's, exploring her mouth with her tongue before parting. "I want to make this moment right for you."

"Adora, this... fuck," Catra whimpered, hating herself a little for how much this ridiculous situation was turning her on. The blonde was still smirking at her, waiting for a response. "All of that sounds good."

"Got it," Adora winked. "Hot or iced? What size?" Seeing that Catra looked like she was about to lose her mind or at least her libido, she slid back down into her sultry voice, "I'm done, promise, love," she was not thinking about her choice of a pet name.

Catra had exactly one second to panic about hearing the other woman call her 'love' before Adora was pulling her pants and already soaked underwear off, finally. She slid one hand between her legs, teasing the sensitive skin around before running one finger slowly up from her entrance to her clit. It made the other woman roll her hips upwards already in search of more. Adora pressed her body down onto her to keep her still and wrapped her lips around one of the other woman's taut nipples. She nibbled and licked while starting to work her fingers more.

"Fuck, that feels good," she managed between needy noises that she couldn't possibly hold back anymore.

Adora released her nipple with a pop and looked up at her, admiring her face contorting in pleasure as she tried new techniques with her fingers, "You're the sexiest woman I've ever seen," she said in awe. "I can't believe *I* get to make you feel good."

She swallowed and tried to collect herself. "I'm yours, do whatever you want."

Adora smiled. She had a feeling this kind of submission was something special for the other, far more powerful woman. Maybe even it was something brand new.... something just for Adora, and she certainly wasn't going to waste it. She traced kisses down her torso, enjoying the way her skin was dotting with goosebumps. Finally, she lowered herself down between her lover's legs and hooked one of her knees over her shoulder to display her wide and open before her.

"My girlfriend is so gorgeous," she said with reverence.

When she finally brought her tongue down to taste what was hers, Catra arched into her again already with a needy whine. Encouraged, she kept working her tongue and lips, intermittently swapping her techniques to see what fit her lover best. Once she landed on what seemed to draw out the most delicious reactions, she slid a finger into her now very welcoming entrance. More mumbled expletives came from the other woman and in turn, she began clawing her fingers through her long blonde hair. After she could feel her body clenching and craving more, Adora added a second finger and Catra gasped at the sensation before relaxing into it. She steadily continued her work, determined to show her lover how much she appreciated her for letting her into her life.

Catra could've sworn she was in heaven, but she was never the religious type. Instead, this must be some other magical world where lonely ass nerds like her were rewarded for long-suffering singledom with sex goddesses. In the minimal amount of experience with others or even her very expertise touching of herself, she had never felt anything that could compare. Adora did everything with utmost dedication and seriousness, it turned out. Not that she was complaining. Fuck, no. More like *coming*, because that what she was on the edge of as she opened her tightly shut eyes and looked down only to meet Adora's blue ones staring up at her with intensity. As though encouraged by her attention, the blonde doubled down her efforts with her tongue and curled her fingers to press against her inner walls. That was all it took. The feeling of intense pleasure ran through her body as she arched off the bed, with a desperate cry. She collapsed down and tried to recover her mind, breathing, and heart as Adora continued to gently stroke her before planting one last kiss.

"That... was amazing," Catra panted out once Adora crawled her way back up to lay beside her. "*You're* amazing."

"When you receive a survey please give me a strongly agree--" she started before Catra stopped her with a kiss.

After they parted, she asked with a curious look on her face, "Should I expect barista role play every time we have sex?"

"Mmmm, nope," Adora said after thinking about it for a minute. "I think next time I'd like to be an investor you're seducing."

"I like the sound of that," Catra smirked and looked Adora up and down with hungry eyes. "Once my heart recovers, I'd be happy to return the favor."

Adora smiled and placed her hand on her cheek. "I think tonight all I want is for you to hold me."

"That was already on my menu." She grabbed her phone and turned off the lights.

The two worked their way under the blankets, entirely forgoing any thoughts of sleepwear. Neither wanted to give up the feeling of the other woman's warm, soft skin against their own. Catra enjoyed how when laying down, she could wiggle to the top of her pillow and wrap her arms around Adora to pretend she was the tall one. They discussed their plans for the morning in sweet whispers. It turned out the barista did have an opening shift, and so it made sense for Adora to take the 'spaceship' as she called it. Catra would just use one of her car services that *wasn't* a limo. Plus, this guaranteed them both an excuse to get back together in the evening. Not that they needed one.

Catra was sitting out on the roof drinking some homemade espresso while the sun was rising. She had decided to give Adora space to be with her friends and not barge in with her usual Starbucks order. Plus, god, if DT was right, there might already be people annoying her there. She set a reminder to text after the rush and see how things were going. As she enjoyed the coffee, she gave some thought to looking up on her phone if there were any new developments in the drama.

It turned out, she didn't really need to. Right as she was ready to head inside to get dressed for work, her phone started ringing and the caller id read: Valerie Harper.

Chapter End Notes

As always, hope you enjoyed! Let me know what you think! I have nothing witty left to say here except that I hope I sufficiently mortified all the other fellow former/current Starbucks baristas with Adora's choice of dirty talk.

Business as Usual

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora return to work. Glimmer joins the war. Lonnie makes a move.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As Adora parked the 'spaceship,' she could see in the rearview mirror the reflection of Bow and Glimmer waiting for her inside the door at Starbucks. This wasn't entirely unusual; typically, one of them was standing by to unlock the door to let whoever came in last. Something did seem unusual, though. Although the store didn't open for another 45 minutes, there were already cars waiting in the parking lot. As quickly as she could, she grabbed her belongings and fled her girlfriend's car after making sure she locked it. Her friends flung open the door and let her before the various people waiting had a chance to catch up. Glimmer locked it behind her friend and eyed an unfamiliar person looking back at her on the other side.

"We aren't open yet!" She said loud enough that she hoped it carried through the door.

Adora started to apologize, "I'm so-"

"Save it until we get in the back, Blondie!" Glimmer grabbed her hand and started leading a procession to the back of the store, away from prying eyes and windows.

"We came in a little early and finished all the opening stuff already," Bow declared, very proud of their efforts. "If we did this every morning, I bet we'd co-win partner of the quarter!"

"So I can just go home then?" Adora joked nervously.

"Not a chance," Glimmer looked over her shoulder at the blonde she was still dragging by the hand. "We didn't hustle that hard to let you get away."

Once they were finally in the back of the store, Glimmer directed Adora to sit down in the one chair that managed to fit in the tiny storage room.

"ADORA," Glimmer started her interrogation, more annoyed than truly angry. "Tell me why I had to find out from people sharing trending videos about my best friend dating a multi-millionaire!"

Adora gave another goofy smile as she scratched under her ponytail awkwardly. "Wellllll, to be fair, you knew I was dating Catra. You didn't know she was rich, but I didn't either until yesterday afternoon, I swear."

"Obviously!" Glimmer threw her hands up. "You wouldn't have gotten this far already if you knew. You'd be all…" She struggled to find the words and looked to Bow.

"Adora about it," Bow finished, and she nodded. Finally, having a chance to get a word in, he started going off with his enthusiastic interrogation. "You got to drive a Darla here?! Was it amazing? Is it

yours forever? Can I sit in it during my break?"

"Bow, calm down about the car," Glimmer scolded him before turning her attention back to Adora. "You could've given us a heads-up once you found out. And now you're in a Twitter war with some woman claiming she was already with Catra? I let her know how I felt about her rude ass comments about you two."

"What?! Oh no," Adora grabbed her phone out of her bag and quickly pulled up Twitter. She didn't need to ask Glimmer's handle, as she was already in her notifications from mentioning her.

SparklesTheBarista : @ValerieSHarper - ADORA IS WORTH MORE THAN YOU IN EVERY SINGLE WAY THAT MATTERS [angry face emoji] #facts

SparklesTheBarista : @ValerieSHarper Admit that you were lying, and then shut up. The best you can hope for is some influencer does something dumb, and you can fade into the SHADOWS where you BELONG.

SparklesTheBarista : MY bestie only tells truths! [quote retweet of IAdoraCatra ‘Dumb. Face. [100 emoji]']

SparklesTheBarista :@ValerieSHarper Jealousy is a disease; get well soon, girlie!

SparklesTheBarista : @IAdoraCatra & @CatraDarlaCEO are the hottest lesbians I know, and they've been basically in love since they met [100 emoji] #TeamCatradora #BestFriendSquad #Thatsmybestfriend

"DT is going to kill me," Adora said to herself with wide eyes as she scanned Glimmer's feed.

"Who's that?" Bow asked. "Catra won't let anyone kill you."

"That's Catra's… I guess our PR person. I'm not supposed to cause too much trouble because it could hurt her image," Adora whined.

"Well, they're not my PR person, and she's not my girlfriend." Glimmer shrugged. "Plus, my tweets are some of the thousands she's had coming her way! They are, obviously, the best ones, but Catradora has some serious fans."

"Should we feel bad? I mean, that's a lot of people telling you that you suck," Bow offered, ever the compassionate one of the group.

"She's been awful for a long time," Adora quickly stopped herself from getting into the private details. "But let's lay off for now, please. What if we all get fired? You put barista in your name! They'll know you work with me."

"If we all get fired, we'll move in with Catra. Problem solved!" Glimmer joked. "But seriously, I'll back off for now. Sorry if I caused problems. Still…if she says anything else awful about you two, I make no promises for what I will or won't do."

"Thanks for defending me." As much as she shouldn't encourage it, she did *love* those tweets. She planned a similar line of attack before DT asking her not to go too intense on Valerie.

"Of course! How could I not?" Glimmer knelt and hugged her.

"If someone attacks a member of the best friend squad, we all roll initiative." Bow joined in the Adora group hug. Of course, the other two didn't get his joke, but in his heart, he knew that Catra would've appreciated it. They bonded over coffee and mutual nerdiness. How had he not realized who she was?

After they all released the hug, Bow asked, "How are you feeling? This is some big stuff. I always thought Catra was cool, but, whoa."

She thought about it for a second before answering happily, "Nervous, a little. I don't want to mess anything up for her. But other than that, it's perfect. I've never felt this close to someone so fast. We get each other, and being around her makes me so happy. I don't even care about the money part."

"But hey, it has its bonuses," Glimmer pointed to her new phone with a smug smile.

"Yeah," Adora scrunched up her face and appeared conflicted as she stared at the phone in her hands.

Bow and Glimmer exchanged a look that said, 'she is going to Adora this.' The former spoke up, "Adora, you don't have to feel bad about getting things from Catra. It's okay. It doesn't mean she thinks you only want her for money, she's trying to buy your love, or whatever silly thing you're worried about. If I won the lottery, don't you think I'd want to buy things for Glim?"

"And if I won, Bow would have all the dumb nerdy stuff he could dream of," Glimmer winked. "From what I've seen of you two here being disgustingly cute with each other, I think she'd buy you the moon happily."

"You think so?" Adora smiled as they both enthusiastically said yes.

The trio hung out in the back with the time left until the store opened. Adora filled them in on everything that had happened— from the fun first date that ended in drunk Catra ordering a limo on accident to the whirlwind of a day that finished with her spending the night at Catra's penthouse… well, she didn't fill them in on *all* the details about that.

"Tell her I'm demanding a double date so we can get to know her better," Glimmer declared. "It takes more than money to be worthy of dating my bestie."

"I'm sure I can arrange that," Adora beamed at the possibility. None of her previous possible love interests had stood up to the Glimmer double date test, but she had a feeling this was going to be quite different.

Finally, it was time to open the door and face whatever media onslaught was waiting for them. They had opted for a play that put Adora on bar. Not only had she become the fastest of the three, but with the way she zoned out to stay focused on making drinks, it would be hard for anyone to break through to bother her. Glimmer took the front register, which she usually would want anyone else to do. However, she knew she had the perfect customer service voice to tell someone to fuck off without getting in trouble.

When Bow went to unlock the door, there was already a line wrapped into the parking lot. "Everybody ready," he called back to the others, and they gave him a thumbs up and had their best game faces on.

He opened the door and greeted everyone pleasantly. People pushed in with more purpose than a Black Friday morning. Thankfully, Bow had skipped his way out of the fray and safely managed to get back behind the counter. Camera flashes were already going. Adora gave an awkward smile and busied herself while waiting for the first drinks to come through. She ducked low and opened the refrigerators below to check if all the opened non-dairy milk had been dated and everything. The blonde still heard the clicks while examining almond milk. 'Oh god, are they taking pictures of my butt?!' she thought to herself in a panic and then immediately got back up. There were calls of her name, questions about Catra, questions about *Valerie.* Even if she wanted to comment on something, it was impossible with the noise.

"WELCOME TO STARBUCKS!" Glimmer screamed from the top of a small step ladder she had grabbed from the back. "I WOULD LOVE TO TAKE YOUR ORDERS. Otherwise, LEAVE! Thank you!"

The mob managed into a more orderly grouping and lined up to place orders with who they were speculating might be 'Sparkles.' Pictures kept snapping all the same, but at least Adora had a steady drink queue to keep herself politely busy.

"Can I have a tall blonde? I hear that's Catra's favorite drink," some snarky young male reporter said and laughed annoyingly. "Looks delicious to me."

Glimmer looked at him with a big, customer service smile as she said with a honeyed voice, "Get the fuck out of my store. Thanks!" He looked at her, surprised and unmoving. She narrowed her eyes while keeping the smile. "Did you know that we brew our coffee at nearly 200 degrees?" He looked scared and hurried his way out of the line. "Next, please!"

The crowd wasn't full of such poor examples of humanity. Many were happy to order their drinks like normal customers. People that were pleasant and patient were rewarded with at least one of the baristas entertaining a non-controversial question. Bow and Glimmer both happily reported how great Catra had always been to them, even before Adora started working there. When pressed about what the 'Adora' would be as a beverage, she went with an iced chai plus a pump of vanilla. She could've thought of a drink that fit her personality, but she hoped other baristas out there would appreciate her for the simplicity. When asked what's something about Catra that people wouldn't know, she smirked and replied earnestly, "She *loves* puns."

"You've reached Catra, CEO of Darla Industries, the world's leading manufacturer of electric, AI-powered vehicles. Hold please," she recited robotically while heading back into her bedroom.

"Really?" Valerie asked on the other end. "Is this how you answer all your calls?"

"Oh, no, of course not," Catra said with a smirk as she put the phone on speaker and hit a button on her laptop. "It *did* give me enough time to start recording this call. How can I help you, Ms. Harper?"

"Paranoid much?" She sounded bemused.

"I think a certain amount of paranoia is healthy after the spin I've dealt with this week."

"I suppose that's fair, darling. I have put you in quite the position, haven't I?"

Catra had a visceral reaction to being called a pet name by this wretched woman again. "I don't understand your end game here." She wanted to say more, but the recording only protected her from

her words being twisted. It didn't protect against what she said if she let herself say what she truly wanted to.

"My end game has always been the same. I've been anything but subtle. I think you and I would be good together, Catra, and it's a shame you didn't come back that night. We could've been something so much more than you're going to get with her."

"Uh-huh. A real shame you didn't get to have me as your pet millionaire." She wished she hadn't said that on the record, but she couldn't let her get away with pretending like this was some great love story Catra ruined. There was a long pause of silence.

"You heard that?" Valerie softly asked finally.

"Yep." She popped the p for emphasis.

Valerie cleared her throat and swapped to a more conciliatory voice, "Explains a lot then. I was only *joking* , darling, and you would've known that if you asked me instead of running away. And *I* am doing quite well on my own in that department. I am interested in something much more with you. If you think your barista girl isn't only interested in you for your money---"

"You don't get to say anything about her." She gritted her teeth to keep herself from the verbal attack she wanted to lay on the other woman. Why did she even answer the phone?

"I'm afraid she's making that very difficult. Between her sudden Twitter appearance and her friend attacking me on there before I even woke up today, I find myself in a position to say many things about her."

"It's almost as though actions have consequences. They didn't teach you that at MIT? Man, thank god I didn't bother with college."

Valerie laughed. "You are *so* funny. I'm trying to warn you of the same. This will fall apart, and it will ruin you, Catra. Do you want the world watching when it does? Wouldn't you rather be with someone who stands to lose as much as you? I say this as a concerned friend."

"Apply this much focus to your own life and company, and perhaps you could have a tenth of my net worth someday. Best Wishes, Ms. Harper."

Catra hung up and stopped the recording. She walked over to the bed and punched a pillow before taking a deep breath and closing her eyes. 'Don't let her steal this from you,' she admonished herself internally, 'Focus.' Her phone beeped. "Fucking hell," she groaned aloud and prepared to block the other woman's number. Only it wasn't Valerie; it was someone whose mere name made her smile.

Adora : This is Luisa, and she wanted me to tell you that you're her hero. She says she'll have a company someday that makes flying cars. [photo of Adora posing with an adorable elementary schooler with a cake-pop and a drawing of her and Catra high-fiving in her flying car]

Adora : I want to be brand loyal for you, but... Luisa's cars sound pretty fly! [drum emoji]

Catra : Tell her I'll be her first investor when she launches. If they haven't left, can you see if her family will give you some contact info? I'd love to give them a tour of the complex.

Adora : Oh, perfect! I'm on it. Hope you have a good day at work! I miss you already.

Catra : Thanks. I miss you too. Tell Sparkles not to get in Twitter jail for me. There's no bail for that.

With that, all thoughts of the awful redhead were dismissed from her mind. It was uncanny the way that Adora was always exactly what she needed. Catra went about her morning routine, dancing and singing along to an embarrassingly large love song playlist that blared through all corners of her penthouse. Even Melog was treated to a twirl around the living room before she headed out for the day.

As requested by DT, she was back on campus at her usual time and dressed in one of her favorite suits. She was every bit the polished and put-together CEO she was supposed to be. Well, aside from her mind's desire to shift to daydreaming about Adora at any given moment.

"Boss? You there?" Lonnie waved a hand in front of the CEO's face. The engineer had been walking her through her latest designs for the brand's first SUV.

Catra focused again and looked embarrassed. She had been paying attention to Lonnie's fantastic work, but then she mentioned something about an optional feature that would let the back-half of the vehicle convert to a bed. Then her mind drifted to going on a road trip with Adora and having sex in new and exciting locales.

"Sorry," she cleared her throat. "I was listening, I swear. This all looks perfect to me."

"The young CEO is losing her focus," Lonnie quoted the article with a smug grin.

"Just a lot on my mind right now," Catra hoped she wasn't blushing. At this point, she feared she was constantly red. "Um, speaking of that, though. We haven't had our meeting this month to talk about union concerns."

"And you want to know if people are upset or nervous about this whole drama situation?"

"Yes and anything else that they're concerned about."

Lonnie pulled up some notes on her tablet. "People want to know if the wedding day will be a paid vacation for everyone."

"Be serious, please," Catra groaned as she rubbed her temples.

She laughed to herself and shook her head. "Honestly, no one is worried about it. Everybody knows DT's handling things. Plus, all you think about is work normally. The consensus of the people is that Blondie's good for you."

"I think about other things," Catra protested but couldn't come up with a good example pre-Adora.

"When's the last time you took a vacation day?" Lonnie received only silence in response. "Exactly. Take care of yourself. We don't want you having a heart attack before you're 25."

"Fine, whatever, if that's not an issue, is there anything else? I don't get to talk to everyone as much as I used to."

"Ah well," Lonnie looked down at her notes. "There is a lot of support for an ice cream machine in the cafeteria."

"I'm sorry, what?" Catra asked incredulously.

"You know, one of those little soft serve ones that swirl in the middle."

"I know what an ice cream machine is. That's the most pressing thing they're bringing the union steward? Really?

"People love ice cream," Lonnie laughed. "I don't know what to tell you. You're already paying everybody way above industry average; everybody's got good benefits. Reasonable hours. I can't think of an issue you haven't already addressed. Hell, you started a free daycare when Rogelio and I were watching his nephew for a week. People are happy."

That made her breathe a sigh of relief. One of her fears about running a business this large was that she would let down the people below her. Lonnie had strict orders to strike her down if that happened. "Do a survey and see what toppings people want. I'll get it done next week."

"Pleasure doing business with you," Lonnie extended a hand, and they shook on it. "Probably need two vacation days, by the way. Don't want us all hungover working with heavy machinery and complex coding after the big day."

"Ha, ha." Catra rolled her eyes. "Got anything else for me before I go? I'm supposed to have a working lunch with DT."

"Actually," Lonnie gave a mischievous grin. "Any way you can get me the number of that reporter, Kyle, that was here yesterday?"

"Trying to sell your story about working with me?" Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Course not! Too loyal for that. Rogelio and I wanted to get to know this particular blondie," she winked. "Promise no leaking work secrets."

Catra sighed and went into her wallet to get Kyle's business card. It was so goofy looking; she couldn't decide what was worse: his use of comic sans or the pixelated picture of his face that was barely recognizable. She handed it over, "Good luck."

"You too, boss. Hope DT doesn't put you in detention."

When Adora walked out of the elevator into Catra's home, Melog immediately greeted her with a happy meow. She grabbed him up into her arms and talked to him as though he might respond, "Hi there! Where's your nerdy mommy hiding? Hmmm?" She carried the cat around the bottom floor but didn't see any sign of her anywhere. How odd, they had talked on the phone when she was on her way over. She was supposed to be home. "Maybe she's taking a nap," she pondered aloud before kissing his furry head and letting him down.

When she reached the top of the spiral staircase, she didn't find the other woman in bed. She started to head outside but stopped as she heard "In here!" called from a door she hadn't explored yet on the top floor. She opened it and walked into the most beautiful bathroom she had ever seen. It was all white marble accented with gold features and hanging plants. It reminded her of what an ancient empress might have built for herself. Of course, to Adora, the most attractive part of the space was her girlfriend laying back in a gigantic bathtub along a wall with frosted glass that let natural light in.

"Hey, Adora," Catra beckoned as she moved to the front of the tub and propped herself up on her arms.

She couldn't summon a sufficient reply with words, but she started her way across the bathroom, slowly shedding various pieces of clothing along the way. When Adora reached the tub, Catra wrapped her arms around her lower half and kissed the bottom of her stomach.

"Stressful day at work?" Adora lovingly stroked the other woman's hair.

"A little," Catra admitted and pushed herself back to let Adora climb in with her. "DT gave me a hard time about some things, but otherwise, everything's good. You? I'm sorry if it was ridiculous." Once the blonde was fully in, Catra leaned against one of the tub walls and pulled her into her lap.

"It was pretty wild, but this more than makes up for it," Adora happily leaned into her.

Catra grabbed a washcloth and began delicately running it over the other woman's skin. "Thought we both could use it." She planted a soft kiss on the side of her jaw. "Plus, I've been thinking about getting you in here all day. It's even better than I imagined."

"Mmm, let's never leave, okay? This is officially my happy place," Adora closed her eyes and let the soothing sensations wash over her.

Catra had thought about bringing up the whole early morning call situation, but she decided there was no room for someone so terrible in *their* happy place. Instead, they took turns doting on each other with massages and help with 'washing up.' Only, most of that was an excuse to run their hands over each other and see who gave in to turning it into making out first. By the time they finally exited the bath, it was drawing towards dinner time, and both women were happy raisins.

"My butt is going to hang out of this," Adora joked as she held up the robe that Catra had given her. It was one of her shorter ones, and with their height difference, it was a problem.

"That's my evil plan," Catra joked as she threw on one of her other robes. Of course, she had selected a regular length one for herself.

Adora put on the robe and proudly spun around. "It's all fun and games until I answer the door for delivery." A bewildered look appeared on her face at the thought. "Wait... how does that work? You don't really have a door."

"Normally, I go down to the lobby for delivery. Knowing our luck, that means some really interesting pictures of you would appear online." Catra shook her head. "I shouldn't joke about that. It's too close to reality at this rate."

A part of her DT talk had been about the photos of Adora at work this morning. Of course, nothing was inappropriate. It was a healthy mix of her making remarkably unflattering faces while concentrating or her genuine, gorgeous smile. Still, they discussed how to prepare for this being a daily occurrence. Many people in the public eye could be caught in their worst moments and buried for it.

"Yeah, seriously. I still can't believe this is my life now." Adora had already seen some of them pop up online, and the "Adora Chai" was taking off with its hashtag full of people proudly posing with their drinks.

Catra frowned. "I wish I could make it stop. I would understand if you didn't want to deal with this."

Adora tilted her head as she stared at her girlfriend. She looked so tiny all of a sudden, and all she wanted to do was build her back up. "You're the dummy in this relationship if you think I'm going to

let something like that make me walk away. I'd deal with a thousand times worse if it means that I also get to do this," she wrapped her arms around her and drew her in for a kiss. When she pulled back, she looked into those happy mismatched eyes and said as seriously as possible, "Plus, I'm proud of my ass. If they want to put it online, I'll retweet it."

Chapter End Notes

Ca$htra is the CEO I wish every company could have. She works with her union, wants her employees to be well paid and cared for, and makes sure they have the proper ice cream toppings.

Also Catra would literally pay someone off ~~or have someone murdered~~ before she let unauthorized Adora butt photos go on the internet.

A Brinner to Remember

Chapter Summary

This chapter is the opposite of a goat rodeo. Catra and Adora have history's most romantic breakfast for dinner, and the CEO learns to use a little power in the bedroom with the barista. Emotions are felt and expressed. Big Tech's Bad Girl gets a new image.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Mmm, nope," Catra shook her head dismissively as she moved her hands down her back, "I'm afraid I can't allow that to happen. I don't like the idea of the whole world looking at my girlfriend's perfect ass like that. I'd have to buy Twitter and shut the whole thing down."

"You'd do that for me? So romantic," Adora swooned overdramatically.

"Might have to liquidate all my assets to afford it depending on the market, so maybe we keep this one up here and away from paparazzi."

"I suppose I'll consider pants then."

"Let's see if I have anything we can turn into dinner. No need to go to such drastic measures.”Catra grabbed her by the belt of her robe and began leading her down to the kitchen.

"I'm going to get the cabinets. You check the fridge," Catra started rummaging around. "If you knock on it, you can see what's in there."

Adora did as told and was shocked as knocked twice as instructed and the darkened glass changed and she could see through the door, "This is the most ridiculously fancy fridge I have ever seen."

"Yeah, it's a bit excessive," Catra laughed while searching her cabinets fruitlessly. "When I first had enough money to get whatever I wanted, I felt kind of guilty about buying things like this. But, fuck it, some people thought I'd never amount to anything, and now I have a fridge that's smarter than them."

"If someone could meet you and think that, *my* fridge is smarter than them, and it's never the right temp."

"Thanks," Catra smiled to herself. Take that 7th-grade math teacher who got mad at her for doodling during class and still making 100's on her tests. "Any luck in there?"

"Not exactly for a dinner per se," Adora looked over at her with a bemused grin. "You've got eggs, milk, juice, and random condiments. Oh, and something in a Tupperware that looks suspicious. When was the last time you went grocery shopping?"

"I normally send my assistant a shopping list once a week, but I *was* supposed to be out of town until last night. We know how that worked out."

"Can't help it that I'm so missable," Adora laughed and came to join her in peering into her cabinets. "Is it time to give up and get dressed?"

"I don't admit defeat so easily." Catra started pulling out various items from her baking cabinets. "Grab the milk and eggs. We're making pancakes."

"Oooh, breakfast for dinner. This *is* the good life." Adora went back and started gathering what they needed.

After they got everything situated, Catra gave the barista a lesson on making pancakes from scratch after she admitted she had only ever used a mix that you add water to. She definitely needed some cooking classes, and Catra was more than happy to provide *whatever* she might need. Once Adora was able to be trusted with flipping on her own, Catra began setting up for dinner on the rooftop.

"This has to be the most romantic breakfast for dinner anyone's ever had," Adora said as she joined her girlfriend. She placed the carefully balanced plates of steaming pancakes on the table Catra had set. It was lovely--- candles, flowers from her garden, and a bottle of champagne on ice for mimosas.

"I do what I can," Catra winked as she started pouring drinks for the two of them before she sat down.

"Can we take a picture? We haven't taken any that are just for us."

"Of course." Catra happily scooted her chair close enough that Adora, with her long arms, could reach out and center a selfie. The resulting photo was the two of them smiling like happy idiots in their robes, proudly displaying their breakfast for dinner. The city's lights behind them made it look like they were glowing.

"Now we can remember when you officially reached level one in cook," She held up her glass to toast to the blonde's success.

"You sound like Bow," Adora laughed as they clinked glasses. "Oh! That reminds me. Glimmer is demanding a double date."

Catra raised her eyebrow after sipping the mimosa. "Is she now? Should I be worried?"

The blonde shrugged as she gave a goofy smile. "I don't know... none of my previous dates have made it past the Glimmer double date."

"Eh, if I can make billion-dollar deals for the company, I've got half a chance to win over Sparkles at a dinner. Better give me her number so we can coordinate."

"Oh! I'll add you to a group chat," Adora started plugging away with her phone before Catra had a moment to protest.

"Thanks," Catra shook her head, knowing she was in for a deluge of texts now.

After devouring pancakes and most of the champagne, the two women were giggling over some of the ridiculous tweets Adora had received that day. Mostly they were light-hearted, but they laughed their way through some of the few insults Valerie's fans had sent her way.

"How did someone get my yearbook photos anyway," she pondered while showing Catra a collage someone had made of young Adora's.

"I don't know, but I'll have to send them a thank you for proving you've been a dork forever," Catra cackled.

"Uh-huh, laugh it up," Adora teased as she swapped over to her photos where she had saved a picture someone had made that was a side-by-side comparing them in elementary school, "Someone else happens to be the cutest nerd ever."

"There goes my short-lived bad girl image," Catra laughed as she examined her little self. She was all wild curls and almost comically oversized glasses. She had to admit that she and gap-toothed little Adora were a very adorable pair. Looking at all of this had been fun, but it did remind her of less pleasant things. "Hey, Adora? I didn't want to bring down the mood, but I should probably let you know that *she* called me this morning."

"Really? That woman doesn't know when to give up." She scoffed. " Did you talk to her?"

"I did for a couple of minutes," She cast her eyes down at her empty plate as she felt guilty about having given in to her trap. "I recorded it. I know that sounds super paranoid."

"Not at all. If you didn't, she'd be splicing together a marriage proposal from her recording!"

"Why is that so fucking true," Catra shook her head and looked back over at her. "It seemed like she only called to mess with my head and make me question myself about you."

"Did it work?" The way her blue eyes lit up with concern as she asked made Catra's heart break.

"Of course not, Adora," she answered quickly, "I've never been more sure about anything in my life." To prove her point further, she leaned in, sneaking an arm inside of the other woman's robe and pulling her closer with her hand on the bare skin of her back. Their lips crashed together hungrily, and she could feel the other woman shiver under her touch.

Adora bit her lip after they parted and looked like she was thinking about something. "You know, I *do* have work in the morning. What if we clean up and get in bed already?"

The way she asked made Catra's heart start beating faster than it already was. "Very responsible idea." She gave a flirty smirk that Adora returned, and they quickly began bringing everything back in.

"Can I get something started for *you* tonight?" Catra mimicked her Starbucks come-on once they returned to her bedroom. She wrapped her arms around her waist from behind as she kissed her neck. "Been a while since I worked in the customer service industry, but I'd do my best to leave you completely satisfied."

Adora happily sighed as she leaned into her touch. "I'd be up for trying *whatever* is on your menu." She untied her robe and shimmied so it began to fall. Its descent was paused as it caught on Catra's arms before she pulled away and let it drop to the ground.

Catra quickly let hers join in a happy pile below their feet. She pressed herself against Adora's back as her hands ghosted along her torso, enjoying the feeling of goosebumps growing from her touch. She brushed her lips against her shoulders and gave a gentle nibble with her teeth. That made Adora’s knees give a little, and she tightened her grip on her to keep her steady. "Is that okay?" she asked sweetly, her lips only a breath away from the lightly reddened spot she'd made.

"Very," Adora responded, "Harder is good too."

"Good to know," Catra noted teasingly, planting simply a sweet kiss on the spot instead of another bite. She released her hold on the other woman as she commanded with the same voice she used delivering orders at work, "Lay down for me."

Adora complied without question and laid waiting for her on the bed with her eyes drifting up and down Catra's naked form. Catra meanwhile stood at the bottom of the bed, unmoving and admiring her in the same way. "Fuck," she breathed out. She could barely think for the desire building up in her mind and body.

"That's the idea," Adora laughed. "Now get up here, please. I'm cold without you."

She smirked as she descended on the bed and slowly began crawling her way up to the blonde. She paused along the way, pressing her lips against whatever bit of soft skin was closest and looking most inviting. Sometimes, they were merely kisses. Others, she gave some of those promised bites. By the time she reached her thighs, Adora was squeezing them together reflexively. Catra decided this was a perfect place to check in with her partner. She rested her chin on the soft cushion of those delicious-looking thighs and looked up at their owner. "Is there anything else you want me to know that you like or don't like?"

"Oh, um, well," Adora's face managed to get even redder.

As Catra stared at her, she knew something was bubbling under the surface. "It's okay," she propped herself back up on her elbows, giving her more space. "I want to make sure you have a good time, is all."

Adora ran a hand through her hair and looked sheepish. Still, she managed to get it out, "I have a hard time getting *there* . All the way I mean, without um..." She sighed and held her face in her hands. " *Extra* stimulation with like, you know, other things."

"Toys?" Catra raised an eyebrow as she asked, and the blonde nodded quickly, her face still buried in her hands. "Hey, dummy, there's no reason to be embarrassed by that. If that's what you need, well, in my years of being a rich single woman, I've built a large collection of implements of orgasmic destruction. Well maintained and immaculately clean, of course."

With that, Adora uncovered her face and looked more relaxed again. "If you really don't mind. The only time I've asked before, the girl got offended about it like I was saying she was bad."

Catra finished her ascent to the top of her girlfriend and kissed her reassuringly. "Then she's an idiot. You fucked me hard enough last night that I forgot what damn world I was in. I want to do whatever it takes to make you feel even half as good." She maneuvered her thigh between the other woman's and pressed, earning a sudden intake of air from the blonde.

"Okay," Adora managed, her voice breathless and content again.

After a few more minutes of worshipping her goddess's body, Catra climbed off and disappeared into her walk-in closet. She returned with a chest that she had to put in a code to unlock, which made Adora giggle. "What? Sometimes I hire cleaners, and I don't want them going through this shit," she protested and waggled a random insertable toy she had found at her. "Now, be good, or I'm not sharing."

"Yes, boss," Adora replied with a smug smile. It got even bigger as Catra looked back at her wide-eyed at the choice of nickname. She had a feeling the blonde was filing that under her own 'good to know' file.

She cleared her throat and tried to do the same for her mind. "If you're in the mood for strong," she noted as she held up a small handheld toy with what looked like a suction cup at the end, "I love this one. It uses air and magic; I'm pretty sure."

"Sold."

That was all Catra needed to hear. She put the chest back on the ground and made her way into the bed with her girlfriend. "How about I start simple, and we finish up with this, hmm?" She asked, and the blonde nodded enthusiastically.

"Wow, Adora," Catra mused once she was finally between her legs again, parting her swollen lips with a gentle finger. "How are you so beautiful *everywhere*?" The blonde responded with a noise somewhere between a moan and a hum. She found that Adora certainly wasn't lying when she said it took a lot to make her come. All the same, Catra was relishing every minute of listening to her delightfully filthy noises while she worked her tongue and fingers. Once it seemed like she was getting close but still not able to get *quite* over the edge, Catra pulled back and grabbed for the toy they had selected. Looking up for approval, she found it in Adora's heavy-lidded eyes and an eager nod.

She gave her clit one last kiss before replacing her lips with the toy's silicone ones and turned it on. Adora's hips bucked up at her almost instantly. "You like it?"

"Uh-huh," she replied breathlessly as she threw her head back. "Fuck, yes, please."

"That's what I want to hear," Catra propped herself up and watched her girlfriend's reactions with lustful amusement as she tried different settings. When Adora finally came, she was sure it was the sexiest thing she had ever witnessed. Anyone who wouldn’t want to do this for her had *no idea* what they were missing.

Catra made her way up and kissed her cheek tenderly. Adora turned over and wrapped her arms around her petite frame. "Thank you. I get the whole not knowing what world you're on thing now."

"Guess I know what I'm getting you for our monthiversary of meeting," Catra teased.

"Monthiversary? What a sap," Adora gave right back.

"You're rubbing off on me is all," she answered back cooly. It's not like she had put it as an alert on her phone's calendar already, and planned out something equally sappy.

"I'll rub *you* off," Adora winked.

"You're such an idiot," Catra laughed, "I love you anyway." She looked panicked as soon as she heard herself say out loud what she was supposed to only be thinking. It was *way* too early for that kind of thing. This is what happens when you've never had a girlfriend your whole stupid life til now. Fuck fuck fuck---

Adora smiled back at her and took her face into her hands. "I love you too." She brought her in close for a kiss that in combination with the words took Catra's breath away.

"I'm pretty sure nothing's going to top that for me tonight," Catra joked to cover up how emotional she was feeling. "Cuddle and sleep?"

"Whatever you want, love," Adora kissed her forehead. "Or should I call you boss? Hmm?"

"Let's save that one for next time," Catra gently guided her partner onto her side so that she could spoon her. "My heart is going to explode as it is."

Thankfully, Catra did not perish of a sexy-blonde-induced heart attack. Instead, they slept peacefully wrapped in each other all night. Adora wasn't sure when it happened, but when she woke up her girlfriend was sleeping on top of her despite the bed being more than enough for the two of them.

"Morning," she cooed as she kissed the top of the brunette's messy hair. Catra mumbled something against her chest that she figured was a return of the greeting. "How about I make us some coffee before I go? I've got a little wiggle room since I'm not opening." One thing she noticed in her girlfriend's kitchen that was well stocked were her coffee supplies. She even had an espresso machine that put their store's to shame. It's a wonder she ever needed to go to Starbucks at all.

"Mmhhm, sure, thank you," Catra responded groggily as she rolled off of her. "Flat white?"

"Good idea," Adora hopped up from bed. She grabbed the t-shirt she had intended to sleep in from her bag and threw on some underwear before heading downstairs. Melog greeted her with a needy mew from his window seat looking out at the sun rising. "Good morning, son," she said happily as she diverted from her mission to give him some pets.

By the time she had finished with their drinks, Catra had finally made her way downstairs and was waiting at the table. Adora walked over and presented them, and started laughing as soon she saw the other woman's shirt.

"Eat the rich, really, Catra? Are you allowed to wear that?"

"I've had it since high school. I probably should retire it," she laughed as she looked down at the front of the well-worn t-shirt. "You know... maybe I should give it to you instead."

"I have earned it." They toasted their drinks to that with a laugh.

After they finished up with coffee, Adora headed upstairs again to shower and put her work uniform on. It turned out that even the other woman's shower was high-tech. She almost had to swallow her pride and ask how to work it, but finally, after serious tinkering, she got everything set right. When she made her way back down the stairs, Catra called out over to her, "Hey, do you know anything that means a chaotic situation that starts with goat? I need five more letters." She must have gone down to grab her newspaper while Adora was gone.

She couldn't help herself. She grabbed her phone and took a picture of Catra, face scrunched up as she stared determinedly at the puzzle. Her short hair had a serious case of bedhead, and she looked so adorably nerdy in her glasses. "If I tell you, can I tweet this?"

"Adora, seriously," she whined as she looked back at her. "Fine, but *only* if you're right."

"Try rodeo," she offered as she peered over her shoulder.

"What the fuck's a goat rodeo and why is that the right answer?" Catra appeared baffled after she filled it in and it lined up perfectly with her guesses for the next spots.

"It's a chaotic situation, obviously."

"Thanks," she laughed as she got up. She wrapped her arms around the barista, "Have a good day at work. Text me if I need to come to yell at someone. What else am I going to do with my Saturday?"

"Plan our big double date with Glimmer, of course," Adora reminded her as she returned the embrace. "She's off today, but maybe wait til noon at least before you try her."

"Right, Need to perfect my plans on how to bribe Glimmer into letting me keep dating you."

"She'll have to. I love you and all," Adora knew they had already said it, but it still made her heart skip a beat.

"True," Catra smiled back at her. "I love you too."

With a few more hugs and kisses to be safe, Adora made her way into the elevator and began preparing her tweet. She figured that DT wouldn't mind her putting something like this up. If anything, it was going to be the fix her image needed. That was the blonde's excuse anyway.

IAdoraCatra: Big Tech's Bad Girl [image of Catra doing her crossword, tongue partially sticking out of her mouth while she was concentrating]

Someone must have texted Catra giving her shit about it. By the time Adora got to work she had a message from her despite her being on DT-enforced social media hiatus.

Catra: I'm being sent fancams that have every nerdy ass photo of me online set to M.I.A.'s Bad Girls. They all start with the one you just took.

Catra: Why is this my life?

Catra: I still love you.

Actually, Adora had another text waiting for her as well.

DT: This is the content I'm living for, Blondie. Look at our girl. Who could say a bad word about this sweet nerd?

She decided that she would call it a success.

Chapter End Notes

From dictionary.com:
goat rodeo [goht roh-dee-oh]
WHAT DOES GOAT RODEO MEAN?
A goat rodeo is a slang term for something going totally, unbelievably, disastrously wrong, and there’s nothing left to do but to sit back and watch the trainwreck.
In other words, a goat rodeo is a chaotic situation, fiasco, or, more vulgarly, a shitshow. And yes, there are also literal goat rodeos. 🐐

Also, I picked it from a from a Washington Post crossword. It felt like horse girl Adora would think of rodeo as a possible follow-up.

Hope you enjoyed! Little light on plot, heavy on the feelings and smut. Next chapter we'll see what Glimmer and Catra come up with.

Comments are my favorite part about sharing stories.

Oh! Shout-out to u/pinkhotchocolate ‘s comment on Reddit that inspired me putting Catra in a “Eat the Rich” shirt.

Eat the Rich

Chapter Summary

Catra deals with the unusual sensation of being a lovesick idiot, and manages to plan things out with Glimmer. Adora and Bow have the world's most harrowing day at Starbucks where they do battle against the dreaded soccer moms. Rich Catra lore is revealed as we start the big double date.

Chapter Notes

This chapter features art by the incredibly talented WinnieWeiner_art who I commissioned for the world's cutest chibi Rich Catra that you'll see as "fan art."

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After Adora left for work, Catra spent her morning trying to keep herself busy so that she would not give in to her desire to count the hours until the other woman returned. There was plenty to do, of course: put in her much-needed grocery order, wonder what to order that Adora would like, brush Melog, buy Melog a shirt that says his moms love him, get out some Valerie generated aggravation against her punching bag, wonder why she hadn't suggested Adora work out in her gym with her yet. *Those abs...Focus, Catra,* she reminded herself. It didn't help that DT had checked in and gushed to her about how perfect Adora was as though she wasn't already aware. Of course, they meant perfect for her image and putting out this drama trash fire. Catra would've given it to her even without all of that.

By the time noon was coming around, she had run out of her usual distractions and was grateful to get plans in motion with Glimmer. When she pulled up the group chat that Bow had already renamed "Best Friend Squad 2.0," she read through the various messages she had missed since immediately muting it the night before.

Bow: CATRA! Hi!

Bow: I'm sorry I didn't realize you were *the* Catra.

Adora : How many Catra's can there be? [laughing emoji]

Bow: True. Plz get here soon. There's a youth soccer tournament nearby. Soccer moms are scary.

Adora: Buckling in now, be there to save you soon.

Adora: Oh my god, guys, Bow and I might die today. It's been almost four hours nonstop. I'm just now taking my ten-minute break. Glimmer, I leave you my sword and pony figure collections. Catra,

all my hoodies and horse shirts.

Glimmer: What's that? I can't hear you over the sound of sleeping in and not having to deal with that shit.

Glimmer: JK I'd come in but then I'd be at overtime and I'll get in trouble

Catra sighed as she took it all in and focused on suppressing her urge to tell Adora to quit and come back home... well, not home, but...

Catra: What the fuck? Why would you get in trouble for overtime?

Glimmer: Because they have to pay us more

Catra: But why would that matter if it's voluntary and it means better customer service?

Glimmer: Tell me about it. I'll send you my resume.

Adora: Aw hi you two! I'm so glad you're on during my break. Also, look at the cutest thing I've ever seen. Someone drew you from this morning already and made it even better:



Glimmer: I'm making that my wallpaper

Catra: I'll pay you not to.

Glimmer: $100

[Catra Apple Pay to Glimmer $100]

Catra: You're too easy, Sparkles. I would've gone up to 1k at least. Also, text me separately to discuss this double date you're demanding.

Adora: I made a collage out of it and the original picture as my wallpaper and I won't be paid off.

Catra: You can do whatever you want, Adora. You know that. [wink emoji]

Glimmer: Ewww not in the group chat.

Bow: ADORA. Get back up here. The green bean dropped a whole container of mocha.

Bow: Ah man I missed free money.

[Catra Apple Pay to Bow $101]

She smirked to herself, knowing that the other woman would be distraught over the extra dollar her boyfriend had earned for nothing. She patiently waited for her to start up the side chat. Surprisingly, Glimmer called her instead. "Wow, a real phone call, how old-fashioned of you," Catra laughed.

"I figured you'd appreciate not having a record of this conversation."

"Is that a threat, Sparkles? Am I about to get blackmailed?" Catra was mainly joking, but honestly, it seemed possible with her life lately.

"What? No, of course not," Glimmer said quickly with a laugh, "I mean if someone hacks my phone or something! The media's obsessed. So, since it's *off the record* , what the fuck is up with this Valerie chick?"

"Ugh, we really have to get into this?"

"Adora's my best friend, and I can tell she's head over heels for you, Richie Rich. I want to make sure she's not going to get her heart broken by you over some other woman."

"I promise you, that's not going to happen," Catra assured her with a heavy sigh. "She's stirring up shit to stay relevant. I want nothing to do with her."

"That's what I figured," Glimmer's voice softened. "I know I probably seem too protective, but Adora is like a sister to me."

"I'm glad she has someone like you. Really. If I ever do something that could hurt Adora, call me out, Sparkles. I don't want that either."

"Trust me. I will gladly take you up on that," Glimmer laughed. "Alright, now that I've put the fear in you, let's talk dates!"

"Obviously, I'll cover whatever we do. So, what do you think everyone would want?"

"Oh. Hmm," she could hear Glimmer continuing to hum to herself in thought and then came back. "I'm a foodie. It would be awesome to try somewhere we can't normally get in. Bow's, um."

"A huge nerd, yes. I've met him."

"Adora's easy. She's game for literally anything. I think it's because of how she grew up, you know," Catra could hear the hesitation in her voice.

"She didn't get to do much. Right? "

"Yeah, exactly. Catra," she paused for a long time. When she started again, her voice was soft and pleading, "This is like a fairytale for her after everything, okay. That's why I'm so worried."

"Glimmer," Catra took a deep breath before continuing with the sappiest thing she was sure she would ever say in her life, "I don't know how else to reassure you. She's *my* fairytale."

Glimmer laughed. "I kind of wish this was on the record now. How am I supposed to remember this for my speech at the wedding?"

"Why the fuck does everyone leap to wedding talk?" Catra groaned. "Can we please plan this one date first?"

After a back and forth comparing schedules, they decided on the following Friday for the big event. Other than that, Glimmer offered Catra complete control over the plans. After the call concluded, Catra realized she'd forgotten something.

Catra: [contact card shared] This is the head of HR. That's who you'd send your resume to. I'm hands-off on hiring if it involves friends.

Adora felt like she positively couldn't take another step by the time she entered the penthouse. She sighed heavily, feeling guilty that she knew she wouldn't be much company for Catra at this rate. All the same, the other woman met her in the hallway and wrapped her arms around her.

"I think I hate soccer now," Adora whined into her shoulder, basking in the clean smell of the other woman's shirt. The barista was sure she smelled like spoiled milk and sweat. "And I *love* soccer."

"I'm sorry," Catra kissed the side of her face. "I'd buy the fields out to shut these things down, but that *kind of* feels like an evil thing to do."

"I'd hate to be the cause of your rich evil villain arc," Adora laughed as she released the other woman, "I'll settle for another bath if you don't mind. I feel gross."

"I think I can arrange that. Do you want some alone time?"

"Not if I can have *you* time," Adora gave a smug smile. She could tell that her girlfriend was pleased with her response despite the earnest offer.

This bath time was all about Adora. Catra sat on the edge of the tub with only her legs dangling in. She shampooed the blonde's long hair and massaged anything presented to her that needed attention. She intently listened to her play-by-play of the most unbelievable parts of her and Bow's day of work. For a moment or two, Adora found herself feeling guilty about soaking up all the attention without giving the other woman anything. Then she caught sight of Catra's face in a reflection, and she saw how perfectly content she looked. Maybe being cared for wasn't as selfish as it seemed.

"Thank you," she blissfully whispered as she looked up into the mismatched eyes of her girlfriend.

Catra kissed the top of her wet forehead. "Least I could do. You and Bow went to coffee war today." Adora could tell there was something else on her mind with how she looked away from her after she finished talking. Before she could ask, the other woman kissed her one more time and slowly swung her legs out of the bath. "You finish up. I'm going to go grab some clothes for you."

Adora tried to read her expression before she headed out. She didn't look upset or anything. Thus, she decided not to Adora this by panicking about nothing, as her best friends would say. Once she was all rinsed and toweled off, she headed into the bedroom to rejoin Catra. She had laid out two options.

"Okay, we have loungewear," Catra gestured to a pair of sweat pants that she had put with her infamous 'Eat the Rich' shirt since she had only worn it a couple of hours anyway. "And we have activewear." That was a pair of shorts and a tank top with nothing exciting on it.

"Not even a contest," Adora laughed as she picked up the eat the rich shirt and sweats. "This is my shirt now, anyway."

Once Adora was dressed, the two could not stop giggling about the ensemble. The shirt had been washed enough times that it barely covered Catra's torso. On Adora, it looked like an awkward length crop top. At least she could roll up the sweatpants a couple of times to make their short length look intentional.

"This is it," Adora declared as she posed in Catra's three-way mirror. "This is my magazine-cover look. Take a pic so that DT can prepare themself."

"Oh, absolutely," Catra chuckled as she pulled out her phone and took a photo as Adora gave her best model pose. "That'll show them for saying you're perfect. Pffft."

"That's okay; nobody's perfect," Adora bent down to pick up the cat that was circling between them for pets. "Except Melog. He's purrfect." She scratched behind his ears lovingly and continued making sweet, doting noises at him.

"Oh yeah, that's why I love you," Catra came up to join the two of them, stroking the cat's back before looking up at Adora. "I'm a secret lover of puns. The Journal quoted that one from a *reliable* source. Do you have any idea how many puns I'm going to get in partnership proposals now?"

"Oooh, I can't wait," Adora cheered as she gently put the cat back down. "Please send me them, and I'll judge by the punniness if you should work with them. If they're earnest enough to think up a good unique pun, I bet they have good business practices."

"I can't think of the last pun I made," Catra countered. "Does that make me a bad businesswoman?"

Adora thought about it for a moment. "Of course not, *boss,"* she winked and enjoyed how immediately flustered Catra became. She casually continued as though she hadn't struck a bundle of nerves, "Did you get groceries yet? I'm starving."

"Ordered, not here yet," she answered quickly, clearly trying to keep calm.

Adora shrugged. "Oh well. Guess I'll have to *eat the rich* instead," she gave a sly smile and waited to see if the other woman was interested.

"I do believe in feeding the hungry," Catra quipped back. Adora happily seized both the moment and her girlfriend.

After a late afternoon into the early evening full of sex, laughter, and warm-fuzzy new relationship feelings, the two finally had to face reality. There was dinner to be attained from somewhere and a nagging to-do list at the back of Adora’s mind.

"As much as I don't want to, I probably should go back home after dinner," Adora said sadly as the elevator descended. "I've got a test on Monday and a couple of papers due this week. I'm sorry."

"Hey, don't apologize for that, dummy," Catra gave a reassuring smile. "I want you to have *everything* you want, Adora. That includes your degree, and I'm not going to stand in the way."

"I really do love you." She glanced back to check the number of floors they had until the lobby. Seeing that she had time, she couldn't help herself. She pressed Catra up against the back wall of the elevator and kissed her with the same reckless abandon she had in the club bathroom. Mentally she ticked down the floors as the dings rang. Leaving only a moment to spare, she released her and moved to her side, modestly holding her hand.

"God damn, Adora," Catra tried to catch her breath and look casual as the two of them stepped out into the lobby. "Fuck work, you're the reason I'm going to have a heart attack."

"Does that mean I should stop?" Adora was a little worried that the other woman wasn't joking.

"Not even a little bit," Catra laughed. "What a way to go."

The two nights apart were more fraught than Catra would've liked to admit, given how early it was in the relationship. She had always been such an independent person, and a couple of months ago, she would've told anyone who asked she preferred being alone. Then came this whole lovesick thing… All the same, she was not going to smother Adora or make her give up anything for her. She could sustain herself on dorky texts for now.

For the rest of the weekend, she found her biggest distraction in burying herself in work. Entrapta wanted to give a pitch for the board to fund a new branch of Darla that focused on robotics. Her prototype, Emily, had become quite proficient in helping with numerous tasks and functioning as an assistant of sorts. But, of course, as with all early drafts, she wasn't perfect. Thus they were tinkering and brainstorming ways to make the next model better. Well, Entrapta would not have used *better* . She loved Emily for her imperfections. The next version would simply be better suited for reliable use and investor-friendly performance.

By Sunday evening, she had been staring at lines of code long enough that it was blurring together when a new text came through.

Adora: [picture of herself posing with a bowl of cereal while wearing some track medals from high school] Brinner of champions facetime date?

Catra cackled, saved the picture immediately, and made a mental note to look into how one hosts an unveiling party. She turned on facetime and was live with the other woman's goofy smile looking back at her, "Hey, Adora."

"Catra!" Adora made a concerned face. "You look terrible. Go get something to eat right now."

"Geez, way to lower a person's self-esteem," she joked as she got up from her desk with a yawn. "Didn't sleep well last night."

"Cause you missed me?"

"Maybe," she smirked.

"How embarrassing for you. Buuuut…I missed you too. I only slept because I was exhausted. I think you'll have to come to see me at Starbucks tomorrow morning."

"Was already planning on it," Catra put the phone down on her counter as she started to prepare her own bowl of cereal. "News people still coming by?"

"Mmmm... not today that I noticed. If they were there yesterday, they definitely left when they saw that shit show."

"That's good. Maybe it's blowing over," she brought Adora-phone back over with her to sit at the kitchen island.

"Not exactly," Adora made an awkward face. "This morning, I may or may not have been tweeted a picture of us walking downtown yesterday."

"Oh my god, the shirt." Catra started laughing, too lovesick and sleep drunk to be worried about her image. "I'm going to retweet that when I get my logins back tomorrow."

"You better not," she waggled her spoon at the phone.

"And what are you going to do about it," Catra said then took a big crunchy bite of cereal.

"Look at you like this." Adora put on the saddest, puppy-dog-eyed face, Catra had ever seen.

"Gah! Fine," she relented. "I think I'm going to bring you the next time I need to land a deal. If it's going sour, I'll have you hit them with those eyes."

"I like it. I can't wait to be your sad eyes trophy wife."

"You can be whatever kind of wife---," Catra started to say but stopped herself, mortified. Did she almost say that to her girlfriend of literal *days*?! She dipped off the screen for a second to recover.

"Catra?" Adora called nervously.

"Mmmhmm? Yeah?" She tried to come back casually. "Sorry, choked a little."

"Finish eating and go to sleep. I think you're getting a little loopy."

"Yeah, that's probably for the best," Catra laughed. "I'll see you in the morning at least."

"I'll be brewing for you," Adora winked. "I love you. Sleep tight."

"I love you too." Sleep came easier that night with the promise of seeing her favorite dorky barista in the morning.

After a week of flirting over coffee orders and finding only a few hours to spend together, Catra could not be more excited for the date night she had planned for the group. She had instructed them to meet her at the Darla complex at four. She stood waiting in the front entrance, tapping her foot and feeling rather anxious to go along with her excitement. This whole love thing was ridiculous, she decided. She wasn't worried earlier in the day when she put her foot down with one of their partners about increasing their wages or Darla would drop them (how hard could it be to make their own tires anyway?). Yet, here she was, worried that the date she planned to impress her girlfriend's friends wasn't going to be good enough. Ridiculous.

She was taken out of her inner thoughts by the sound of the door opening and the trio walking through happily chatting.

"I CAN'T BELIEVE I'M HERE," Bow shouted as he looked around the atrium.

"And now everyone knows it," Catra laughed as she moved up to meet the group. "Customer service is right there, and I'm pretty sure that could've picked up on their phones." He gave her an apologetic nod. "I'll bring you back for a tour, promise. Today we're on a bit of a timeline."

"I thought we were meeting here for a tour," Bow raised an eyebrow.

"Oh, yeah, I guess I let you think that," Catra chuckled. "But no, not today."

"Are we all riding together?" Adora asked as Catra grabbed by the hand.

"Yep, sure are," Catra confirmed but started further into the facility.

After winding through halls and having to pry Bow away windows looking in on tests and manufacturing, Catra finally brought them back outside.

"WHAT?! You make helicopters now?!" Bow asked as his eyes caught sight of the ride the CEO had been talking about. Sure enough, it had the Darla Industries logo on the side.

"I'm so glad I demanded this date," Glimmer said approvingly.

"The things I planned are all at the coast," Catra explained once they were settled into the helicopter and given headsets to communicate over the loud hum of the blades. "Only way to get there without being stuck in traffic for hours."

"And it's the most awesome way to get there," Adora squealed. She was staring down at the world passing below her. Catra knew Adora had never even flown before. There were so many firsts she looked forward to being there for.

After a little under an hour of travel, they landed and were greeted immediately by the car Catra had arranged to pick them up. It was an *intentional* limousine this time. She figured if she had already done a helicopter, anything less than a limo would seem a disappointment.

"What else do you have planned for us," Adora curiously asked as she snuggled against her in the backseat.

"You're going to have to wait and see," Catra smirked. "It's a three-part plan based on your interests, and Bow's part is first."

"What?! Really," he lit up with excitement and was practically bouncing. "What is it?!"

Catra glanced out of the window to get her bearings. "We'll be there in ten minutes. Contain yourself, buddy. Have some champagne." She gestured to the bottle on ice next to Glimmer, who happily accepted the duty of opening it.

With a pop, she declared, "Best Friend Squad Double Date Night!" to the enthusiastic whoop-and-hollering from Bow and Adora.

Catra shook her head, "Man, I knew you were all dorks from being your customer, but I *really* underestimated the amount of dorkiness."

"Aww," Adora whined as she turned Catra's chin to look at her. "Don't be sad, love. You're still the dorkiest of all at this goat rodeo."

The limo pulled up in front of an unlikely stopping point for such a vehicle. It was a giant, retro-looking arcade already all neon and glowing despite the sun not having set yet.

"Wait," Adora said as she got out. "Is this *the* arcade of the arcade story I forgot to ask about!?"

Catra didn't answer; she merely sighed and started in with the trio following behind her. For rows and rows, every legendary, well-loved arcade-machine Bow could think of was lined up.

"This place is AMAZING.” . His eyes scanned over the entire place. "Noooo, I didn't bring any coins."

"It's uh, not a problem," Catra scratched at the back of her head and looked slightly embarrassed. "The arcade story is that, well, Entrapta and I came here with some coworkers celebrating after a big deal. We were drinking and playing games, and then it was time for the place to close. And I decided that I'd rather it *not* close, but the only way to do that was to buy the place. So."

"You drunkenly bought a whole arcade," Glimmer asked with amusement.

"Yep, pretty much. I wrote the owner a check, sent my new 'employees' home with big tips, and told them I'd lock up the place. I thought I was hot shit," she rolled her eyes. "It wasn't even that good of an arcade back then. Terrible investment. I bought most of these machines."

"Is it a real business still," Adora questioned as she looked around. "No one's here."

"Yeah, it does pretty well most days. I booked it out till we're done. The machines are on free-play right now," Catra explained.

With that, Bow was off, running like a kid in a candy store, trying to decide which treat to devour first.

Chapter End Notes

Better, more focused writers than me would've finished writing out this double date before submitting it to publish. *However* I have so many bits planned for it, I didn't want to feel like I was yatta-yattaing too much. I love some good BFS dynamics, and I want to make sure I give them time to develop together. At the same time, I wanted to share more of the story sooner then I thought I’d finish all that. Thus, here we are.

As always, let me know what you think! As the audience for this story has grown (which I'm so grateful for and amazed by!), I've found my paranoia about not writing it well grow too. I hope it's still the fun, low-angst, high-fluff romp you're looking for in an Untitled Rich Catra Story.

Venus

Chapter Summary

The second half of the Best Friend Squad double date concludes with some luxury, laughs, and a little lust. (and some puns)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I was going to complain that this music is annoying, but considering I am smoking you all, I love it! Dayyytoooona." Glimmer sang above the sound of the 90s racing game's soundtrack and her friends' subsequent jeering at her taunts.

Bow took his eyes off the bright screen for a moment to look over to Catra, "It's a classic! I can't believe you got a full eight cabinet! I've never seen one before."

Catra, however, was engrossed in trying to get caught up and barely noticed him talking to her. "Yeah, totally, it's cool," she said quickly, drifting around another curve. At this rate, though, it was rather hopeless. Glimmer took the win, with Catra coming in second and Bow in third. Adora had fallen behind towards the end when she got distracted by her girlfriend's face. She was making the same determined look she had when working on her puzzles.

"You're so cute when you're competitive," Adora teased as she leaned over from her chair and kissed her girlfriend on the cheek.

"Competitive? Me? Never," she winked and then started to get up. "Good game, Sparkles."

"Thank you, thank you," Glimmer dramatically said as she stood and bowed. "I've always said I'm the best driver of the squad, and now I have proof!"

"Uh-huh," Bow laughed. "You're the most exciting driver of all of us. Oooh, Catra? Do you have any of the old TMNT games?"

"Of course," she looked incredulous that he asked. "Should be two aisles that way," she pointed over to the left. With that, the other couple raced off, arguing about who would get to be which turtle. Catra turned to her girlfriend and gave an unsure smile. "Do you think things are going okay so far?"

"Are you kidding? This is the most fun we've had in a long time," Adora enthusiastically confirmed. "And it's only part one! Now, since it's *just* me, what else are we doing, hmm?" She leaned in close, running a hand down the other woman's back as she did, "I won't spoil the fun, boss, promise."

Catra tried to contain the reaction she was clearly trying to coax from her. "Trying to seduce my secrets out of me? Wow, Adora. I should've believed those reports about you being a spy from a competing company," they both began laughing at that. It was the second most unbelievable theory thrown their way. "You know what, I'll make a deal. You pick any game in here, and if you can beat me at it, I'll tell you what we're doing next," she put a hand on her hip as she presented the challenge.

"You're going down!" Adora declared as she started to look around and decide on her machine.

"I mean, if you're in the mood for me to later," Catra followed up quickly with a wink, which caught her off guard. She hoped they would never get tired of getting rises out of each other like this.

After wandering around the large arcade, Adora's eyes lit up when they came in front of a machine she was very familiar with. "This is it," she confidently declared as she stepped up onto the dance platform.

"Are you serious? Of everything in here, you're choosing Dance Dance Revolution?" Catra raised an eyebrow as she watched her girlfriend situate herself on the 'stage.'

"Yes! Unless you're too scared to get beaten by me." Her smuggest smile accompanied the taunt.

"Of course not. I seem to remember you saying you can't dance." Catra stepped up onto the second platform.

"The mall near my house had it, and since it was older, it was super cheap. I'm not going to lie. I am pretty good. But if you're intimidated, you can play beginner. No pressure." She winked.

"Nope, I'm doing whatever you're doing." Catra was not going to back down now.

"Your funeral!" Adora smirked and then started tapping her feet to go through the menu.

Catra quickly regretted this decision because she was already struggling to keep up after fifteen seconds into the song. Adora, meanwhile, was 'gracefully' stomping and bopping her way to combos and a series of 'perfect' ratings. "Give up yet," she joked as she looked over to Catra and still managed not to miss any steps. "I've got this one practically memorized."

"I'll lose with honor," Catra stuck her tongue out and continued trying to keep up.

"Don't panic now, but we have an audience," Adora noted as she waved over to the other couple walking up.

"I'm so recording this," Glimmer's voice carried over the blaring music.

"Adora," Catra panted as they had to hop and were facing each other, "How much longer is this song?"

"One more minute! You can do it," Adora winked and continued effortlessly.

Glimmer and Bow were laughing and cheering them both on as Catra managed to hang in there despite being clearly outmatched. When the song finally ended, Adora cheered triumphantly at her perfect rating while Catra looked happy for it to be over.

"I told you I was good!" The blonde smirked as she looked over at her girlfriend who was paused, leaning back against the hand railing. She waited for a quip back, but instead, she noticed that Catra was staring down and looking unsteady on her feet. Adora immediately hopped over to the other platform and grabbed her as she whispered, "What's wrong? Are you okay?"

Catra waved her concern away and shook her head. "I'm fine, it's.. I didn't eat enough today, that's all. Was a little dizzy."

"Time to get you a snack then, I love a good concession stand," Adora smiled reassuringly. "Do I need to carry you?"

"What, no, I'm fine," Catra tried laughing it off. "You can if you really *want* to."

"You don't have to tell me twice," Adora winked. She held her hand as they stepped down to the floor together and then whipped her up into her arms. She looked over to the other couple, "We'll be right back."

"I'll be here uploading that to Twitter as soon as I get a connection," Glimmer teased, she and Bow were already rewatching the video.

Catra was glad that they seemed to not notice her dizzy spell at the end. She wasn't exactly what the cause was, but she felt fine now and being carried around by Adora wasn't a bad price to pay. "Looks like I should've gone beginner after all."

The blonde was humming to herself the song they had played as she carefully navigated them to the concession area. "Mmmhm, DDR is very serious stuff," Adora gave her a weary smile. "You're sure it's not something serious? We could call it a night if--"

"Absolutely," Catra confirmed quickly. "Just skipping lunch and leftover stress from work is all, I'm sure. Can't blame me for taking advantage of an excuse for you to carry me around, right?"

"Okay," Adora narrowed her eyes at her as though she was trying to get better insight into whether she was hiding something. Then, she brought back another smug smile. "What are we doing next, by the way? You owe me!"

"Right, I almost forgot you nearly out danced me to death," she laughed, but Adora decidedly did not find the comment humorous based on her expression. "We're going shopping. The restaurant we're going to is pretty fancy. Thought I'd treat everyone to a costume change."

"I can't wait to pick out things to make you try on," Adora smirked.

"Only if I get to put *you* in what I want."

"You didn't say this was a clothes optional restaurant," she winked and then gasped as she realized she said this in front of the attendant who had popped up to assist them.

After retrieving some popcorn and soda, they rejoined the other couple and had a Street Fighter tournament. Adora managed to beat Catra (which was due to excessive button mashing, Catra wanted to be noted), and she went to the finals against Bow, who ultimately took the crown.

"I can't believe I bring you all here to share in my greatest shame, and you have the nerve to beat me at every game we played," Catra joked as they headed back out to the limo.

"Hey, I will happily lose to you if you take me back out here again!" Bow patted her on the shoulder. "I promise to never make you play DDR."

"Really? Wow, I might give the place to you with that deal." Catra appeared to be teasing, but she made a mental note to look into it.

Much like the arcade, Catra had paid for the boutique to close to the public while they were there. She'd rather not deal with people in general or if some paparazzi managed to figure out where they were.

"Oh my god! Adora, since you retweeted my video, it's been viewed a few thousand times!" Glimmer declared as she showed the thread.

"Darla CEO, Catra, is having a quarter-life crisis," Catra groaned as she considered the extra exposure. "This is what you're signing me up for, Sparkles."

Adora pulled out her phone and showed it to Catra, "No way. People think we're fun. We're couple goals!"

"Definitely," Glimmer assured her. "You both look so cute in this; it's gross, really. Plus, you're young, Catra! You're allowed to have fun and be a business god." She stopped in her tracks as they reached a display of dresses. "Oh, wow! Talk about, *Sparkles,"* she declared as she held out one she picked for herself-- a shimmery lavender knee-length cocktail dress. "What do we think?"

"I love it!" Bow shouted from the other side of the store. "Oh! I think I can match." He started flipping through some options as she headed his way with her pick.

Catra and Adora laughed as they continued hand in hand, waiting for something to catch their eye. "Are we going to be like that?" Catra asked, and the blonde tilted her head in confusion. "You know, matching and all? I've noticed they always look like they go together. Would you want that?"

"If you do," Adora looked down at her with such glowing affection. "I'd love for everyone to know we're a set like a pair of shoes... a couple of *sole* mates!"

Catra couldn't help but burst into laughter, as stupid as it was. "Why are you like this?!"

"I don't know, why do you love it," Adora smirked. She couldn't argue against that. "Sole mate, I think I'd like to see you in..." she grabbed for the item she had been eying on the wall. "This!" Adora held out an all-black sleeveless jumpsuit with a deep-v plunge for the neckline and a small cape attached at the left shoulder.

"Cape's not normally my style, but I'll give it a try for you," Catra mused as she ran her hands over the fabric. "I do like a good jumpsuit. I was thinking about that one for you." In fact, she knew it was the one the moment she saw it. Everything about it spoke to the goddess she believed Adora to be. It was a cream crochet jumpsuit with gold sequins layered over golden silk. The bodice was twisted with cutouts at the waist and back and finished with a halter neckline decorated in crystals.

"Catra, that's too nice," Adora's jaw dropped. "Seriously, are you sure? I'll probably tear it before we even get to dinner!"

"Eh, wouldn't be my worst investment. We already went there today. Come on, please, I've got to see you in it." Adora gave in and nodded enthusiastically. Catra gestured for the employee at the front desk who had been waiting on them. The delicate jumpsuit was intentionally hung out of reach. "We'll take that in her size."

"Of course, Ms. Catra. I'll have it in your dressing room if you'd like to look at accessories. I'll add this one as well," he reached out and took the black jumpsuit from Adora.

After picking out some coordinating jewelry and shoes for their black and gold theme, they headed back to the dressing room.

"Don't suppose either of us can wear bras with these," Catra pointed out as she took hers off and added it to her neatly folded pile of work clothes.

"Should've seen it coming, really," Adora teased as she came up behind her girlfriend and reached around to cup her breasts. She ran her fingers over her nipples, "These are half of why I want to see you in that."

Catra's voice dropped into a low, sultry tone as she asked, "What's the other half?" She leaned back into the other woman as she gazed up at her.

Adora brought her lips to her ear as she whispered, "You're going to look fucking hot with that cape, boss." She laughed to herself as she winked and released her.

Catra took a deep breath and tried to calm herself, her cheeks flushed and heart racing. "You love doing this to me, don't you?"

"I can't help myself," Adora finished taking off her street clothes and stood watching Catra try to focus on her potential new outfit. "I could help you with that, though."

"I think I've got it," she shrugged as she started to unzip the jumpsuit while it hung on the wall. "Not like yours, you're definitely going to need---" Whatever she was going to say, it fell away as Adora placed her hands on her again unexpectedly. This time her fingers glided over the thin fabric of her underwear. Catra braced herself against the back wall of the small dressing room.

"You did say you were still holding onto some *tension* from work, and I am going to be a physical therapist," Adora whispered, gliding her hand back over to squeeze her thigh as she waited for her reaction.

"Uh-huh," Catra swallowed hard. "Don't think they're teaching you this in school."

"All self-taught. So... would you be okay if I---"

"Yes, please," she whimpered as the other woman started to pull away from her. *Fucking whimpered, god damn, this is what Adora reduced her to.*

Adora quickly pushed back in, pressing herself against Catra’s back. "Somebody's been ready for this," she whispered as she slipped her hand in and felt the silky wetness waiting for her.

"Always ready for you," Catra managed before she had to bite her lip to hold back the noises that were already wanting to escape. She could tell she wasn't going to last long as Adora brushed her thumb against her already very sensitive clit. She wasn't about to complain about it being fast. The last thing either of them needed was getting caught doing this. However, she did need *this* -- Adora's fingers artfully playing against her and forcing the CEO's busy mind to be able to focus solely on her pleasure. When Catra could tell she was getting close, she grabbed for Adora's free hand and moved it over her mouth.

"Good idea," her partner whispered. "No one else gets to hear you like this but me."

Fuck that was sexy . Between that declaration and those skilled fingers, Catra was done for. "Adora," she moaned, muffled into her girlfriend's hand, and her knees felt like they were going to give out.

Thankfully, Adora transitioned into holding her up as she worked through the feeling. "How are your stress levels now, boss?"

"Gone," Catra happily confirmed as she straightened back up. "Thanks. That was...unexpected."

"Really? I've been thinking about it since-"

"Is there anything else I can bring you, Ms. Catra?" another muffled voice called out.

"NO," Catra shouted, probably a little too defensively. "We're good. Almost done. Thanks!"

"That didn't sound suspicious at all," Adora giggled. "Better hurry before Glimmer's knocking next."

Once they put their minds to it, they were able to get dressed quickly enough to cover up for their little distraction. As they stood staring at themselves in the mirror, Catra sighed, "This outfit on you was a mistake."

"Really? I love it," Adora spun and showed the back. "What's wrong with it?"

"I'm not going to be able to think about anything else all dinner," Catra smirked as she eyed her up and down. "You're so gorgeous, Adora."

Before Adora could respond, there was a knock at the door. "Hey! You guys okay in there? Glim and I are ready!" Bow asked innocently, and they could hear Glimmer snickering in the background.

They quickly headed out to meet the other couple and were very impressed with their outfit selection. Bow found a light grey button-up crop top that he paired with a matching lavender suit jacket and white pants. Glimmer's sparkling lavender dress was paired with matching heels. The squad looked like they were on their way to a red carpet or a magazine spread. Still, their silly natures betrayed them as they joked and laughed with each other as they left. Catra paid the bill on her own lest anyone (i.e. Adora) feel guilty about the price of everything before heading out to join them in the limo.



Beautiful Art by Piritos

Catra had picked a well-lauded restaurant on a cliff edge that overlooked the ocean. With a private table right beside the floor-to-ceiling windows, they had the perfect view of the sun setting over the sea. Adora couldn't stop smiling as she watched the light sparkle on the waves as they rolled. The menu offered a small plates concept with everything from staple fine-dining dishes to experimental cuisine, unlike anything the trio had ever seen. Of course, they opted for ordering plenty of the latter.

"Catra, this is AMAZING," Glimmer declared after sampling the first dish she ordered.

"This whole day has been like a dream." Bow held up his cocktail glass, "A toast to our host!"

"To Big Tech's Bad Girl," Adora chimed in as she held up hers, and the others repeated her as they clinked glasses.

"I hate you all," Catra pretended to be annoyed, but honestly, she was relieved it had gone well thus far.

"Do you think you'll retire while you're young," Bow casually asked as he cut into his food. "You wouldn't have to deal with all this press stuff anymore. Seems pretty annoying!"

"Fuck no," Catra shook her head emphatically. "I love what we're doing with Darla. If I stop loving it or I start being bad for the company, I'll step down, but I'd never do it because of those assholes."

"I can't imagine being in charge of something that huge at our age," Glimmer noted with wide eyes. "Running a shift at Starbucks is enough pressure for me right now."

Catra scrunched her face up for a moment and stared at her food as she answered, "Yeah, it's stressful or whatever sometimes, but nothing I can't handle."

"Plus, now she has me," Adora smirked as she squeezed Catra's hand below the table. "I make her laugh *and* help her relax."

"Don't know how I survived without you, really," Catra's smile reappeared as she turned and got lost in her girlfriend's eyes.

"Awww," Bow cooed as he watched the display. "You are the cutest couple ever."

"Hey!" Glimmer protested with a laugh.

"Other than us, babe, obviously."

The rest of the dinner went by smoothly as they filled themselves with enough food and banter to last a lifetime. Of course, they still found enough room for a selection of mind-numbingly delicious desserts.

"This seriously has been the perfect day," Adora contently declared once they finally left and the cool, salty air hit them. "I don't want it to end."

"Good thing it isn't over yet," Catra could hardly contain her excitement for the next surprise. "I forgot to mention that the shopping was part one and a half. The next thing, I picked for you. We actually can walk there from here."

With that, she led them down a set of stairs that winded around to the beach below. Torches set in the sand aided the moonlight in revealing what was, in fact, the third 'part' to the date.

"OHMYGOD" Adora squealed out in one word. "Really?! Is this it?! This is my part?!"

"It is," Catra confirmed with a wide smile.

They hurried across the sand to two beautiful riding horses and their owner. "Good evening!" She said cheerily. "Everybody, meet Venus and Diana."

"Hi Venus and Diana," Adora's hands were pressed to her cheeks as she spoke and approached carefully as not to spook them. She looked to the owner with pleading eyes, "Can I pet them?"

"Of course, honey, you're going to ride one! Now, this lovely lady is Venus," she said as she patted the mane of the chestnut brown horse. "And this here's, Diana," she explained as she gestured to the dapple gray.

Adora took her time loving on both horses, stroking them softly and whispering sweet nothings about how they were the most beautiful horses ever. Catra decided this was handily the biggest win of her date planning.

"I think the newlyweds should get Venus," Glimmer joked as she approached the gray horse. "Goddess of love and all!"

"Oh, congratulations! You didn't tell me you were getting married!" The owner looked to Catra. "Now, as we discussed, I've placed some guiding torches along your way to your destination. Once you arrive, tie up our gals here and let me know."

"Thank you," Catra didn't have it in her to correct the woman. "Promise I won't let this one run off with them," she joked as she watched her girlfriend, who was hugging 'their' horse, Venus.

Once they were briefed on horseback riding safety and rules for the beach, they mounted their noble steeds. Adora happily took the reins and did what little guiding Venus needed. Glimmer, Bow, and Diana followed along behind.

"Catra, I can't... I can't even," she choked out, overcome with excitement and emotion. "I love you and I love this so much."

"I love you too," Catra said as she kissed the side of her face. "Figured my horse girl would be happy with this."

"I didn't even know I could be this happy." It was truly a perfect evening -- the sky was clear and full of stars to accompany the bright moon. The ocean waves soothingly rolled in and out against the shore.

"Me either." Catra snuggled against her tighter and rested her chin against her shoulder.

They let the rest of the ride pass in comfortable silence as they enjoyed the majesty of it all. Finally, they reached the end of the torches, and everyone carefully dismounted.

"Is the limo going to pick us up here?" Bow asked as he looked around. The street attached to the beach was relatively empty and appeared residential.

"Nope." Catra shook her head dismissively. "At least not tonight anyway." She pointed to a yellow beach house above them. "Did I forget to mention this is an overnight?"

"But... I have work in the morning," Adora panicked. "Catra, I don't want to ruin everything. I'm so sorry."

"Actually," Glimmer smirked as she went to stand beside Catra. "Guess who pulled some strings and got your shifts covered?!" She and Catra exchanged an entirely too-cool-to-not-be-planned fist pound.

"Annnd," Catra pulled out her phone and made a couple of quick transactions. "I'm covering your lost wages. If you need more, let me know."

"I can't believe it! This gets better and better," Bow looked down at his phone as it pinged. "Wait, a thousand dollars?! Thank you, but this is too-"

"Bow! Shush. I think we all need to accept that we have a friend who's rich as fuck and be cool about it."

"Finally, somebody gets it. Thanks, Sparkles," Catra winked.

Chapter End Notes

As always, feedback and comments are so appreciated. Thanks for reading!

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Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora have some talks about their pasts. The whole squad has a ton of fun at the beach house, and enjoy the rest of their time before returning to the real world where new opportunities and challenges present themselves.

Chapter Notes

Content Warning: This is a chapter that will touch briefly on the loss of Catra's parents at a young age as a result of a car accident.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Sparkles, why don't you and Bow head up already? Your bags should be in one of the first-floor bedrooms," Catra suggested, and the other couple began up on their way to the beach house. She turned her attention back to Adora, who was stroking Venus's mane. "Thought you might like to wait until their owner gets here."

"Of course! We wouldn't want these beauties to be all alone," Adora confirmed with the biggest smile. "Right, Venus? Hmm?"

"Have you always been such a horse girl," Catra asked as she joined her. She started to reach to pet Diana but got spooked when she moved. This evening had marked her first experience with the horses up close.

"Pretty much! During summers off from school, I'd get to spend a few weeks with my cousins. They lived on a farm with a couple of horses. I practically spent every minute with them," she wistfully recalled as she reached over and guided her girlfriend's hand to pet the gray horse. "She likes you! Don't be scared."

"I'm not scared! This is new for me. I spent my summers watching TV and sweating when the AC went out half the time."

"Mmhm, that was me when I was back home. At least the farm gave me something interesting to say for back to school."

"I *hated* that. What did you do this summer? Fucking nothing, Miss Jones, but please make me share that with Samantha and her trip around the world," she laughed to herself as she remembered, "I eventually started making shit up based on the shows I watched."

"Brilliant."

"Little me certainly thought it was. We only had one TV, and my foster mom always watched these super old shows. Kids didn't know any better to call me out."

"Catra," Adora ventured softly. "I haven't asked because, well, I thought you'd share when you're comfortable, but..."

Catra sighed and gave her a knowing look as her girlfriend's voice trailed off. "How did I end up in foster care?" Adora nodded. "Can we talk about it after she comes for the horses?"

"Of course, or we don't even have to talk about it. I don't want to upset you," Adora frowned, worried that she had ruined the moment.

"No, it's fine. We should talk about it. But right now, I want to focus on how *adorable* you are with horses," she gave a wink and mimicked one of Adora's amused grins.

"Aw, you made a pun for me. You really do love me," Adora placed a hand to her heart. "Oh! That reminds me. Will you take a picture?"

"Be a shame not to," Catra stepped back and lined up a photo on her phone. Adora and the horses were aglow with the light of the guiding torches set in the sand around them. "Say cheese."

"More like hay!" Adora declared, earning a pained laugh from her girlfriend as she took the picture.

"As awful as *that* was, this picture is something else," Catra showed her. "You look magical. Is it okay if I share this? I haven't posted anything about you on my page yet."

"Whoa, definitely," Adora confirmed as she looked over the picture. "Ooh! You go over there too, and I'll post the same kind of picture of you. I think DT would say this is good content."

"If you really want." Adora quickly nodded with a goofy grin, and Catra was helpless to her request. "Okay, okay."

"Sayyyy hay!" She giggled as she watched her girlfriend roll her eyes before smirking for the photo. "*You* make the hottest horse girl."

After a while longer of lingering with the majestic beasts, their owner arrived, and the horses were on their way back home. The couple walked down the shoreline to sit on a small bench, looking out at the water.

After sitting in silence for a while, Catra sighed. "I haven't talked about this in a long time. God, since high school, I guess, when I started therapy."

Adora squeezed her hand, "I love you. You can share as much or as little as you want."

"I love you too," she took a deep breath and closed her eyes, focusing on the rhythmic sound of the ocean to keep herself grounded. "My mom and dad passed away when I was in second grade. My mom was estranged from her family, so none of them were in my life. From what I little I know, they were awful to her. My dad was an only child, and his parents were halfway across the country and were too old to want to take a kid. I had only seen them a couple of times anyway. Thus, foster care. The people I ended up with were nice enough. It just never felt like a real family because I knew already what that was supposed to feel like. Nothing was going to replace my parents. I wish you could've known them. They were a couple of dorks too, would've loved your jokes. When we get back to my place, if you want, I've got some photos and stuff I can show you."

"I would love that," Adora whispered, moving her arm around her shoulders and pulling her close, "I'm so sorry, Catra."

"The fucked up thing is, losing my parents is a part of what brought me to the industry in the first place. They died because some asshole teen was texting and driving; he swerved into the opposite lane when they were on their way to pick me up from school. When my counselor pulled me aside and said they were in a car accident, I didn't believe them. My dad was the slowest, most overly cautious driver. Seriously, my mom would lie and tell him an earlier time to get places, so he'd have a shot at being there on time. And all it took was one idiot…" She gritted her teeth and shook her head, trying to dismiss the anger that was bubbling up.

Adora moved her hand down from her shoulder to brush against the exposed skin on her back. Catra breathed, focused on the sound of the water and the feeling of her soft caresses, and found the space to start again. "Making Darla felt like finding a way to solve that problem. Can't trust people like that to stay focused long enough to get from point a to point b safely, but my cars will. I think of my parents as my first investors, because when I turned eighteen, I got what was left of a small life insurance policy, about three thousand dollars. It covered the first few months at my apartment and a decent computer when I graduated so I could focus on getting our start-up going."

"Wow," Adora continued her soft, loving touches, "I'm sure they would be so proud of you. I know I am."

"Thanks," she lifted her head to meet her gaze. The amount of affection she saw reflected in Adora's eyes made her feel like her heart might burst with love. Still, more tears were welling up in her own. She tried her best to blink them away. "Sorry, god, this was supposed to be a good time. I didn't mean to unload all of this stuff on you tonight."

"I asked you because I want to know. Thank you for telling me. I know how hard that must have been."

"You're the only person I have told about all of this. I even had my foster family sign an NDA in exchange for a 'gift' so it wouldn't spread once we were getting big. Because, yes, that was a traumatic and shitty thing that shaped who I am, but that's <u>not</u> my whole story... or Darla's, for that matter. And the way the media is… that's all they'd focus on. People love a tragedy."

"You're not a tragedy, Catra; you're a triumph," Adora cupped her face in her hands and kissed her softly before pressing their foreheads together.

"I like the sound of that better. Thanks." After they parted, she wiped away the last of the tears that had gathered. "Do you think Sparkles and Bow will be able to tell I was crying? Don't want to bring the whole mood down."

"If they ask, I'll say it's because umm… I told a hysterical joke, and you laughed until you cried."

"I don't know, sounds pretty unbelievable to me," Catra laughed as she stood up from the bench and offered a hand to Adora, "Alright, ready to check out this place?"

They headed off hand in hand up to the beach house while Adora tried out some more awful jokes to lighten the mood and prepare them to be social again. They were taken aback by the loud music blaring from the sound system as they entered. Glimmer and Bow were having a two-person dance party in the middle of the big, open concept first floor of the three-story beach house. Adora scanned over the space with wonder as she took in all the details.

It was luxurious and modern with high ceilings and gorgeous furniture. However, it also had the unique attribute of looking as though half of the decor belonged more to a cheesy, kitsch-inspired rental. For instance, the chandelier hanging over the dining area along with dangling crystals had blown glass tropical fish catching the light. While every bit as grand as Catra's, the kitchen featured flamingos on the provided linens and the backsplash. The other couple had mixed up some beverages poured into pink flamingo glasses and left a pair for them on the white marble island.

"This is amazing!" Adora said as she pointed out all of the goofy details.

"See, Sparkles," Catra shouted over the music. "Told you we needed a place with character."

"The character of a rich grandma!" Glimmer shouted back over.

"WE MADE SEX ON THE BEACH," Bow shouted, then started cackling, clearly a little tipsy already. "THE DRINK, I mean! NOT real sex, we didn't have sex while---" Glimmer covered his mouth and shook her head.

"Wow, we've been missing quite the party," Adora winked as she picked up their flamingo beverages and handed one to her girlfriend.

"Apparently," Catra laughed, then tried her drink. "Not my choice of cocktail, but it'll do."

"Not my choice of sex, either," Adora noted flatly. "Seems like you'd get sand all in your bits. Sorry if that's on the itinerary."

Catra nearly spat out the next drink she was taking. Adora’s delivery was so earnest, making it that much funnier. "Pfft, now I've got to update the sex agenda I made for us." Lest Adora decide to get her heart racing again with the boss talk 'sex agenda' probably invited, Catra grabbed for her hand and led them further in to join the others. "Ready for some *real* dancing and not stomping around?" Adore nodded hesitantly. "DJ Sparkles, can I get something slow?"

"On it," she grabbed her phone off of the coral-reef-themed coffee table and swapped it to her romance playlist. She turned the lights to a soft, pinkish hue before going back to her dance partner.

After sitting down their beverages, Catra held out a hand to Adora as she bowed slightly, "May I have this dance, princess?"

"Princess," Adora asked with a raised eyebrow as she took her hand, grateful they had switched to slow dancing.

"Have you seen yourself," Catra answered smoothly as she began to lead them through a slow dance.

"If I'm a princess, then you're a queen," Adora smirked.

"I'll take it," Catra laughed to herself, then dipped her low, "I look forward to combining our kingdoms."

As she was swept back up, Adora narrowed her eyes as she asked cheekily, "Is this a proposal?"

"When I propose, you won't have any doubt," Catra whispered in her ear as she pulled her close again.

Catra and Adora retreated to the third floor after the squad had tired themselves out dancing, laughing, and making plans for their morning. The top floor was set up as a master suite and, mercifully, lacking in much of the goofy decor. Well, aside from a giant painting of a parrot that Catra was pretty confident was staring at her no matter where she moved in the hall.

"Shoot," Adora realized something as she started to take off her shoes, "I know you wanted this to be a surprise, but I wish I would've known to pack! We'll have to go shopping tomorrow morning if we want to go swimming."

"I may have already solved that problem," Catra walked over to the closet and opened it. She had sent her assistant with some items the day before. Adora finished kicking off her shoes and walked over to join her in gazing into the closet. Inside was a collection of swimsuits in different styles and some general beach wear -- flowy dresses, shorts and tanks, sandals, and a couple of giant hats. It helped that Adora had to give all of her sizes to DT. "I got a *little* carried away. Wasn't sure what you'd like."

"Catra! You didn't have to do this," Adora declared as she started to examine all of the beautiful pieces. "It's all so cute. I love everything. Thank you," she turned and wrapped her arms around her.

"You're welcome," she squeezed back and kissed the side of her neck. "Shopping for you is my new favorite hobby."

"Are you sure that's your favorite because," Adora let her go and pointed down a familiar chest on the floor of the closet, "Is that what I think it is?"

Catra sheepishly nodded while she shrugged, "Okay, second favorite."

"There *is* a sex agenda," Adora declared with a gasp.

"There is something I've been thinking about since I picked this place online," she bit her lip for a moment, then gestured over to the sliding glass doors that led out to a big, private balcony facing the ocean.

Adora looked over and then back to her with a grin as she raised her eyebrows, "Tell me more."

"I want to sit you down on one of those big comfy chairs, bury my face between these thighs," she demonstrated with gliding her hand on one, "And see how long you can last before we have to come inside, so you don't wake up the neighbors. Thoughts?"

"I approve, boss," she winked. "Get that open, because I have an.. oh, shit, what's it called um.. when you add something to an agenda."

"An addendum?" Catra asked with a laugh as they grabbed the chest and brought it over to the large bed. She put her code in and stepped out of the way. "Have at it."

Adora started rummaging through the various items and produced a box. She cleared her throat and continued in a very businesslike tone, "My addendum is I get to use this on you while you do it. And we'll see *who* has to give up first."

Catra's eyes went wide for a moment as she took in the challenge. Adora had pulled out something new she had recently added to the 'collection,' as it were: a remote-controlled bullet toy. Although, she bought it thinking about using it on her girlfriend. She swallowed and nodded, "Addendum

approved." Internally, she lamented that she was probably about to lose *another* game today, but, like all the others, it would be fun to play.

Adora gave a wicked smile. "This is going to be fun. Help me out of this?" Catra carefully undid the clasps and zipper that helped the delicate jumpsuit stay on. Adora slowly stepped out of it and hung it up in the closet. She opened the box and handed over the bullet portion to her girlfriend. "You get yourself *situated,* and I'll see you out there." With that, she made her way towards the balcony, hips swaying as she could feel her girlfriend's eyes on her naked body. She glanced back over her shoulder, "Oh, and, could you put the outfit back on after? I was right about that cape."

"Fucking hell," Catra let out a sharp exhale after Adora left, and she went about 'situating herself,' as she had put it. She could hardly believe that she had gone from being single forever to *this,* not that she was complaining. While she was pulling back on her outfit, she jumped as she felt a sudden, surprising sensation from the toy.

She hurried her way out, and Adora was looking smug as she sat waiting for her, "What's wrong, my love? You look flustered."

"You're not playing fair already," Catra gave her best attempt at faux anger.

"Wanted to make sure it works," Adora winked.

"Uh-huh," she leaned down and tilted her chin up to look at her. "Are you ready to start, princess?"

"Always ready for you," she repeated her own words back, "I think we should establish a safeword, you know, for when you give up. How about... espresso?"

"Espresso, of course," Catra laughed, then shook her head, "Works for me."

Without further warning, Adora tinkered with the remote in her hand and enjoyed seeing the other woman lose her focus. Not to be outdone so soon, Catra buried the noises she was already making by bringing her girlfriend into a deep kiss. She ghosted her fingertips along her breasts and to her center. Adora's hips lifted off the chair to try to meet her touch, but she pulled away as she stepped back to kneel in front of her.

Before getting to her main conquest, she took time to kiss and nibble at her thighs, earning muffled whimpers. She was tempted to continue teasing her, but Adora had already ramped up the toy's vibration. Catra simply wasn't going to lose before she had even gotten a chance to taste her. Plus, she couldn't think of a better way to bury her own desperate noises. She gently pushed her legs apart as far as they would go against the chair. Even in the dim light of the moon, the sight of her exposed like this was mesmerizing. She kissed her clit delicately before pressing in with her tongue with slow, deliberate motions.

"Fuuuck, Catra," Adora groaned softly into her free hand. With the other, she swapped the remote to a new setting that was pulsating. Catra's reaction was to moan against her sensitive skin, and that only made it worse in the best way.

Catra looked up at her as she worked, gauging her responses to various speeds and pressures. God, she could practically get off from pleasing Adora alone. Not that she would let her, because it seemed as though every time she thought she had Adora on the edge of a scream, she would react with a sharp change to the vibe, and Catra would have to pull back. They continued this back and forth until finally, Adora took her hand off her own mouth long enough to whisper a needy, "Espresso."

"Oh, thank god," Catra said as she leaned back. "Finish this up inside?"

"Yes, please," Adora mumbled happily.

They hurried inside as quickly as their shaky legs would carry them and started back up again. This time Catra pulled from her chest of toys the 'magic' air one they had enjoyed previously. She continued working her girlfriend with her fingers and now the added toy. At the same time, Adora had not forgotten about the one inside of her. She continued ramping it up until the two of them came nearly simultaneously, calling each other's names. At that moment, Catra felt grateful that she had found a rental that put the other couple a couple of floors below them.

Once she collected herself from between the blonde's thighs, Catra worked her way up to the top of the bed and gently rolled her over to spoon her. "Thoughts?"

"I can't think," Adora breathed.

"Now you know how you make me feel all the time," Catra laughed as she kissed the back of her neck. "You shut my whole brain down."

"Good," Adora snuggled back into her, closing what little distance there was. "You need the break."

"I think you're right about that," Catra mused.

As they wound down from all the excitement, they continued to whisper sweet nothings to each other and finally drifted off into a peaceful sleep. They woke with the sunshine beginning to peek into the windows and play out over the sea. Adora threw on a t-shirt and went out onto the balcony to enjoy the beginning of the day. It was glorious, all oranges and pink mixing with the blue as the day started.

"You know, I can still see your butt," Catra noted as she came out to join her. She had put on a robe and brought one out to her.

"A lot more than my butt was on display out here last night," Adora winked as she put on the robe, covered in designs of various animals wearing sunglasses.

"I can't start thinking about that, or we're never going to make it downstairs to see Sparkles and Bow."

"No more sex agenda?"

"Not unless you plan on feeling me up in a bathroom at brunch," Catra teased and then immediately followed it with, "Actually, as much as I'd like it, let's not. I think she already knew something was up in the dressing room."

"Truce," Adora held out a hand, and they shook very seriously. "Wait, is a couple's shower out of the question?"

"Allowable, it's good time management," Catra laughed and started leading her back inside.

Once the couple showered without getting too distracted, they went about getting dressed. Adora opted for a yellow tank top Catra bought for her that said 'Beach please' and a pair of shorts. Of course, she topped it with one of those ridiculously giant beach hats. Meanwhile, Catra had gotten herself a light blue short-sleeved button-up decorated with tiny pineapples that she paired with dressier shorts. It wasn't her usual style, but it felt like as close as she could get to Adora dorkwear. Once they were ready, they met the other couple downstairs where they were drinking coffee on the first-floor deck.

"Good morning!" Bow cheered, ever the chipper one.

Adora yawned and stretched before replying, "Morning. Sleep well?"

Glimmer and Bow exchanged a knowing look. "Oh, yeah! We, um, slept great, thanks," she blushed and quickly changed the subject, "We're really excited about brunch."

"Me too, I'm starving," Catra complained; her stomach had been yelling at her since she woke up. "Ready to get to it? It's walkable from here."

The rest of their time on the double-date went by as perfectly as the first half. Brunch at the mom-and-pop style place Catra had found was nearly as delectable a feast as the night before's fine dining. After changing into their swimsuits and applying copious amounts of sunscreen, the squad played on the beach for the rest of the day until it was time to get ready to go back home. They had only booked one night because the trio each had something they needed to finish up for school (and, Catra, of course, could find something from work that needed doing). Still, every minute of the short trip had been fun enough to recharge them for the week ahead.

Reentry to the real world of school deadlines and slinging coffee had been going okay for Adora. She and Catra had already made plans to see each other again on Wednesday, and that was enough to tide her over along with their facetime dinner dates. Tuesday afternoon, she was in the zone making drinks while thinking over what to add to the couple's playlist they were building when Glimmer tapped her on the shoulder.

"Hey, you've got a call," she said as she handed over the phone's cordless phone. "I'll take over for you." Adora raised an eyebrow but took the phone anyway and headed towards the back.

"I don't see why everyone is making a big deal about this," Catra felt small as she sat at her desk, and her coworkers were standing around staring back at her. "I'm fine."

"Catra," DT sighed as they looked over at the rest of the group for backup. "You fainted during a meeting this morning. You're not fine."

"I got checked out," she protested, though trying not to get too worked up. "The EKG was fine. The nurse said it was stress-related. I need to take it easier than I have been, that's all."

"Which is why we're asking you to take a vacation," Lonnie crossed her arms and looked back at the CEO very sternly.

"I can't! We've got the shareholders' meeting in three weeks," she gestured to her co-founder and CTO, "Entrapta, tell them! The robotics proposal. I can't just take time off right now."

"I agree with our friends," Entrapta noted as she looked up from the tablet she was holding. "While your help has been instrumental in our progress thus far, I can finish it on my own! Plus, I've got Emily. We'll get it done."

"Do you know how this is going to look? Everyone's going to think I'm losing it," Catra huffed.

DT waved off the concern. "*Imagine* for a moment, if this happened outside of company property? Everyone that knows what happened *here* won't say anything."

"Exactly," Lonnie added. "Seriously, Catra, if you're only going to listen to the *business* part of this, what will they say if you end up in the hospital? Or this happens on the stage at the meeting?"

"I guess that's true," she grumbled to herself. "But--"

Her phone speaker kicked on. "Excuse me, Ms. Catra," her receptionist said, "You have a visitor."

"Finally," DT mumbled to themself before leaning down to answer, "Send her in."

Apparently, the visitor had not been waiting for permission because the door to the office burst open before DT even finished. "CATRA," Adora yelled as soon as she entered. She was still wearing her Starbucks uniform. "What's going on?! Are you okay? They said you passed out," she hurried across the room, paying no mind to the small gathering, and slipped around the desk.

"I'm fine, Adora, please, calm down," Catra softly replied.

"No, you are not," Adora quickly replied as she looked over her face then to DT. "She almost fainted Friday too. Did someone call an ambulance?"

"Adora, honey, it's okay. We have a company nurse on-site," DT answered and handed over a clipboard of the nurse's notes. "They checked her out, ran some tests, and she's got an appointment to see her regular physician for a follow-up. It's stressed induced is the conclusion right now. They suggested she take some time off."

"Oh, okay," Adora started to panic a little less as she read over the details. "That's a good idea."

"Blondie gets it!" Lonnie gestured at the other woman. "Thank you."

"But--" Catra started, scrunching her face up.

"Catra, please," Adora looked at her with those big blue eyes full of concern. "Do it for me? So I don't have to worry about you."

"Fine," she relented, knowing full well this is why they had called in her girlfriend. "Tell me again how this is going to work without me," she asked towards her collection of coworkers.

"I've got it all worked out," Entrapta swiped on her tablet, and a screen in the middle of the wall lit up. It was a flowchart of various duties and responsibilities. "Lonnie will take over your day-to-day. Rogelio will step in for Lonnie; we've got some new people in engineering that can split his duties. I'll handle anything that needs executive approval. Finally, DT will handle any press inquiries about your much-needed vacation. Given that it has been," she swapped over to some notes, "Nine hundred and eighty days since your last vacation day, I think the media will be forgiving."

"Sounds perfect to me," Adora smiled reassuringly at the reluctant CEO.

"And so it's settled, yes, kitten?" DT asked, and Catra nodded wordlessly. "Fabulous. We'll leave you and miss blondie her to make plans about how you're going to spend your time off."

Chapter End Notes

Wowee. This was a jam-packed chapter! I am excited to hear what readers' take aways are and what you think about what's to come. Thank you for reading!

ALSO: NO, Catra is not dying or about to actually have a heart attack. I have always been super adamant about this being a sweet, comfort fic. She really just needs a break! 980 days since a vacation?! Adora is there and happy to provide all the relaxation she needs :)

Past, Present, Future

Chapter Summary

This chapter explores some of the time before Catra and Adora met each other. We end with Adora getting Catra home and the forced vacation begins.

Chapter Notes

I had planned to actually put more in this chapter, but I realize it's been a long time since the last update! Why not two medium chapters instead of one long one, right?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The thumping sound of music filled her ears as Catra stood back in the hallway staring into the giant conference room turned... nightclub? That's what it resembled right now. The description in the schedule said there would be music and drinks, but it did not give the impression of the full-blown bacchanalia before her. Older, severe business people she'd been trying to hold her own with and impress were worked into this mass of people now, shaking it like there was no tomorrow. Not that she was judging them; everybody deserved to let loose sometimes. She merely wished she had been prepared for *this*.

"What a fascinating display," Entrapta enthusiastically said beside her.

"Yeah, seriously," Catra laughed as she looked over at her co-founder. "I have a feeling we're overdressed."

She hadn't changed out of the business suit she had worn all day at the conference. It was a great suit, custom-made, and her favorite of her growing collection. The problem was most everyone else had packed "party" clothes, for better or for worse. She hadn't even thought about bringing something like that.

"I think you look amazing, darling," a voice that had become somewhat familiar to her reassured her. "Though, I do have an idea that might be more comfortable."

Valerie appeared from the shadows at the entryway where she had been waiting on them. She asked Catra to text her when they were heading to the opening night event, and that was the only reason she decided to give it a try. Typically, she would've preferred to stay in her room and recharge after this much interaction with strangers. However, Valerie had intrigued her, and she was willing to endure more 'people' time to see where it went.

With a coy smile, the redhead came in front of Catra and asked, "May I?" as she reached for her tie.

"Sure?" Catra's heart started racing at the woman's hands grazing her body.

With permission granted, Valerie started to untie the tie and removed it from around her neck delicately. She tucked it into one of Catra's jacket pockets before beginning to unbutton her shirt down to the point that it was open with a wide v at her chest. While she worked, Catra couldn't help but notice that she *had* changed from what she saw her in that morning when they first met. She was wearing a green strapless dress that hugged her curves.

"Now we check your jacket," Valerie explained as she stepped back, and Catra began to shrug it off. "And voila, you're ready to be a party CEO out there with the rest of them."

"Thanks," she felt a little less silly at least, "I'll pack something for this next time. You look gorgeous, by the way. Green's your color."

"Aw, thank you, you're too kind," Valerie winked as she went to interlock their arms together and kissed her on the cheek. With that, she led the way over to where items were being checked.

"What's the point of this, anyway," Catra asked as she looked around. "I thought it was going to be more... I don't know, professional."

Valerie laughed with a roll of her eyes and explained while Catra was checking her jacket, "It probably started that way, but give a bunch of nerds a chance to pretend they're at a college party, and all bets are off. Plus, *no spouses*. The point is fun, debauchery, and, most importantly, copious amounts of alcohol."

"I don't know about debauchery, but I can't even drink legally for a few more months," Catra joked. Just another reminder that she was the youngest person in her position.

"Darling," Valerie gave her a wicked smile, "You're on track to be more successful than everyone here, and we all know it. No one is going to say no to you if you want to live a little."

It was true. Darla had been steadily building steam over the last year with investments in their AI technology and then took off like a rocket only a few months ago after they produced their first car. People didn't exactly recognize her on sight here, but as soon as she introduced herself and mentioned Darla, they would explode with enthusiasm and questions about the company. She probably should've packed something to organize all the various business cards and information that they threw at her.

"Guess I'm still getting used to that." She paused and wondered if it would be worth it. It wasn't like she hadn't drunk alcohol before. The difference was now she felt the weight of her blossoming company on her shoulders, and the idea of getting drunk in public seemed like a sure way to start a rumor about her not being fit to run Darla. "I'd rather not drink with all these people around. Who knows what kinds of deals someone might talk me into, right?" She tried to laugh it off and seem relaxed about it before offering smoothly, "Do you want anything? I'd be happy to get you something."

"You're so sweet, but maybe later. In the meantime, fancy some dancing?"

"Definitely." There wasn't any way that she could make herself look worse than most people out there.

Valerie cut their way through the crowded dance floor to find a spot that wasn't overflowing with humanity. Once they started to dance, it helped calm Catra's nerves as she had always considered herself a good dancer. Her partner wasn't half bad either, though Valerie was certainly more aggressive in the way she moved her body against hers. Catra debated with herself all day whether the

other woman was interested in networking or something more, but the hungry looks she was giving her while dancing extinguished all doubt. This was new.

After an hour of them out-dancing more or less everyone in the room, Valerie leaned in close and whispered, "Do you want to get some fresh air?"

She took a deep breath of the current non-fresh, muggy air. Now or never, she thought. "Yeah. There's a balcony in my room, actually. If you want, we could go hang out for a while."

"That sounds absolutely divine," Valerie smirked, "Lead the way." She interlocked arms with her again, and they headed out of the 'party.'

They were waiting on the elevator when Catra started to panic. "Fuck, I'm sorry," she said abruptly, "I forgot my jacket. I'll be right back."

"Seriously, Catra? You're too funny. Just buy a new one. Not like you can't afford it," Valerie teased. Or was she teasing?

Catra frowned at the comment but shook it off, "I'll hurry."

Leaving the frustrated woman behind, she sprinted down the halls back to where the hotel connected to the conference center. Logically speaking, she knew there was no reason for her jacket to be in any danger. All the same, the idea of losing it made her heart hurt.

When she arrived at her destination, the coat check person handed over her jacket no worse for wear, and she tipped him profusely. She reached into the pocket to make sure the tie was still there and finally felt like she could breathe again. If it were any of her other suits, she'd chance to pick it up from a lost and found the following day. However, this one was special. Her tailor made the jacket's lining from the fabric of one of her mother's dresses, and the matching tie was one from her father's collection. Not something she could replace with a quick purchase.

When she finally made it back to Valerie, the redhead looked up from her phone where she had been furiously typing away and gave her a big smile. "You are fast," she laughed and pressed the button to the elevator again. "Shall we?"

They were generally quiet on the way up to the penthouse suite of the hotel. Catra thought she would've felt butterflies bringing a beautiful woman up to her room, but that wasn't the case. All the same, it was progress from where she had been. When they went inside, the other woman gushed over the luxury of the space before they made their way to the promised balcony. They stood, staring out at the city lights and stars as the cool air whipped around them. Catra looked up to say something, but all of a sudden, Valerie was in her space.

"Wait, um," Catra pulled away as the other woman was leaning into her.

"You're such a nervous little thing," Valerie teased as she stood back against the railing analyzing her. "What's wrong?"

"God, this is embarrassing." She cleared her throat and looked down at her feet sheepishly, "I haven't done this. Any of this. The area I grew up in was pretty conservative, so I didn't try anything. Then starting Darla took all of my time when I moved out... So..."

"Oh," Valerie looked surprised, then she looked her up and down with a sly smile, "No need to be embarrassed about that, darling. And, well, I don't know about you, but I've got *time* right now."

"Yeah, I do too," Catra smiled and wrapped an arm around her.

Valerie pulled her in and led the kiss, Catra's *first* kiss. It wasn't the fireworks she had been hoping for after waiting so long. But... it wasn't terrible. She was taken out of the moment by her phone ringing in her pocket. It was Entrapta's ringtone.

"Fuck, sorry. I've got to take this," she parted from her and answered the phone. "Hey. Entrapta? What's up? I'm kind of---"

Entrapta sounded either panicked or excited or both, "Come to room 108 right now. It's urgent!" She hung up the phone before Catra could ask for any more details.

"I don't know what's up, but I've got to go check on her. I'm sorry. You can stay if you want," she raised an eyebrow and gave a hopeful smile. "It probably won't be too long."

"Of course, I don't mind waiting for you," Valerie put a finger under her chin and tilted her up into a kiss that was more hungry than the last.

"Thanks. Make yourself at home or whatever," she said awkwardly before heading to find Entrapta.

After hustling her way down there, she knocked on the door to room 108, not knowing what to expect. It certainly wasn't Entrapta's room. However, she was the one who opened the door and started to try to drag her in after cheering.

"Wait, what's going on," Catra asked as she tried to look over her shoulder in the room.

"Oh! I made some friends," she gestured back at a few people who were sitting around a table. They waved politely. "We're going to play Dungeons and Dragons! I knew you wouldn't want to miss it!"

Catra exhaled sharply and shook her head, "I'm kind of in the middle of something right now."

Entrapta looked confused, "But you bought dice at that gaming store today as your souvenir! I thought it was kismet when I found these guys."

"Any other time, but I've gotta get back to my room," she gave an awkward smile and hoped that the other woman wouldn't press.

Entrapta shrugged and started to close the door as she said cheerily, "See you tomorrow!"

Catra couldn't help but laugh to herself as she headed back to her room. Of course, this was why she dragged away from... well, whatever it was that she and Valerie were going to get into. As she opened the door to the penthouse, she started to call out to her but realized she was on the phone. She quietly made her way down the hall to be polite but came to a complete stop when she heard the conversation.

"I know, I know, I cannot believe my luck," Valerie laughed as she giddily spoke to what must be a friend, "Not only am I in the CEO of Darla Industries' penthouse suite right now, BUT I'm going to have her eating out of the palm of my hand when this is through. I could be her first *everything,* and you know how attached that can make a lonely little nerd. Ah, and to think I almost skipped this year. Suffering through this bore will be worth it when I have my very own pet millionaire. Actually, what am I saying? I'm sure she'll be a billionaire!"

Catra felt nauseous as she listened to her. The only thing that seemed more mortifying than hearing all of this would be Valerie *knowing* she heard of all this. She quietly started to tiptoe back out, grabbing

her backpack on the way. Her mind, on the other hand, was anything but quiet, drawing from the darkened depths of her insecurities and splashing the acrid thoughts on her heart. After all this time, this happened when she finally let herself *try t*o be with someone? All the god damn crushes she ignored...desires she pushed away for fear of upending what stability she had in her life... she was able to navigate all of that just to be too stupid to see through this leech. Fuck.

When she got into the elevator, she clenched her fists and wondered what she should do. What she really *wanted* to do was curl up in a ball and stop existing for a while. You know, take a break on this whole humanity thing and start fresh when the humiliation had faded. Instead, she clicked a button on the elevator and went tail between her legs back to room 108.

Entrapta cheered again once she opened the door. "I told them it was going to be you. Come on, we're still making characters, and I ordered tiny food from room service! They don't normally make tiny food, but I offered to tip them a thousand percent."

Catra felt numb as she followed her into the room to sit down at the table with these three strangers, "Is it okay, really? I don't want to mess up your game if you're ready to start."

"Never hurts to have another party member," a woman who looked about their age answered with a smile. "Nice to meet you. I'm Lonnie. This is Rogelio; he's going to be our DM for the night. He's got a real way with words," she gestured to the larger man behind the screen and then to an older, nerdier looking guy beside her, "And this is Trevor."

"Catra, thanks for letting me join. Turns out I could really use a distraction." She picked up her phone to send off a quick text before getting her new dice and paper out of her bag.

Catra: I'm going to be tied up for the night after all. Let yourself out.

Valerie: Hate to hear that! See you tomorrow for breakfast, perhaps? I know a great little place we could sneak off to. Or... I could come up for some room service [wink face emoji]

When Catra read the answer, she turned off her phone and put it away. She looked up at her new party, "Alright, what classes are we working with already? I normally like to play rogue, but I can be a paladin if we don't have a healer."

To say Adora was overwhelmed and frustrated would be an understatement. Were she not already accustomed to random bouts of misfortune, she would probably give up for the day and curl up in a ball somewhere. Not her style, though. She was going to push through this. This being her smoking car that she was literally having to push out of the middle of a road. She couldn't leave it out there for someone to hit and get hurt. Thankfully, a passerby had stopped, put her blinkers on, and helped before another vehicle came.

After profusing thanking the stranger, she checked her watch and saw she only had thirty minutes left to get to class. Today was a test day. Of course it was, because it wouldn't be a proper comedic tragedy without everything working against her. After making sure her car wasn't actually about to burst into flames, she grabbed her backpack and started running down the sidewalk.

Though more than a bit sweaty and out of breath, she made it to her anatomy test with a few minutes to spare. Some of her peers looked judgingly at her beet-red face, but she smiled back all the same. She finished the test before everyone else and knew it was an A when she turned it in. Her lousy luck worked hard, but Adora always worked harder. Take that, car gods.

She took her time as she walked the long walk back to her disaster vehicle, debating on what to do next. She had already poured more money than she would've liked to admit into keeping it running with minor repairs here and there. Something about this particular meltdown seemed like the final death rattles that had long been coming. She had enough money in her savings to be able to buy something used that ran, but that would mean she'd be out of luck in terms of, you know, eating and paying rent after a month. She grabbed her phone out of her pocket and shot off a quick text to the Best Friend Squad Group Chat:

Adora: My car died.

Glimmer: AGAIN?!

Bow: That thing is a hazard, Adora.

Adora: Yeah. I think it's time to let her pass over [ghost emoji]. I'm going to need to pick up a job to cover buying a new one. Is Starbucks hiring?

Glimmer: I think so! We'll talk you up to the manager today.

Bow: Best Friend Squad working together!!! This is going to be amazing.

Glimmer: Fair warning, sometimes this job is the worst. Today a guy yelled at us for not making his drink iced WHEN HE DIDN'T ASK FOR IT TO BE ICED.

Bow: One of our regulars yelled at him until he apologized and tipped us! It's not all bad.

Adora: Sounds fun! Thank you [heart emoji]

Adora laughed to herself as she read the messages. This was undoubtedly going to be an adventure if she got the job. She was lucky up to this point to not require a job during the school year due to a small amount of excess scholarship money. She was no stranger to hard with though. Adora worked her summers away since she was old enough to have a job doing all kinds of things: lifeguarding, grocery store clerk, summer camp counselor, and the occasional youth sports coaching.

Once she made it to her car, it had at least stopped smoking. She gave a hopeful turn of the ignition. Nothing. A call later, she had someone on the way to tow it back to her apartment complex. The cost was going to be more than the car was worth. Oh well, she thought. At least she was safe, made it to her test, *and* knocked it out of the park. Plenty to be grateful for.

After a pleasant ride with the tow truck driver, she said goodnight to her car and climbed the stairs to her apartment. What a long day. When she entered, she threw her backpack down and collapsed on her bright blue couch, her newest and proudest thrift acquisition. She was pondering what she had to make dinner out of when her phone started ringing.

"Hey, mom," she answered.

"Hi, sweetie," her mother's voice called on the other line. "Had some time before I go in for my shift. Wanted to check-in. How are you? How's school?"

"Everything's great," she lied. She wasn't about to mention the car to her mom for fear that she might offer to send her money. Adora couldn't let her do that. "School's going really well. Aced a test today!"

"That's my goose! I'm so proud of you."

"Thanks, mom." She never doubted it, but it made her heart feel so warm to hear it.

"Anything else new to report, hmm? I've been waiting to hear how things worked out with that girl from your yoga class."

She laughed; it really had been a long time since she and her mom discussed her social life. "They didn't. She was nice, but more of a friend thing, you know? It's fine, though. I'm not even worried about it, staying busy with school! I actually might be picking up a job with Glimmer and Bow."

"Wait, Adora," shoot. She could tell her mother wasn't going to let that pass casually. "Do you need money? Is it your car again? I thought your scholarship---"

"I'm fine, mom! I promise. My course load is pretty easy this semester, and I thought I'd try to see if I could handle a job too. No big deal for me, pfft. You worry too much."

"Adora," she was using her stern mom voice. "There's nothing wrong with asking for help if you need it. I love you."

"I know. I will. I love you too, mom," she started to tear up a little.

"I've got to get into the hospital now, but tomorrow I am going to pack you up a nice care package with all your favorite treats. Okay?"

"Sounds great," she smiled. That was definitely something to look forward to. "Get in there and save some lives. Love you."

"More like take things out of people's... well, you know," she laughed. "Night, sweetie, love you too."

Speaking with her mom always made her feel better and simultaneously brought up pangs of homesickness. The stretch from winter break to the end of the spring semester was always the longest she went without seeing her mom in person. As uncomfortable as those long greyhound rides were, knowing a big hug was waiting for her at the other end always made it worth it. Right now, though, she needed to focus on the present. Adora wiped away the couple of tears in her eyes, took a deep breath, and grabbed her laptop to start looking up used cars. Maybe she'd find a gem. Her luck was bound to turn around sometime. She was sure of it.

"This has been the second most embarrassing day of my life," Catra whined after everyone had left the office but Adora. She opened her arms needily, and the blonde wrapped her in a loving embrace that ended with a tender kiss. "I'm sorry they called you at work. It really isn't--"

Adora silenced her with fingers over Catra's lips, "Ssh. Quit being a *dummy.* We're going to get you out of here and into some pajamas. Do you need anything before we go?" Before she removed her fingers, she added, "*NOT* work-related. Like, do you want to take this plant," she gestured to a plant on the corner of her desk. "Or will your assistant water it?"

"I think it'll survive without me," She sighed and gave up the fight. This was happening. She was actually going to leave and *try* not to think about work. It would've seemed an impossible task pre-Adora but potentially achievable today. "I guess I don't really need anything. Do you want to ride together back to my place? You could use my car while I'm off."

"I wasn't going to let you drive anyway, obviously," Adora stepped back to give her room to get up. "Do I need to carry you?"

Catra closed her eyes and exhaled sharply. "No, I'm fine. Really."

"Uh-huh, well, if you look the least bit dizzy out there, I'm scooping you up, and you know you can't resist it," she gave a smug smile.

They settled on holding hands as they navigated the complex. People were staring, but they always did when Adora came around. Catra wondered how much the word of what happened had spread around the facility. She was consoled by the fact that there had never been a leak in all their years at Darla. Her employees were fiercely loyal that way. Turns out that's a happy consequence of ethical practices and treating people like they matter.

When they got to her car, Adora insisted on opening the door for Catra and waiting until she was inside and buckled up before moving to the driver's seat. After she got in, Adora tuned the radio to a spa channel.

Catra laughed as the calming tones poured in the car, "This is a bit much, don't you think?"

"Nope, nothing's too much. If something happened to you," her voice started to break, and she shook her head to dismiss the thought, "I love you. I want to make sure you're going to be okay. You work so hard, but there's nothing wrong with asking for help."

"I love you too," she leaned across the seat to kiss her cheek, "Please help me not think about my stupid billion-dollar company for a while."

"With pleasure," Adora smirked and started the car. "Is it okay if I stay while--"

"Yes, please," Catra cut her off too eagerly, but she couldn't even be embarrassed by it. "I sleep much better when you're around."

"I am pretty cuddly," her smile widened, "We're going to be so domestic by the end of this."

"Maybe don't practice your cooking though. Smoke alarms spook Melog and me."

The rest of the drive back, Adora kept on the spa music and told Catra silly stories to keep her mind off of work. There were plenty of hijinks from old Best Friend Squad days and kid Adora to keep them laughing until they pulled up to her building. Adora resisted the urge to restate her offer to carry her girlfriend when they dropped off the car with the valet. Catra appeared to be okay, as she kept insisting, and she worried that trying to assert otherwise would actually stress her out. Not a desirable outcome. Instead, they held hands and chatted until the elevator came to a stop, and Melog wandered over to greet them.

"Hi buddy," Catra cooed as she bundled him up in her arms. "You and I are going to get some real couch bonding time."

"Good idea, cats are good for stress relief, isn’t that right, you fuzzy angel," Adora could hear his purrs as she stood to the side and petted his soft head. "Now, about those pajamas. I could go for a nap."

"Seriously? It's two. I can't remember the last time I took a nap."

"You're past due then. This is why you're so stressy," Adora started to usher Catra and their son up the spiral staircase to the bedroom. "Naps are good for the soul. Don't you want an excuse to cuddle?"

Catra looked back at her with a soft smile, "Always."

It turned out that Catra was *very* past due for a nap because when Adora woke back up, she was still snoozing beside her. She grabbed her phone to check the time and realized she forgot about her weekly check-in with her mom. She carefully made her way out of bed and out onto the roof to not wake up her partner.

"Hey, mom. Sorry! Was taking a nap. How are you?"

"Same old, same old here. Can't complain. How are things going for you? Still enjoying Starbucks?"

Adora chewed the inside of her cheek, debating on whether or not finally broach the topic she'd been avoiding for weeks. She felt like she might jinx it if she told her mom and made it totally real. "Yeah, I love it. I'm really glad I started working there."

"Uh-huh. I know nervous Adora when I hear her. What's wrong?"

"Nothing's wrong. Everything's amazing, actually," she looked out over the city from her birds-eye view. "I feel bad, because I should've told you sooner... but I met someone while I was working. We're pretty serious. She's my girlfriend."

"That's wonderful, sweetie. You'll have to bring her out to the house when you visit next... but I can't make any promises I won't pull out baby photos."

"She'd love that," Adora laughed. The idea of her mom and Catra together made her heart melt. "This next part isn't a huge deal. I didn't even know until we started dating that she's kind of.. um.. well." She paused, entirely too nervous about how to word this.

"The CEO of a massively successful company?" Her mom laughed after she finished for her. "Honey, I love you, and I wasn't going to bring it up until you did. But you must really think poorly of us lowly country-folk if you think the news hasn't hit here yet."

"What?! Why didn't you say something?"

"I didn't want to put you on the spot. I knew you'd tell me when you were ready, and you look so happy in all the pictures you post. There was nothing to worry about. Goodness, you two are beautiful together."

"Wait, how long have you known?" Adora wasn't upset, more like fascinated.

"Since the interview. I saw it on Twitter and started following you two. Oh, that Rich Horse Girling trend is hysterical. Everyone keeps doing it at the hospital with that statue out front." She giggled to herself. "All this to say, I'm thrilled for you. She's a good person from what I've read."

"She's really amazing," Adora dreamily replied.

"Listen to you," her mom teased with another round of giggles. "Now, don't you go ringing any wedding bells before I can give her a hug in person. I've got some photos she has to see."

"Noted," Adora replied.

From there, they chatted more about everything that had transpired since she and Catra met. By the time Adora hung up and headed back into the bedroom, the sun was starting to set. The bedroom was dark except for the light of Catra's laptop illuminating her face. She jumped when Adora entered.

"Catra," Adora said sternly. "What are you doing?"

"NOTHING," Catra shut her laptop quickly, "It was porn, I promise."

"Uh-huh," she walked over and held out her hand to confiscate the device. This was going to be more challenging than she thought. "Can't believe you'd lie to me like that."

"I'm sorry," Catra frowned up at her. "I wanted to check my email one last time, but Entrapta locked me out anyway. So then I went to look at our stocks and..."

"I'm going to turn that brain of yours off one way or another," Adora threatened with a devilish grin. "*Boss"*

Chapter End Notes

Okay. So, I know this wasn't our typical chapter, but I hope you enjoyed it. I had two goals:
1. Make you hate Valerie more than you already did.
2. Make you love Adora even more than you thought you could.

Hopefully, I succeeded?

As always, thanks for readingl!

Our Little Talks

Chapter Summary

We take another trip to the past to see Catra's perspective in meeting Adora the first time, and how Entrapta did her best to help. Meanwhile, in the present, Catra and Adora make plans. Catra also tries to... do... nothing, no matter how much it hurts.

Chapter Notes

Two thirds of this chapter are brought to you by Tomoe_Minlert commenting last chapter about whether or not we'd see Catra's perspective on when she first met Adora. Once I started thinking about it, I wanted to explore it! There's a lot going on in her sweet head.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The day started like any other. Catra woke up to the blinds automatically lifting in her bedroom to reveal the sunrise coming up over the city. As soon as she sat up in the bed, Melog perched on her chest and purred happily.

"Good morning," she said with a yawn as she petted the cat's head. She grabbed for her phone and started looking through her agenda. Nothing too serious on the docket until the afternoon. That meant she could afford to swing by and get some coffee on the way in. After giving Melog the requisite number of morning pets, he swapped from sweet needy cat to ravenously hungry. She followed him down the spiral staircase to set him up for the day. The sound of her footsteps echoed through the large main floor of the penthouse. Probably influenced by a night of unpleasant dreams, it felt very empty and lonely today. Sometimes she felt guilty about having all this space to herself. It seemed like a waste. Especially... She shook her head to dismiss the thoughts and refocused as best as she could. Shower, put on the suit she'd picked out the night before, get out of the building before she'd run out of time for coffee.

With the weird thoughts swirling in her mind, she left the autopilot on with her Darla. Always better safe than sorry, she figured. That gave her more space to think anyway. She was glad that she had picked out the suit she was wearing; it was one of her favorites and comforting in a way. Like her full walk-in of beautifully crafted suits, it was made by the tailor downtown she had come to love and be loyal to since she first started out. The tailor and her wife, who ran the shop portion of their business, basically felt like the aunts she never had. But, of course, she couldn't tell them that. That was fucking weird. She had a habit of getting attached to people at places she frequented, for lack of having anyone else in her life other than work relationships.

Take, for example, the two baristas who had been at her local Starbucks the longest, Sparkles and Bow. She was going to miss them whenever they graduated college and hopefully found jobs in their fields. Bow once had made a joke about them playing Dungeons and Dragons together sometime, and while she very genuinely affirmed she would be interested, he hadn't brought it up again. She sighed at the memory as she opened the door. The nerdy barista in question was behind the bar today and

gave her a wave before turning his attention back to the blender he was working on. She could tell he and Sparkles were having some kind of spirited discussion on their headsets. Logically speaking, she knew it probably wasn't about her, but it always *felt* like it when she saw them chatting away.

When she got to the register, she noticed a barista working on grinding coffee beans that she hadn't seen before. The blonde woman looked back at her as though she might say something but then turned back around almost immediately. Catra was really fucking glad too because, in that brief moment of meeting eyes with her, her whole fucking brain shut down. God damn, she was beautiful. "Be cool, be cool," she thought to herself repeatedly. It was ridiculous for her to get this wound up over a pretty girl at her coffee shop. She was going to be an eccentric, single old cat lady millionaire. That was a fact she had accepted when the one time she tried to do anything different turned into new material to keep her therapist in business for years to come.

Finally, the blonde got the coffee going and turned back around to her. She looked at her with the sweetest smile Catra was sure she had ever seen before and gave a very nervous canned, "Hi, thank you for choosing Starbucks. What can I set started for you?"

Catra couldn't help but smirk. It was so cute; this was clearly her first week. She gave her best smooth, nonchalant response, "Hey, could I have a grande nitro cold brew and a croissant?"

"Absolutely," the blonde said cheerily as she started pressing buttons, "And that's, Catra? Right?"

"Yep, how'd you know," she joked and hoped to god that she didn't know who she was. When Bow popped up by the register with her drink ready before she even sent it through, the mystery was solved. "Clearly, I come here too much." That made her feel oddly self-conscious in a new way.

"You're a bit of a legend, I'm afraid," she teased as she dipped over to grab her bakery item and hand it over, "I'm told you defend us against mean customers."

She sent a silent thank you to the other two baristas for talking her up like that. "It's the only reason I come here. Someone's gotta stand up for Bow." Encouraged by the welcomed banter so far, she gave a wink as she took the food.

The blonde's beautiful smile had only gotten bigger, and now she was pretty sure that she was blushing too-- what a vast improvement to how Catra had started her day. She started again with a voice betraying her enthusiasm, "I guess I'll be seeing a lot of you. It's really nice to meet you. I'm Adora," she held out a hand that Catra took.

She almost accidentally introduced herself again as though Adora didn't already know her name. She caught herself in the nick of time and instead said a simple, "Same, Adora. See you tomorrow." She dropped some money in the tip jar while she wasn't looking before grabbing her things and heading out.

When she got into the parking lot, she exhaled and tried to gather herself. *Why was she like this?* She never faltered in confidence when doing business with people who had been in the tech and automotive industries twice as long as she'd been alive. Yet, one dreamy blonde at a coffee shop and the charismatic CEO was falling to pieces. As she was about to get in her car, she almost dropped her nitro as she heard over the drive-thru speaker Adora saying, "What? No. I mean, she's hot." Her eyes widened as she looked back. Was that about her?

It turned out that thought was a tough one to push down. It was there while her assistant was running down her agenda for the day. Adora's sweet face was floating around while her engineering team updated her on their current design triumphs and challenges. Finally, at lunch, she was a powderkeg

of pinning and curiosity about to explode. Entrapta had joined her in her office, where they were eating and chatting. Her co-founder was doing most of the talking. She tilted her head at her after pausing in the middle of a story, "Catra? Are you feeling okay?"

"What? No. Yes, I mean, I'm fine," she said rather unconvincingly.

Entrapta frowned as she analyzed her, "Is this about Tiny Food Tuesday in the cafeteria? Because the employee surveys have been very positive."

She looked down at her half-eaten plate of various tiny lunch items, "Not at all. It's great. I had something weird happen to me this morning at the coffee shop I go to. It's really stupid; I don't know why I can't stop thinking about it."

"You're proveably brilliant. It can't be that stupid," she gave her a reassuring smile.

Catra laughed to herself and shook her head, "I was leaving, and the new girl said over the drive-thru speaker, 'she's hot.' And... I'm kind of wondering if she was talking about me."

"Oh," Entrapta's smile dimmed for a moment before she recovered, "I was wrong. Yes, that is stupid. However, is this what you were wearing?"

"Well, yeah, I didn't go home and change or anything," Catra shrugged as she looked down at her outfit.

"Come stand over here," Entrapta pointed at a space in front of the wall beside them. Catra felt weird about it but complied. "Okay, I have determined that I cannot apply the hot moniker to you based on the kind of friendship we share. However," she took out her phone and snapped a picture before Catra could move, "I will get to the bottom of this with data."

"Entrapta, please, god, no. What are you doing?" Catra knew it was fruitless to try to stop whatever idea she had in her head.

The other woman finished typing out something on her phone and then gave her a thumbs up, "We are going to see what the world thinks! Over one million people follow me on Twitter. There should be a reasonably large number of sapphic data points that can participate in our poll."

Sure enough, Catra heard her own phone going off from notifications. "You have to take that down," she grumbled as she walked back to her desk to grab her own phone. When she opened up Twitter, she sighed at the response it was already getting. At least the photo was good.

"But, we've gotten so much good data already! Right now, 99% of respondents have said yes to: Is @CatraDarlaCEO hot in this suit? [Yes] [No]," she started scrolling through the replies, "Oh! The one no says she hit the wrong button, and you're definitely hot. This is excellent news."

Catra sat at her desk with her head in her hands, pulling at her hair as she focused on *not* losing her mind. "Great, thank you. Take it down, please," she tried to keep the edge off her voice. She knew that the other woman was only trying to help.

"What's a sugar baby?" Entrapta asked, paying no mind to the request. "Lots of women are interested in applying for that position. Does this have to do with the dessert bar in the cafeteria?"

Her desk phone rang, and she already saw on the ID that it was from the PR department. She put it on speaker, "Good afternoon, Kitten. I assume you know why I'm calling."

"Yes, I'm trying to tell her to take it down," she groaned.

"Hi DT!" Entrapta shouted, then got up from her chair so that she could talk to the speaker, "I am merely helping Catra with determining her aesthetic appeal."

DT must have moved the phone away from their face because Catra could hear their quiet cackling laughter before they came back more severe, "It appears that 99% of the Internet thinks our CEO is hot *and*, presumably, desperate. Let's go ahead and cut off this little experiment, please."

"Will do," Entrapta started working on her phone.

DT paused to confirm the erasure and then started again, "Fabulous. Thank you. Now, do I *want* to know what inspired this? Catra, you're always telling me to turn down those listicles for World's Sexiest CEOs and the like."

"Keep doing that. I'll see you later about my keynote," Catra hung up the phone unceremoniously before looking at her friend with pleading eyes. "Entrapta, please, don't tell anyone about this or why you made that post."

"Got it," Entrapta affirmed before going back to her tiny food lunch.

After lunch, Catra was doing her usual walk-through of the complex. When she got down to engineering, she caught Lonnie before she was able to oversee a test. "Hey, boss," she said with a smirk, "How's it feel to know the world thinks you're hot? I know you are a little behind on this, but there are separate apps for dating."

"I hate it here," Catra mumbled to herself. "I'm going to sell my shares and retire."

Lonnie started laughing so hard she had to pause to catch her breath, "You're going to have to try something we'd actually believe. Seriously, are you actually on the market? Because I know some equally hot women..."

Catra waved her hands out in front of her emphatically, "Can we focus on work, please?"

This is what Catra got for trying to talk about even *potential* feelings about another woman. It seemed that the very task itself of trying to open herself up in that way was cursed. She was going to stay single, and that was fine. At least she was hot? That... was reassuring. This was still invading her thoughts when she entered DT's office for their previously scheduled meeting.

"Kitten, I've been reviewing your potential suitors, and I have to say... you've got some good options," DT teased as they were still scrolling through the replies that were visible despite the original tweet being deleted.

Catra rolled her eyes before taking a seat, "Is this going to cause problems?"

DT waved off the worry, "Impression-wise, it didn't get *too* big considering Entrapta's circle. Of course, I'm sure there are screenshots. The good news is it wasn't posted to *your* page. I think people are laughing it off. No serious inquires coming in or anything of the like. So, let's talk keynote. Their rep contacted me earlier asking for a draft."

"They're not getting one," Catra shrugged. "I'll give them an outline if they want, but I'm not giving over my whole speech. I have a feeling they'll try to censor me on some of this shit, and there's no way I'm accepting that. I've got a chance to stand up there and explain how the industry is set up to exclude people like us. I'm taking it for all its worth."

DT nodded and narrowed their eyes as they listened. "Uh-huh," they made a popping noise with their mouth, "Sorry, I'm trying to process how to politely say, 'Our CEO agrees to send a vague outline, but she will be saying whatever the fuck she wants.'"

"You say they can either have the CEO of Darla Industries give the keynote she wants to give, or they can go hunting for someone else from a company not even half as important as ours."

"I'll sweeten it a bit, but you aren't wrong about that," DT winked before looking back at their computer, "Now, speaking of sugar... I've got a young lady named--"

Catra distracted herself by pulling up her speech notes while they rambled, "How about I do the draft I have right now, and you give me some notes? Doesn't that sound more productive?"

"Mmhmm. I'll bookmark these for later then," DT pulled out a legal pad and prepared a pen, "Go."

When she got home that day, Catra went about her usual evening routine. Cook dinner, feed Melog, look over her plans for the next day, consider watching something on streaming before giving up and thinking about work again. Even still, in the midst of all that, Adora's face kept popping up. It was... weird. Not annoying at all.

Catra decided to do what she usually did when she needed to work through what she was feeling. She headed upstairs and out onto her favorite space to talk things out. Her rooftop oasis was lit by the moon and stars of the clear night. She sat down in one of her lounge chairs and pulled her knees up to her chest, and started by taking a series of slow, deliberate breaths.

"Hey," she said aloud to the cool night air. "I can't decide if I'm losing my mind or if you two weren't lying about this... I don't know, love at first sight stuff when you met. God, saying it out loud feels so stupid. Even stupider than talking to you like this even though... you're gone. I met this girl today, Adora. I don't even know five things about her. How can I not know five things about her, and I can't stop thinking about her? That's ridiculous. I know you'd probably tell me that I'm ridiculous for giving up on this kind of stuff in the first place. That there's plenty of fish in the sea and catching a rotten one first doesn't mean I should starve or whatever cutesy thing you'd find to say."

She shook her head and laughed despite the few tears that were forming in her eyes. "I'm scared, I guess. And I don't have any time to be scared or distracted or whatever. There are too many people counting on me for me to fuck up. But, ugh," she buried her head in her hands for a moment before looking up at the stars again, "I miss you. I miss what love and having a family felt like. I'm worried I'll never get to feel it again." She stared up at the stars for a long time in silence before resting her head on her knees.

It was a weird ritual, but she'd been doing it since middle school. Something about talking out loud as though her parents were there with her made her see things more clearly. She could always imagine what they might say --- whether it was herself talking or precious pieces of them she'd been able to keep alive in her memories. And so, with their wisdom, she had a plan.

She would not go into the complex for work tomorrow. Instead, she would do something that felt more productive in solving this problem. If you want to know five things or more about a person, you have to actually talk to them. Plenty of people worked from Starbucks instead of their offices and home. She could be one of those people, and maybe it would allow her a chance or two to really talk to Adora. If she was interested anyway... If she didn't look her way or try to chat, she'd let it go.

Thus, after sending an email to notify her team she'd be working remotely for the following day, she tried on about five different variations of a "casual" outfit before deciding on something simple -- a

fitted t-shirt, black jeans, and her glasses. Just your regular, cool non-millionaire going to work from a coffee shop. Hopefully... *also* hot.

"I don't know if I can handle your sexiness tonight. I did pass out earlier," Catra joked though she felt genuinely weary of the prospect. That would be a great news story. The world is mourning the loss of Darla CEO, Catra, who died mid-orgasm.

Adora's come-on face immediately changed to concern, "I'm so sorry. I didn't think about that." She gave her a sweet forehead kiss instead and sat down beside her. "I suppose we ought to give it a day or two."

"Might be for the best," Catra reached for one of Adora's thighs and squeezed, "Though, I have to say, knowing what's waiting for me when I stop stressing about work is a hell of a motivator."

"I promise I will make it worth your while. Shoot," she scrunched up her face and looked disappointed for a moment, "There's probably a good pun in there somewhere. Being all worried about you has me off of my game." Adora laughed and laid her head over on Catra's shoulder, "That was my mom, by the way. Apparently, she already knew about us. She saw it on Twitter the night of the interview."

"Your mom had a Twitter before you? Now I have to meet Helen so we can tease you about it."

"Her whole plan basically revolves around you two teasing me. Even if I'm going to die of embarrassment, I can't wait. But, I don't plan on going back until the semester's over. Well, you know, because normally I have to take a bus and--"

"And obviously, you don't have to anymore," Catra quickly reminded her with a smile. "We can go whenever you want. Say the word, I'll buy plane tickets. Maybe check with your mom first, though. My parents always said it's rude to invite people over without asking first."

Adora lifted her head up and turned to look at her with shock. Catra wondered when Adora would remember as a matter-of-fact that her girlfriend was rich. That she didn't have to struggle anymore, not at least in ways that money could fix. Catra would make sure she had anything she wanted.

"Thank you," she squeezed her girlfriend in a tight hug as she gushed, "I miss her so much, and the thought of you two together... it's all I could ever want." She grabbed her phone and started looking through her calendar. "I don't know if this is too soon, but my spring break is in a couple of weeks. She'd kill me if I missed school over it."

"I'll tweet at her to see if she's available," Catra teased. This meant she was going to take the *full* three weeks off before the shareholders' meeting. Nothing about that seemed nearly as important as this trip. A thought occurred to her, "Wait, how country is your hometown? I feel like I might need to invest in... I don't know, western wear or something."

Adora started giggling as she was typing out a message to her mom, "Not necessary, but don't tease me like that if you don't mean it. I *need* to see you in some sexy western wear now."

"I'll give you a card and my sizes, and you can go wild. I'll wear whatever you want me to... in reason," Catra added to be sure. She didn't want to look like a complete idiot when meeting Adora's mom the first time. "Also, I'm starving. What if we get some pizza from that place we went on our first date?"

Adora looked more than thrilled at both propositions, "You're my soul mate. Did you know that?"

Yes, she wanted to say.

When Adora left for class the next morning, Catra felt an emptiness she hadn't let inside of her mind in a very long time. 980 workdays plus weekends and holidays, to be precise. The steady routine of working on Darla gave her something to occupy her mind at any given moment she needed it. It was a protective barrier against processing unwanted feelings. "Focus" has become her mantra. Starting to panic? Angry? Feelings of grief? Loneliness? Focus, Catra. Think about the big picture, her company, her employees who needed her. There was always something that she felt deserved her attention more than whatever was swirling in her mind.

She remembered the "talk" she had with her parents when she first met Adora. When she saw her, it had awoken this feeling in her heart that she needed to be more than the CEO of Darla Industries. She needed to be Catra, too, and she deserved other things in her life. And so, she brought her laptop and all work materials into her office and shut the door. Out of sight, out of mind. Hopefully.

"Okay, now what," she asked Melog who was staring at her from his window perch. She went to join him and watch the world spin without her. After a few minutes, her phone pinged in her pocket and she pulled it out.

Adora: Just got to class. You better be doing something relaxing.

Catra: I'm talking to Melog.

Adora: Tell him I love him. What else are you going to do today?

Catra: Idk

Adora: It's also okay to do nothing if you want. I'll be home to do nothing with you before you know it.

Catra: I'll try. Have a good day at school. I love you. Can't wait for you to get home

Adora: I love you too.

Adora calling the penthouse her *home* ? Yeah, that was enough to keep her heart happy for the day, whatever she ended up doing. She landed on organizing her pantry, which most people wouldn't call relaxing, but she was using it as a chance to plan more couple's cooking lessons. She was in the middle of checking the expiration dates on some canned goods when there was a buzz from the speaker by the elevator. She hurried over to press to reply, "Hello?"

"Ms. Catra, We have a couple of rather large deliveries for you. I believe they are art canvases. We wanted to confirm with you before having one of the guards escort the delivery people to you."

"Yes! Send them up, please. Thank you," she happily confirmed. She had forgotten all about this in the midst of everything else going on.

After finding a place to store the canvases, for now, she tipped everyone for their help and lined up a picture.

Catra: [photo of wrapped canvases]

Catra: Guess we'll be hosting an unveiling party soon.

Adora: I FORGOT ABOUT THIS. What photos are they?!

Catra: You'll find it out at the party with everyone else.

Adora: When??!?! [crying emoji]

Catra: Next Friday? I'll let you plan it if you want so I don't get all stressed or whatever. You can invite whoever you want.

Secretly, she didn't have the slightest idea about planning this kind of event. She hoped that Adora would latch on to the opportunity to do so, and she could be more of an assistant to the whole thing.

Adora: Of course! Ooh. I'm going to be thinking about themes all afternoon. Get me a list of who you'd invite from work and stuff.

Catra finished up in the kitchen and then decided to do something she hadn't done in a very long time. She laid out on the couch with Melog purring on her lap as she put on some truly mind-numbing television -- dumb reality shows. One of her guiltiest of pleasures. She was in the middle of a particularly ridiculous episode of the previous year's Big Brother when Adora popped out of the elevator.

"I've got it! Monochrome," she declared triumphantly with jazz hands before dancing her way across the penthouse floor.

Catra sat up with a raised eyebrow, "Monochrome?"

"Yes! That's the theme. It's very... arty," Adora answered with authority as she collapsed down on the couch beside her. "Everyone comes dressed monochrome in shades of whatever color they want. And we'll do the decor grayscale! Our guests and the art bring all the color."

Catra liked it. It was very "arty" and simple enough for people to prepare for. They could be silly or traditional in their dress. She only had one request, "As long as the food doesn't have to be gray. I can't think of a gray food I like."

"Hmm," Adora rubbed her chin, "Same. We'll do rainbow food instead. Is an art unveiling party supposed to be fancy?"

Catra shrugged, "I think it can be whatever we want it to be. There aren't any rules. It's our... home," she almost didn't say it, but let the word fall out of her mouth anyway. The way Adora smiled back at her reminded her of when they first met. Her brain stopped working, but her heart? It was perfectly fine.

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think! Thanks for reading. I have to say writing a bit about Catra kind of processing things through the lens of not having work to distract her was something that's actually pretty personal to my heart (as is the idea of her having little talks with her parents. I hope that wasn't too cheesy. It's a literal thing I do with my parent that passed).

Next Chapter *should* include a Party Planner Adora, a fabulous arty event, and some dramatic moments along the way. I say should, because I feel like whenever I write a note about what the next chapter is supposed to be my heart takes me somewhere divergent.

Don't Go Breaking My Heart

Chapter Summary

> Catra tries letting more people into her life and home. The Best Friend Squad reunites and seeks victory.

Chapter Notes

> This chapter features characters drinking at a bar. Please take care around this content if alcohol/drunkness is a sensitive topic for you.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day two of forced vacation started with Catra waking up late with Adora still in her arms from the night before. She couldn't help the sleepy smile on her face as she stared at her girlfriend-- her long blonde hair a mess and drool on her face. Even like this, she was still the most beautiful woman she'd ever seen. She squeezed her gently and kissed her cheek. "Good morning," she whispered.

Adora awoke with a smile and peeked open one eye at her, "Morning."

"I'm going to go make us some coffee and breakfast. Any requests? The fridge is full." Catra moved her soft kisses down her face to her jawline and neck.

"Mmm," she hummed aloud happily, "I'm thinking... french toast, fruit, bacon."

"Sounds perfect." Catra climbed out of bed finally and pulled on one of Adora's t-shirts.

"It'll have to do," Adora rolled over on her side to watch her as she was getting dressed. When Catra looked back, she gave a cheeky grin. "Since what I really want is off the menu unless you actually relax. No organizing." Catra gave her narrowed eyes and a childish grumble but nodded before heading downstairs.

Over breakfast, they worked on planning invitations for their "art party." Given the somewhat spontaneous nature of the event, they had to get everything printed and out ASAP. Adora suggested making e-vites with animations... which was a hard veto from Catra. She'd much rather pay someone for their expertise. And, god, she loved Adora, but the e-vites she showed her were genuinely awful. For example, one involved using their pictures as the heads for singing characters. No. Thank You.

Who to invite? That was a simple process for Catra. Her social circle was pretty small - i.e., nonexistent outside of work. She picked Entrapta, Lonnie, Rogelio, DT, her personal assistant, and a few other people Adora hadn't gotten to meet yet. She wondered how things were going with the Kyle situation. If that kid was coming, she was going to have her lawyers draw up the most ridiculous NDA anyone's ever seen. Then, she'd have everything, including his grandmother's cat, if he spoke or

wrote about whatever happened in their home. Not that she was *expecting* scandal, but she'd already been burned enough to be wary.

"Is there anyone you'd want to invite? Other than Sparkles and Bow, obviously."

Adora tapped her chin with her pen, "I know this is probably weird, but maybe their parents? They've all kind of been my home away from home at times. Bows' dads live just outside the city, but Glimmer's mom and dad are close to my place."

"Sounds good to me. I have a lot of questions for Sparkles' parents," Catra teased.

"Of course," Adora smirked. "Oh! Speaking of," she grabbed for her phone. "They want to know if we'll go to Trivia tonight. It's at a pub not far from here."

"What," Catra lit up with enthusiasm Adora reserved for horses, "Like a trivia competition?"

"Yep! Bow says we'd be the dream team with you. We've tried before, but the closest we've gotten was third place."

"Oh, we are going to win. Are there categories I should study?"

"Absolutely not," Adora reached over and booped her on the nose, "It's for fun, remember? Plus, your big, beautiful brain is full of all kinds of stuff already."

"Fine," Catra frowned. "What do you think about inviting them to stay the night? I was just thinking, you know if it's late and we're drinking."

She clutched her hand to her heart and looked at her with glassy eyes, "Really? You've never even used your guest room."

"Hey, Melog had a stage where he liked having his own big bed," Catra pointed out, trying to play down the emotional implications of actually letting more people "in" quite literally. "But... yeah."

Adora got up and wrapped her girlfriend in a tight hug. "I love you."

"I love you too, weirdo," Catra pulled her down from the hug into her lap, "So, what are your top categories for tonight?"

"I'm sports, certain sciences, *some* history. What else? Hmm..."

"Puns, horses," Catra added as she held her close, "*Muscles*."

After Adora left for her afternoon classes, Catra sent off a proposal for the invitations to a graphic design contact along with a promise of extra pay for the rush.

Next on the agenda was getting out to her tailor's shop to see what they had in the way of a monochrome suit. It was probably too late to do something entirely custom, but their "off the rack" styles were always handsome and could be fitted in time. Taking a leisurely stroll downtown while listening to one of their playlists turned out to be a treat unto itself. It had been a very long time since she allowed herself the benefit of not being in a rush. When she reached the shop, she was relieved to see that she was the only customer.

"Catra, what a nice surprise!" a woman called from behind the counter where she was working on a computer.

"Hey, Spinny," she smiled as the other woman came and wrapped her in a quick hug. "How's everything going here with you two? Kind of surprised no one else is here."

"Everything's been wonderful, don't worry about us." Spinerella assured her.

"Trust me, we're staying plenty busy," the voice of her wife, Netossa, came from behind. She must have been in the back working on something, "I'm finally out from under the orders I got after your appearances last month. By the way, that keynote? Fantastic. I shared it everywhere."

"Thank you," Catra couldn't help but blush a little bit. "Um.. so. I'm hosting a small event at my place with my girlfriend next Friday."

"Adora?" Spinerella asked with a big grin, and Catra nodded. "Oh, she's the sweetest. We both approve. Right, darling?"

"Yeah, seems like you've actually been having a life outside of work," the other woman teased with a wink. "Tell us about the party. What are you thinking? I can't promise the world in that turnaround, but I'll try."

"Actually, before we talk about that, I wanted to invite you both. I mean, there will be a *real* invitation in the mail, but I thought, you know, since I'm here." She felt a little awkward initially but watching the reaction on their faces relaxed her as she kept going. "It's technically an art unveiling party, but it's really an excuse to have people over. I've never hosted anything before at my place. And, well, it would really mean a lot to me if you came."

"Of course, we'd love to," Spinerella wrapped her up in a big hug again.

Netossa wasn't usually a hugger in the years since Catra's been coming here, but she joined in too. "Wouldn't miss it."

Once they parted, Catra explained to them about the concept of the party, "And I'm thinking maroon maybe? It's my favorite color. If you've got something to work with."

"Any other preferences?" Netossa eyed her up and down in thought.

"It's up to you. Whatever you can make work. I know it's a rush."

"I love a good challenge," she gave a wink. "Alright, I'm going to check what I have to work with while I've got time. Always good to see you, Catra. Can't wait to meet *the* blondie."

When Adora and Catra entered the pub, it was already full of people. Glimmer's voice rang out over the buzz of conversation and the music playing, "Over here!" She and Bow had secured a tall table near the front of the venue.

"Dream Team Best Friend Squad," Bow cheered as he hopped up from his stool and hugged both of them at once.

"This is pretty serious," Catra noted as she sat down. "I expected like half as many people."

Glimmer laughed, "Yeah. It's ridiculous; everyone gets so competitive. I don't even know why. I think the prize last time was some t-shirts."

"But we are going to get whatever dumb prize it is. We have a secret weapon this time," Adora made finger guns towards her girlfriend. "A genius!"

"And if we don't win, you'll buy us shirts right," Glimmer said with a wink.

"We have to earn them, Sparkles. There's no honor in buying them," she turned her attention to Bow, who seemed to be as serious about it as she was, "Tell me everything. Adora wouldn't let me prepare."

Adora rolled her eyes and held back a laugh, "While the two of you plot, why don't Glimmer and I go get us some drinks, hmm?"

"Sure," Catra grabbed her wallet and handed over one of her cards, "Open a tab for the table on me. Thanks," she kissed her on the cheek before the other two headed off.

Glimmer and Adora cut their way through the crowd and up to the bar. While waiting for the bartender, they contemplated what to get.

"Oh shit," Adora said with a frown. "I didn't ask her what she wanted."

"Your first ordering for your girlfriend test," Glimmer said with amusement.

She glanced back at Bow and Catra, who were leaned into each other, clearly trying to whisper about strategy. "All I know is she doesn't like super sweet drinks."

Before they could contemplate more, the bartender was in front of them and waiting, "What can I get for you?"

"Um," Adora stammered. "Uh. Whatever is most expensive."

"Excuse me?" He raised an eyebrow.

Glimmer sighed and took over, "Can we get a pitcher of margaritas with your best tequila and also..." she glanced over at Adora, who was still partially mortified. "What would you recommend for someone that doesn't like sweet drinks? Something fancy."

The bartender shrugged, "Probably something like a whiskey or bourbon."

"Bourbon," Adora confirmed. "Your best one."

"Got it," he still looked partially amused but went to work on preparing everything.

"You're too cute," Glimmer teased while they were waiting. "You know if you brought something terrible back to her, she'd smile and pretend to like it. The amount of junk she taste-tested for you at work without complaint is proof."

"Hey, I was really onto something with that matcha do about nothing."

"So gross," Glimmer grimaced at the reminder, then looked over her shoulder back at the table, "Do you know her?"

When Adora turned around, she felt a flare of jealously spark up. Another woman around their age was standing beside the table, chatting and laughing with Catra. She wasn't anyone she recognized from Darla. "Nope," she crossed her arms as she leaned back against the bar, watching the situation.

"Calm down the rage eyes," Glimmer teased.

"I am not raging," Adora huffed. "It's just... I mean, who IS she?"

"Probably a girl who agrees with you that your girlfriend is super hot."

As they were returning to the table, Adora made a point of coming up from behind Catra and wrapping an arm around her. "Here you go, love," her voice was smooth and sultry as she placed the drink down in front of her. Then she looked over at the other woman quizically, "Oh? Who's this? A friend?"

"Just a fan," The other woman's enthusiasm deflated significantly. "Anyway, it was nice to meet you. Good luck tonight."

"Same," Catra nodded. Once the 'fan' left, she turned her attention back to Adora, who was still clinging to her. "Now, what was all that about?"

"Nothing," Adora swung around to her front and pulled her into a deep kiss. When they parted, she gestured to the drink to change the conversation, "I didn't know what to get you. I hope this is okay."

"If it's not, I'm going to leave you for that girl you scared off," Catra teased before trying her drink. She made an awkward face after sitting it down. "Too bad for her, it's perfect," she said smoothly with a wink as she leaned over and kissed her again.

"You two are ridiculous," Glimmer commented as she was finishing serving the margaritas. "I thought Adora was going to punch her."

"Pfft, of course not," Adora grabbed hers and took a big drink.

Bow grinned at his girlfriend, "Glim, you don't have any room to talk. Remember last week? That guy in the drive-thru was flirty when he placed his order with me, and all of a sudden, you need *me* to go wash dishes before he got to the window."

"That was a strategic partner play, not at all motivated by Mr flirty frappucino." Glimmer shrugged.

"Uh-huh," Catra laughed and held up her drink to Bow, "To being nerds with hot jealous girlfriends." They clinked with laughter.

Trivia finally got started about thirty minutes later. They registered their team under "Best Friend Squad 2.0" at Bow's insistence. Glimmer was in charge of the marker and board, and they were deadly serious about keeping their voices down to hide their answers.

The host posed the first question, "From what language does both Portuguese and French derive?"

Adora's face lit up, and she leaned in, "Latin?"

"Look at you," Catra laughed, "Actually remembering things from that class."

"I have a super sexy tutor," Adora winked and started to scooch her stool closer.

"FOCUS," Bow scolded. "No time for making out!"

"Sorry," Adora frowned. "I get so flirty when I'm drinking and look at her." She grabbed Catra's chin gently, "I just wanna—"

"Maybe drink some water, dummy," Catra pushed a water glass over to her. "There's time for that later."

"Mmhm," she confirmed and chugged some water. Meanwhile, they had their answer checked, and it was correct.

The next question was announced, "What is a hybrid between a male horse and a female donkey called?"

"A mule, right?" Glimmer whispered and started to write.

"NO," Adora shouted and then lowered her voice, "Sorry, you'd think that, but it's actually a hinny. A jenny and a stallion make a hinny."

"Are you sure?" Bow asked incredulously. "I've never heard of that."

"If there's anyone I trust for horse facts, it's Adora. Even a little drunk," Catra whispered to Glimmer, "It's gotta be hinny."

When the answer was announced, they were the only table that got it right, bringing them to the top of the leaderboard. Adora punched the air above her head wildly as she cheered, "Horse giiiirl." Catra leaned over to kiss her cheek.

The next few rounds of questions brought them a couple of failures along with many successes. None of them knew what year Netflix was founded, for instance. Bow made them one of two tables to know how many keys were on a piano. Glimmer knew where the most coffee was produced in the previous year and what an affogato was. She didn't earn that coffee master apron for nothing. Catra helped with a smattering of questions -- tech-related (what gif stands for), cooking (the meaning of 'sous vide'), and a comic-related question (What superhero group is Sue Storm most known for being a member of?). Even more they collaborated on and managed to get right with their best guesses. They really were something of a dream team.

They were in second place at the break before the final rounds, trailing behind the top team by only a couple of points. They huddled in together.

"We've got this, guys," Bow whispered, "Aesop's Foibles isn't going to know what hit them."

"Pfft, stupid name," Catra giggled and leaned into Adora's shoulder, finally reaching the point of being a little tipsy after her drink and some margarita.

"I hope the final question is about horses," Adora laid her head on top of Catra's.

"I think you got the only horse question they planned," Glimmer noted. "Bow, do you remember how the end works?"

"It's like.. hmm.." he closed his eyes and thought. "The points are doubled and tripled, but you also lose points for wrong answers if you answer. So you can decline to answer if you don't know it."

"Fuck it, we're all in," Catra said very confidently. "Best Friend Squad 2.0 answers everything."

"Yeah," Adora chuckled. "We're either coming in 1st place or nothing."

"Catra, drink some water. I'm worried if we lose, you're going to buy this bar out of spite," Glimmer pointed at her glass.

"I'll rename it Fuck Aesop's Foibles," Catra teased before downing the rest of her water. She really *didn't* need another arcade situation.

Finally, the host returned to start the final rounds of the game. The first question, worth double, was announced: Which Dutch artist painted "Girl with a Pearl Earring"?

"Oooh, I know that," Adora whispered. "Vermeer?"

"How do you know that," Glimmer raised an eyebrow.

"Animal crossing!" she whispered back, "Bow lets me play on his island. The fox man sold it to me."

"You're right! I remember that," he confirmed and reached over to high-five her.

Unfortunately, the other team was correct as well. Next question, another worth double: What is it called when a bottle of champagne is opened with a sword?

Everyone at their small table looked to Catra, who made a face, "Why does everyone think *I* know this?"

"Rich people shit," Glimmer answered as though it was apparent. "Come on! I know you've done it."

Catra sighed and whispered, "Sabering."

"Whoa, I wanna see you do that." Adora swooned as she stared at her girlfriend, who winked at her, "Let's do it at the party."

Catra was correct. Aesop's Foibles had opted to skip the question, which meant Best Friend Squad 2.0 was in the lead but not uncatchable. Finally, the last question, worth triple the points if answered correctly or an inevitable loss if not: In the popular tabletop roleplaying game, Dungeons and Dragons, this deity is known as the Platinum Dragon.

Catra and Bow met eyes across the table and started cheering. "Okay, okay, calm down," Adora carefully guided Catra back down onto her stool as she was leaning across to high-five Bow. "We have to write it down for it to count."

Bow spelled out the answer to Glimmer, and they all anxiously awaited for time to be called. Finally, the host asked for answers. The Aesop's Foibles team hadn't even held up their board. "The answer is... Bahamut! That means our winners tonight are Best Friend Squad 2.0." As the rest of the pub clapped, their table exploded. Catra and Bow bypassed their partners entirely to hug each other and hop up and down.

"We're in love with the biggest nerds in town," Glimmer laughed as she stood with Adora watching them.

Adora yelled over them, "Hey! We answered questions too. No one knew what a hinny was!"

The host made his way over to the table and presented them with their prizes: four trucker-style baseball hats with the pub's name on them. "Congratulations," he said cheerily as he placed them on

the table "You all should stick around. We're doing karaoke next. I'll let you hop to the front of the line as a part of your prize too."

"Really?!" Adora squealed and put on her hat immediately. "Catra, pleaaase, sing with me."

"Whoa," the host muttered as he looked over at the red-cheeked CEO, "I thought the resemblance was uncanny. You really *are* Catra. Should've been here last week; my final question was about Darla. Hey, do you--"

Catra waved her hands and shook her head, "Sorry. I'm on vacation. I'm not allowed to answer work-related questions."

"Fair. Let me know when you pick some songs!" Then, he headed off to set up the karaoke equipment.

"Look at you, being so good," Adora smirked as she came over and put a hat on Catra, "What song do you want to sing?"

"I'm not really a karaoke person, 'Dora," she whined. "Can't Sparkles or Bow go sing with you?"

"Nope," Glimmer said quickly as she sat back down, "I've gotta be available to record whatever happens."

"And I, um," Bow looked like he was thinking really hard and then sat down, "I can't sing with Adora. She's... too.. good. It's intimidating."

"I know that's a lie," Catra laughed and then looked at Adora, who was serving up her big, sad eyes. "Fine, fine. Um. Maybe one of the duets we do in the car from the oldies station?"

"YES!" Adora cheered and hugged her quickly before going to sign them up.

Catra sat back down at the table and finished up the last of her share of the margaritas, "Why do I let her talk me into these things?"

"Because you're in love," Glimmer answered in a sing-song voice.

"Adora mentioned you're going to go visit her mom," Bow said. "That's *pretty* serious. We haven't even met her mom. Planning any big conversations while you're there?"

Catra's already red cheeks got even hotter, and she stared down at her drink, "Uh. Fuck, I don't know. Should I be?"

Before anyone could answer that question, Adora bounded back up happily, "We're in! I also put you two in," she pointed at Glimmer and Bow, "You're welcome."

"What?! You didn't even let us pick songs," Glimmer protested.

"I picked the same songs you both *always* do," Adora smirked. "Come on! This is our victory lap!"

Bow seemed significantly swayed by this argument and raised his water glass, "To the Best Friend Squad 2.0!"

After a few more minutes, Adora and Catra were called to the "stage," aka brightly lit corner with speakers, a couple of mic stands, and a small screen for lyrics. "Wait, what song are we doing," Catra whispered as they were stepping into place.

"You'll know it," Adora winked. "We're going to give these people a show!"

A show? Sure. Catra would agree it was at least going to be *some* kind of show -- more likely on the side of comedy. They stood waiting awkwardly, and in the quiet room, she swore she could hear people talking about her and or Darla. Great.

Finally, the music kicked on, and she found herself smiling again. They did do an excellent car rendition of this one. She took her mic off the stand, and Adora did the same as they turned to each other. This could work if she just pretended she was only singing to her, "Don't go breaking my heart."

"I couldn't if I tried," Adora sang back, so giddy and excited Catra couldn't help but get more into it.

"Oh, honey, if I get restless."

"Baby, you're not that kind."

They were dancing with the music and both giving it their all by the time they reached the chorus. When they finished, the crowd applauded enthusiastically, and they made a show of bowing before leaving the stage area.

"Wow," Adora giggled as they head back to their table, "That's the first time I think people weren't just clapping because they were happy I was done."

"It was definitely our best version," Catra still felt ridiculous, but she couldn't wipe the silly smile off her face.

The squad piled into the elevator in Catra's building, still giggly and now recounting the tales of their trivia win as though it was a long passed, treasured memory. "Oxford comma, bitches!" Glimmer yelled before watching Catra curiously. "Oh my god, Catra. You have your own C button? What a flex."

"I think that was DT’s idea. They were in my office when my realtor called about finalizing the deal on this place."

"Sounds like them," Adora said and then looked amused. "Wait till you meet DT next week. They're hysterical."

"Whatever you do, don't tell DT that. I'll have to add an extra building at work to fit their ego." When the elevator stopped, she held the doors to let everyone else get off first.

Melog was lounging on the spiral staircase and made his way down to meet his guests. "Aww," Bow put his hands on his cheeks as he cooed, "Can I pet him?"

"Oh yeah," Adora confirmed as she lifted the cat up into her arms, "Our son is very friendly." Bow lovingly stroked the Russian blue's head, earning him a happy purr.

"Wow, Catra," Glimmer said in awe as she continued on in. "This place is gorgeous."

"Thanks. You two get to be my first guests," Catra admitted as she led her towards the room they'd be staying in. "Well, aside from Adora, but..."

"Except she *kind of* lives here now," Glimmer finished for her. "Thanks for having us. It means a lot."

Catra smiled, thinking how glad she was that dating Adora came with initiation into the "squad." As if she needed any more perks..

Adora and Glimmer had the unlucky fortune of getting up early the next day to head into Starbucks. They got ready for work, kissed their partners goodbye, and rode together in Catra's car. Even after a prework undertow *and* venti water, Adora was still feeling pretty out of it at the start of the day. Maybe doing pub trivia *and* karaoke wasn't a great plan before an opening shift, but it was fun enough to be worth it.

"Good morning. Thank you for choosing Starbucks. This is Adora; what could I get started for you," she asked over the headset.

"Hello, Adora," a female voice she didn't recognize said, "I was *so* hoping I'd get to see you this morning. I'd like a venti soy vanilla latte extra hot with half the pumps and cinnamon on top. A sprouted grain bagel, toasted, but not too toasted, and a side of butter."

"Okay," Adora answered as she started keying everything in. "That'll be --" before she said the total, the car had moved forward. She shrugged to herself as she stepped over to start prepping the beverage.

"Who was that?" Glimmer asked as she got to work on the bagel.

"I have no idea," Adora answered, and, in fact, she still really wasn't quite sure when she popped over to the window to ring the person up. When she opened it and leaned out with the latte, her groggy mind caught up.

"Just look at you, so cute in your little uniform. I get what Catra sees in you now," Valerie scrunched up her face with the same exaggerated amusement one would look at a baby with. "Is that my drink? I'm so sorry, darling, I wanted that *iced*. Maybe you didn't hear me correctly."

Adora knew what she heard, but she put on her best fake smile, "Sorry about that. I'll get that fixed for you."

"How is Catra doing, by the way?" Valerie asked before Adora could get the window closed again. "Heard she's actually taking time off work. I do hope she's alright. Very out of character for her."

Adora clenched her hand that was out of sight into a fist and forced another smile, "She's great. Taking a very well-deserved vacation. It must be tiring being one of the most successful people in the world, you know. People like you and me, we couldn't even imagine, right? Let get that drink for you, mam."

Based on her face, Valerie decidedly did *not* like the implication that she and Adora were on the same level. She closed the window all the way and went about remaking the drink. While the shots were pulling, she got on the headset, "It's *her*."

"Valerie?!" Glimmer asked as she headed up her way with the bagel. "Not in my Starbucks. Not today."

"Yep," Adora nodded calmly, making the latte to the exact specifications requested but iced. No way was she going to let his woman have something to say about her 'poisoning' or 'ruining' her drink.

Meanwhile, Glimmer grabbed a trenta cup and filled it with water. She made her way over to the window with a mischievous grin. As she opened it, she looked down at the woman in her fancy, non-Darla car. She was all dressed up for something. Whether it was work or simply being petty at Starbucks, who could be sure. "I'm so sorry about your wait," Glimmer explained as she handed over the bagel, "Adora's still pretty new. She's getting the hang of things."

"Thank you," Valerie said as she took the bagel. "Are you the manager?"

Since the two of them had blocked each other on social media after Glimmer's early morning Twitter attack, Valerie had no idea who she was. "Yes, I'll make sure to write her up properly for this," she lied and then started to hand out the rather large water, "It's going to be a *hot* one today. I thought you might enjoy some of our water. It's triple filtered!"

"That would be wonderful, thank you," she reached out to grab it, but as she was about to take hold, Glimmer squeezed the cup and caused the barely on top to pop off. The thirty ounces of water rushed onto the other woman's outfit and her car's interior.

"I'm *so* sorry," Glimmer ducked back in and then out with one napkin, "This is the last one we have. Gosh. What bad luck."

"Wait, you're Sparkles, aren't you?!" Valerie furrowed her brow, and Glimmer winked. "I am going to have both of your jobs for this!"

As she was driving away, Adora came up to the window, having missed what happened. "Wait, what?" She looked at Glimmer, who was still grinning. "Oh my god, Glimmer," she said as she got the gist of it based on the empty water cup and Valerie driving off without her drink. "Did you really pour that on her?!" She couldn't help but laugh as much as she was worried.

"Worth it," Glimmer shrugged. "If she gets me fired, at least I've got an interview at Darla next week."

"We can't tell Catra," Adora said. "She's supposed to be relaxing. She doesn't need to know that snake came here. If Valerie makes a big fuss online like the baby she is, then, sure. But let's not bring it up if we don't have to. Okay?"

"Okay. Sorry, I probably should've thought about that. Hopefully, she won't post about it. She looks pretty desperate coming around here just to stir up shit."

By comparison, the rest of their morning went incredibly smoothly. While on break, Adora opened her phone to see a bunch of waiting texts.

Bow: [selfie of him and Catra at a gaming store]

Bow: Guess what we're doing toniiiiight. DUNGEONS. AND. DRAGONS! And you all can't tell me no, because Catra wants to too.

Catra: Adora, what kind of character do you want to be? If you don't reply in time, I'm just going to buy all the minis they have.

Adora: I don't know! I've never played before.

Catra: Gotcha. One of everything it is. I love painting these things anyway.

Bow: Before you come back, ask Glimmer about getting my dice bag at our place. Pleeease. My lucky dice are in there!

Adora: Will do! Do I need dice? Cause I don't have any.

Catra: I picked you out a few sets, a dice tray, and some random d20s that look like you.

Adora: Aww. That's so cute. I love you.

Bow: We love you too. [wink emoji]

In another, one-on-one text-

DT: Blondie. I hope you and our sweet CEO are having a nice vacation. The singing video last night was simply adorable. But please tell me you are not the reason little miss Valerie is posting about a personal boycott of Starbucks?

She sighed. Damn.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry about the wait this time. Writing has been slow lately. I've got too much going on in my head, I think.

Much like I predicted in last chapter's notes, the muse took me other places with this chapter haha. Maybe I shouldn't write up what to expect next...

Anyway. I hope you enjoyed it! I always enjoy reading through comments. Lately, I've not been able to get to replying to them as much as usual, but rest assured, I still read and appreciate every last one. It makes me so happy.

The song Catradora sang together is Don't Go Breaking My Heart by Elton John with Kiki Dee. You can listen to it here: Music Video
This was suggested by the sweet wildangeline (who also helped me think of trivia questions along with butterfliesinmybrains!) ! Ooh, and what do you think Glimmer and Bow's go-to karaoke songs are? I left that ambiguous for reader imagination ;)

Adventure Awaits

Chapter Summary

After the story god awakes from a long rest, The Best Friend Squad get together for a dungeons and dragons game. Catra has created a monster.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora : It's a long story. My friend poured water all over her like it was an accident.

DT : Cold water?

Adora : Yes.

Adore barely contained her urge to joke about it being tripled filtered. Instead, she waited for a reply nervously.

DT : At least we have the good sense not to scald someone. No impending lawsuit coming then, probably.

Adora : Am I in trouble?

DT : Honey, I'm not your mother! And if I was, I'd be on your side.

DT : Wonder what she's doing here anyway. And, of the thousand Starbucks we have in this damn city, she chooses yours. [nail polish emoji] Bit suspicious to me.

Adora : She was awful to me the whole time, but I was nice anyway. I really didn't know Glimmer was going to do that!

DT : I believe you, dear. No timeouts from mother DT. I'm about to chat up someone in Seattle to do some damage control. I'll check in if I need anything from you.

After buying a dragon's hoard worth of miniatures and game accessories, Catra and Bow were on their way back to the penthouse to prepare for the first Best Friend Squad 2.0 adventure.

"So, I haven't ever asked. How did you and Glimmer meet?" Catra said as they strolled down the sidewalk.

"We've known each other since we were kids. We went to school together from elementary all the way to college now."

"And how long did it take you to realize you were in love with each other?" She asked with a cheeky grin. "Hope you didn't waste *all* that time pining."

Bow looked a bit sheepish, "Sophomore year of high school, she blurted out that she loved me when I almost went to a dance with someone else. It was like I saw a flash of our whole lives to that point, and I knew I'd always loved her too. I felt stupid for not realizing it sooner."

Catra laughed a little to herself, "I have to admit, your whole true love thing was very demoralizing as a single person to see first thing in the morning. Almost made me choose a new Starbucks."

"Well, now you get to know what it's like, huh?" Bow winked.

"Yeah," Catra blushed and looked away, "I hope so anyway. We're still just getting started."

"You're perfect together," Bow patted her on the shoulder. "Sometimes I forget you haven't been a couple for years too."

"Thanks. I don't know if she told you, but Adora's actually my first girlfriend. I'm just trying not to fuck it all up somehow."

"I'm no relationship expert," Bow said sagely, as though he were indeed an expert, "I'm just a regular guy who met his person a long time ago, but I think it all comes down to talking about things. Over the years, Glim and I both have done our fair share of fucking up. But, we know how to communicate after and find our way through it."

Catra nodded, "Talking to Adora's easy at least. I spent so long being in my own head about anything that wasn't business-related. It's a nice change."

"Sounds stressful and…lonely."

"Definitely. And, well, not to be too mushy or anything, but I'm glad to have you and Sparkles too. If I'm embarrassingly honest, you're my first non-work friends in a long time."

"Aww, Catra," Bow had stars in his eyes as he clutched his chest. "That's so--"

"Don't make it weird," she said sternly with a smirk. "Um... can I ask you about something else? Just between us?"

"Anything," Bow smiled.

"Should we get her flowers," Adora asked Glimmer, who was scrolling through Twitter in the passenger seat. "You know... like as a 'sorry we caused extra drama!' I don't know what flowers she likes, though... What flowers are apology flowers?"

"Are there specific apology flowers," Glimmer asked with a raised eyebrow, "I think Catra will understand, anyway. Plus, *you* didn't do anything. It was my fault, and I'll apologize."

"It was **her** fault, actually," Adora narrowed her eyes which made the car remind her to keep her eyes on the road. "I'm sorry, Darla. It's just... this woman is unbelievable! What is she even doing here?! I thought she lived at least a couple hundred miles away."

Glimmer sighed, "Ugh. According to Val's Twitter, she's speaking at our school next week."

"WHAT," Adora threw her hands up, "What department would be dumb enough to want her?"

"*Keep both hands on the steering wheel,"* Darla chimed.

"Listen, maybe we talk about this after we get stopped somewhere," Glimmer said nervously and put her phone away.

"Oh my god. It's not *my* department is it?! What does her stupid business even have to do with anything in health sciences?"

"Adora, do you even know <u>what</u> her stupid business is?"

In all of Adora's dealings with the woman, it had never occurred to her to investigate this. She laughed about it before admitting, "I have no idea. But, whatever it is, I hate it."

"Refined Taste, or RT for short. It's like Spotify but for snobby people and hipsters. RT claims it is an expert, critic curated music experience for those who know what real music is," Glimmer explained in her best snooty voice before pretending to gag. "Anyway, this is a cross-department event. Business, health sciences, and technology. According to the press release her company posted, she is launching a new product that links music and health."

"It sounds like a bunch of bullshit to me," Adora scoffed. "If I have to go, I'll wear a disguise and heckle her." Of course, she could never actually do something like that but imagining it felt satisfying all the same.

"Well, now *I* want to go," Glimmer laughed. Her phone dinged, and she brought it back out of her pocket to read over a text. "Damn, I almost forgot. We still need to grab Bow's dice, and *apparently*, we're in charge of food now. They were going to cook, but he says they're too busy."

"I wonder what they're up to. I don't even know what all Dungeons and Dragons entails."

"I've played with Bow a couple of times. It's like... improv, math, and storytelling combined. Oh... and violence."

Their arms full of enough takeout to feed a small army, Adora and Glimmer walked out of the elevator into the penthouse. Their partners were nowhere to be seen. After placing the food down on the small dining table, Adora called out, "Hellloooo?! Anybody home?"

Melog hopped from his window perch to the table to smell the food. "Where's your other mommy and uncle, huh?" She asked as she picked him up and away from the food with a hug.

Muffled by the walls, she made out Catra yelling back, "The study."

"There's a study in this place," Glimmer asked as she looked around.

"Oh, just you wait," Adora said with a smirk. She led the two of them through the penthouse into the office area. Catra's work desk appeared still untouched since Adora last checked on it (for relaxation accountability and all). Still absent was the rest of their party.

"Um. Are you sure this is the study? I doubt they've invented invisibility while we were at work," Glimmer teased.

Adora approached the back wall of the office and stood staring at the bookshelves in thought. "Hold on," she mumbled as she tapped her chin. Finally, she reached out and pulled on the novelization of

Mara the Dragon Tamer. Instead of coming out entirely, it bent forward and activated a mechanism with a click. The bookshelf slid sideways and revealed a room that was completely different from the aesthetic of the rest of the home.

The walls appeared to be worked stone with dark wood shelving that matched the hardwood floors below. Lamps designed to look like torches were set into the rock. A small bar that looked like a fantasy tavern lined the back wall. In the center was a long wooden table where Catra and Bow sat in ornate leather chairs. Neatly organized in front of them were a collection of tiny figures, paints, and brushes. They were totally engrossed in whatever this arts and craft project was.

"This is the coolest, nerdiest thing I've ever seen," Glimmer said with wide eyes as she took in all the details.

"Thanks. It was one of my first customizations. Never used it for a game until now," Catra glanced up to Glimmer and then smiled over at Adora, "Hey." She was holding a magnifying glass in one hand and a tiny figure in the other.

"What are you doing, and why is it so cute?" Adora walked up behind Catra and stared down at what she was working on.

"I'm teaching Bow to paint minis." She held up the one she was working on, a female warrior of some kind with blonde hair, "This used to be my hobby for relaxing."

"How can this be relaxing? It's *so* hard," Bow whined and held up his own. He had done a decent job painting a pink-haired magic-user with horns, but it was nowhere near the level of detail as Catra's.

"Aw, babe," Glimmer said as she kissed the top of his head. "I love her anyway. She looks very magical."

"That's Sparkles the Sorceress," Catra said with a grin. "The name is official; it's on your character sheet," she gestured over across the table where a few sets of glittery, shimmering dice were waiting along with papers.

"Oooh, you picked for us already? Who am I?" Adora asked curiously.

"Well, since you've never played, I thought you should pick. You don't have to be blondie here. She's just an example."

"I see," she smirked as she wrapped her arms around Catra from above and hung over her, "You just wanted to imagine me with extra muscles and a big sword."

"*Maybe*," Catra winked before tilting up to kiss the side of her face.

"Okay, team! No more distractions. Let's clean up and eat before we get into an amazing ADVENTURE," Bow said in his best heroic voice. He looked like a kid on their birthday. "I've been dreaming of this for years." With that, he realized that Glimmer could see his notes, so he hastily put his arms over them. "No spoilers!"

Over dinner, Catra and Bow excitedly filled Adora in on the basics of how the game was going to work. All of the details were swirling around in Adora's head as she tried to take it in. She was never much of an auditory learner, but she figured she'd find her way once they started playing. She was just happy to see the two of them bonding over something they mutually loved. Glimmer looked amused and shared glances with Adora that she figured translated to 'we love these geeks.'

After cleaning up from dinner, they transitioned back into the study, where Bow had already activated some kind of mood music. It really felt like entering a fantasy video game. Adora found herself wishing they had all dressed for the occasion. Maybe next time.

Mercifully, Catra had pulled out one of her books and opened it up to a table that said the basic details of each class (their abilities, strengths, play style, etc.). This, Adora, could work with. Catra took her time guiding her through each one and then let Adora sit with the book to think it over.

After a few minutes, Adora looked up from the book, still unsure. "What are you guys going to be?"

"As you know, I'm Sparkles the Sorceress," Glimmer said with a laugh. She held up her character sheet, where she had added a doodle of Sparkles based on her mini. "She's a sexy, purple devil woman who solves things with magic, charisma, and violence."

"Feels on brand," Catra laughed and showed her own character sheet with its own doodle of a cat woman with a cloak and daggers. "I'm playing one of my recurring characters: C'yra, a tabaxi rogue. She's ill-mannered and off-putting at first but very good at stealing and killing things. She'll warm up to you eventually... probably."

"These are so good," Adora said with stars in her eyes. She looked back down at the list, "Hmmm... if I play a bard, does that mean I get to sing on my turns?"

Glimmer made an awkward face, "Adora, I love you, but I'm going to get a migraine if you do that all night."

Catra looked pained at the prospect as well. "I mean, the singing part isn't *necessary.* We can't all be Sam." Adora decided this Sam must be some kind of nerd inside joke because Bow laughed without looking up from his notes.

She relented, "Okay, okay. I did already get to do karaoke last night. If I can't sing, I need a big sword."

"Oh, thank god," Catra said quietly before pointing down to the list, "We could probably use some healing so a paladin or a cleric--"

"Nope, too boring." Adora interrupted. "I want to be that one that smashes everything."

"Barbarian?" Catra looked delighted.

"Yes! I would like to RAGE," Adora affirmed enthusiastically. "After a day like today, I need it."

"Wait, what happened?" Bow looked up with a worried face. "Did everything go okay at work?"

"Fuck," Adora grumbled to herself. She had totally forgotten about the whole mess somehow. "I'm sorry, I should've said something. It's just you were so cute and excited, and we were all having fun..."

"Is this about the Valerie thing this morning," Catra asked. She did not seem terribly concerned about it.

"You knew?" Adora shrunk in her chair, the anxiety clearly rising. "I'm so sorry. I didn't mean to cause more problems. I know you're trying to relax and--"

Catra reached over and squeezed her hand, "It's okay, I promise. DT texted me about it after it was handled. Fuck her for trying to start shit in the first place." she glanced over at Glimmer and nodded

approvingly. "Good job, Sparkles."

Glimmer gave a bow, "Thank you, thank you. Meanwhile, Adora was pleasant and mature. It was all me."

"You're really not mad?" Adora gave a pitiful frown. "I was going to get you flowers to apologize, but I don't even know what you'd like."

"Not even a little," Catra was staring back at her lovingly, which started to calm her nerves, "And for the record, I like anything that's from you. Even that ridiculous business horse shirt you gave me."

"Aww. You really like it?" Adora smiled and leaned over into Catra's space.

"Can we please adventure now?" Bow asked as he gave his own sad eyes over his dm screen. They all nodded. "Catra, help her roll up some stats. Glim, pick your spells." Melog decided now was the time to hop on the table in front of Bow, causing his dice to scatter. "Little buddy, noooo," he complained as the cat laid across his meticulously organized papers.

"After a long day of travels, C'yra and Sparkles find themselves sitting in the same tavern enjoying food and drink," Bow started his narration, "C'yra, where would you be," he gestured at the tavern map he'd laid out.

Catra reached out and placed her miniature on the map, "I'd be over here in the corner. Just watching and trying to overhear if anything of interest is being discussed."

"Okay, roll a perception check."

She rolled a d20 that was the same color as her honey-toned eye. Adora was observing as Catra gestured to her sheet to show her what she was doing. "Eighteen."

"You feel like you're getting a solid read on the room. No one's talking about anything you think could be a good take for you, but many people are discussing a newcomer to Oakhurst. Sounds like a goliath who has been causing trouble all day. Rumors say she set some horses free from their pins, but no one's brave enough to accuse her," Bow reported and then looked to his girlfriend, "Okay, Sparkles. Where are you?"

"I'm at the bar," she said as she placed her miniature, "I'm having a glass of wine and trying to talk up the bartender. I ask her how her day has been."

Bow modulates his voice to a softer, cloying tone, "Fair to middling. Thanks, honey. Hardly anyone cares to ask about little old me. What brings someone like you to town?"

"Oh, you know, going where fate leads me. Looking for some *excitement,*" Glimmer ran her finger over her actual wine glass while making eyes at Bow, "And I wink at her!"

"Make a charisma check."

Glimmer rolled a purple, sparkling dice, then checked her own paper, "Seventeen."

"She looks like she's into what you're putting down, but before there's a chance to reply, there's a loud crash as the door to the tavern swings open so hard it hits the wall. Adora, tell us about yourself."

Adora reached out and put her miniature in the doorway. "Okay, so. My character is an eight-foot-tall goliath woman with a long braid of blonde hair down her back. She's wearing a red crop top and leather pants, and she's got a huge sword on her hip."

"Everyone looks up at you, and all conversation seems to stop. So, C'yra, you gather *this* is the goliath they've been talking about."

Catra smirks, "Okay. I look up from my drink and casually nod at her."

"I nod back. And I look around at everyone else and grunt something in um," she looked down at her character sheet, "Giant. I say something intimidating like 'what the fuck are you looking at.'"

Bow nodded, "You get the sense that no one in the room likely knows giant, but they seem freaked out enough that they all stop staring."

"Great," Adora felt herself getting into this more and more. "I walk up to the woman that nodded at me." She turned to Catra. "Got something to say to me?"

Catra drummed her fingers on the table as she leaned her chin on her other hand, "Merely recognizing a fellow troublemaker, that's all. Got a name, Legs?"

"Legs," Adora asked with a raised eyebrow.

"Wow, got it on my first try," Catra laughed.

"Oh no, my name isn't... I'm Shera."

"Shera? I like Legs better, personally. Why don't you take a seat? I could always use a little muscle."

"Shera will sit down across from her and smirk. It's true, you don't have *any*. What's your name, um... Sticks?"

"She'll hold out a hand to shake yours and say, C'yra. Then she'll start asking some basic and personal questions of Shera. She doesn't really care about the answers; she just wants to see how trusting she is and get some idea of how to work her."

Bow interjected, "Shera? How would you react to C'yra throwing all these questions at you?"

Adora chuckled as she thought it through, "Oh, she tells *everything*. And in like, probably way more detail than you should tell a stranger. She's very excited that anyone's talking to her."

Catra nodded, "C'yra is listening with amusement but also occasionally looking over at the tiefling at the bar. She's been eying her bag all night."

"Sparkles, you and the bartender are still flirting, yes?"

"Definitely," Glimmer said, "I mean, I imagine I looked up when Shera slammed her way in, but I'm still focused on Breelyn. Trying to get to know her, see if she can link me up with any powerful people. Maybe see if she knows about any high-paying jobs."

"Make a perception check at disadvantage to see if you notice the tabaxi staring at your bag of holding."

She rolled two dice and frowned, "Damn. Seven."

"Yeah, you are way too caught up in her eyes right now to notice any others. She's stopped paying attention to most of the other patrons too. You get the sense it's going well, but it doesn't seem like Bree knows anything of note regarding opportunities in town. C'yra," he turned his attention back to the other two, "From your passive insight, it seems like Shera is telling you nothing but the truth."

"Great. I'll tell her how impressed I am with whatever random shit she's told me and thank her." Catra smiled. "She-ra... I have a proposition for you. She makes eyes over at the bar. That Tiefling? She's got a bag hanging on her chair, and I'm *certain* it has something of mine in it. I need to check. Since everyone's already so interested in you, do you think you can cause a distraction for me so I can borrow it?"

After succeeding on a deception check, Adora's character was convinced. "Definitely. I'm *very* distracting. And she says it kind of smoothly because she wants to impress her."

"Make a charisma check."

Adora carefully selected a d20 and rolled it. "Um... one. Plus," she looked over her sheet. "Negative one. So... zero."

"Yeah, as you try to say that smoothly, you're drooling, and you realize you're starving," Bow said.

Catra laughed and reacted, "C'yra narrows her eyes at her in disgust before shrugging it off. Her expectations are pretty low at this point. She offers to buy Shera dinner after they're done."

"Shera is *very* excited about that. So, she gets up from the table with a wink and looks around the room. Bow, who's all in the tavern?"

"There are a few different groups," he gestured at the map and started to describe, "There's a small table by the bar with shady types you think would get along with C'yra. There are some farmers at a few tables kind of grouped up by you two. They're all drinking heavily. There's a table with a family of halflings; they look like they've finished dinner. One of the kids is singing in a language you don't know."

"Great," Adora moved her miniature. "I walk up to the family, and without saying anything, I flip the table!"

"Make a strength check?" Bow said, horrified.

"What the fuck, Adora," Catra asked as she cackled.

Adora rolled the dice, "NATURAL TWENTY."

"Yeah, you...," Bow shook his head, "You flip that nice family's table. In fact, you flip it up with such strength that it actually lands face down on one of the farmers' tables. C'yra, Sparkles, and everyone else in the tavern is alerted as screaming starts. Roll initiative."

Bow, the players, and the dice told the story of the fight. C'yra managed to grab the bag of holding while Sparkles was trying to defend the bartender. When she realized that happened, the sorceress threw caution to the wind as she started slinging chaos bolts at C'yra. The acid ones burned through the tavern floor while fire ones lit up some of the rest. Shera was busy punching drunk farmers and waiting for C'yra to leave with her. Eventually, the City Watch came in, and everything was halted as their resident arcane member cast hold person on Sparkles, Shera, and C'yra. After properly

restraining their hands, the spell dropped, and the would-be party was marched through the street towards the jail.

"I try to convince the city watch I didn't do anything wrong! I was helping," Glimmer said desperately. "I don't even know these idiots! One was stealing from me."

"Roll for persuasion," Bow said.

She rolled, "Um.. twelve!"

"They seem like they could believe you but tell you that you're going to have to wait until the morning. Then, they will get the local cleric to do a zone of truth on you all."

"Fuck," Catra mumbled. "Okay, I'm going to cast a message at Shera. And I'll say... if they don't take all my shit, I can break us out. You can reply to this message. Whisper, please."

"Shera, you hear this message in your mind like Catra's whispering it in your ear even though she's a few feet away," Bow explained.

"Whoa, this is cool," Adora whispered in real life, "You're in my head! I didn't know you did magic. But what if they take your stuff?"

"C'yra sighs and then casts it again. That's what I'm worried about. Do you have anywhere I can hide some tools? It's a small pouch."

"Umm," Adora thought about it for a moment, "My boobs." Everyone else started laughing so hard they had to pause the game for a minute. "They won't look in there!"

"C'yra thinks this is the dumbest idea ever, but she decides to cast mage hand and try to tuck her thieve's tools deep into Shera's cleavage."

"Shera blushes," Adora said and winked at Catra. "This is the closest she's ever gotten to second base."

"Well, this is *not* how I saw this night going," Bow chuckled. "Make a sleight of hand check. Then, Sparkles, you can make a perception check and see if you notice."

Catra laughed again to herself as she rolled. "Nineteen."

"Me too," Glimmer said as she gestured proudly to her dice.

"I rolled for the watch, and, as far as any of you can tell, they didn't notice this 'exchange.' Sparkles, you do see what seems to be a floating pouch nestling itself into Shera's top."

"I won't say anything for now," Glimmer said as she shrugged. "But they are not leaving that jail without me."

"I can't believe you tried to rob me," Glimmer yelled at the conclusion of the session.

"I would've succeeded, but *someone* 's idea of a distraction caused the authorities to get involved."

"Hey! She's working with a low intelligence score, okay. I thought it was the right character choice," Adora said as she crossed her arms.

"Sure, but did it have to be that table?" Bow asked. "Of all the tables, you picked the sweet family of four."

"They were already done eating," Adora said. "Plus, then we all ended up in jail together to bond and meet that weird old lady. We'd have never learned about the sword of protection!"

"I can't wait to sell that thing to the highest bidder," Catra laughed.

"What! No, I want it," Adora whined. "Please, C'yra. It sounds so cooool."

"You'll have to take it from me first," Glimmer crossed her arms.

"You can't even use swords like that, Sparkles," Catra said.

"It's the principle! You ruined my chances with the hot bartender," Glimmer protested. "I'm going to get it and throw it in a volcano or something. Are there volcanos on this continent?"

"You'll have to find out next game," Bow smiled.

"I can't wait," Adora clapped joyously, "This was so much fun! You were amazing, Bow. I didn't know you could do so many voices."

"Thank you," he bowed. "I tried my best."

"You are honestly my favorite dm," Catra said, "Shit, don't tell Rogelio that at the party next week. He was my old dm."

"Speaking of," Glimmer asked as she was starting to pack things up, "Do you need any help with that? You know my dad owns a catering business."

"YES," Adora shouted, "I forgot! Tell him we need rainbow food."

"Um, I think he's going to need more specifics than that," Glimmer said as she grabbed her phone and started typing away, "I'll text him and tell him to call you tomorrow."

"And we're both in for whatever you else you need," Bow offered. "Just say the word! We'll roll initiative." Everyone gave pained laughs at the joke.

"Thanks," Catra said with a big smile on her face. Adora thought she'd only seen her look *this* perfectly happy one other time, and that was when Adora said she loved her back.

"You're a natural," Catra said as she crawled into bed after Adora, "I've never seen someone take to DND so fast."

"Thanks," Adora replied, "It was nice to turn my brain off and smash things."

"Hey, she had some strategy too. Don't sell Shera short."

"She's too tall for that," she gave a childish grin.

"Ah, finally, a dumb Adora joke. Now I can sleep peacefully."

"Too bad because we need to break down this game and come up with a plan for the next session."

"You are really into this, huh?" Catra couldn't believe her luck.

"Duh, this is my new obsession. Can goliaths ride horses? If so, I'm going to need a huge one. You can ride with me."

"Who says C'yra wants to travel with you? She hadn't been thrown in jail in ten whole years of thieving. You're nothing but trouble, Legs."

"But where are you going to hide your tools without me?"

Catra rolled over on her side to face her, "Hmm.. you've sold me. I need these boobs of holding," she reached out and gently caressed one of her breasts.

Adora laughed, then slipped into a more alluring tone, "Another pun? I am making you so much funnier."

"Are you? Or are you making me dumber," Catra challenged, but her reddening face betrayed how flustered she was suddenly.

"You can't resist my charms. Even when I have a charisma of eight," Adora slowly glided her fingers down Catra's neck and then traced her collarbones, "I could've gotten you to kiss me in-game, but I didn't want to ruin Bow's plans."

"C'yra is not looking for romance," Catra protested.

"Please, she wants Shera already. C'yra could've gotten away, but she didn't want to leave her and those *legs* behind."

"It's a business arrangement," Catra rolled her eyes.

"Business? But you're on vacation, boss," she whispered into her ear before nibbling at the lobe.

"You're really mixing up your metaphors here," Catra huffed. "I can't tell if we're about to fuck or not."

"Are we?" Adora asked innocently as she pulled back. "I thought you didn't want me."

"Listen, Legs. If you want to fuck, I'll do it, but that doesn't mean I'm falling in love with you," Catra said in her gruffer, character voice. She pushed Adora on her back and straddled her. "Understood?"

"We'll see about that," Adora winked and glided her hands up Catra's thighs to squeeze her ass. "What do I roll for romance? Persuasion?"

Catra started laughing again before sighing and running her hands through her hair, "You know, I really shouldn't be surprised by this. You came on to me with barista roleplay the first time."

"Do you find my nerdy roleplay even sexier? Because I've learned all kinds of phrases tonight that I can misuse in ways that will drive you wild." She gave one of her signature smug smiles.

"I've created a monster with how easily I let you turn me on."

"Then **slay** me," Adora winked before releasing her grip on her and laying back against the bed.

Catra stared at her for a moment, taking in the sight of her beautiful girlfriend. Then, finally, she leaned in and whispered against her neck before biting it, "Gladly."

Chapter End Notes

Yeesh, I know, I know. The longest break ever in writing this story. I'm sorry! Sometimes I just hit blocks with certain works. I don't ever intend to give one up before concluding it. I hope you enjoyed this very belated chapter? Forgive me for my indulgence in my obsession with DND. It's the only thing I love almost as much as I love She-ra. I promise I will do my very best to get an update with a more normal chapter within the next week or two. (You may have to suffer through briefly DND-themed smut for the opener next chapter if the muse takes me there and I'm not sorry).

Also Mara the Dragon Tamer is a reference to my beloved butterfliesinmybrains' Force Captain is Typing.... Go read it and literally her whole catalog. It's all chef's kiss.

If you enjoyed the little random moments of adventure I made here, you might like my other work by the same title as this chapter: Adventure Awaits. It's good fun, and -way- fluffier than anyone would expect a DND fic to be. It's written like a fantasy story as opposed to gameplay like you saw here, and it requires no DND knowledge to understand.

P.s. what do you think Catra asked Bow?

All the Rumors are True

Chapter Summary

Truths are spoken in the bedroom, farmer's market, and in 4k.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora wiggled her wrists playfully underneath Catra's hand that was holding them down. "I don't care what you do to me; I'm not letting you have the sword," she said breathlessly. Catra's free hand that was touching her through her underwear paused.

"Wait," Catra leaned back, "We're really doing this *roleplaying* thing the whole time?"

"Why not? I think it's **hot**," Adora lifted her right leg and pressed her thigh into Catra's center. "I'm *pretty* sure you do too."

"Yeah, sure, but," she admitted with a long exhale. Her cheeks were turning even redder. "I don't know; it feels silly? I guess."

"Sex *is* silly," Adora declared sagely, "It's a ridiculous thing to do! I've watched us in that mirror over there enough times to know."

"What," Catra panicked and looked over at her three-way mirror. She had never quite appreciated its existence the way Adora had. "I'm moving that thing."

"What? Nooo," Adora whined, "I like it. Even if I think, fuck, my sex face is not cute right now, I get to see how sexy *you* look. That's the trade-off. Maybe you feel silly doing or saying what you're doing, but all I see is the sexiness."

Catra thought about it for a moment and relented, "Okay, I get it, but if you giggle about anything, I swear..."

"If I do, you can gag me," Adora winked. "Although, it'll be hard for me to tell you all my secrets then, C'yra."

Catra smirked and let herself fall back into character. She changed her voice to be lower and raspier as she said, "Oh, Legs. You know you could *never* really hide anything from me." She held her down more forcibly and worked her way into her underwear, teasingly running a finger down without quite enough pressure. "I think you're pretending I need to fuck it out of you because you're jealous."

"What did you expect? You weren't exactly *stealthy* bringing that elf back to our camp last night. Or was that another business arrangement? It was pretty *short*, and your turn never came up."

"Fuck, you are really good at this," Catra mumbled out of character briefly. Unfortunately, the many hours she'd spent playing roleplaying games did *not* quite prepare her for this.

"Yeah, that's what *she* said to you, but I've yet to see the proof," Adora said in her unimpressed voice.

Catra narrowed her eyes at her. "When I'm done, you'll be eating out my hand like I charmed you."

-Forced Vacation Day 4 of 19-

Catra couldn't help but wonder what Adora was up to while she sat waiting for her. After she had gotten home from Starbucks, the two of them walked down to the weekly farmer's market that sprung up downtown each Saturday. The goal was to find some fresh produce for making dinner together. However, of course, they had gotten distracted by all kinds of other exciting items to buy. For instance, the bamboo palm sitting at Catra's feet.

Barry the Bamboo and Catra were waiting at a picnic table by a coffee cart. Just after receiving her order, Adora looked over her shoulder and got incredibly excited about something. She grabbed Catra's face and made her look in the other direction while declaring, "I'll be right back! You two stay here. DON'T LOOK."

Thus she was sitting obediently looking at her phone instead of trying to see where Adora had disappeared to. The whole kerfuffle with Valerie the day prior had sparked a renewed interest in their drama. As much as she didn't want to care about it, it was hard when every notification she had seemed like it was a request for comment. And, of course, not commenting was its own news story. After her absence at a couple of meetings involving their partners, her 'vacation' was also public knowledge. All the same, DT knew how to do their job and work the angle about her well-deserved vacation. Thus, the majority of the reports on that seemed positive. Still, in the comments and social media, there was an undercurrent of speculation around the timing.

I really shouldn't be looking at this, she thought to herself. Curiosity killed the cat and all. Still. A plan started to formulate in her head, and she couldn't decide if it was a terrible or fantastic one.

Catra: Are you free in about an hour? I have an idea I want to run by you.

DT : If you're asking me to go to the spa with you, the answer is yes. [spa person emoji]

Catra: Ha.

DT: You're no fun. Didn't we send you on vacation with a hot blonde to fix this?

DT: But, yes, of course.

"Surprise," Adora yelled as she suddenly popped back up at the picnic table.

Catra was jolted out of her thoughts and was met with a beautiful bouquet of flowers wrapped in brown paper with a twine bow. "You really got me flowers," she asked, more touched than she probably should be. It was just... she'd never gotten flowers from anyone.

"I even picked them all out myself," she gestured over far off in the corner of the market where a 'make it yourself' flower stand was. It was undoubtedly a more mismatched bouquet than a professional would make, but she went flower by flower type, explaining her choice. Last, she landed on a collection of purple and white ones. "These are snapdragons, and..." she squeezed one gently, and it looked like the shape of a dragon opening its jaws.

"I love them all, thank you," Catra smiled as she took the bouquet. Of course, she immediately had to replicate the dragon movement in amazement. "I need to grow these. I never knew that's why they're called that."

"Right!" Adora chirped. "I thought it was too perfect."

Catra clutched the bouquet in front of her gingerly and smelled it with a smile. "Now that you're done with your secret mission, are Barry and I allowed to leave timeout? Because I'm pretty sure we need to grab a few more things to make something resembling a meal."

"Hmm, yes," Adora lifted the palm up and then rested it on her hip like a parent carrying a child. She held out her free hand to Catra. "Come on. Let's follow our hearts. I'm sure we'll figure out dinner."

"Sure, our hearts, not recipes. Makes sense," Catra laughed as she stood and took her hand.

After finding a place for Barry to live and a vase for the dragon bouquet, the two washed their various vegetable purchases. Catra rinsed while Adora was stationed beside her to dry and sort.

"I honestly have no idea what to turn this into," Catra laughed as she handed over a turnip, "But I'm sure there's an app for that."

"If not, you can invent one," Adora gently wiped down the turnip and added it to the bowl.

"Pfft, apps are small potatoes. I made apps in high school," Catra bragged with a wink.

"Yeah, who needs dumb apps. I don't need a snobby app to tell me what music is good."

Catra sighed and smiled at the same time. "I take it you've been doing some research," she noted as she handed over an actual potato.

Adora looked like a kid who had been caught with their hand in the cookie jar. "Yeah... Glimmer and I were wondering why she was in town. Apparently, she's launching something with a talk on *our* campus of all places."

"Yeah, I may have seen that too," Catra admitted. "I had too much time to play with my phone earlier. Speaking of, I was going to call DT in a bit if that's okay with you. I realized there are a lot of things I have to say, and I'm tired of being quiet."

"Hey," Adora reached over and placed her hand on Catra's, "You do whatever you need to do. I don't want you to feel like I'm trying to control you. I just want you to take care of yourself."

"Of course," Catra sat down the next vegetable she was reaching for and pressed into Adora instead. She backed her up against the side of the refrigerator. "Be a shame to miss any of this time with you," she said before brushing her lips across her neck, making her way up to join them together in a deep, passionate kiss.

-Forced Vacation Day 7 of 19-

It took some convincing, but DT ultimately relented to Catra's request to set up an interview. DT, of course, took the time to remind her that this was not what they would call a vacation. All the same,

they couldn't deny that Catra's business instincts rarely missed.

And so, she was sitting in her living room watching while people flitted around to set up lighting, take pictures of her interior design, and test sound equipment. This was *really* fucking weird. Going from keeping her private life on lock and key to having people from the media in her home was quite the change. But... many things were changing lately.

"Are you sure this is okay," Adora asked quietly as she appeared from the guest bath turned wardrobe and make-up station.

"More than okay," Catra said approvingly with a glint in her eyes.

Adora was wearing her first look for the photoshoot before the interview. Catra had specifically wanted it to be selected out of Adora's actual wardrobe. Thus, she was wearing a horse pun shirt. It was the only one Catra thought was legitimately funny --- it said 'Horse Drawn Carriage' and featured a horse sketching a carriage onto a canvas. This was paired with a pair of her regular jeans and sneakers. Similarly, Catra wore a vintage style Dungeons and Dragons t-shirt, her glasses, jeans, and converses. They looked like your average pair of 20-somethings.

"I'll change to my business horse shirt if you need me to," Catra whispered as Adora sat down beside her on the couch.

"Nope, as long as you aren't afraid of being overshadowed by me," Adora winked.

"Eh, I'm always overshadowed by you," Catra said smoothly as she reached out and tucked a strand of Adora's hair behind her ear. "No one else could look this good in something so dumb."

"Thanks," Adora giggled and leaned her forehead into Catra's.

Snaps started ringing out, and they both realized that photoshoot was officially on. This part was *supposed* to be simple: candid shots of the two of them being themselves. Whenever they remembered they were being photographed, that's when the trouble started. "Be natural," DT advised as they stood behind the photographer, "Not like that."

Eventually, they were instructed to do everyday things around the penthouse. They made coffee, walked up the spiral staircase, hung out on the rooftop looking at the cityscape. The whole time they were teasing each other about the process.

"Look at me, making espresso myself. Now everyone's going to know I only go to Starbucks for the hot girls," Catra teased as she started the machine.

Later, Adora whispered as they moved through the bedroom to the roof, "Do you think they want to capture how you look when I say dumb things to you in bed?"

"Absolutely not."

"Mmm, you're right. That's private." Adora smirked. "Ooh, we should get a polaroid camera for things like this. We'll put the prints in the sex safe."

"Sex safe?" DT asked. Neither of them had realized they were so close behind.

"SHE'S JOKING," Catra said far too defensively.

After a few more 'candid' shots, it was time for a wardrobe change. Catra was now in a statement-making dark red suit. Adora wore a white, off-the-shoulder dress with gold accents. They had stumbled across it while shopping for her "monochrome party" outfit. While Adora's heart was ultimately set on a dark teal suit for the party, neither wanted to leave behind this dress. Catra was a sucker for Adora in gold, after all. They'd find another occasion for it.

"God damn," Catra said under her breath as her girlfriend emerged again. On top of the outfit change, the stylist had done her hair up into a more elegant ponytail, complete with a grown-up version of her signature hair poof.

"You like it," Adora said as she twirled. Catra nodded enthusiastically. "I can't believe I was in class a few hours ago, and now I look like *this*."

"You truly can do it all, blondie," DT said as they joined the two. "For this, I'm told the concept is more posed. What are we thinking?"

Catra grinned widely, "Oh, I know what *I* want."

She had been thinking about this since she came up with the concept of the photoshoot. At her insistence, they started out in the more tight space of the secret 'study' room. Sitting in the elegant head chair of the table, she pulled Adora down into her lap. Whether or not they would use this particular piece for the spread, she didn't really care. She already requested all of the originals, and this would look good in their personal collection. It turned out the photographer liked the concept, though, because they were placed in the same pose out in the more modern setting of the living room. Adora requested one where they had Melog on her lap, too, for a family portrait. He enjoyed his time in the spotlight (probably because the spotlights were rather warm and all).

Finally, after about what felt like a thousand more photos, this phase of the afternoon was finished. Now came the hard part. Hard maybe wasn't the right word, though. More like the *risky* part.

"You sure about this," Adora asked as she wrapped her arms around Catra one last time. "You don't owe anyone anything."

"I know," Catra whispered back and kissed under her ear. "I want to do it."

"Okay, but," she looked back over at the journalist who was getting set-up and narrowed her eyes, "She better be respectful."

"If she isn't, you can personally tell her to leave."

"Good," Adora kissed her cheek. Then, she reluctantly left Catra's side to join DT on the sidelines.

Beautiful art I commissioned from the talented Lesbeanlatte that is a representation of their second looks:



Tragically, I have not yet commissioned art featuring Adora horse pun shirts.

The reporter seated across from Catra in the living room was cued and began, "Catra, thank you for inviting us into your home. This has been a welcomed surprise after so many years of privacy. Especially considering you *requested* this interview. What brings us together today?"

"It's relatively simple. I thought I'd calm down all of the talk out there by confirming that, yes. All of the rumors are true," Catra said with a confident smile. While the reporter and everyone else in the room seemed to recoil at the declaration, Catra didn't skip a beat. "Since the beginning, I've dealt with people questioning me, my personal life, and whether or not I was the right 'fit' for **my own** company. So I thought it might be easier to settle it once and for all. Yes, whatever you think about me, it's true. Because if you think negative things about me, I no longer care to waste my energy worrying about or trying to change that."

"That's a lot," she laughed a little uncomfortably. "Let's break this down a bit. One of the current attention-grabbing headlines has been about your sudden, out-of-character vacation. The rumor is that there is more to it than simply having a good time with your beautiful girlfriend here. Now, obviously, there is some tongue-in-cheek involved with your statement earlier. But.. would you say, yes, that rumor is true?"

"Absolutely. In fact, that's one thing I'm happy to have a platform to talk about," she took a deep breath and glanced over to Adora, who gave her a reassuring thumbs-up. "Do you know how long I went without taking a day off?"

"If I remember the press release right, I believe it's nine hundred and eighty days."

"Exactly. Good memory," Catra chuckled. "That includes weekends and holidays, of course, because since I started Darla I never really have stopped working on it until now. Whether it was working on

the actual tech, planning proposals, making deals, doing research, whatever you can imagine... I found a way to work every day. I did this in part because I love our company. The problem was, I came into this business with all of the wrong cards. Thanks to that, I felt like if I left any room for relaxing, I'd make a mistake, and there would be calls for me to step down."

The reporter nodded thoughtfully as she spoke. "What do you mean by the wrong cards?"

"I entered this industry young with no money and certainly no connections. Nobody knew who I was, and when they did put a face to my name, they saw that I was a woman of color. Before they even knew me, I was cast in their heads to be emotional, unintelligent, and a million other negative stereotypes." Catra shook her head and paused for a moment. "It's not a mystery why my personal life lately has come under such scrutiny. I kiss my would-be girlfriend in a club, and it's a news story. Meanwhile, where's the accountability and headlines for CEOs who are legitimately doing harm? Why isn't that more newsworthy than the young Latina CEO having a life?"

The reporter pressed, "That is very true. The news these days is motivated by what readers find captivating, if you will. For instance, there's the incident with Ms. Harper at Starbucks last week. That generated a lot of traffic."

In a second, Catra ran through all of the angry words she *wanted* to say about this but knew she didn't want to ultimately hurt her message. "Again, I would challenge that narrative. I am sure that felt like a big deal for her, but in the end, Ms. Harper had to go back to her hotel and change into another designer, mustard-colored dress. That's a news story? A real story is how many service workers in our country are treated like shit on a **daily basis** as though it's a part of the job description. They stand there and take it with a smile, because they feel like they don't have another choice. What does that say about our culture? I find that to be a much more captivating story."

"Interesting," the reporter thought for a moment. "What would you say that the news story should be about Catra, CEO of Darla Industries?"

Catra laughed to herself, "You want to know why I do as few of these personal interviews as possible? It's because no matter what I say, someone will use it to confirm the stereotypes I mentioned earlier. There's a moment that's burned into my mind from our early days as a start-up. During one of our first rounds of funding, a potential investor said he was very interested but that he wouldn't invest until we had someone as the company's face who wasn't so 'off-putting.' Entrapta actually recorded the presentation. I rewatched it to prepare for today. Was I green? Of course, but I failed to see what was so off-putting about a young woman passionate about technology. Yet, somehow that older white guy did. You tell me."

"That must have been very disheartening," the reporter nodded and sounded compassionate.

"It was. And so, for almost a thousand days, I've kept my head down and worked *relentlessly*. I thought if I did the work and proved them all wrong, it would silence those voices. But you know what? It didn't. And even though we've accomplished a lot in that time, I *also* worked myself to an unhealthy point. I passed out last Tuesday during a meeting because of anxiety and stress. So yes, check that rumor off. I'm on a doctor-prescribed vacation, and I am *so glad* it happened. I was working myself to death and told myself I didn't really matter. I was wrong. I've left the reins in the incredibly skilled hands of my team, and it feels *good*. Really fucking weird, but good all the same," she laughed.

And so, Catra and the reporter began to work through the burnout culture of the tech industry, bias, and everything else she wanted to get off her chest.

"Another rumor I've heard is that people think my love life has impacted my work," Catra said as they transitioned topics.

"And, let me guess, that's true?" The reporter asked with a grin.

"Yep, can't deny that one either," Catra laughed and looked over at Adora for a moment. "Adora has been the balance I've needed in my life for a long time. She's helped me open up and get *way too soft and mushy*. Embarrassingly so, but... you know, it takes a lot of strength to let yourself be soft. Staying closed off is easy. I'm happier and surer of myself than I've been in a long time, and that makes me better for myself and, ultimately, the company too."

"Why would you say that?"

"As my co-founder would say, look at the data. Darla outperforms every one of our competitors each quarter and in every measure. Why? It's because we accelerate at the speed we do *without* pushing our employees to burn out. People come in refreshed, well cared for, and enthusiastic about the work they do. That happens because we value the support, security, and happiness of our employees above everything else. But, you know what, I'm willing to share that secret because it's awfully lonely for us here at the top. If any other companies want to come for us, step one is to copy our company culture. I'll even send you the blueprint. I'd rather see more people getting treated like they matter and paid what they're worth than dominate forever."

"That is *quite* the statement," the reporter said with wide eyes, "How do you think your shareholders and investors would feel about that?"

Catra waved it off and shook her head, "If they disagree with that, they're welcome to walk. Because, honestly, they don't deserve to be a part of what's next."

The reporter's eyes lit up with a new kind of interest, "And what is that?"

"I'm afraid I can't discuss that. I'm on *vacation*," Catra winked as she leaned back in her chair. "You'll just have to wait until my first day back like everyone else."

Chapter End Notes

I was literally doing dishes today and heard Lizzo's new "Rumors" (ft. Cardi B) and I was like... huh, this gives me an idea. Thus, here we are.

Also, Catra's words about it taking strength to be soft come from a friend who was sharing her wisdom with me about this subject! I thought more people needed to hear it :)

The Unveiling Party

Chapter Summary

Fresh off her big interview, Catra gets some valuable feedback from Adora. DT has their own things to say about that. Some irrelevant person launches an app that like no one really cares about that much but is maybe not that bad. Adora throws a colorful and fabulous art unveiling party. Catra lets herself be vulnerable in new ways. And... we're off to the historic birthplace of Barista Adora.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As soon as Catra was free from the sound equipment and done saying her thank yous to the crew, Adora swooped in to grab her. "Hey, boss, I need your help with something."

The way Catra grinned at the request gave her an idea that her girlfriend knew where this was going. "Lead the way," she said simply.

After guiding the two of them through the people still floating around the penthouse, Adora brought them to the empty study and immediately set the secret door to close again. "That was perfect... and really hot."

"Thanks," Catra looked like she was going to say more, but she wasn't dragged back here to talk.

Adora backed Catra against the wall, towering over her with the heels wardrobe selected for her. She crashed their lips together with such ferocity that she didn't realize her mistake until they parted to breathe.

"Fuck," Adora said with a giggle. "I..uh… may have forgotten I'm wearing lipstick." Said bright red lipstick was now smeared on Catra's own lips and chin.

"Seriously," Catra said, more amused than worried.

Adora grabbed the pocket square out of her suit jacket and tried to clean her back up again. Only… it wasn't quite working, and she smudged it from kissed on to clownlike. Adora was about to spit on the cloth when the door to the study started to slide open.

"Why am I surprised," DT chuckled as they stepped in and set the door to close behind them. Without saying another word, they dug into their bag and handed over a make-up wipe.

"How did you even get in here," Catra asked as she worked on cleaning off her face. "No one saw me open it."

"It's a dungeons and dragons room, kitten. Mara the Dragon Tamer is about as subtle as an actual dragon." DT rolled their eyes before smiling, "Moving on, I wanted to tell you that was one of the best interviews of your career. Very impressive. *I* was moved, and I already knew all of that."

"It felt amazing," Catra said, grinning ear to ear in pride. "Hopefully, this will end all the speculation bullshit. Everything's out in the open."

"Mmhm, exactly. And, of course, per our agreement, they are publishing this tomorrow at eleven am sharp."

"An hour after Valerie's talk," Adora said with a devious smirk. "It'll bury whatever silly thing she has to say."

"That was all DT. I can only strive to their level of pettiness," Catra laughed.

"Her off-brand-me will never see it coming. Bless an NDA." DT's eyes went wide, and they whispered, "Speaking of secrets, what *is* a sex safe? Normally I wouldn't pry into my CEO's personal life, but you ***are*** on vacation, so as a curious friend, I think I'm allowed to ask. Is it human-sized? Do you lock each other up when you've been naughty?"

"You're ridiculous, you know that?" Catra crossed her arms and shook her head. "It's a good thing you're also brilliant at your job."

DT batted their eyelashes and appeared touched by the compliment. Then, disappointment set in, "I could've been looking for the sex safe this whole time you were in here making out like teenagers. What a missed opportunity!"

"That's it, you're disinvited to the party Friday," Catra pressed the button to open the door back up.

"Aww, fortunately, I know you don't mean that," DT started to reach over and pat her on the shoulder but could tell she was absolutely not having it. Instead, they used the hand to lead a twirl from the room as they said, "It would be a travesty if the world missed out on the look I've prepared. I'm reviving the evening glove, and fashion will never be the same."

"Can't wait," Adora said, then peered out of the room, "Can you get all of these people to leave our house now?"

"Our?" DT stopped in their tracks, "Precious, simply precious. Yes, darling, I'll kick them out in the most professional of fashions. You two keep hiding and get back to... well, whatever it is I interrupted."

Although her attendance at the presentation wasn't required, it *was* incentivized with extra credit in one of Adora's classes. Not that she needed it. She was carrying a high A either way but damned if she wasn't driven to do her very best... even if it meant sitting through an arch enemy's boisterous talk about her stupid company. Although Glimmer wasn't available, Bow had come along as one of his classes offered a similar deal. They sat together in the back, hoping to go unseen by Valerie or the press that was there. The duo leaned in for a selfie that they sent to Catra to update her on their feelings.

"I can't wait for this to be over," Adora groaned. "This is s*upposed* to be my break to hit the gym or take a nap in the library."

"Hey, it might be worth our time," Bow said, his assertation weakening as Adora narrowed her eyes at him, "I mean, yeah, she's a jerk, and her app is super snobby, but the promo for this sounded interesting."

"Bleh," Adora stuck her tongue out at him and crossed her arms. Then, somewhere in the back of her head, she could hear DT scolding her. What if someone took a picture of her with a dirty look during Valerie's speech? "You know what, you're right," she leaned down and grabbed a notebook from her backpack before sitting up straight, eyes forward, neutral smile.

Finally, the lights dimmed, and triumphant music bleared out over the speakers. Valerie danced out onto the stage, taking in the claps and cheers from the crowd. Once everything was quiet again, she started, "Thank you for being with us today as Refined Taste embarks on an exciting new journey." Thus began her introduction to how her company would be launching a new service that linked the scientifically proven *perfect* music for a given physical activity.

As she watched the other woman on stage, Adora found herself softening to her despite what she thought was utter hatred. Valerie was... charismatic, charming, even. She commanded the room in a way that reminded her of Catra's keynote she watched (even if she wasn't nearly as good). On top of that, she looked *gorgeous* in the patterned suit she was wearing, her red hair all perfect, skin glowing. She could see how Catra had become interested in her in the first place. *Is this the kind of person she really deserves?* She found her self-conscious mind thinking. Not Valerie per se... but another giant, someone with big ideas and making a name for herself. Not some broke undergrad slinging coffee...

When the speech was over and the new product, Refined Health, was officially launched, Adora and Bow snuck out while the applause was still happening. They must have had disadvantage on their stealth check because before they left the atrium of the auditorium, someone called out, "Adora?"

Deciding that running away was an unwise PR move, Adora turned around and gave as genuine a smile as possible. Looking back at her was that scrawny reporter from the Times again. "Hi, Kyle."

"Nice to see you again," he said, "I was wondering if you might have a comment on Ms. Harper's release today."

Adora had a lot of comments about Valerie swirling in her head. When Bow put his hand on her shoulder comfortingly, she felt herself relax and landed on the *right* one, "I attended today because I'm in the physical therapy program here at Brightmoon. Anything that can help my future patients on their path to healing is a good thing. I'm excited to see how it works."

"And that's all we've got to say about that," Bow said as he reached out a hand, "Bow, nice to meet you. Adora and I have to get to class."

"Of course. Thanks! See you Friday," he sounded nervous with that last comment, Adora noted.

-Forced Vacation Day 8 of 19-

It was a perfect afternoon for Catra to be relaxing on her rooftop oasis. A light breeze, the right amount of sunshine, and nothing on her mind to worry about. Well, *mostly* nothing.

The release of the photoshoot and accompanying article had gone off without a hitch that morning. Adora had made her promise to limit herself to thirty minutes of reading reactions to it and swore she'd let her know if something else came up. Thankfully, it was generally very positive.

Thus, she could indulge in an afternoon glass of chilled white wine while reading an admittedly trashy but endearing romance novel. It was from a basket of "relaxation materials" from Adora. Her mental

cursing of these two idiots for not figuring it out already was interrupted by her phone ringing. She grabbed it from the side table, and her bliss was immediately replaced with panic.

"Is everything okay?" Catra asked as she answered, forgoing a customary greeting. "I've got to call a car if you need me."

"Wow," Lonnie answered with a laugh, "What happened to trusting your incredibly skilled team? Fake news strikes again."

Catra let out the breath she'd been holding and forced herself to loosen up again, "You haven't contacted me in a week, and I'm supposed to think you calling me today of all days isn't about a problem?"

"Maybe I miss you," they both laughed at that. "I'm calling about Friday and this fucking hysterical document you've had legal make for Kyle."

"Listen, he's a member of the press. You're lucky I like you and Rogelio enough to invite him," Catra said and took another sip of wine, "Plus, I'm pretty sure he's scared of me."

"Oh, he definitely is. He's prepared to be strip-searched at this point. Reason I'm calling is I didn't know if you needed it notarized, and I am *not* going down there and asking Mermista. It's weird enough you asked her to do it."

"I can't help it if my personal lawyer is also on our team," Catra chuckled. "And, yes, I definitely need that shit notarized. I don't care how harmless he is. What if the paper puts pressure on him to do a write-up?"

"Eh, I doubt he'd cave. I'm pretty sure he knows a couple of good things when he sees them; that's all I'm saying," Lonnie countered smugly. "I'll get him to come in later and have DT take care of it. Anyway, I hope you're actually taking a break so you can come back soon. As much as I appreciate the resume builder, I like my job better than yours."

"I turned off my google alert for Darla," Catra said as evidence of her relaxation, "And I haven't checked stocks this week."

"Good for you, boss."

"I told you that you have to stop calling me that."

"Uh-huh, and *why* after all these years, I wonder," Lonnie sounded accusatory. "I'll let you get back to whatever you're up to. Rest assured, the place isn't burning down without you."

"Yeah, of course, we let that guy go." Catra shook her head at the memory. She dropped into her more serious tone, "Thanks, though. I meant it when I said I trust you to take care of things."

"I know, b-- Catra."

-Forced Vacation Day 9 of 19-

Catra was cooking dinner while Adora sat at the kitchen island, keeping her company and panicking over the impending party. She had all her plans scrawled out on a portable whiteboard she had rolled all the way from the office.

"I'm pretty sure you've thought of everything," Catra assured her as she glanced back, "It's twenty or so of our friends and their partners, not some epic fundraising gala. Calm down, dummy."

"I know, but I want our first event together to be perfect," Adora said sincerely. "Wait! Should we have party favors?! I didn't get anything for that... Oh god. What if everyone's mad?"

"Party favors are for children's birthdays and weddings," Catra reminded her. "Unless you're planning a surprise wedding for us, I think we're okay."

Adora smiled to herself before she popped up to stroll over to her girlfriend. She wrapped her arms around her from behind while she peered over her shoulder, "Who says I'm not?"

"But Helen's not coming," Catra countered before turning her head to kiss her on the cheek.

"We'll have to get married again next week and tell her it's for the first time, obviously."

"Starting out with lies? Tsk, tsk," Catra laughed. "If I wanted that kind of marriage, I'd call up a certain redheaded asshole."

Adora gasped. "Don't even joke about that," she said with a growl in her voice as she wrapped Catra up tighter.

Catra calmly laid down the spoon she was using and leaned back into her embrace, "But what if I like it when you're jealous."

Adora slipped a hand up Catra's shirt to delicately ghost over her stomach before replying, "If I knew that, I would've invited her when she was on campus yesterday, boss."

-Forced Vacation Day 10 of 19-

"Why am I so nervous," Adora whined before she reached out to grab Catra's hand.

"Because you're a goof with a huge heart," Catra teased her. "This is more than perfect, Adora. I can't believe you pulled this off so fast with school, work, and everything."

They were standing in the bedroom, looking out at the rooftop patio that had been transformed. Micah's employees were busy arranging the "rainbow" food that Adora had planned with him. It was a mixture of naturally bright fruits and vegetables with experimental small plates with no less color.

The bar featured a mixologist Adora had collaborated with to craft cocktails and mocktails for the night. Her favorite? The *Adorably Teal* --- a fruity, blue beverage designed to match her suit. Catra's *The Boss*, a maroon-colored drink featuring a mixture of darker liquors and a bit of Chambord for the color, was a close second.

Already setting the mood was a live jazz band that specialized in more 'modern' music covers. They were all dressed in greyscale. The lead singer deviated only for a rich red on her lips. Even from inside the bedroom, they could hear a fantastic rendition of one of Catra's favorite songs as their warm-up.

"Honest to god," Catra laughed to herself, staring at Adora as she listened to the music, "If all I got tonight was seeing you look like ***this*** while we listened to the band, it would be enough."

Adora was all red, set off by the teal of her suit and accessories. Unlike the custom outfit that Netossa had made for Catra, this was off the rack and then altered to fit her perfectly. "Thank you," Adora said, tearing up, "I really wanted it to be good enough."

Catra smiled as she rolled her eyes a bit, "Dummy, everything you do is always going to be good enough."

"Aww, more wedding b-roll!" Glimmer declared as she stopped her phone's camera, and they became suddenly aware of her presence at the top of the stairs.

"Sparkles," Catra sighed heavily. Maybe she wasn't... She dropped her annoyed tone, "Looking good."

"Thank you," she said as she twirled. The outfit she landed on was a sparkling pink jumpsuit with matching heels and accessories. "You two look sickeningly hot as always." She looked back behind her with a big grin, "And so does someone else."

Bow emerged from the stairs in his candy apple red suit, crop top undershirt, sneakers, gems in his ears, and a fedora. "I feel ridiculous," he said as he tipped the fedora. "Glim wouldn't let me *not* get the hat."

"It's all BEAUTIFUL," Adora gushed. "I'm jealous. I should've gotten a hat."

"Pfft, and miss out on this hairstyle?" Catra said as she stared lovingly at her. She hired a professional stylist who helped the two get ready an hour or so prior. One less thing for Adora to panic about, she figured.

"We're all too hot, it's true," Glimmer confirmed.

After visiting with the squad and enjoying some time for the four of them to sample food, it was time for the actual party to begin. Adora and Catra were stationed downstairs to greet guests as security cleared them for entry. Bow lingered in the bedroom to make sure that folks went directly to the roof rather than snoop around (ahem-- DT).

Arriving first was the "trio," as Catra had taken to calling them. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle were all dressed in the same color of dark purple. Rogelio offered up a bottle of wine while Kyle held out his notarized letter.

Adora accepted the wine, "You must be Rogelio? I hear you're a great DM! Nice to meet you," she offered him a handshake that turned in a polite hug, "We'll have to play sometime. Catra's still teaching me."

"Mmhm," Catra confirmed as she was inspecting Kyle's signature. She folded it up and put it in an inner suit jacket pocket. "Just remember, kid. I'll take your grandmother's cat. That's how deep I'll go if you fuck this up."

"My grandmother actual---," Kyle started to say then was elbowed by Lonnie. He cleared his throat and nervously straightened his purple skirt, "Yes, mam. Thank you for inviting me!"

"Good boy," Lonnie teased. "I confiscated his phone," she whispered to Catra before they strolled on by to join the party proper.

Not too far behind them was another ding from the elevator. This time it was carrying the "parent squad," as Adora had called them. Angella, Micah, George, and Lance stepped into the penthouse

with wonder on their faces. Catra felt her anxiety peak as she considered how this was basically a trial run at meeting Adora's mom. She straightened up a bit and took a calming breath.

"You made it," Adora squealed. "Catra, these are Bow's dads, George and Lance," she gestured as the two men in matching gold waved, "And Angella and Micah, Glimmer's parents." They had coordinated in dreamy, lavender outfits.

"Thank you for coming," Catra said as she stepped forward to meet them. "It means a lot to both of us."

"Thank you for having us," Lance said cheerily as he reached out and embraced both Adora and Catra at the same time. "We were so thrilled when we got our invitation! We couldn't believe it. *Our* Bow friends with *the* Catra? Not to mention that you're dating *our Adora*?!"

George pulled back Lance a bit, "It's a pleasure to meet you. We've been following your career quite closely these last few years. As a couple of history buffs, meeting someone who's *making* history is a unique honor."

"The honor is mine," Catra said smoothly as she and George shook hands, "You've raised one of the best people I've ever met."

Lance couldn't help but go for another hug, "He really *is* wonderful, isn't he," he said weepily.

With that, George collected his husband once more and followed Adora's directions to find their son and join the festivities.

"I don't know if we can top that," Micah said jovially. "But Angie and I are happy to be here! How's the rainbow spread? As good as it looks?"

"Are you kidding?! It's perfect," Adora said. "We may have already sampled *everything* ."

"Honestly, I'm tempted to hire you as my full-time chef," Catra laughed. "And, for the record, Glimmer's pretty great too. I'm excited about her joining us at Darla."

"Don't you mean, Sparkles?" Angella noted coyly with a smirk. Seeing Catra tense a little, she reached out a hand, "Lovely to meet you, Catra."

"Same," Catra shook her hand, wondering what Glimmer had told her.

The rest of the introductions that night were all for Adora. Generally speaking, it was people from work that she hadn't gotten to officially meet yet- Mermista from legal, their head of security Juliet, Catra's personal assistant Scorpia, and even more she couldn't keep track of. She shook hands, accepted various gifts of wine and flowers, and complimented everyone.

The only Darla outsiders invited by Catra were the women behind her impeccable fashion. Netossa and Spinerella looked red carpet ready in stunning icy blue and fuchsia dresses of their own design.

"Turn around for me," Netossa said after their initial greetings as she crossed her arms.

"I promise I haven't fucked anything up," Catra laughed but still followed her tailor's orders.

"And, darling, you know you've already checked everything more than enough times," her wife reminded her.

"You're right, I am good," Netossa winked, then turned her attention to Adora. "You've got your own file now, by the way. You let your girlfriend know when you need your first Netossa original."

Her eyes went big, and she nodded enthusiastically, "Thank you, I would love that. Your designs are marvelous."

Soon the duo was on their way upstairs after each giving Catra a silent "we approve" look. After waiting for a while without anyone new arriving, Adora pulled out her phone to check the list of attendees. Everyone that had RSVPed yes was there except one person. One theatrical person.

"Maybe they thought you really disinvited them," Adora said nervously. "Should I call or text?"

"No, they know precisely what they're doing," Catra sipped the drink that had been delivered to her while they were waiting. "Fashionably late nonsense. They've got one more minute, and then ---"

Ever directed by their own innate theatre cue, the elevator dinged, and there was DT, a sight to be seen. "Wow," Adora said dumbly.

As promised, DT was most certainly reviving the evening glove with long, lime green gloves that covered up to their elbows. Their outfit was a matching, sparkingly sequined backless jumpsuit with a plunging neckline. High upon their waist was a detachable, poofy, glamorous train. Their blonde hair was pulled into an understated, simple bun to help draw the eyes to their dramatic make-up.

"My domestic lovebirds," DT said as they clacked towards them in their impossible heels, "What gracious hosts, waiting for little old me."

Catra's eyes went wide as she took it all in, "This is really something, DT. Even for you."

"What, this old thing? Why, I only wear when I don't care how I look," DT winked before strutting away, train swishing behind them as they headed to the stairs. "Time to unveil some art, darlings. Oh... and I suppose then we'll show off whatever you've got on those canvases."

"Yep, definitely going to need that extra building for their ego," Catra said with a sigh before looking to Adora. "Alright. Ready to really get this thing started?"

"Yes, I am one hundred percent prepared," she said confidently and reached into her jacket, pulling out some index cards.

"Wait, you wrote a speech?" Catra tried to steal the cards, but Adora yanked them out of reach.

"It's my hostess speech," she declared very proudly. "I take all my duties seriously."

"Damn, now I feel bad. I didn't prepare anything for the art," Catra chuckled.

"Pfft, I do not believe that at all," Adora looked at her suspiciously before tapping her forehead with an index card, "You might not have it written down, but I know you. You've been rehearsing something in your head since you ordered these."

Catra scrunched up her face, "I'm that easy to read, huh?"

Adora leaned into her ear to whisper in a honeyed voice, "Mmhm, you're like a picture book for me."

Catra started laughing and grabbed her hand to lead her upstairs. "That's it. That's the dumbest thing you've tried to make sexy."

"Then why did your pupils dilate, huh," Adora teased.

"I am **not** turned on right now," Catra declared defiantly as they rounded the top of the spiral staircase.

"That's, uh, good to know," Bow answered a bit awkwardly when he met them at the top. "I wanted to check--"

Catra covered her face briefly as she cringed,"God, please, forget you heard that."

"Should I also forget," Entrapta asked from her spot where she was lounging on Catra's bed.

Bow pointed, "About that."

"This is fine," Adora said calmly. "We're all going to move on from that joke and go to the roof where we're all **supposed** to be."

"Right," Entrapta nodded and sat down Catra's laptop she'd been fiddling with. "This does seem like a violation of privacy."

"I'm begging you not to tweet this," Catra whispered once Entrapta was near her.

"Of course not!" Entrapta reassured her. "DT banned me from tweeting about you after the hot or not poll."

Bow and Adora exchanged a bewildered look. "Hot or not poll," Adora asked with a giggle after Bow and Entrapta went to mingle in the crowd.

Catra, looking for a distraction, found one in cueing the band to pause. "What do you know? It's time for your speech," she whispered to Adora as people's attention was diverted their way.

Adora felt like a deer in headlights for a moment, but her gaze found some friendly faces to focus on. "Welcome, and thank you all for joining us tonight. For those of you who don't know me, I'm Adora... or *blondie."* That earned her some laughs, which helped her loosen up more. "When I first joked with Catra about having an art unveiling party, I didn't think it would become a reality. But... what I've learned is that Catra makes things happen. Whether it's for her employees, friends, or me... her motto is," she paused for a minute to read over her card, "Aut inveniam viam aut faciam. I will either find a way or make one. Right?" She looked to Catra, who nodded at her.

"She's my part-time Latin tutor. It's very Roman...tic." She had put in her note cards to pause for the laughs, which were less abundant than she'd hoped. Catra, at least, was cracking up beside her. She went on to thank Micah, all of the people who helped, and the guests for putting together show-stopping monochrome fashion.

Finally, she was coming to her big finish. "Later tonight, we are going to be unveiling whatever it is she has hidden on those canvases. But until then, let's celebrate the beauty and color we all bring into each other's lives. And..." She stepped over to Catra, who had dipped away for a moment, to grab a couple of items.

"Please don't hurt yourself, dummy," Catra pleaded as she handed over a saber sword and a bottle of cold champagne.

Adora winked at her in reassurance. They may have already run through a few bottles practicing this week. "Let's say thanks to Catra for laughing at my dumb ideas and saying yes anyway," she declared as she drew the saber along the seam of the tilted bottle and struck the top causing the cork to fly away. With that, everyone cheered and clapped for the real party to begin.

While the band was taking a break, Adora had arranged for a playlist of the songs she thought were significant to their relationship to be playing. To start, of course, were a few of the club songs she could remember from their first night out dancing.

Catra almost spat her drink out when the first profanity-laden song began playing. Of course, she was in the middle of a conversation with Angella and Juliet, already feeling like a kid at the adults' table.

"I remember this one!" Angella said with a laugh. "Glimmer was in a dance team for a while in high school. This was a popular selection. Of course, I do believe it was the censored version."

"CATRA," Adora yelled from the 'dance floor,' "Get over here."

"Sorry, I'm being summoned," Catra said with an awkward laugh. At least she had an excuse to getaway. "Good luck with this blind date you're trying to set up."

While Catra was on her way to Adora, the other woman held up a hand and made her stop. Then, Adora dramatically swung her hands back over one shoulder and pretended to cast a fishing line out to Catra, who stood there mouthing, "Absolutely not." Adora pouted dramatically and then "cast" her line again.

I'm such an idiot for this girl, Catra thought to herself. She hooked a finger in her mouth and used her other hand to mime swimming towards her as Adora reeled her in. Once they got together, Adora held her hand over Catra's head like displaying a prize catch while Bow snapped a photo.

"When you said you've been practicing dancing, I didn't expect the fish move," Catra teased.

"I've learned more! That's only my favorite one. This is my second favorite," she turned on her heel, and Catra's hands happily fell to her hips. Though still not having perfected her technique, she was able to drop low and rise back up reasonably smoothly, "Now... you just stay there and look handsome. I'll do the rest," she said coyly with a wink.

"Outdone by my own line," Catra laughed.

"Get it, Adora!!" Glimmer cheered at the spectacle as she led Bow and their new acquaintances, Mermista and Sea Hawk, to join the dance party.

"Truly, that was some of the finest fish choreography I've seen performed on the dance floor," Sea Hawk said sincerely.

"Don't get any ideas," Mermista said as she put her hand on her hip.

"Of course, I wouldn't want to upstage our gracious hosts," Sea Hawk bowed slightly, "I want to personally thank you, Catra, for allowing me to come tonight. I know after that unforeseeable incident in---"

"Less talking, more dancing," Mermista commanded and grabbed his hand. Then they were off in a swirling hurricane of ocean blues.

"Do people seem like they're having fun," Adora asked casually while still finding her rhythm and trying her new dancing techniques.

"Definitely," Bow confirmed. "All the Darla people want you to plan their holiday parties. Apparently, they're kind of boring normally." Catra shot Bow a look that told him she likely is in charge of planning those.

"If you can't hire Adora, maybe you can add that to my role," Glimmer said as she twirled Bow around, "Communications and head Party Planner."

"I'll make a note," Catra said quickly, unfocused. Her throat suddenly felt parched as her partner spun around and led them into a body roll. Adora really *had* improved her dance routine.

Mercifully, after a few more songs, the playlist moved from the club mix to, of course, "Don't go Breaking my Heart." The party joined them in belting out the lyrics, DT most of all. As always in their life, a spotlight had found them as they deftly swapped between Elton and Kiki's parts. The sequins on their jumpsuit made them shine like a lime disco ball. When the song finished, everyone clapped.

"I think two extra buildings," Adora noted to Catra while they joined the applause.

By the time the band was back on, the two needed a break of their own. They made their way over to a table away from the action and sat down to enjoy some water. After a few minutes of catching their breath, Catra asked with a smirk, "So, professional party planner, huh? Are you tempted?"

"No way," Adora shook her head adamantly. "I don't think I could have the energy to pull this off again for a few months."

"Ah, well, good thing my birthday is in October. Plenty of time to recharge," Catra teased.

"Costume party!" Adora squealed.

"I'll agree to this only if I get to pick your costume," Catra bit her lip as she considered the possibilities.

"Oh, of course, bo--" Adora leaned in to kiss her and jumped back suddenly as someone else was in their space.

"Hey there, Ms. Catra! Wanted to see if there's anything you need from me," Scorpia, Catra's overly enthusiastic assistant, asked. "What a party, Adora. Best I've ever been to!"

Catra bit back her frustration and smiled, "Yes, it *is* a party. You're off duty. Have fun."

"Sure, but it's so gosh-darn nice to see you is all," Scorpia patted her back too hard. "If you ever need anything, even while you're on vacation, I'll be there in a jiffy! It's a real honor to work for you, mam. Anywho, I'm going to get out of your perfectly styled hair, Madame CEO and Adora. Thank you again for inviting me." With that, she was on her way back out to find her date.

"I need a title. What about CEO's Consort?" Adora joked, then leaned in to get that kiss she'd been robbed of. "I guess just *Adora* is better than Barista Adora like some magazines call me."

Catra ran a finger around the rim of her glass, "I know I've said it before, but... you know you can quit, right? I don't know if you're worried about what would happen if..."

"Ssh," Adora reached over and put her fingers over Catra's mouth, "I'm not worried about anything with you. We can talk about this later, okay? We've got a party to get back to," she checked her watch, "Ooh! And it's almost art time."

"We better go then. I need a chance to get you back for that performance," Catra winked as she stood up and held out a hand to Adora, "Care for a slow dance, princess?"

The evening was drawing towards the last hour of the event as the mood turned relaxed and content. After an announcement was made, the crowd moved to a seating area set up around the two covered canvases. Every table was set with sparkling juice and champagne.

Catra stepped up in front of everyone and cleared her throat before she began. She was suddenly very grateful that she had cut herself off from drinking already. "As Adora said earlier, thank you all for coming tonight. I also want to say a big thank you to her for having amazing 'dumb ideas' and being the best partner I could ever dream of," She led a clap for Adora that caused the blonde to blush as she took it in. "The whole reason we're here tonight, other than to celebrate me relaxing and being social, is to appreciate art. As you all entered, you may have noticed the unique works I've purchased over the years. The two new pieces we will be adding are simply photos that I've had touched up, enlarged, and printed. And while they're different in a lot of ways, they share a theme."

While she talked, she strolled over to the large easels that were holding up the canvases. She gently maneuvered the black cloth covering the first. She stepped away to let the crowd look at it as aw's and laughter filled the air. "This photo is called I'm Brewing For You, and it was captured by Adora with a shaky hand on a very out-of-date cellphone." *Catra had wanted to print something newer, but... even if the photos from her new phone were better quality, nothing could beat its charm.*

She took a deep breath as she moved to the other canvas and prepared to lift off the cloth. She willed her hands to stop shaking as she finally pulled it and stepped to the side. Instead of focusing on the crowd, she let her eyes drift over to Adora, who put her hand over her mouth. The photo wasn't another captured pun or even one of the many beautiful, professional photos the two had taken. It was one of those cheesy family portraits that used to be popular to get at a department store. A woman and a man sitting with a laughing little girl in their laps.

"This was taken by some college-aged photographer who I'm sure wasn't paid enough," Catra joked, trying to hide her emotions, "I'm still working on a good title. Maybe Adora can help me with a pun. But... that's my mom, Elena, and my dad, Anthony. And in the middle, there, with all the hair, is me. I've been so cagey with my family history that some of you probably think I'm an alien who got abandoned here."

In the front row, she heard Entrapta mutter to Scorpia, "I did consider this possibility."

Catra couldn't help but laugh a little. "I'm sorry to say, it's much less exciting than that. They passed away when I was younger, and for me, it felt easier to keep that inside. Lately, though, I've started to realize how wrong that was. I wouldn't be here in more ways than one without them. And, whatever legacy I will leave behind is theirs too." She had more she wanted to say, but her thoughts felt jumbled. Grief is tricky like that. It doesn't really care how prepared you think you are.

But then there was Adora, coming up beside her to take her hand. With her free hand, she held up her champagne flute, "To Elena and Anthony."

-Forced Vacation Day 11 of 19-

Bow: Everything's almost back to normal here! Are you sure you don't want me to watch Melog for you? We're best buds now.

Catra: Do you know how to do CPR on a cat?

Bow: No.

Catra: Thanks, but Derek, his professional pet sitter, does. Can't be too careful.

Bow: Ouch. Fair point.

Catra: Plus, I've already given you a mission.

Bow: That's right! Operation transmutation is a go starting tomorrow! Glim and I have it handled. *wink emoji*

Catra: Thanks for everything. I left an envelope on my desk for you two. I'll let you know when we land.

Adora had been transfixed staring out the window beside her, but the volley of texts caught her attention. "Everything okay?"

"Yeah, it's Bow. He's been updating me on the clean-up," Catra explained and turned her phone off. "How are you feeling?"

"Like I wish I listened to you when you said we probably shouldn't book a flight the day after the party," Adora said with a yawn as she snuggled down to lay her head in her lap.

"Mmhm," Catra kissed the top of her head, "It's hard to be right all the time."

"Hey, I was right about how attractive you'd look in a denim button-up shirt," Adora swooned as she ran her fingers along the fabric.

"What if I told you I'm wearing a dumb horse shirt under it," Catra whispered.

"Then I'm ready for the mile-high club," Adora said with a devious grin. "If no one else is in first class, can we just do it right here?"

"Um, excuse me," a flight attendant cleared his throat above them, and Adora sat up with a beet-red face. "We will be departing shortly. Please make sure to fasten your seatbelts and.. to.. be in your own seat, please. Thank you."

Chapter End Notes

As I always have to say lately, sorry for the belated update. I hope you enjoyed the chapter, and that it was worth the time. I do love this story and these versions of our delightful SPOP characters. Excited to get Catra into Adora's world next chapter and see how she handles it. I reckon it's gonna be a good time.

Thank you for all the sweet comments and support of this story. I hope to continue to earn it.

Country Roads

Chapter Summary

Rich Catra finds herself in the hometown of the world-famous Barista Adora.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

-Forced Vacation Day 11 of 19-

Forget an inflight movie to pass the time--watching Adora kept Catra plenty distracted as the hours passed. Given this was her first actual flight, Adora's childlike amazement with it all was nothing short of *adorable.* (Not that Catra would use that pun out loud...again) Adora smiled this sweet little smile the whole flight as the landscape changed from sprawling cityscapes to mountains to fields.

An announcement played over the speakers asking them to prepare to land at the airport closest to the middle of nowhere, snapping the two of them out of their content daze.

"Is landing scary?" Adora finally turned from the window to buckle her seatbelt and gaze at Catra with big, scared blue eyes.

"I don't think so personally. You already survived takeoff, and that's the part that spooks me." Catra reached over to hold her hand reassuringly. "You definitely handled it better than me my first time."

"Is that why you don't have your own plane? Too scared?" Adora teased as she squeezed her hand back tightly, clearly a little nervous.

"Pfft, of course not. I simply take our sustainability awards at Darla very seriously, and private planes are awful."

"And you haven't done anything exciting in almost a thousand days, so you didn't *really* need one."

Catra shrugged, "Eh, I've been *doing* this one *exciting thing* for a couple of months now. This is the only time I've needed a plane for her."

Adora started giggling uncontrollably at that, especially considering the flight attendant was, once again, catching the wrong part of their banter. The plane continued its safe descent as Catra pondered if she ought to pay off everyone on board to not repeat this shit.

Upon exiting the plane, Catra found that the airport was smaller than any she had ever been in, which was refreshing. Less hustle and bustle. The only shop it hosted was full of ridiculous tourist junk, and, of course, they browsed for the absurdity of it. That was how they came to be standing at the car rental counter with Adora sporting a new horse-themed trucker hat with her ponytail threaded through.

The man working the counter looked up from his phone and offered a less than friendly "Can I help you?" as he eyed them up and down.

Not exactly a shining beacon of customer service, Catra thought, but maybe you don't have to be when you only see a few customers a day. Catra took her phone out of her pocket, "We've got a car rental reservation, Confirmation 4815162342." She made sure to say the number *extra-slow* for him.

"Uh-huh," he typed it in and then got a snide look on his face before chuckling to himself. "Says here you're registered for an elite class, and, sweetheart, I don't think I've ever even seen a car like that."

Catra did **not** care at all for being called sweetheart by this guy. "What do you have available?"

He sighed, "Why don't I just show you instead of getting into the specifics? You can pick whatever suits your fancy for color and all that."

"Sure." Adora reached for Catra's hand and squeezed for a moment as the man led them out towards the small selection. They just needed to get a car, and then they'd leave this asshole behind.

"As far as a nice reasonable little car, you're looking at your best two options here," he said as he stood between red and white cars of the same make and model.

Adora crossed her arms and shook her head, "No, thank you." She looked around the lot and pointed at a large, fully-loaded truck, "That would do."

"I don't know what you girls are getting into, but I guarantee that's way more vehicle than you need," he said dismissively. "I've got some real cute midsize—"

Catra cut him off with a wave of her hand, "We're taking the truck."

He looked confused but ushered them back inside to get the paperwork ready. "Now, I highly recommend the rental insurance. Driving a vehicle like this when you're not used to it can put you in a real-world of hurt when it comes to damage."

"If we break it, I'll buy it." Catra took out her card and slid it through.

"Everybody thinks that until they see the bill," he said as he went about organizing everything and getting the keys.

"Considering I could buy the whole damn company if I wanted to, I think we'll be alright," Catra said nonchalantly as she took the bundle from him.

"You and blondie here some kind of movie stars or something," he asked with a raised eyebrow as he eyed them. "Never seen you before."

"Oh no," Adora said with a deceptively pleasant smile. "Doesn't seem like you know too much about cars, but maybe you've heard of Darla Industries? She's the CEO."

He looked dumbfounded at this revelation. The rusty gears in his brain started turning as he undoubtedly was pondering what this meant for him. Before he could say anything, Catra reached for Adora's hand and said with a wink, "You have a nice day, Carl. I'm looking forward to filling out this experience survey."

When they got out into the lot, they both started laughing. "I think Carl peed himself a little," Adora said as she opened one of the backdoors of the truck to load their bags up.

"As he fucking should," Catra stood back, eying the behemoth of a truck that was going to be theirs for the next few days. It felt a little hypocritical given her earlier rant about energy conservation, but Catra wasn't about to undercut Adora's power move. "I think since you signed us up for this monstrous thing, you should have to drive." She tossed the keys over to Adora, who caught them easily.

"Gladly," Adora said with a big smile as she opened up the driver's side door and climbed in.

Catra pulled herself up into the passenger side and found Adora busy tinkering with the screen to put in her mother's address. She watched curiously as her girlfriend tried to navigate the less-than user-friendly interface.

"Does it make you cringe seeing such an inferior system," Adora teased after finally getting everything set up.

"Mostly that it has ads in the GPS," Catra shook her head and pointed out the Taco Bell location that was on their route. "Of all the ways to make an extra buck."

"Yep, just terrible," Adora said wistfully as she stared at the screen.

"You want to go, don't you?"

"Weeeell..." She gave a big winning smile. "It is over an hour and a half to my mom's from here."

"You're the driver. I'm going wherever you're going."

"Ooh, I like this power," Adora dramatically revved the engine peeling out of the parking lot.

"Is there a straight road in this whole god damn state?" Catra groaned as she leaned on her elbow against the passenger door. Taco Bell and country roads snaking through the mountains weren't a great combination. "I miss the grid system."

"Aw," Adora reached over and patted her shoulder as she swung them around another blind curve on a hillside. "I'm sorry. Do you want me to go slower?"

"No, thanks. I can make it," Catra took a deep breath and closed her eyes as she wiggled down further to relax. "Wake me up if we're going off the side of a cliff."

"Do you need me to sing you a nice lullaby?"

"NOW PLAYING - MICE LULLABY," said the radio system, accidentally mistaking it for a command. A squeaky-voiced, ripoff chipmunks' lullaby song began playing loudly over the speakers.

"Wow, Adora, have you been taking voice lessons? You're really improving."

"Ha-ha," Adora huffed, "Just for that, I'm going to let it finish."

Finally, they had reached Adora's hometown, and the roads were decidedly more passenger-friendly. Catra listened with a smile as Adora pointed out every single point of interest along the way.

After passing a water tower painted to look like a hot-air balloon, Adora cheered, "This is it! Almost there," and demanded the radio begin playing Take Me Home, Country Roads by John Denver. "I've got it worked out. We should be at my mom's driveway by the time this is done! Unless there's a cow in the road or something."

"Does that happen a lot," Catra asked with a chuckle.

The sinking feeling in the pit of her stomach could no longer be blamed on car sickness. No, now it was pure anxiety. Since the big 'reveal' that there was actually nothing to reveal to Helen, Adora had put her mom on speaker for several chats between the three of them. She was nothing but pleasant and seemed to appreciate Catra's humor. Still... there was still that nagging, gremlin voice in the back of her head telling her she'd mess it up somehow. Maybe...

The gremlin started to be drowned out by Adora's full lung belting of, "Mountain mamma, take me home, country roads!"

They drove down a gravel driveway to a small home with happy yellow siding as the song ended. Before they could even park, the front door opened, and a woman walked out to the porch. She was hopping up and down and waving at them excitedly.

"Why does this look so familiar," Catra joked as she waved back from her window. It was true. Everything about Helen seemed like an older version of Adora. The butterflies in her stomach calmed down a bit at the realization. She was even wearing a ridiculous shirt that said "Mamasaurus," no doubt a gift from her daughter at some point.

As soon as she had the truck in park, Adora jumped out and ran to nearly tackle hug her mom with a hug. Catra exited much more carefully and hung back to give them their moment while taking a couple of candid photos.

Helen broke from Adora and clutched a hand over her heart as she looked at Catra, "Finally, I get to meet the woman making my goose so happy." *Goose*? Filing that one away in the 'things to tease Adora about later' folder. "Could I give you a hug?"

"You're responsible for the existence of my favorite person, of course," Catra said with a laugh, and she was wrapped up in a hearty, warm hug. Another little piece of that 'family' feeling she'd been missing was filled in. "Thanks for having us."

Catra worked on grabbing all of their luggage while mother and daughter caught up with happy tears and fast-talking. Adora had been home for less than five minutes, and she had already dipped back into her more country self. The twang and slang were off the charts. *Cute*. But also... half the time, she was wondering what exactly they were talking about.

"Catra, honey, you don't need to be carrying all that. You're supposed to be relaxing," Helen said as she realized she was loaded down.

Catra had a feeling there was no use in protesting, and she was quickly relieved of everything by the duo before they headed into the home.

"I'm afraid it'll be a pretty short tour," Helen joked.

"I love your style," Catra said sincerely as she took in all the details. Her eyes lit up once she landed on a section of the wall with photo frames. She inspected more closely-- it was Helen and Adora

throughout the years, looking entirely too precious together. "This is the best picture I've ever seen. Is that a real pig she's riding? "

Even Helen's laugh sounded like Adora's. "Yep, that's Esther! One of our first places was a spare room on a farm. The animals were way more likable than that ass of a landlord."

Catra found her brain working through some kind of donkey and ass pun but resisted the urge. Adora's quirky sense of humor had really taken hold. After showing off the rest of the house, Helen went to work on dinner and left the two in the 'guest room' that was more or less Adora's room.

"Soo," Adora said expectantly after closing the door. The look on Adora's face reminded her of when she first came to the penthouse, all self-conscious and small. "What do you think? I know it's not exactly fancy, and there's not a lot of space for privacy. I get it if you want to try to find a hotel after tonight."

Catra tilted her head at Adora in confusion. "What hotel is going to offer me the chance to look at your big head baby photos? I want to be here, dummy. It's perfect." She put her hands on the side of Adora's face, rubbing her fingertips gently across her skin, and pulled her down into a soft kiss. "But... I didn't want to ask in front of your mom. What's Frito pie?"

"It's a bowl full of love and deliciousness," Adora said with a hungry look in her eyes. "You'll see."

After getting their belongings situated, they went into the kitchen hand in hand to see Helen stirring up something on the stove. From the smell, Catra figured it must be chili.

"Smells great," Catra said happily as they sat down at the small kitchen table.

"Hopefully, it'll taste even better," Helen mused as she was sampling and tinkering with seasoning. "Oh shoot, I forgot to ask. Do you have any allergies?"

"No, mam," Catra said politely.

Helen started giggling, "Mam! I appreciate the manners, but you can call me whatever you'd like."

"Sorry, it just came out." Catra felt a bit embarrassed.

"Mom will have to wait until after the wedding, of course." Helen looked back to wink, then assembled three servings of whatever 'Frito pie' was. Now the both of them were sitting in awkward silence, trying not to stare at each other. Helen turned back around with the first bowl and shook her head in amusement as she laughed. "Y'all are too easy!"

"You sure you don't want to stay in at a hotel," Adora stage whispered to Catra so her mom could hear.

"Pfft, you're not going to get this kind of high-quality entertainment at the Drunken Firefly in town; I'll tell you that right now," Helen stepped over to kiss the top of her daughter's head. "Plus, you'd miss me."

"Yeah, you're right," Adora relented with a smirk.

The food was being served, which would put an end to future plans talk... for now. "Thank you," Catra said as she looked down at her bowl. It was chips covered in chili, cheese, and sour cream. Simple, but enticing. Adora was definitely right about it being delicious.

They chit-chatted over dinner about the party the night before, their travels, and how exactly they came to rent that ridiculous truck out in the driveway. Finally, as they were cleaning up, Helen looked a bit worried before bringing up a topic that had clearly been on her mind.

"I don't know if you two have made other plans, but," Helen stretched out the last word nervously. "Aunt Deb planned a big shindig at her house tomorrow night. She *said* it's a surprise party to celebrate your visit, but you know her."

"Like she's ever cared about me coming back home before," Adora groaned and leaned her forehead against a kitchen cabinet.

"That's what I'm saying," Helen rolled her eyes. "If you want to make plans to be unavailable, I'll back you up one hundred percent. I'll say... you went to go skydiving."

"If she's already planned it, I don't want to be rude and not show up," Adora said.

Helen waggled a sudsy spoon at her, "Don't you worry about her. You do what you two want to do, sweetie. I'll deal with her either way."

"Maybe we can sleep on it," Adora offered with a hopeful smile to Catra.

"Works for me," Catra shrugged. This Aunt Deb person had been mentioned in passing to her, but she didn't know enough for an outright refusal or acceptance of the invitation. Still, something in Adora's tone made her feel uneasy.

With the number of hours they'd lost in timezones, it was already getting to be quite late in the day. After more hugs and plans for a big country breakfast in the morning, Helen went to bed. She left the couple to their own devices. (Although, not *literally* their devices because, for fuck's sake, someone around here in city planning must have believed in the cell phone tower conspiracy bullshit. Even browsing Twitter was impossible).

"Alright, spill," Catra said after changing into her pajamas for the night. "What's the deal with Aunt Deb? Because I'm with your mom, if you don't want to go, we're not."

Adora sighed and sat down next to the box of the childhood things she'd been digging in. She had pulled out a multi-colored owl/koala/flying squirrel-type hybrid plush and held it to her chest tightly. "She's not a terrible person or anything. She's just... ugh," she buried her face in the plush, "Too much."

Catra came over to sit down criss-cross apple sauce beside her and wrap an arm around her shoulders. "She's not mean to you or anything?"

"No," Adora shook her head, sounding conflicted. "Definitely not. She actually was a big help to us. She'd take care of me when my mom had to cover shifts at work or if she needed to study for an exam, and she was always really sweet. But in the last few years, she's all about herself, trying to be young and hip, and recruit everyone into her business."

"Uh-huh. Soo... she's like annoying or something?"

"YES," Adora yelled, then lowered her voice. "Exactly. I feel bad for not wanting to spend time with her because she hasn't done anything wrong per se."

"Being annoying can be a crime in my book," Catra assured her. "I'm up for whatever you want. If we go and it's awful, I'll fake a heart attack so we can leave."

"Sounds like a plan," Adora chuckled and reached over to place a hand on Catra's chest. "How are you feeling, by the way? I know you don't like talking about it."

"Good, no palpitations or dizziness, doctor, I promise."

"Your heart feels like it's beating pretty fast," Adora said in a cloying tone as she casually tossed away the plush with her other hand.

"Tends to happen when pretty girls are feeling me up," Catra whispered against her skin as she planted a few soft kisses on Adora's neck.

Adora closed her eyes for a moment before seemingly coming back to her senses. "We can't. This is my mom's house."

"Aw, I'm sorry, Adora," Catra whispered with a devious look in her eyes. "Are you getting all hot and bothered unexpectedly? I can't even imagine what that must be like."

"Keep it up, and I'll drag you off into some fields."

"Mmm, tempting," Catra traced a finger along the neckline of Adora's top. "You, me, and the moonlight. Sounds romantic."

"Until you get a mosquito bite on your bits! Oh god, or a tick--"

"Alright, you killed it. Let's go to sleep," Catra popped back up to her feet and offered a hand to Adora.

-Forced Vacation Day 12 of 19-

The following day started with the absolute best breakfast Catra had ever eaten in her life. Homemade biscuits and jams, gravy, eggs, bacon, hashbrowns, coffee. You name it, Helen was serving it, and with such home chef skill that Catra wondered how Adora hadn't managed to pick up any of it before leaving home. Helen was delighted and proud to hear about her forays into couple's cooking with Catra. Adora promised to whip her up something tasty and unburnt when she came out to visit them sometime.

After that, some small-town sightseeing. There wasn't much to see, but mother and daughter kept Catra amused with stories to go along with all of it. They picked a kitschy restaurant for lunch, and it became clear why when Adora posed next to her photos on a local high school sports legends wall. Their basketball team had won the state championship her senior year, and along with that, she played a little bit of everything else (and she was damn good in all of it, Helen noted).

Finally, it was time to prepare for the great unknown, a surprise-but-not party at the infamous Aunt Deb's place. Catra picked out one of her favorites from the 'dress me country' collection Adora put together for her: a pair of fitted black overalls with a short-sleeved maroon button-up (which, of course, had embroidery of tiny horse heads on the tips of the collar). Adora, meanwhile, went for black jeans and a plaid shirt in maroon and black. Seeing the two of them in the bathroom mirror made Catra smile, remembering that silly conversation back at the fancy boutique.

> *"Are we going to be like that? You know, matching and all? I've noticed they always look like they go together. Would you want that?"*

"I'd love for everyone to know we're a set like a pair of shoes... a couple of sole mates!"

"Alright, I can definitely do this now," Adora said confidently as she put an arm around Catra. "If she's annoying me, I'm going to stare at you to distract myself. How do you look so hot in everything?"

"What can I say? Some people are simply born devastatingly handsome," Catra said in her most dramatic fashion, evoking her PR head.

"I got chills. It felt like they were here."

Catra had read a few snarky articles about the idea of the McMansion: an overly large home for its neighborhood, designed with no particular architectural vision or knowledge. However, nothing could've truly prepared her for seeing one in real life. The front of Aunt Deb's house looked as if a person took an architecture magazine, cut out all the features they liked from all kinds of styles, and then pasted it together in the least sensical way possible. There were fake balconies, mismatched window styles, a random castle-looking turret. Brick, siding, stonework were all in use. It was *something*.

Before she could even comment on it, Adora and Helen were cackling as they watched her expression. "I told you," Helen said between laughs. "More money than brains."

"You know, maybe coming here wasn't a bad idea. If I ever have a house built, I have a reference for exactly what I *don't* want," Catra said as she shifted the truck into park.

"That's the spirit." Helen unbuckled and leaned up to talk to the two of them conspiratorily. "Now, if at any point you two want to leave, give me a signal. If I need to, I'll pretend the hospital called."

"Definitely a better plan than a fake heart attack," Catra laughed.

"We need a code," Adora whispered, even though no one appeared to be anywhere mulling around the packed driveway. "How about...horseradish."

"Sure, that'll be easy work in naturally," Catra teased.

With their plan in place, the trio exited the truck. Catra reached for Adora's hand as they walked up the stone pebble path to the front door. "Remember, horseradish," Helen said, clearly just as weary as they felt, and the other two nodded at her. She rang the doorbell, which blared out some kind of twangy, country-sounding melody.

Within moments, the door was swung open, and there was what Catra presumed to be Aunt Deb in all her glory. Her hair was a spiky brown bob with red and blonde chunky highlights worked in. She was wearing a shimmery, golden sequined shirt with cheetah leggings. Was Catra being pranked? This was a cartoon, not an actual person.

"SURPRISE," she yelled as she wrapped Adora up in a hug. Behind her, other party-goers echoed the sentiment. Though, no one had even *tried* to hide themselves or the fifteen vehicles parked up front. "Adora, hun, you look great," Deb said as she stepped back, still clinging to her wrists. "These arms! I need you to get me that workout routine. My trainer down at World Fitness ain't got a damn clue what she's doing!"

"Sure, I'll send you some things I like," Adora laughed uncomfortably, then looked over at Catra with eyes that said, 'help.'

"And I see you brought your main squeeze," Deb turned her bright blue eyes to Catra. Something about them felt *really* fucking unnatural. She wasn't sure if it was the contrast against the large, floral-covered glasses' frames or if she was actually wearing colored contacts underneath them. "Now those are some **arms** too, honey! You two must work out together. Talk about a power couple. Reminds me of my sweet Mason James and me when we were young. Afraid he's not around tonight. He's been staying at the Firefly, you know, just taking a little *break* from it all. ″

Well, that was far more information than she was expecting from a stranger. Catra cleared her throat. "Hey, Deb. Catra, nice to meet you," she held out a hand and hoped against logical hope not to be wrapped up.

"We are **huggers** in this family, girlie. Better get used to it. I have a feeling we're going to be joining these trees sooner than later," she declared, and that was it. *Ugh*. She was wearing some kind of floral perfume that Catra was sure was going to linger in her nostrils all night. Finally, she released her and backed away to allow everyone to enter the foyer. "You two are **the** picture-perfect couple. Shame they can't make you some grandbabies, Helen, honey! "

Is it too early for horseradish? Catra wondered.

"I do have an early shift at the hospital. Probably won't be able to stay that long." Helen interjected, clearly having the same thoughts given that she was actually off the next two days.

"Alrighty, then this night is WASTIN. Let's get to it. So many people to introduce you to! Everyone's been dining out on Catradora around here since y'all went toxic last month!"

"I think you mean viral," Helen corrected her dryly.

"Silly me," Deb started cackling with the most annoying laugh. "Hard to keep up with these kids. But, don't get me wrong," she winked at Catra and Adora. "I've been learning some of those tick tack dances! This body's got the moves," she started undulating her hips as she began to lead them further in the house. "Alrighty, this party train is a-moving, girlies!"

"What. The. Fuck," Catra whispered to Adora as she leaned in closer and took her hand.

"I have no idea," Adora squeezed her hand tightly.

They were led through the living room and down to a spacious pool area where Catra was introduced to more people than she could count. There were... actual relatives, practically family, neighbors, and Deb's number one customers. Everyone was overly excited to meet Catra, and more than a few not only took a selfie with her but did so without even asking first.

"I don't wanna take up too much of your time, Miss Catra," a young man who was somehow, *maybe* related to Adora said, "But if you're ever in the market for getting into agricultural vehicles, I am your man." He held out an envelope and card, "You'll find some of my plans and my business card in there."

"Thanks, Chuck," Catra accepted the paperwork and slipped it into one of her giant overall pockets she was glad to have.

Adora must have made eyes at him because after he looked over to her, he scurried away. "I'm sorry," she whispered as she directed them over into a quiet corner. "I didn't realize I was signing you up for a meet and greet."

"Eh, it's fine," Catra shrugged, feigning being less annoyed than she was. "I'm gathering material for my memoir."

"Ooh, what's the name," Adora teased.

"As of yet, Untitled. But if I don't think of something, I'll have you pick me out a good pun."

"I kind of like the ring of Untitled."

Their flirting was interrupted by the sound of microphone feedback. A spotlight was swung around and directed unflatteringly on Aunt Deb as she stood by the artificial waterfall at the end of the pool. "Oops! Sorry, but that'll wake y'all right up. Now we are gathered here tonight to give a big welcome home to our sweet Adora," she paused and allowed for hollers and claps. "And I reckon it's too early to say welcome to the family," she joked. Adora squeezed Catra's hand tight. "But welcome to our neck of the woods, Catra! For those of you who have had your head in the sand since this little romance began, Catradora is the biggest thing since sliced bread, and I can't wait to see what these two can do together. To Catradora!"

Everyone held up their various cocktails, beers, and wine glasses as they looked directly at the red-faced couple.

"Thanks," Adora answered for the two of them, more like a question than a declaration.

"HEY," a little voice came up from behind the two of them. "DORY. Dory, I gotta show you something."

They turned around, and Catra saw the first small child she'd seen all night. "Hunter James!" Adora said excitedly as she knelt down to wrap the little boy up in a hug. "I've been wondering where you were hiding."

"In the laundry room," he said proudly. "I was waiting til everybody came outside. I wanted to show you something cool!" He leaned past Adora's shoulder to look at Catra, "Whoa! Hi! You have the coolest eyes."

"Thanks," Catra chuckled. "Catra, nice to meet you, Hunter?"

"Hunter James," he corrected and gave a little sigh, "Mama gets mad if people don't use my whole name."

"Well, what do you want me to call you when she's not around?"

He hummed loudly and tapped his foot in thought. "Sasha! That's my favorite character. She's so cool."

"Alright, Sasha," Adora said, "What were you wanting to show me?"

"I got a new game, come on," he grabbed Adora's hand and looked back at Catra, "You too?" Catra nodded, and the three of them escaped back into the main house.

He led them through a labyrinth of rooms into what must be the game room. It had a few pinball machines, a foosball table, and a giant projector screen hooked up to some consoles.

"I GOT THIS," he said as he held up a couple of VR sets. "We can fight aliens like they're really there! Do you wanna play with me?"

"YES," Adora said excitedly as she took the gear.

"No offense, Dory," Catra said with a smirk, "But I'm going to take some big steps back. Good thing your mom is a nurse."

Their hideaway did not last for long, however. Eventually, some other party-goers made their way back to cheer and laugh at the display. Helen was eagerly awaiting her turn to get out some frustration.

"Catra, honey," Deb said as she tapped her shoulder. "While Adora's tied up, do you mind if I bend your ear a minute about something?"

Catra turned around and scrutinized the other woman for a moment. "Sure," she said cautiously.

"Gonna need a little change of venue away from all this ruckus," Deb noted and started hustling back through the house.

Catra followed along after her, hoping to catch Helen's eyes since Adora was otherwise occupied. Unfortunately, she was doubled over laughing at her daughter's absurd, hectic movements. *It's okay*, she told herself. *It's not like Deb was planning to murder her... in theory.*

After ascending a poorly constructed spiral staircase, Deb swung open double doors to **not** a secret killing room but instead what almost looked like a clothing store. Racks were all lined up around the room, and an oversized circular leopard print couch sat in the middle of it all with mismatched-in-non-charming-way pillows.

"I was hoping we could talk businesswoman to businesswoman," Deb said, taking on a more serious tone than Catra had heard from her all night. "If you wouldn't mind taking a seat," she gestured towards the couch.

"Uh-huh," Catra's eyes shifted around at the racks upon racks of tacky leggings, tunic tops, and more. *God, was she going to ask her to buy this shit? Please no.* She took a seat in the middle of the couch, taking a defensive stance while waiting for whatever this pitch was going to be.

Deb cleared her throat and began to walk the front of the room, showing off her clothing racks. "This place is the home that Deb's Treasures built. What's Deb's Treasures, you might ask? It is a *luxury* collection of this area's finest tops, handmade jewelry, and accessories. We're also an independent contractor for the top leggings company in the world, Peachynunu."

"The company that filed for bankruptcy earlier this quarter and stopped paying out to their suppliers way before that?" Catra raised an eyebrow. She was more than familiar with the scandal.

"Yes, sugar, the very same," Deb shook her head, "Now you see my problem. I was the first one in our area to start selling it a couple of years ago, and business was BOOMING. Could hardly keep up with demand, you know how that is," she winked.

Catra took exception to her billion-dollar business being equated to this woman's pyramid scheme, but she managed to hold her tongue.

"When the money was good, it was great. Mason James was able to quit his job! But, well, things started to slow down at the end of last year, and almost all of my downline cut and run with their refund program," Deb sighed and shook her head.

"That's not me. I'm a fighter. I was going to weather this storm and come out on top! Only... well, hell, Cat, take a look at this place," she gestured to the racks on racks of clothing, "All that passion don't amount to a hill of beans when they're sending me this crap. I got some that look like they're covered in little ding dongs," she waggled her eyebrows and whispered, "You know, private parts. Now there's a hard sale outside of some party wear!"

Catra was really glad that she was the designated driver tonight because not bursting out laughing at Aunt Deb saying 'little ding dongs' earnestly took every bit of her perfectly sober willpower. "That is tough," Catra nodded, trying to stay neutral.

"That's what I'm saying," Deb sighed and shook her head. "I just don't know how we're going to get back on track with the mortgage like this."

Oh. That's where this is going. "If it were me, I'd probably sell it as a lot. You won't get all your money back, but there's probably someone out there looking for stock. Is your husband getting back to work?"

"I worked so hard to retire Mason James at only 45, I'd hate to make him turn tail and head back to the shop."

Catra knew this wasn't the answer the other woman wanted, but the logical, business part of her wasn't going to shut up. "You have to downsize then. There's no way you'll ever catch back up if you could only afford this place when business was good. Especially if there's no other source of income you can rely on. The housing market is actually great for sellers right now. I could get you in contact with a good realtor."

Deb nodded as Catra spoke, getting increasingly more emotional. "Well, you see, honey, I was really hoping that we could keep this place. I put my blood, sweat, and tears into building on it over these last few years. You can only imagine what it means to little Hunter James and me... and my daughters, Angeline Jane and Abigail Maxine. They're off to college now, and I know having a stable home for summer break is important to their development."

There was a pregnant pause as Deb stared at Catra after issuing her complaints and worries. Catra stared back at her, poker face on like she was at an actual business meeting. "I can see why it would be hard for you to let this place go, but it's the right thing to do. Trust me, businesswoman to businesswoman."

Finally, she dropped all pretense and shifted into a more persuasive, less honeyed tone. "What family means to me is sharing blessings when you can. I guess what I'm trying to wrap my mind around is why a great philanthropist like yourself wouldn't want to help. I mean, donating five hundred thousand dollars at the drop of a hat a couple months ago? It'd take less than that to get this place paid off and give me a fighting chance to get back on my feet. It won't mean a damn thing to your bottom line."

Catra raised an eyebrow, but before she could ask how Deb knew that, she went on. "You remember Backpack Helpers, the same organization my sister had to rely on for sweet Adora? I know it was done by an 'anonymous' donor, but I can't hold it to coincidence, seeing how the times lined up. It seems like you love a good charity case. I figured you'd be jumping at the chance to help our family.

What do you say? I've got a *great* new business idea to launch. All I need is a blessing to get it going."

Chapter End Notes

I said to myself... if the creek don't rise, I'm a-going to get this here Rich Catra update out before 2022. And here we are. I apologize to those of you who have been waiting patiently for more URCS adventures while I tinkered with other things. I hope you enjoyed all the same! As always, I love to read your comments and feedback.

Have I accidentally made a more despicable character than Valerie? Will Catra lend a hand or call horseradish on the whole night? Is Helen going to have to be held back by her daughter when she finds out what her sister is up to? Are Catradora going to try to just take Sasha home with them? Find out all this and more in the next... hopefully not 3 months from now... chapter of Untitled Rich Catra Story!

Goat Your Own Way

Chapter Summary

Catra and Deb size each other up, and the experience leaves one of them more shaken than the other.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra gave herself a beat to process everything before saying calmly, "Are you trying to hustle me right now? If so, I recommend that you start over because it's not going to work with me." The other woman went from smug to uncomfortable as those words sunk in. However Deb thought this was going to go, it certainly wasn't like this. Catra raised her eyebrows expectantly. "Well?"

Deb cleared her throat, and the light reflected off her bedazzled loafers as she shuffled her feet awkwardly. "I don't know why you'd get that impression, Cat, honey. There's no hustle going on here. I know you're too smart to be taken like that."

Catra crossed her arms and leaned back against the ugly couch. "Excuse me if I *can't hold it to coincidence*," she said, matching her tone from before, "That you'd bring up that donation like it was some kind of bargaining chip. If you drop the bullshit, I'll hear you out. If not, I'm done here. Up to you. I'm good either way."

The other woman sighed and flopped down into a bright fuchsia armchair. "Caught like a rat in a trap, but I'm desperate here grasping at every straw I can think of. I know that doesn't excuse me talking to you like that. But... Things have been bad for a real long time. Mason James isn't away on some fun staycation. He left when he found out how bad a shape I let our credit get in. I also spent all the savings behind his back, trying to keep my rank with Peachynunu. That didn't get me a damn thing anyway. Thank God the girls' tuition is already paid for the year. Then, I found out you were coming here. It was like a second chance sent by an angel. Believe me, I wouldn't be asking if I wasn't at rock bottom."

Despite her misgivings, Catra felt herself soften the tiniest bit but kept up her poker face all the same. "I don't understand why you're so resistant to downsizing then. This **isn't** sustainable."

"This place is mortgaged out the wazoo already. Even if we sold it on a hell of a deal, we'd still be coming out with little to nothing. Then what? We're broke and homeless. How's that make anything better?"

In Catra's head, all she could see was sweet Sasha. How god damn unfair. "What exactly were you planning to do before me?"

"Well," Deb twiddled her thumbs. The brain cells she hadn't killed off with copious amounts of hairspray were working overtime. "All I know to do is get a loan from *someone* as seed money for my new business venture."

All that empathy Catra had been finding dwindled. "If your next business venture is like this one," she gestured at the racks on racks of unsellable clothes, "It's not going to get you anywhere. MLMs are designed to prey on people. All they do is promise bullshit that they can't deliver on no matter how hard you 'work' at it. That you even had some time where this was profitable was a miracle. If you can't see that, I could give you a million dollars right now, and you'd be back here in a year."

Deb nodded and brought her hands together before her, appearing in deep thought. "I'm not asking you to write a check right now or anything, but I'm begging you to think on it. I swear I will do my very best to right this ship. You're my last hope."

Catra sighed and stood up, prepared to finally leave. She'd had enough of this for one night. "I'll think about it, but I don't make a habit out of bad investments. I need a write-up down of every penny in this whole mess and some reasons to trust it won't happen again."

"Thank you for giving me a chance. I'll have it together ASAP as possible. No bullshit this time, Cat. I swear." Deb stood up from her chair and approached like she was going to hug her.

She held out a hand before Deb got into her space. "Nope. And it's ***Catra.***"

Deb rambled apologies and nonsense that Catra tuned out as the two of them left the legging disaster room. At the bottom of the stairs, she saw Adora walking into the main room with Sasha hanging off her back by her shoulders.

"Catra!" She yelled, looking relieved. "We were wondering where you went."

Sasha popped up excitedly. "WE WON! We stopped the invasion! You shoulda seen it. We got the best score EVER .″

"Wow, sorry I missed that. Maybe when school's out, you can visit us, and we'll play all kinds of games."

"Whoa," Sasha said, eyes wide, "That would be SO COOL."

"Catra has her very own arcade." Adora gave a sly smile before adding, "But if we go, we have to be nice and let her win sometimes. Last time she didn't win *anything* ."

Catra rolled her eyes. "You're so nice, Dory."

The three of them headed back to the game room in time to watch Helen finishing out her turn at fighting back an alien incursion. When she emerged from the virtual world, mostly victorious, Catra seized the opportunity to set up a getaway.

She caught Helen's attention as she rejoined them, "I've been meaning to ask you this since we got here. Has Adora always had a love of puns?"

"Absolutely," Helen confirmed with a laugh. "Took her senior picture in a shirt that said 'You Can Goat Your Own Way.' It's even funnier in the yearbook because the people around her are dressed to the nines. Then there's my goose in her goat shirt. Timeless."

Catra definitely needed to see that yearbook, but she needed to focus on the mission for now. "I was thinking how weird it is that she doesn't have a horseradish shirt. That's an obvious one, right?"

Helen nodded knowingly, "There's a shop in the next town over that I'm sure would have one. We'll have to go before you leave!" Then she looked down at her phone and sighed dramatically, making

sure to catch her sister's attention, "Seriously?! My baby is in town for only a couple of days, and they're going to call me into work. Doesn't anybody else work at this hospital?"

With that, they gave quick but polite goodbyes. Deb had started to say something that might hint at their conversation, but after the evil eye that Catra gave her, it was quickly swallowed. Helen and Adora seemed none the wiser. The drive back to the house was full of laughter and the mother-daughter duo serenading Catra with Dolly Parton's greatest hits. *What a couple of dorks.*

Catra didn't want to ruin the mood by bringing up the whole situation with Aunt Deb. *What was she supposed to say, anyway? How would they react?* The more she thought about it herself, the more she worried she'd handled it wrong. This was a family in need. Even if their need was created by a healthy dose of irresponsibility and other unkind words she could use, it didn't make the situation any better. *Was she heartless?*

Fucking Aunt Deb. This wasn't the kind of shit she needed on her mind right now. All she wanted to do was have a nice vacation with her girlfriend and get to know her mom so--

"Helllooo," Adora sing-songed and waved a hand in Catra's face. "You okay?"

"Sorry, spaced out there for a second," she said as she shifted the giant truck into park in the driveway. "I'm fine," she gave her most convincing smile.

"Don't feel like you need to pretend," Helen said as she leaned up from the backseat, "I saw how many people were trying to chat you up for something or another. I'd be exhausted too if I were you. I'm sorry we didn't get out of that shit show sooner."

And she only knew half of it...

"MOM, please, why are you torturing me," Adora begged as Helen returned to the living room with a stack of yearbooks, "She doesn't need to see *everything* ."

"Oh yes, I do," Catra said with a mischievous grin on her face. "This is the mental reset I need after that 'shit show,' as Helen here so eloquently put it."

"She deserves some joy tonight," her mother said with the same grin.

"It isn't fair," Adora groaned and laid her head down on Catra's shoulder while she started flipping through her senior yearbook. "You don't have any yearbook photos after like fourth grade."

"I can't help it if I was smart enough to be strategically 'sick' on photo days. Plus, not like anyone cared to buy my school pictures after," she started out casually, then her voice dropped off as she seemed to realize what she was saying. Instead of continuing her sentence, she kept flipping through the pages in silence.

Adora frowned and hated herself a little for bringing it up. Before she could think of the right way to apologize, her thoughts were interrupted by uproarious laughter.

"Oh. My. God," Catra declared between cackling. "Your quote!"

"What's wrong with my quote," she asked defensively, looking back over it. "It's a great quote!"

"To ride on a horse is to fly without wings, from Anonymous," Helen read aloud sagely. "I'm not sure if that makes sense, honey. It sounds nice, though."

Catra tried to rein her laughter in. "It's the fact that there's you in this goat shirt with your nonsensical horse quote next to Amanda Hill in her suit jacket with her philosopher quote. Don't get me wrong. I like yours better, but..."

"She probably searched up 'good senior quotes' and picked a random one," Adora said as she crossed her arms. "And for the record, I graduated with a higher GPA than her."

"If it makes you feel better, senior me would've loved it too," Catra said as she leaned to give her a quick kiss. "If I took a senior picture, I definitely would've worn my Eat the Rich shirt and had some kind of cringy quote about the education system."

"Sounds like a match to me," Helen said with a laugh.

After another hour of sitting around and decompressing after their time at Deb's, everyone headed off to bed. As Adora laid watching Catra change into her pajamas, she couldn't help but notice her mood had dropped significantly.

She'd seen her partner annoyed, angry, sad... but none of those quite matched the look in her eyes. If anything, it reminded her of when she was trying to parse through a problem related to work. Maybe that comment about her parents had sparked something... maybe she hated the time at her Aunt's more than Adora knew... maybe she even hated her mom, her whole family... maybe she didn't want to have her name linked to them... maybe... maybe...

"Catra," she said softly as the other woman crawled into bed beside her, determined to quiet all of those maybes.

"What," she said with a yawn and reached out to run a hand through her loose blonde hair. "You know I was only teasing about the yearbook stuff, right? I wouldn't want you any other way. I love my punny horse girl."

That made Adora smile despite her worries. "I just wanted to check-in, you know, since we didn't have much time to talk today. Make sure everything's good."

There was that look again. Catra rolled over onto her back and stared up the ceiling while reaching to hold one of Adora's hands. "The party was kind of weird, but other than that, it's been perfect," she brought the hand she was holding to her lips and kissed it softly, "Don't worry about me. I'm happy as long as you're happy."

"Well, what if I'm only happy if you're happy," Adora challenged impishly.

"Hmm... I'm not sure. I'll have to ask Entrapta to do a flowchart to sort that out."

After another few minutes of chatter about what to do with the next day, Catra rolled back over and pulled Adora into her arms. Wrapped up in the safety of their cacoon, the two of them drifted off to sleep.

The first hours of sleep came easily enough for Catra. The problem was when she woke up in the middle of the night and no longer had a conscious Adora to lull her back to sleep. Now, all she had

were thoughts of guilt. Plus... fuck, does it count as lying that she hadn't told Adora about what happened yet? Lying by omission... that's what they call that. Ugh. A whole new thing to worry about.

When she gave up falling back to sleep, she ever so carefully unwrapped herself from Adora. She was a reasonably heavy sleeper and didn't seem to notice as Catra crept out of the room. She sat down on the couch and started to look through her texts from earlier that day. There were photos of Melog from her pet sitter that made her miss her fuzzy son even more, as well as updates from Bow and Glimmer. They were mostly done with phase one of the project she had entrusted them with-- a project that now felt at risk given *stupid fucking Deb* .

Her chest tightened as her mind treated her to a double feature of an unkind retelling of how she had handled things earlier and how it could be taken by Adora. And, of course, she had forgotten to pack the medicine she needed for taming her panic attacks. Fucking fuck... After she felt more stable, she got up to get a glass of water. As she did, she stared out the window and got an idea.

Making sure not to lock herself out, she snuck out of the house and found a tree to lean against in the backyard to look up at the night sky. It wasn't exactly like her tranquility garden, but, damn, there was nothing quite like actually being able to see the stars. Deep breaths, calming thoughts, *Focus* . The panic loosened its grip on her heart. Any other time that would've been enough, but... She grabbed her phone out of her pocket and dialed the one person she figured would give her an unbiased opinion on the situation.

"Am I a bad person," she asked point-blank when they picked up.

"You pay me an awful lot of money to tell people what a good person you are."

"Forget that for a second. What do *you* think?"

There was an audible sigh, shuffling, and Catra barely made out a whisper, *"It's going to be a minute. Why don't you start without me?"*

Then DT was back, "Objectively? You're a good person, and you know I'd let you hear it otherwise. Now, what's this about? Getting high on all that fresh air?"

"If only," Catra chuckled before she paused to wipe away a stray tear running down her cheek. It shouldn't be embarrassing admitting the truth, especially considering DT already knew. So why was it so hard? "I had a panic attack. I’m mostly fine now."

"Where's our blondie," they asked, more softly than she was used to them speaking to her.

"In bed."

"Uh-huh. Makes sense for almost four in the morning on your coast. And where are *you* at this ungodly hour?"

"In a little field behind the house. Thought fresh air would help, and it did. But the thing that's bothering me... I don't know what to do about it. I feel like I'm fucking up no matter what."

"And you knew that a good talk with your best friend DT would put your mind at ease," they said in such a way that made Catra roll her eyes even if they couldn't see it. "And, as always, I am here for you. Won't even put this on my timesheet. So, lay it on me. To reiterate: you *are* a good person, my dear. As good as you were when I first met you. One of the best people I know. Gold stars all around."

Catra tried to explain as best she could what had happened with Aunt Deb earlier in the night. DT similarly did their best to limit themself to only the occasional snarky commentary. Catra sighed at the end. "Before she dropped the attitude, she made me feel like trash for not immediately writing a blank check. Now I don't know… maybe I am?"

"Oh honey, trust me when I tell you that you are not the trash in this equation."

"Maybe, but… fuck, DT. They're going to lose their home, and I sat there and said, 'okay, sell it' while making enough money to buy it in a day. That's fucked up. I'm gross and selfish, and… she was right; it wouldn't mean a thing to me. Why shouldn't I do it?"

"Alright, I've got my pen and paper ready. Let's write a list of the whole world's problems that are somehow yours alone to solve."

Catra groaned.

"What? I'm telling you the truth; that's where this is going. Pay off her house if you want. I certainly wouldn't out of spite alone, but, like I said, you're a good person. Keep in mind that at some point, you'll have to draw the line."

"Will I, though? I could never spend it all. No one should have this much money. Eat the rich, right? That's what I used to say. I'm becoming what I hate. I should give it all away."

"I'm all for philanthropy, but I cannot advise it to be done under distress. Why don't you go to bed, dear? Splash your face with some cold water, snuggle with Adora, and go to sleep. You can talk it out with her in the morning. If I know our blondie, the person she'll be mad at is **not** you. Now before I let you off this phone, I *am* going to need to talk to her, so I know--"

"YOU BETTER HAVE A DAMN GOOD REASON—" a gruff but still familiar voice called out from behind. When Catra leaned to peek beyond the tree, she saw Helen lower the baseball bat she was gripping with a laugh, "Catra! Sorry, honey. I heard something back here and thought it was somebody causing trouble with the animals."

"WHAT WAS THAT," DT yelled. "Don't you go getting yourself in some kind of true crime--"

"It's Adora's mom," Catra explained and waved.

"Helen! We love her. Tell her I want to say hello," DT demanded sternly.

Before Catra could even get up to approach her, Helen was looking down at her worriedly. "Um. DT wants to talk to you," she mumbled. She held up her phone, and Helen took it with a confused smile.

"Hello, beautiful. How are things?" Helen said happily. They'd all had a group call earlier that week to prep her on what to do if the 'press' came to document this chapter of the Catradora experience. "Oh, I see. Mmhmm," she sounded rather serious now. Great. She's getting told on to her girlfriend's mom. "Well, I'll make sure we're all good here. You get out there and have some fun now! Bye!"

Catra looked up at her sheepishly. "Sorry I woke you up."

"Nothing to be sorry about. Love an excuse to stargaze," Helen said with a smile and sat down on the ground beside her. "DT mentioned you were having a hard time this evening. Do you want to talk about it? If not, that's okay too."

Catra tucked her legs up into her chest before she let it all spill out the same as she'd done with DT. Unlike them, however, Helen stayed quiet as she listened. "I don't want to cause problems with your family. I should've just written her a check and called it done."

Helen gave a slight smile. "You know, all of this reminds me of Adora's favorite book growing up, If You Give a Mouse a Cookie. We read that book so many times I can still recite most of it. If you give a mouse a cookie, he'll want a glass of milk. When you give him the milk, he'll probably ask for a straw. Do you know that one?"

Catra nodded, "I think I can see where you're going with this."

"It sounds like my sister has gotten herself into one ***hell*** of a mess, and one check isn't going to be enough for her to stop asking for more. She is not your responsibility, honey. No matter what she said or if you were the richest person alive."

"But, what am I supposed to do? Just go back to my expensive ass penthouse while her whole family gets kicked out on the streets? That's fucked up." She needed to calm down. This isn't the impression she wanted to give...

"You've got a good heart, Catra," Helen said comfortingly as she reached over and put a hand on her shoulder. "It isn't fair that she unloaded all this on it because I have a feeling you can't just ignore it. You're too much like my goose. No matter how much we read that book, I think she missed the message. She'd give until there wasn't anything left for that needy little mouse or herself."

Catra laughed knowingly. "Then she'd just tell herself she doesn't even like cookies that much anyway."

"Exactly," Helen sighed. "Listen, I will support you no matter what you decide to do. If I know my daughter, and I *do*, she will too. Don't you worry about them having somewhere to go if they have to sell her place because she knows *damn well* I'd let them stay here. There's a reason she's asking you first."

"I mean, where would she fit the antler chandelier and the creepy vintage doll collection?" They both started cackling at that.

Helen continued to lighten the moon with some choice stories about growing up with Deborah and watching her become the *Aunt Deb.* Finally, she looked over at Catra with a soft smile that reminded her of Adora's. "Well, I don't know about you, but I think I've gotten enough fresh air. Ready to head back in?"

"Yeah, I am." Catra confirmed, and they helped each other back up. "Thanks for listening." She went for a hug that Helen wholeheartedly returned.

"Anytime, sweetheart. What are mothers for," Helen caught herself and quickly apologized, "Sorry, sorry, Adora keeps telling me I've got to stop with those kinds of jokes."

Catra took a deep breath. Now was as good a time as any. "Actually, before we go inside, can I ask you about one more thing?"

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter we'll wrap up the visit, see how Catra ultimately decides to handle the Deb of it all, and we'll fly back home to see just what Catra has Glimmer and Bow working on. Oh. And I guess we'll see what Catra's asking Helen about. Hmmm...

Failsafe

Chapter Summary

If you tried to read the original version of this that was all mixed up, I am so sorry! Here's a fixed copy. Lesson learned about trying to update from your phone/forgetting laptop chargers.

Thanks to everyone who helped me recover my original summary:
Aunt Deb gets a charitable offer, but will she take it? Catra and Adora round out their visit with horses, relaxation, and star gazing. When they touch back down in Bright Moon, it is clear that things will never be the same.

Chapter Notes

There are probably *more* errors in this because I had proof read the last copy, and deleted it in a panic when I was informed the format was all mixed up. Fingers crossed they don't take away too much from your enjoyment! At least nothing is doubled/tripled... I hope...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was flying on the back of a winged unicorn, having a magical time, and then she fell to earth with a thud. She jolted awake in bed, prepared to lunge at the intruder responsible for the disruption to her dream.

"It's me, sorry," Catra whispered as she wiggled down under the covers.

"Was gonna fight you." Adora giggled as she reached for her girlfriend. She realized two things all at once -- Catra was freezing, and the top of her shirt was slightly wet. Now Adora was awake for real. She tugged Catra in close, trying to shield her from a monster creeping in the shadows. "What's wrong?"

Catra squeezed her back and rested her head on Adora's chest. "Ssh, I'm alright. Go back to sleep," she whispered unconvincingly.

Adora began to run her fingers through Catra's hair, gently scratching at her scalp as she puzzled over what must be wrong. "We don't have to talk about it if you don't want to," she said in a sweet, sleepy voice. "But... you don't have to hide your feelings from me, no matter what. Okay?"

"Okay," Catra replied, sounding defeated. "My head's loud tonight. Couldn't fall back to sleep."

Adora bent down to kiss the top of Catra's head before scolding it, "Be quiet in there, brain. My girlfriend needs to sleep so we can go ride horses tomorrow."

Catra gave a raspy little laugh that made her feel warm again. "I love you, Adora."

"I love you too, more than anything." Adora used her leverage to pull Catra all the way on top of her, holding her close as she whispered, "Whatever you're thinking about, you'll figure it out. I know you will. And if you don't, I will. Or I'll punch somebody. Easy."

Catra shook with quiet laughter again before she brought herself up on her elbows to look at Adora. "Thanks."

Even in the dim moonlight, the intensity of her stare made Adora's cheeks hot and shifted the mood in the room. Catra leaned in, pressing their foreheads together a moment before her lips sought Adora's, soft at first but growing in desperation. After Catra caressed her breast through her shirt, she pulled back like she'd touched a snake. "Got carried away, sorry," she said with a laugh, "I know this is your mom's place, and you---"

Adora silenced her words with another crushing kiss and moved Catra's hand back onto her breast. "What if we have PG-13 rules? I can work with that if you can." She reached down to graze her fingertips along the inside of Catra's thigh at the edge of her shorts.

"I have a feeling this is *not* going to help me sleep." Catra shivered at her touch. "But my head is pretty fucking quiet right this second."

That was how they spent the night—cautiously pushing the boundaries of the agreed-upon rating, peeling back edges of clothing to leave marks in inconspicuous places. Every creak of the house settling was treated like Helen was about to bust in. They would completely stop and separate like they were about to be discovered before giggling and going back at it. Eventually, sleep came with the two of them peacefully intertwined.

-Forced Vacation Day 13 of 19-

Catra's therapist would probably disapprove of the "make out with your girlfriend to avoid communication" strategy, but last night, she *couldn't* talk about it. There was no energy left in her body to defuse the bomb that Aunt Deb had so casually gifted her. It wasn't that she wanted to hide anything. It was about trying to solve the problem before Adora needed to worry. Catra knew she would manage to blame herself or feel guilty about Deb's ridiculous attempt at a hustle. If Catra had a solution, then hopefully, she could mitigate that.

And so, while Adora showered and worked on getting ready for the day, Catra sipped coffee at the kitchen table with a legal pad where she intended to write out her plan. However, she mainly had filled it with silly face doodles of them and Melog while she thought.

"Heard you're a big fan of these," Helen woke Catra out of her thoughts as she placed the local paper down in front of her. It was opened to the daily crossword as well as other word games. "I know it's not the Times, but the puzzle writer is my friend, Angie. She's clever as a damn fox. Writes circles around most people."

"Sounds like a worthy challenge," Catra said approvingly. Waking up her brain with some puzzles might just do the trick. She picked up the paper to start reading.

Catra was so in the zone of puzzle-solving that she didn't realize Adora was there until she waved a hand in front of her face. "Hellooo?"

She blinked a few times and came back into the world. "Sorry."

Adora peered over her shoulder at the current entry Catra was puzzling over, Format for *The Umbrella Academy* . "Well, it's definitely not goat rodeo."

As good a segue as any...

"Speaking of goat rodeos," Catra started cautiously. "I need to talk to you about something your aunt's roped me into."

Adora groaned as she plopped down into the chair beside her, "Did she sell you a bunch of ugly clothes? We can donate them."

"That's the opposite of charity," Catra chuckled as she recalled the horrendous patterns and shitty quality fabric. She took another big drink of her coffee before she admitted the truth. "Actually, she tried to shake me down for half a million dollars."

"What," Adora said incredulously. "SERIOUSLY?"

Catra nodded, and before she could explain any further, Adora was back up on her feet again, raising her voice and gesticulating wildly. "Who does that?! Doesn't she have enough money? Does she need to add another floor to her tacky house!? A castle spire?! She probably threw this whole stupid party as an excuse to pull this bullshit. Nice to meet you, please write me a check. Shameless!" She snatched up the keys to the rental truck from the counter. "I'm going to give her a piece of my mind and fix this. Don't worry about giving her a penny. I'm going to charge *her* for our time!"

"Hey, Adora, can we talk about it first," Catra stood and put her hands gently on her shoulders, rubbing a bit to calm her down. "Then you can slap her or whatever you want to do."

"Fine," Adora huffed and allowed herself to be led back to the kitchen table.

"I thought it was fucking classless myself, but... money makes people do stupid shit." Catra grabbed her notebook and opened it up to a new page to sketch out her thoughts as she spoke. "I don't know all the specifics yet, but she ran whatever money they had into the ground and *kept going* . That Peachynunu nonsense she was 'working' for is the biggest god damn scam in the MLM world. That's saying something."

"I knew you couldn't make money off those ugly things. She had some horse leggings that even *I* wouldn't buy. Whoever stole the design didn't pay attention, and a bunch of them had a fifth leg that looked like..." Adora turned red and started giggling. "You know."

Catra shook her head, writing down figures while she talked, "Yeah, sounds right. She wasn't making money anymore, but she was good at spending it. Even if she sold that McMansion, she'd still be a couple hundred thousand in debt. Maybe more."

Adora sat quietly now, blinking at her in shock as her mouth hung open.

"Yep," Catra said, "I'll have the specifics for my accountant to look over later, but I think she'll say... they're fucked. It's either filing bankruptcy or finding some gullible rich idiot to bail them out."

Adora reached over and placed a hand on hers, "It doesn't make you gullible to care about people."

Catra shrugged, "It feels like it because even if I'm pissed at her for all of this... I keep thinking about the kid, you know? And your cousins that are off at school? They have no idea this is happening. They'll have to quit or take on a bunch of debt themselves. That's fucked up. It's not my fault, but it

isn't fair. I can't have that shit floating around in my head. I have to do *something* ." She finished up what she was writing and spun it around to show Adora. "Here's what I'm thinking."

Catra detailed her plan of what to 'offer' Deb, nonnegotiable. It wasn't a big check for all the money she wanted. Instead, her idea was to build a foundation to give them a chance to start over. Step one, she was going to get the adults signed up for financial literacy courses. Then, Catra would take on paying tuition/school expenses. On top of this, she would pay the home's utilities, mortgage (though she hoped they would decide to sell the godforsaken place), and other significant expenses for two years. At that time, they would reevaluate the arrangement.

While Catra explained, Adora began to nervously drum her fingers on the paper in front of her. The speed and intensity of it crept up like a war drum. By the time it was her turn to speak, Catra was afraid she might explode. "That's a lot," she said simply, her eyebrows tightly knitted together.

Then, she broke. She pushed back from the table and began ranting as she paced the small kitchen again. "Are you sure you want to commit to that...? Two years? Maybe more? *We've* barely been together two *months* , and it's all my fault you even have to deal with these people. THIS is *exactly* what Valerie and all those gossip papers say."

Well, so much for mitigating Adora's anxiety with an established plan. Now her own was creeping up, but she took a deep breath. Silence hung between them for a moment as Adora, on the verge of frustrated tears, continued her pacing. Finally, Catra said, "Ultimately, I'll do whatever you want me to. If you want me to say, fuck it and walk away, I will. But this isn't your fault, and it doesn't make those assholes right."

Adora scrunched up her face in thought and finally sat back down again, pouring back over Catra's estimates. She jotted down her own calculations to the side before declaring, "Maybe *I* can take out a loan to cover what they're behind on right now. I've got excellent credit. I could probably get approved for it, and then she'll owe me, not you, and I could pick up extra shifts if she doesn't pay and..."

"Adora," Catra said affectionately as she reached over and turned her chin to look at her, "If you think I'm going to let you do that, you're an idiot. A sweet idiot, but an idiot all the same."

"A gullible rich idiot and a sweet poor idiot," Adora said with a sad laugh. "What a pair."

"Oh, come on, there was some kind of pun in there. You're losing your touch," Catra teased. "Let's table it for now. I'll email my accountant and lawyer about it. They can draft up an official plan. Then we can review it together and make changes before They have send it to her. Sound okay?"

Adora sighed as she nodded. "If this doesn't work, I say we steal Sasha."

"Deal," Catra winked. "For now, I think we're supposed to be seeing a person about a horse."

As excited as Adora was for herself, she couldn't *wait* to help Catra with her first solo ride. She'd dressed her up in her most country outfit yet --- a black button-up with bright red embroidery around the neck, jeans, black boots, and the perfect black cowboy hat. Meanwhile, she had decided to at least *dress* like her childhood dream of being in equestrian sports. This meant sleek riding boots, tight khaki pants, and a white shirt, all finished off with a fancy 'show coat' she'd found online.

Catra's eyes traveled up and down, slowly taking her in when she stepped out of the restroom. Then she looked off to the ceiling and shook her head.

"What," Adora asked innocently.

"I'm trying to figure out why you get to dress all sexy horse girl, and I have to look like this." Catra tipped her hat at her.

"Don't you worry, boss," Adora whispered as she leaned into her, "You look very sexy to me." She smacked her butt and declared, "Let's go! You've got a lot to learn."

The stable they were visiting was owned by someone Helen knew from work, so they had free reign to do as they pleased after introductions were made. Helen retreated to the outside of the fence to watch the 'lessons' and document it all.

"Normally, I'd show you how to groom and tack up our friends, Silvie and Caspian, here," Adora spoke in her best teacher voice, "But! Ash was nice enough to get these beauties ready for us already. You'll be riding Silvie because they said she's easier to start with. She's a bit older and calmer, but she's still a magnificent horse, aren't you," she stroked the horse's mane.

"Not going to argue with that," Catra said as she glanced between the two horses. Although he had the demeanor of a sweet puppy, Caspian towered over the other horse. He was chestnut brown, beautiful, and composed of muscles and energy.

"We'll start with learning how to lead Silvie so you two can get to know each other. Are you ready?"

"Yes, mam," Catra said with a grin.

Adora earnestly demonstrated every step before handing the reigns, quite literally, over to Catra. She and Silvie began walking around the circle. "Nice to meet you," Catra said to the horse casually as they walked. She listened to the responding horse noises and nodded. "Yeah, I've tried, but she loves that dumb hair poof."

"Hey," Adora whined.

"We're getting to know each other by making fun of you. Silvie and I are feeling *very* bonded right now." She stuck her tongue out for emphasis, and the horse whinnied at just the right moment.

Once they finished a couple of laps, Adora brought them to a stop and had Catra swap out her hat for a helmet. Then, Adora demonstrated the steps for mounting a horse. She could tell Catra was much more worried about this as she watched intently with a blank expression. When it was finally her turn, she stood frozen.

"You can do it, Catra." Helen yelled from the side, "Like riding a bike!"

Catra looked over at her and gave a wave and thumbs up before nervously turning to Adora. "I never learned to ride a bike," she admitted in a whisper.

"Pfft, this is way *easier* ," Adora said with a reassuring smile. "Plus, I'm here! I won't let anything bad happen to you. I promise."

"Thanks," Catra leaned in to kiss her on the cheek. She slowly started to climb up the steps of the mounting block. When she got to the top, she whispered, "Alright, stay still for me, please, we're friends. I'll buy you nice horse stuff, whatever that is."

"Be calm, silly. She can tell if you're scared."

"I'm not scared," Catra declared with gritted teeth but still took one last deep breath before finally doing as instructed to pull herself into the saddle. "See. Totally..." Adora began leading Silvie forward slowly, and Catra tightened her grip, "Fine."

"Yep, you're a real horse girl," Adora winked.

After they finished up beginner lessons and Catra felt more confident, Adora was able to mount Caspian for a ride around the property. First stop, posing for a picture by Helen.

"Are you sure you don't want to come, mom," Adora whined. "They've got another horse named Princess! She looked sweet."

"I'm fine, goose. I can ride whenever I want. You two deserve a nice romantic time together," Helen waved her off with a wink. Adora *swore* the wink was directed more at Catra.

As they trotted around the field by the treeline, she glanced over at Catra. She was doing that thing where she bites on her tongue when she's focused. "You're looking good! Nice form and control," Adora approved. "Silvie likes you, I can tell."

"I hope so; I don't want her to decide to kill me," Catra said with a nervous laugh. "Wait, before I forget again, *why* does your mom call you goose?"

"Oh," Adora chuckled. "I *may* have wrestled a goose and brought it home when we rented a room at that farm."

Catra took her eyes off the field ahead for the first time to look at Adora in shock. "Seriously? Why would you do that?! Geese are terrifying."

"Not my goose! After I caught her, I took really good care of her, and she loved me," she said proudly. "She stayed on the farm after that. My mom says she was my first friend! Just a couple of silly geese."

"Only you could make a wild goose into a friend," Catra laughed. "You're something. You know that?" She said with such affection and a look in her eyes that made Adora's heart skip a beat.

They kept riding until they reached a hill with a nice view of a pond shimmering with the sunlight. Even Adora's energetic horse was still and seemed to appreciate the scenery. She glanced over to Catra and caught her giving that 'heart-bursting-love' look again. She returned it, wondering if something *special* was about to happen. Something perhaps she would've talked to her mom about... but, gosh, it was so soon and--

Catra broke the silence declaring, "Italic!" with wide eyes.

"What?" This was not what she was expecting to hear.

"The puzzle. It referred to how the title was written, not something to do with the series," Catra said proudly. "Man, I wasn't going to be able to sleep until I got it. That Angie *is* good."

"Oh, ha, yeah, the puzzle, of course," her face turned red, and she awkwardly scratched at the base of her ponytail. What a *goose* indeed. There was no reason to be daydreaming about such silly things.



Goose Adora by RamenFever

Under the guise of wanting them to spend more time together, Catra insisted that Helen ride up front with Adora on the drive back to her place for the evening. In reality, she was on her phone catching up on anything that she had missed without prying eyes. After reading over updates from her petsitter, she got to her group chat with Bow and Glimmer that had many texts throughout the day:

Bow : Everything is still going smoothly here!

Bow : [picture of Melog in a cube of a bookshelf, snuggled in next to a horse plush]

Bow: Melog has found some new places to hide.

Glimmer : **Darla's** still standing without you too. The office has been living for Helen's Twitter updates today! We love Cowboy Catra [cowboy hat emoji]. If you go to a country bar, please make sure she films your line dancing.

Glimmer : look at these [tiny cowboy hat cookies] Entrapta special ordered them for everyone as a treat before we left for the day. Is this our new brand?

Glimmer: jk, but maybe that's our next theme party. Regards, Glimmer, Darla Industries, Party Planning Chair

Catra : I don't recall giving you that title.

Glimmer : You're on vacation. Maybe I got approval from someone who isn't! [wink emoji]

Catra : [roll eyes emoji]

Bow: Hiiiii Catra. Do you need us to do anything else before you get back?

Catra: Nothing I can think of. If you see anything come up about us online, will you let me know ASAP?

Glimmer: Your name has been trending for the last few days.

Before she had a chance to clarify if it was good trending or bad trending, Adora had cranked up 'Country Roads' to signify they were almost back. Catra couldn't help but put her phone down to join the mother-daughter duo.

-Forced Vacation Day 15 of 19-

Another day in the country had passed without much to note. No drama. No hustle. Just fresh air and learning more about the woman she'd come to love. They finished the day with a movie in this one-screen theater that Catra couldn't believe was real. It was all very peaceful and quaint.

Aunt Deb reached out to interrupt their lazy Wednesday afternoon, perhaps hoping to add some excitement to the docket. Catra knew Deb had received the proposed contract that her team had prepared.

"You have some nerve," Helen said coldly to her sister when she picked up. "You didn't think you should let me know before you go begging my daughter's girlfriend for money? For goodness sake, Deborah, you know I would've helped if you asked before things got so bad."

Catra and Adora drank their iced tea in silence as they listened to one half of the conversation. Deb must be giving a lot of excuses because all Helen was doing was cutting in with some 'uh-huhs' and 'mmhm' and 'You think?'

Finally, Helen pulled the phone away from her ear and looked over to Catra, "She wants to talk to you."

Catra reached out for the phone, but Adora snatched it up before she could take it. "AND ANOTHER THING," she declared.

After receiving her second family scolding, Deb was somewhat repentant when she got to Catra. "Catra, from the bottom of my heart, I am so sorry for how I handled this. I'm ashamed of how I treated you. I know I've made a whole truckload of mistakes. If you look up dumbass in the dictionary, I swear it's got my picture by it. But not anymore. I am ready to take this opportunity and make some big changes. My babies deserve that."

Helen and Adora were watching her intently. Catra tried to stay neutral, "That's good to hear."

"Now, I did have a quick clarifying question about this contract," Deb said. Catra braced herself. "Sweetheart, I am as big of a romantic as they come. Lordy, I've been in love with my Mason-James since I saw him walk into Bear Necessities when I was waitressing. But I've got to ask... if things don't work out with you and Adora, well, where's that leave this arrangement? A woman like me has to be prepared for all these scenarios."

Catra was not expecting her to ask about this. Even at her team's urging, she hadn't included any language that implied a possibility that her relationship might dissolve before this deal was complete. The idea hurt too much to contemplate, and she didn't feel like giving it room to breathe in her mind.

And so, she put on her poker face and used her best business voice as she answered vaguely, "A situation like that wouldn't impact the terms. Everything would proceed as planned."

"You've got a heart of gold, sweetie. I sure hope it does work out. You two deserve each other."

Catra felt more suspicious than complimented. "Is there anything else you need, Mrs. Cunningham, or are we done here?"

"No, mam, thank you. I'd sure love to shake your hand over this deal, but I'm getting the feeling y'all *are not* in the mood for a pop-in from little old me. I'll get everything all notarized and sent back to this Ms. Mermista as quick as a cricket. Y'all enjoy the rest of your visit!"

"Thanks," Catra said and hung up the phone. She handed it back over to Helen. "I think it's done."

They all let out the collective breath they'd been holding and settled back into relaxing in the sunshine.

-Forced Vacation Day 16 of 19-

After a day of packing in every last place Adora wanted to share with her, Catra was surprised when Adora grabbed for the truck keys after Helen went to bed.

"You are not dragging me out to some country bar when we're leaving in the morning," Catra said in protest as Adora gestured at her to get up and follow her out.

"I'm not, *promise* ," Adora whispered. "You'll like it."

"Fine," Catra said with a yawn and allowed herself to be dragged out to the truck. Adora climbed into the driver's seat, and instead of heading out onto the road, she slowly began to direct it out into the fields around her mother's small home.

"Adora, why do I feel like you're taking me out to bury my body," Catra asked with a raised eyebrow as they bumped along towards the edge of the property.

Adora gave a menacing laugh that did little to convince Catra of her safety. Finally, she put the car into park and cut the power. "We're here," she declared in a happy whisper and hopped out of the truck again.

Catra followed suit, still no more sure of what 'here' was.

"Ta-da," Adora declared as she lowered the tailgate and revealed her surprise. She'd laid out a couple of blankets and pillows she'd stolen from their bed. When? Catra had no idea. She hadn't seen her sneak out. "I thought we'd stargaze... and, you know." She gave a smug smile. "This is technically the furthest out you can go and still be on my mom's property, so it's uh... *private* . No neighbors over here."

"Oh my god," Catra said with a laugh. "It's one more night, Adora."

Adora's shoulders dropped, and she looked a bit embarrassed. "I know, I'm just... I can wait. You're right; I can wait." She tried to cover up her embarrassment with a smile, "It'll still be nice to look at the stars, right? It's a beautiful night. You can't see them like this in the city."

"Mmmhm," Catra hummed as she climbed up into the back of the truck. "Shame I'm not going to be seeing them." Adora looked up at her, her lips parting in confusion and hope. "Now, get in here and lay down for me. We'll see if you're still thinking about the stars when I'm done."

"Yes, boss," Adora said enthusiastically and followed her orders.

-Forced Vacation Day 17 of 19-

After an excellent night of *stargazing* , they had snuck back into the house quietly at almost two am to hurriedly toss everything back on the bed and collapse into sleep. Adora slept better than she had since they arrived. It was a good thing, too, because her alarm was set at an unforgiving hour. Still, she rolled out of bed with a pep in her step.

"Where are you going," Catra asked groggily.

"Taking a shower," Adora whispered and leaned back down to kiss her forehead. "You go back to sleep. I'll wake you up when it's your turn." Catra mumbled something and snuggled back down under the covers. Adora figured she had earned an extra twenty minutes of sleep.

After they were both showered, fed, and packed up came the worst part of any visit back home---saying goodbye. When they'd loaded the last bag into the truck, Adora stood staring at her mom, wondering who would cry first.

"Thank you for everything," Catra said, breaking the silence. She reached out for a hug that Helen returned with a tight squeeze.

"Of course, honey," Helen replied, "I'm just so glad I got to meet you. I couldn't have picked a better person for my goose."

As they parted, both had started to tear up, which, of course, made Adora start crying. "I love you," Adora squeaked out as she wrapped her mom up in a hug, squeezing her so tight she lifted her off the ground. "I miss you already."

"I love you too," Helen said sweetly. "Catra and I were chatting earlier. I think it's time to plan my first flight so I can come to see you two! Check out this city life you're always telling me about."

"What, really," Adora asked, choking on more tears. They both nodded, and everyone shared one last group hug.

The long, winding country roads back to the airport were traveled with a comfortable silence. Catra was focused on handling the ridiculous curves while Adora stared out the window, fondly taking in the sights of what' home' used to be. Increasingly, the definition of home was evolving in her heart, becoming less of a 'place' and something much more.

Just before they were boarding the flight back to Bright Moon, Catra's phone pinged.

Glimmer: ALERT.

Glimmer: TAKE ADORA'S PHONE.

Bow: THIS IS NOT A DRILL. [alarm emoji]

She furrowed her brow, wondering what the hell this could mean. All the same, she trusted the 'squad' and their judgment. As soon as they were escorted to their seats in first class, she reached for Adora's phone.

"Hey, I was going to play my game," Adora whined.

Catra's brain ran through various reasonable responses as to why she needed her phone. Unfortunately, she landed on, "I got a text from Entrapta. She said we have to turn off our phones and turn them into her, something about a hack."

"What," Adora asked, wide-eyed. "Is this because of My Horse game?! I knew I learned about it from an Instagram ad, but I read the reviews. It sounded legit!"

"No, I'm sure that's not it," Catra tried to assuage her guilt while she made a show of turning off both their phones. "Probably something network-wide. Just taking precautions, you know."

"Mmhm, can't let all these sensitive texts out," Adora said with a smirk. "I'd hate for the world to see my big sexy--"

And, on cue, the *same* flight attendant from last time was there to look distressingly down at them.

"GOATS, sir, it was a joke," Adora pleaded as if that made any sense, even if it was the truth. "I send her goat memes!"

"That's it. I can never fly on this airline again," Catra said as she buried her face in her hands.

When they landed in Bright Moon, they were surprised by reporters and photographers waiting for them. Thankfully, there were so many, and the airport was so busy that Catra couldn't make out any specific questions. It was simply a cacophony of noise. Adora had pulled down her trucker horse hat like a seasoned pro, squeezed Catra's hand for dear life, and pretended to be very taken by the airport tile as they were hustled through by security.

As luck would have it, the majority of the press was convinced that they'd be getting into a limousine that was here for someone. Thus, they laid in wait at exactly the wrong spot as Catra and Adora slipped away and into the backseat of Glimmer's purple sedan.

"Welcome back," Bow cheered from the front seat.

"Thanks," Catra said, then glanced back to see the hoard of press realizing their mistake. "I think we need to get out of here."

"On it," Glimmer gave a thumbs-up before revving her engine.

"Make it quick," Adora said as someone neared her window. She kept making weird gestures with her hands, and Adora had just shrugged back before Glimmer peeled off out of the airport. This was by far the most intense reporters had been since the start of their relationship.

No one was aggressively following them after all. Thus the squad could relax and catch each other up on their time apart. Adora didn't bring up her aunt, so Catra *definitely* wasn't going to. Perhaps Deb had sold her story to a reporter, and that had conjured all of the press madness. It certainly didn't seem

beyond her to do such a thing. Maybe Catra should've gone with the NDA her team was trying to talk her into, but she didn't want to give Adora the impression---

Catra's brain clicked back into focus on Adora as she said, "Maybe we should stop by my place first? I need to make sure my landlord hasn't kicked me out for not being home for weeks!"

"I don't think that's a good idea," Catra said quickly.

"Yeah, your landlord is a jerk. He'll probably kick you out if all these press people show up," Glimmer added. "Remember when he had my car towed from a visitor's spot! I WAS VISITING. That's what it's for."

"Plus, I know Melog really wants to see you guys," Bow said.

"Melog! You're right. I miss him so much," Adora said with a frown.

When they finally pulled up to Catra's building, they once again found themselves in a bubble of press. Thankfully, the property's security wrangled them out of the private drive and they were simply set up on the sidewalk.

"Listen, I don't know about you, but I am really, really tired," Catra said as she took Adora's hand. "I can't play nice with these people right now. I just want to be home."

"Same, sooo, we run," Adora asked with a mischievous grin.

"Exactly. *If* you can keep up."

"We'll drop your luggage off at the front desk," Bow said with a thumbs up. "AND--- cause a distraction!" He hopped out of the car and approached the press, "Excuse me. My name is Bow, and I represent the Best Friend Squad. I have a very important message about Catradora. STAY TUNED -- and LISTEN UP-- YOU ARE NOT GOING TO WANT TO MISS THIS EXCLUSIVE---"

He kept going on, saying nothing in particular, but all eyes, ears, and cameras were on him. While they had a chance, Catra flew open her door and the two of them sprinted all the way into the building like it was a race. They doubled over laughing and catching their breaths in the atrium.

"We did it," Adora cheered and stuck her tongue as she looked back through the glass.

"Ms. Catra, Ms. Adora, welcome home," a woman at the front desk said enthusiastically.

"Thank you," Catra waved.

Once they were in the safety of the elevator, Catra should've been able to relax. But.. instead, her heart was racing a thousand beats a minute as the floors flew by on the way up to the penthouse. Adora was going on about something -- she couldn't quite focus on it. She smiled and nodded when it seemed appropriate. Meanwhile, her mind was rehearsing her upcoming speech with the same fervor as her first pitches for Darla.

"What?! Really," Adora asked in horror at her most recent nod, "I was only joking."

"Sorry, what were you asking? That sprint took it out of me, too much sitting around today," she lied.

"Do you think Melog forgot me," Adora asked very seriously..

Catra rolled her eyes and laughed, "Give our boy more credit than that. It's not like we've been gone years."

"Yeah, you're right," Adora said. She got a childish grin as she declared triumphantly, "Dibs on the first hug!"

Catra frowned. There was nothing like that first hug. "Fine, I know there's no fighting the ancient rules of dibs."

"I'm just too fast for you," Adora said smugly.

Then, the elevator door opened and they stood at the foyer of the penthouse. Adora's eyes first flinted around trying to find Melog, but then she stopped dead in her tracks. It reminded Catra of when she'd first brought Adora home. She stood, mouth agape and looking up at the grand walls where, along with Catra's art pieces, were some new curious new items -- a couple of the swords Adora had collected over the years, displayed with some new art that featured their DND characters, a painting 'done' by a pig at a rescue she donated to.

Melog had come to greet them and Adora pulled him up into her arms, "Melog, do you know what's going on," she whispered to him and kissed the top of his fluffy head.

Catra chuckled and reached over to scratch behind one of his ears, "He's not sure himself. Been a lot of changes while we were gone." She led them in further and Adora's eyes went to what had been her simple, four-chair dining table. Its replacement was larger, more welcoming, and less sterile. Around it now were eight chairs, four of the mismatched ones from Adora's apartment and the four originals. Everything was cleaned up and made to look brand new.

Before Adora had a chance to question or protest, Catra moved them along again to a space that was brand new. Another part of the open floorplan had been closed in to create a small reading nook near the office. The back wall was covered with a custom-built bookshelf that held not only a selection of their favorite books but also trinkets from Adora's home and memories of their relationship. It was built around Adora's sky blue vintage couch which had been restored to its original glory. The smile on her face as she approached and ran her fingers lovingly over the couch's fabric made this whole ridiculous effort worth it.

"Alright, really, Catra, what's going on," Adora said as she sat down. "I think I know, but..."

"You hate being wrong," Catra finished for her with a smirk. *Here goes nothing* . "I've been thinking about this since I started this 'vacation,' and it just makes sense. I can stand up here and give you the business pitch. It fiscally makes the most sense. There's no reason for you to pay rent somewhere you aren't going to be most nights. You're closer to school here. You can quit your job, and focus your time and energy on what *you* want, Adora. Not some jerks yelling at you for a no-foam cappuccino."

"That does sound nice, but Catra," Adora frowned. "I don't want you to think you have to take care of me."

"I know." Catra said as she moved closer, reaching out to take Adora's hands into hers, "None of that is the *real* reason you should move in. I want you to live here because I don't want to wake up without you. I want to listen to you sing terrible parody songs about Melog while we cook dinner. I want to be excited about leaving work because it means coming home to you and laughing about the dumbest shit. It's very selfish of me, really. I know this has all been a whirlwind, but I love you and I **know** you want this as badly as I do."

"I do," Adora said softly, "But..."

But?

As Adora struggled to find the words, Catra began to panic and all her confidence faded. This was a terrible idea, she found herself thinking suddenly. Why oh why did she have to go and ruin a good thing?

Catra remembered that she had one card left to play. Maybe it would help Adora feel safer? Show her she was serious about wanting to make her happy. Catra reached into her jacket pocket and pulled out a check she'd written before they left. "I know, you might be scared about things not working out. I would never want you to feel stuck or whatever so... think of this as a failsafe. You can use it to leave or if you need space or whatever you need if I fuck up."

Adora accepted the check, but without even reading it, she tore it into pieces and tossed it over her shoulder. "If either of us needs space or fucks up, how about we talk about it instead? It's *much* cheaper." A smile brightened on her face, all the worries seeming to wash away.

"I like that plan," Catra said. When Adora was staring back at her wantingly, she realized... she hadn't directly asked. "Adora, please, will you move in with me?"

She was met with one of those smug smiles. "It looks like I already did," she said with a chuckle, "And... yes, I'd love to. I strongly believe that our son needs a two mother home for his development."

Catra laughed before pulling her into a deep kiss. "Thank you."

"What if I said no," Adora asked with a curious grin.

Chapter End Notes

Special thanks this chapter to WildAngeline for being my puzzle master, RedRaptor for letting me borrow their Caspian for horse inspo (and warning me about the format), RamenFever for drawing the world's cutest goose Adora, and everyone who has participated in my polls/random brainstorming questions.

It has been a whole year since I started Untitled Rich Catra Story! Whether you've been here since day one or just picked it up, thanks for reading! There's still plenty to come for these two.

Excited next chapter to get into Adora’s perspective on this whole situation (b/c really, what was Catra going to do if she said no?), new challenges that might arise, Catra’s big return to Darla, and more.

Rags

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora live together now, and apparently that's a news story...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

What if I said no?

Fuck.

It wasn't that Catra had ignored the possibility that Adora *could* say no. The thing was -- she had planned for every reason that she might say no and mitigated it. This was her specialty-- anticipating and solving problems **before** they happened. It helped her run her company -- why not her romantic life? And Adora *hadn't* said no, so it was a successful plan, right? (Right?)

Thus, Catra put on her best smirk and shrugged as she offered, "I'd spend all day moving your stuff back."

Adora laughed, which was a relief. "Yikes. That would be a cruel punishment for trying to be romantic." *Trying?* "Wait." Her face dropped. "Is this why the press is following us today? Did you ask DT to run a story or something?"

"What, no. I wouldn't do that without asking you first." She reached into her jacket pocket and pulled out their phones. "Maybe someone called in a tip? I haven't read anything yet. Sparkles warned me to take your phone on the plane."

"I wonder if I'm the last person in the world to know we moved in together." Adora's demeanor still seemed playful, but when her phone loaded, her eyes went wide. "I've got like a thousand notifications! This is crazier than after our first interview."

Catra didn't have time to investigate because as soon as her phone caught a signal, it was ringing. "Shit," she mumbled. "It's DT. Mind if I take this?"

"Sure." Adora slipped off her shoes and laid back on her couch, resting her head on a horse pillow. "I've got plenty to keep me entertained."

Catra hurried out as she answered the phone. "Hey. Sorry–"

"KITTEN," DT practically yelled on the other end. "What about 'CEO moves her barista girlfriend into her penthouse' says I don't need to consult my fantastic PR person about this?"

Great, she was getting scolded right off the bat. "I wanted to make it official with Adora, see what she wanted to do. I didn't think we'd get fucking scooped or whatever," she grumbled as she sat down at the dining room table. Her head felt dizzy as her mind jumped from one anxious thought to the next. So much for three weeks of relaxation...

There was the sound of a heavy sigh. "You *really* didn't think someone would notice her stuff being moved? I bet somebody in that apartment complex of hers called it in for a few bucks. Probably the landlord!"

"Sometimes I forget I don't get to live my life without it being the media's goddamn business."

"Aww. I'm sorry *I* forgot how hard it must be to be rich and famous," DT teased. "Alexa, play the world's saddest song."

"You're such an ass." Though, it was true. She needed to get her shit together and stop whining. "Fine. Just tell me what you need me to do. I don't see why it's such a big deal anyway. The people love Catradora. That's what you're always saying. They should be happy."

"Oh, honey. You haven't read anything yet, have you?"

The Etherian Chronicler

Your daily dose of truth

Why Buy the Barista When You Can Get the Coffee For Free

Tiffany Ingram @TiffanyTruth

Rumors swirled like the whipped cream on a frappucino this week around the personal life of Catra, CEO of Darla Industries. What's that, dear reader? You don't know who Catra is? Have you been living under a rock in the Crimson Waste? Let me put it this way – a little birdie told me that within a month, at twenty-two years old, she will be the youngest self-made **billionaire** in the world. *How's that for a girl boss?*

Now that you know who we are dealing with– the tea at hand starts with our forever single CEO shopping for more than just her daily brew at Starbucks. She and her "favorite barista," Adora, went public with their relationship in the wake of the Valtra Scandal (click to read more). Many were shocked that the multi-millionaire would be interested in dating a college student whose weekly income is what Catra makes in the time it takes her to fix her tie.

In the month since, Barista Adora has become a social media darling. The previously guarded life of the mysterious 'Cashtra' has been displayed through the eyes of the *adorable* blonde. Where before we were only treated to seeing her looking handsome in a suit (which this writer still appreciates!), now we know what her day-to-day life looks like. We see it all – whether it's Catra doing a crossword (bedhead or sex hair? You be the judge [link to Twitter image]), playing in an arcade, snuggling with her cat, or staring back at Adora with hearts in her eyes over dinner.

This week has been no exception as these two jetted across the country to Adora's humble hometown. But… I'm not here to bore you with the details of cowgirls and horses. The meat of the drama is what was happening back here while they were away. An eagle-eyed, anonymous source provided The Etherian Chronicler with photos indicating that Adora has been moved out of her one-bedroom 650-square-foot apartment. And, where do we suppose she was going? This reporter decided to get on the scene and scope it out for herself. While the staff at the URCS

Building was none-too-pleased to have me poking around, I snapped a photo of one BLUE COUCH being loaded into the freight elevator that you'll find *very similar* to the one we see in the provided witness photos.

The real question is… what does the timing of this all mean? We aren't in the middle of the holiday season. No reason to be taking that long plane ride out to the middle of nowhere to meet the family… *unless* ? Did Catra ask Adora's mom, Helen, permission to ask her daughter the BIG question? Photos uploaded by @IAdoraCatra show the two of them quite cozy. (*I know my parents would be more than happy to say 'yes' to someone like her putting a ring on this finger!)*

Given that we've never seen a soul from Catra's family, we have to wonder… is anyone looking out for Catra's interests? After the silencing of Times reporter Kyle, we know she does not shy away from using her powerful legal team to protect her name. But… with her youthful heart and starry eyes… will she be able to see the need to draw up a prenup?

Even though you know me as the world's biggest romantic, I must posit that perhaps the young CEO has already solved this problem. Maybe instead of joining their lives, she's merging their households. No engagement means no prenup and **no problems** . She can wake up in those gorgeous arms without a care. I spoke with our financial staff here at the paper, and they agree. This would be the easiest way for Catra to protect herself from the potential fallout of Catradora while getting everything she wants. And no one's ever accused the brilliant CEO of being foolish…

Let me know in the comments below if you think it's Cautious Cohabitation or Wedding Bells Celebration for Catradora!

By the time Adora finished reading the article that had been tweeted at her about five million times, she was no longer lying back on the couch. Instead, she was sitting straight up as a knot started to form in her stomach.

"Cautious cohabitation, seriously," she read aloud as her eyes flitted back over it again. She felt herself getting more and more annoyed. Her logical side reminded her that this was the price of admission Catra had warned her about. Adora needed to rise above all of the drama. It wasn't even worth her time…

Call it pride or morbid curiosity; she scrolled down to check the comments despite knowing better. Although there were plenty of their 'fans' opposing the author's take, she was stuck on one exchange:

salineas-socialite: No way is this all about prenups! Cashtra doesn't care about money, or she'd flaunt it more. This is about moving Adora into high society so Catra doesn't look bad. Think about it -- Someone of Catra's wealth and status having a partner living in a home the size of her walk-in closet and working for minimum wage... yikes!!

Replying to @salineas-socialite: **TiffanyTruth** : [tea emoji] [frog emoji] Oooh. Interesting take! I guess it's only rags to riches if you actually leave the rags behind, right? [laughing face emoji]

replying to @salineas-socialite, @TiffanyTruth: **valtrabeliever** : it's only a matter of time before this all falls apart. Catra can play dress-up and house all she wants with Barista Barbie, but she's never

going to be on her level! [side eyes emoji] hopefully, when she comes to her senses, her actual twin flame will take her back [red hair woman emoji].

Adora should've cooled down by the time it took her to accept the proper cookies, put in her email address, verify her email address, and all that... but...

Replying to @valtrabeliever, **@Catradora4EVER** : WOW. you must be more delusional than your HERO Valerie if you think for ONE SECOND that Catra would ever end up with her. Say whatever you want about Adora, who SEEMS LIKE A VERY NICE AND HARDWORKING PERSON, but Valtra is NEVER happening.

"Ha, take that," she said as she hit send. The smug smile on her face faded as her initial rage turned to... worry. ValtraBeliever was the second biggest dumb face on the planet, but... the other comments and the article? Maybe there were some sprinkles of truth in those. Catra had orchestrated all of this so that it was like she *couldn't* say no, even if she had wanted to. She was dragged right out of the rags, but... was it because Catra was ashamed of her? Pitied her?

These thoughts began to take root in her mind as she continued looking into what the world had to say. Plenty of it was complimentary- the whirlwind romance, true love, being 'couple goals,' all that. But... it was the bad stuff that really stood out.

She glanced up from her 'research' to see Catra walking into her office beside Adora's new reading nook. The clear walls let Adora watch the show as Catra swung her free hand wildly, phone firmly pressed to her ear with the other. She plopped down in her desk chair and started her computer, raking a hand through her messy hair. If Adora were to venture a guess, Catra's talk with DT was not going well.

As if sensing her stare, Catra looked over at her through the glass. "I'm sorry," she mouthed. Adora gave a sympathetic nod in return. Catra began furiously typing something.

Ding, Ding, BUZZ, DING. Adora's phone was still going off like she was at a command center. She decided it was for her own good to log out of Twitter. No doubt DT would be putting them both on social media lockdown anyway. Might as well get ahead of it. When she went to do the same to her email, she noticed that she already had replies sent from the Etherian Chronicler article.

@Catradora4EVER, - **@valeriethequeen** : [laughing crying emoji] the delusion is all yours!! We have the receipts! Valtra is going to come back stronger than ever.

@Catradora4EVER, @valeriethequeen - **@valtrabeliever** : tell 'em, bestie! We'll be drinking those Catradora tears [smug smile emoji], and who will be there to say I told you so to our heartbroken CEO lovingly?

@Catradora4EVER, @valeriethequeen, @valtrabeliever - **@catrathegoat** : no one cares about this stupid shipping shit, omg. go touch some fucking grass. catra can do whatever she wants, as is her right as the boss ass bitch she is [content face emoji].

Maybe she should go touch grass... or punch grass... does that count?

"You aren't even a little curious about the narrative? This article has been trending with your name all day," DT prodded after she declined to hear a dramatic reading of the said article.

"I don't care what the Chronicler of all places has to say. They once published an editorial from someone who claimed to be a **clone** from *OUTER SPACE* ." She was typing while she talked, trying to get down something in the way of a statement. DT was adamant that they needed to put out the fires now before they derailed the press around the shareholders' meeting. "Plus, I just gave an exclusive, hyped-up interview about how I don't give a fuck what these people think of me."

"Mmhm, but, counterpoint --- do you give any fucks about what they think of Adora?"

Of course, she did. She gave endless fucks about that, if only because she wanted to protect her. It was all Catra's fault that Adora was dragged into the limelight in the first place. She glanced through the glass again and saw that Adora had put down her phone and was playing with Melog.

She sighed. "That's the only reason I'm going to dignify this bullshit with a fucking response."

"I hope your response is slightly less sweary, or I might need to fluff it up."

Catra chuckled at that. "I've managed to restrain myself." She made a few more edits and sent it along. "Okay. Does that work?"

Representatives for Ms. Catra and Ms. Adora confirm that the two reside together in the URCS Building. This statement is being issued in good faith that it will stop the press from violating their privacy and place attention back on more important matters. Any future pieces written without their express permission will not be acknowledged.

DT hummed to themself as they read. "Not your most moving work, but I suppose it will do. I take it that there is no other news in Catradora to announce, hmm? Don't want to get scooped on an engagement; I can't handle the shame."

Catra was happy they were not video chatting, or DT would've seen how she froze. She managed a scoff. "We've been dating for like a month and a half."

"And you've moved her in," DT countered immediately. "You're telling me you haven't already looked at rings, planned some grand gesture, and dreamed up a fabulous suit?"

Okay, maybe all that was true. "Believe whatever you want to believe." She heard a barely contained laugh on the other end. "Anyway...give me a minute to check with Adora about the statement before you share it. I'll text you."

"Oooh, bring me to her; I want to say hi and congratulate her for moving up in the world."

"Absolutely not." Catra ended the call abruptly and turned to see Adora helping Melog 'climb' the wall of her office.

"Take a picture; I want to see his beans." The thick glass muffled Adora's demand.

Catra rolled her eyes, but there was no hiding the silly grin on her face. She quickly found the right angle to make it look like Melog was one of those clinger toys you can put on a window.

Once satisfied with her work, she placed the face of her phone on the glass to show Adora, who began laughing immediately. "It's perfect!"

Catra beckoned her inside with a curled finger. Adora gave a cheeky grin before she placed Melog back on the ground. When she entered the office, she leaned against the door frame, "You wanted to see me, boss?"

"You're in a better mood than I expected," Catra said with a chuckle. "Maybe DT's blowing all of this out of proportion. The way they talked, I thought all of the Internet was slandering us."

"Maybe I cope with stress by being a goofball. Gotta be better than violence, and I *really* want to punch someone right now... maybe one of those reporters downstairs."

"As much as I'd like to see it, I think that would end badly for both of us. Buuuut... look over this statement with me, and then you can let it out on the punching bag?" Adora looked pleased with this idea and let herself be gently pulled into Catra's lap. "I wanted to throw in a 'fuck you' somewhere, but then I remembered we have the shareholders meeting this week."

As Adora read the short paragraph, Catra absentmindedly rocked them back and forth. "It's good, but I wish we could include one fuck you to Tiffany Truth specifically."

"Pfft, trust me, the Chronicler gets plenty without us. Stupidest excuse for 'journalism' in the whole country. I told DT I'm not even going to read anything. I can't let them get in my head again."

"Probably for the best," Adora sighed. "I wish I hadn't."

Catra reached up to run her fingers through Adora's long hair, pausing to massage her scalp. "Are you okay? We can talk about it."

"I'm fine," Adora hummed happily and leaned into her touch. "Anyway, it doesn't matter what they say about us. I love you; you love me. That's all that matters."

"That's all that matters," Catra repeated with a small smile.

"Come on." Adora hopped up from her lap and reached for Catra's hand. "Let's go punch our feelings out. Then maybe we can go on a scavenger hunt for my stuff."

When Catra told her that she wouldn't read any of the gossip this time, it was clear what Adora's mission needed to be: bottle up all of her feelings, act normal, and, most importantly, protect Catra from it. Anything less would ruin the last day of her vacation and maybe even the Shareholders' Meeting thing this week. She still wasn't *exactly* sure what happened at one, but it was always mentioned with such gravitas she knew Catra didn't need any distractions. Adora needed to stay busy and ignore her anxious, nagging thoughts. All of those commenters were wrong anyway. (Right?)

Thankfully, there were plenty of things to keep her busy. Catra wanted a trim before returning to work, which became a whole spa day for them. Sure, they'd had cameras in their faces the second they left, but at least Adora *looked* one hundred percent refreshed and relaxed, even if she wasn't all the way there.

She wondered if any of the pictures would be zoom-ins on her ringless finger... *'Cautious Cohabitation it is!'* TiffanyTwat would be tweeting soon with the pic... then the quote retweets... Valerie would have something to say, no doubt. Fucking Val-

"Hey, Adora," Catra waved a hand in front of her face. "You in there?"

"What, sorry," she chuckled, her cheeks getting even pinker. "My brain's all blissed out."

"Uh-huh." She narrowed her eyes at Adora but didn't call her bluff. "I asked what to do about dinner, considering we're being followed. I don't want to bring all this bullshit to Joshua's."

"Ugh," Adora groaned, glancing into the side view mirror. "Maybe we should go home. Between our combined kitchens, we can make something that resembles dinner."

"About that," Catra gave an awkward smile as they paused at a stop sign. "All of your food is still at your old place. I didn't know what you'd want to keep, so I told them to leave it for later."

"Oh." *Complications of not being involved in your own move.* "It's fine; I'll go by after class tomorrow. I need to turn in my keys anyway."

Adora stood in the walk-in closet, having a staring contest with her half of the wardrobe. Perhaps if she won, it would reveal where it was hiding her pajamas. The night before, neither felt like putting clothes on after christening their bed. Now, though, she wanted her pajamas and, by god, she would find them. She became increasingly agitated as she pulled out drawer after drawer of meticulously folded clothes with no pjs in sight. (And, oh god, who put all her underwear into this organizer?! *Please be Glimmer...*)

She shouldn't wish that this beautiful, custom mahogany dresser was instead her old, repainted particle board one. But... in **her** dresser, the pajamas were in the third of the four drawers. Why? Because the left side of that one was always coming off, exposing a row of nails. Logically, only the pjs could be placed in such a risky situation.

Finally, in the ninth drawer, she found some. She grabbed the first oversized shirt she saw, quickly changed into it, and made a mental note of where to find them again (center right). Maybe while Catra was back at work, she'd make a cheat sheet...

When she finally climbed into bed, Catra could barely open her eyes. "Thought you got abducted," she said with a yawn and pulled Adora closer.

"And you weren't going to try to save me," Adora teased.

"Mmmm, I woulda, but I took my sleepy medicine." She nuzzled her head into Adora's chest. "Was gonna invent a new spaceship in the mornin'."

"My hero," Adora kissed the top of her head. All the anxiety started to simmer back down under the surface for now. "You're so cute when you're half-asleep."

"I am **not** cute," she protested in a very cute bratty voice. "Imma titan."

Adora couldn't help but giggle at the declaration. "Titan of cuteness, yes, I agree."

Catra made a dissenting "bah" as she wiggled, pulling herself further on top of Adora. "Night. Gonna miss you," she mumbled, squeezing her tighter.

"I'll be here when you wake up, promise." Waking up in her old bed without Catra? That was something she couldn't dredge up an ounce of nostalgia and longing for.

But also, where were her pillows because she liked that memory foam pillow; it didn't mess up her hair poof during naps and...

Amid announcing plans to expand Darla Industries into the multiverse, Catra was flung back into the material plane by her alarm. Oh well. This was as good a reality as any dream. Given that she'd set her alarm two hours earlier than necessary, she decided to enjoy it a little longer. As she snuggled closer to Adora, she pondered how lucky she was to wake up with her beautiful girlfriend… the love of her life… the woman who snorted and giggled before rolling over and unceremoniously expelling Catra from her arms. Well, it was as good a time as any to get up.

Catra went about her morning routine with the giddiness of a child preparing for their birthday party. Did she enjoy this newfound concept of 'vacation'? Of course! But.. . now? It was time to get back to business and do the work she **loved**. Thus she selected her suit for the day with extra care—holding a few options for herself, pondering the vibe she wanted to give her employees. She landed on a classic, beautifully tailored black suit that she hoped evoked the sentiment *The Boss is Back.*

After getting ready, she slipped back into the bedroom and leaned over Adora to kiss her forehead. Expecting only to receive a snort back, she was surprised when she was met with blue eyes.

Adora leaned up and captured her in a kiss. "Good luck today, boss," she said coyly before plopping back down on her pillow.

"Thanks. I'd say you need it more than me, but you're one of those weirdos who *likes* school."

"Cause I'm *really* good at it." Adora gave the smuggest smile a person can manage while half-asleep. Only-- it faded quickly, replaced with a grimace.

"What's wrong? Remember some research paper you haven't started?"

"I wish. I have to quit Starbucks today. I'm supposed to work at eleven," she groaned. "I've never quit anything before."

"Why doesn't that surprise me," Catra chuckled, sitting on the edge of the bed. "I vote you don't go. Your manager will put two and two together eventually."

"But if I don't tell him before, he won't be able to find coverage. Then they'll be short-staffed for running lunches and breaks and getting all the tasks done and –"

"And he'll learn the consequences of only scheduling the bare minimum of people they need. Sounds like Starbucks' problem, not yours." Catra reached out for one of Adora's hands and squeezed. "I have my opinions on this but... If you want to stay or work a notice or whatever, do it. Do what **you** want, Adora. Okay?"

Adora took a deep breath and nodded. "Okay." She glanced past Catra. "Uh-oh. The sun's coming up. You better get to work, or you're ***only*** going to be an hour early."

"Wouldn't want to damage my reputation." Catra winked.

Chapter End Notes

At this rate I might as well copy and paste my apologies for long swaths between updates. Sorry, dear readers. Life's been *life*.

I really wanted to get more into this chapter, but my creative spark is running low. Figured a sooner shorter chapter would be better than an even more belated longer one. BUT I hope to get this next part knocked out in a week or two (am I jinxing myself? I shouldn't say these things).

As always, thanks for reading. Hope you enjoyed. Next chapter we'll get Catra back to work, see if she can *really* keep out of the dramaverse, and have a shareholders meeting (note to self: learn what happens at a shareholders' meeting of a giant successful company). On the Adora side of things --- will she actually quit? how's school? what's left back at her old apartment? Did Glimmer roll up her underwear into these neat little pinwheels that fit just perfectly into the underwear organizers? AND IF NOT -- WHO? And will Adora talk to Catra about these little silly very annoying and persistent anxieties?

Oh and I think there's a fancy dinner at a super exclusive, fanciful restaurant next chapter. If I ask you, dear reader, to imagine a real fancy restaurant/meal/etc what do you imagine?

(Special thanks to everyone on Twitter/Discord who answer my odd questions to help me with ideas. ALSO special thanks to the amazing ButterfliesInMyBrain who allowed me to borrow the title from the hysterical The Etherian Chronicler

Perfect

Chapter Summary

Everything is going perfectly in Catra's life. She's back to the job she loves, Darla's shareholders' meeting is sure to be a success, and after everything she gets to come home to the love of her life, Adora.

Adora is straight up not having a good time this chapter.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra didn't have a childhood home she felt tied to, no school she'd like to grace the halls of again, but she knew what she felt in her heart standing in front of the Darla Headquarters was like coming *home*.

She had purposefully planned her arrival two hours before most of the staff was on duty. Thus all was quiet and serene. She was free to curl up in her office chair with a cup of coffee to peruse emails and Lonnie's notes. Some much-needed quiet time after the media circus of the last day. *Perfection.*

"Ms. Catra," Scorpia bellowed the second that Catra entered the building.

Well, hell.

Catra practically jumped out of her skin at the sudden greeting. She reflexively put a hand over her heart, "Morning," she said in more of a squeak than she'd like to admit.

"Oh no, I am so, so sorry," Scorpia panicked and leaned down to inspect her boss. "Didn't mean to spook you. Are you okay? Do you need first aid? Should I call the nurse," she already had her phone out.

"Please, no," Catra said, harsher than she meant. She took a deep breath and gave a forced smile. "I'm fine. You surprised me, that's all."

"What a relief." Scorpia let out a big sigh. "I could **not** forgive myself if I sent you back out of here. I know you're not a hugger, but know I am giving you a giant mental hug right now."

"Thanks," Catra glanced around the atrium to confirm that no one else was there. "Did they change your hours while I was gone?"

"Not exactly," Scorpia waved a hand, "Call it assistant's intuition! I **knew** you would be here early, and if you're working, I'm working! I came in a little before five to be safe. I was not going to let you down on your first day back."

Catra stared up at her in disbelief. "You didn't have to do that."

"It was nothing! I've been dozing in our waiting area; super cozy. My compliments to whoever selects our furniture! Wait," Scorpia began swiping around on her device, "Ah-ha! Emilee in furnishings. Going to make a quick note to send her an appreciation email.... and done! Speaking of notes, I've already prepared your agenda for the day, Ms. Catra. Say the word when you're ready to carpe the heck out of this diem!"

For as mismatched as they often were, Scorpia was an excellent assistant. Catra just needed to have a bit more coffee in her system to truly appreciate it. "Can we walk and talk?"

"I'd love to! Got to get that blood pumping! You'll notice everything is still in tip-top shape. No slacking while the boss is away!"

Catra was half-listening as Scorpia caught her up on what felt like unnecessary details -- so and so's birthday in accounting, a few new hires, her love of the soft serve machine, what toppings were most popular, and the like. The pair was scanning their way into the executive offices when she finally got to Catra's agenda.

"Alright. Here we go. You have an 8AM breakfast and chat with DT."

Catra grimaced at that. Not the way she wanted to start her workday. Before she could protest, Scorpia interrupted, "They wanted me to tell you this is not negotiable."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Of course they did."

Scorpia opened her office door for her and followed her inside. "HR invited you to a meet and greet with new hires at 8:45. Lonnie wants to debrief you at 9. Then you're tied up until noon with a meeting in the war room to discuss the shareholders' meeting with Entrapta and the admin team."

"We have a war room now," Catra asked with a raised eyebrow.

"That's what Entrapta renamed her favorite conference room. She made a nifty sign for it and everything," Scorpia explained like that wasn't odd at all. "I set aside an hour for your lunch at noon, so you have plenty of time to browse social media, text Adora, or whatever your heart desires. At one, you will head to the auditorium for a walkthrough of the set-up and a quick 'dress rehearsal.' Then an interview at 2."

"With who," Catra asked, flabbergasted. She hadn't agreed to any new interviews.

Scorpia shrugged. "Not entirely sure on that one. I tried to find out, but DT said worrying about it was above my pay grade. Maybe that's what the breakfast chat is about? Anywho, you **finally** have a gap in your schedule at three. I penciled in some ideas --- yoga, you know, for your *condition* ," she whispered. "You could write some thank you cards, do some company social media, oooor, and tell me if I'm overstepping here, but I thought it would be fun to hang out together. You know, really catch up. Maybe have a high tea!"

She reflexively scrunched up her face at that. *Damn.* All this time away from being 'on' really fucked up Catra's ability to hide her emotions.

"You're right, that is a silly idea; pfft, you've got more important things to do," Scorpia laughed nervously as her face turned red.

Feeling suddenly like the world's worst boss and friend, Catra took a long drink of coffee and said goodbye to the quiet morning she envisioned. "I'm going to need some recharge time after a schedule

like that, that's all." She gestured at the chair in front of her desk while taking a seat herself. "But apparently, I'm free til eight if you are."

A wide smile spread across Scorpia's face as she happily took a seat. "Tell me all about your time off," she propped herself up on the edge of the desk with her elbows. "I'd love to know more about your trip! Oh, and trivia night, I would *die* for an invite next time. A lot of people don't know this about me, but I am an **expert** on---"

At the penthouse, Adora was grateful that all her school stuff was carefully placed in her' nook.' Could she even survive college without her meticulous, color-coded notes and binders? She didn't want to find out. Not to mention how **done** she was with playing 'hide and seek' with her belongings.

Did she need to come clean with her girlfriend? Yes, obviously, but this was **not** the week to lay that on Catra. She couldn't even talk it out with her best friends because they'd been in on this whole plan, no doubt with every bit of good intention as Catra. The best option was to ignore it for now. Not a problem. Adora was *strong* . Everybody said so.

When she walked into her first class, a few people were loudly chatting in the back of the room. Well, at least they *were* until someone looked up and saw Adora. His eyes went wide, and the others glanced over as well. She worried she split something all over herself, put her shirt on backward, or maybe, like a nightmare, forgot to put on pants. However, looking down to inspect her clothing proved that everything was as it should be.

When she glanced back to the group, they were back to chatting, albeit in more hushed tones. Trying to ignore how fucking weird and rude that was, Adora sat in her usual seat and busied herself reviewing her notes. Even if she didn't mean to, her ears honed in on the conversation, and all she could catch were giggles and occasional syllables. They might have said Catra... Great.

At least the actual class went well. There was a pop quiz, a ruthless move by her professor on the first day after Spring Break. Adora, however, took the quiz with a smile on her face. She finished before everyone and *knew* she had killed it. Take that, laughing jerks, she thought to herself as she left.

Next up in her day was the thing she was looking forward to the least... quitting. Her Starbucks was a quick walk from campus, but she dragged her feet the whole time rehearsing precisely what she was going to say. The idea of quitting via no-call, no-show was looking more and more tempting the closer she got to the store, but her damn sense of responsibility forced her through the doors. Of course, the lobby was jampacked with people waiting.

"Adora," Cody, her manager, said excitedly when he saw her. While the baristas behind the counter were slinging coffee and restocking as fast as they could, he was in the lobby 'straightening up' some displays. He hurried up to her, "Can you clock in early? We are *swamped* this morning."

Adora took a deep breath and steeled herself. She smiled awkwardly before taking her hat and neatly folded aprons out of her bag. "Actually, I wanted to tell you in person that---"

Cody dramatically put his hands together in prayer and frowned, "No, please, Adora, you can't do that to me right now."

"I'm sorry, but I--"

He cut her off again, "Please, just work today, okay, and we'll talk about it. Look at this place," he gestured back to the sea of customers, "We *need* you. You don't want to let our regulars down, do you? Who is going to make Elise's cappuccino for her? You're the *only* one who makes it how she likes it."

Adora's eyes darted between her manager, the people waiting, and her would-be-former coworkers flailing. *She could work another day...*

She was about to resign from resigning when Cody's frowning face snarled into anger. He jabbed a finger in the air at Adora's face. "I saw it coming from Glimmer, but I can't believe YOU would be this SELFISH," he yelled. "First, your hot shot girlfriend comes in here and recruits from MY team, and now you're just going to leave your customers and ME in the lurch?! Not even working out a NOTICE? I thought you were a nice, *humble,* **KIND** person, Adora. Instead, you're a BRAT who thinks she's better than *ME and this job* because she's got---"

Turns out, this was going to be much easier than she thought. She smiled and shoved the stack of apparel into him, "Tell Elise I said hi."

With that, she quickly turned on her heel and walked right out of the store.

"What's the fucking deal with this interview," Catra said as soon as DT entered her office.

"Good morning to you too, kitten," DT said as they took a seat in front of her and tossed their long blonde hair over their shoulder. "It warms my heart to see our intrepid leader right back where she belongs."

Catra rolled her eyes. "You know I don't like things being sprung on me."

"I'd hardly call it springing. We always do press around the shareholders' meeting, and you were supposed to be on *vacation* . I figured you didn't want little old me bothering you for approval."

"And yet you still bugged me about the move-in gossip."

" **That** was a big deal. You can do a fluffy interview with a tech reporter about our company in your sleep. Am I right, or have you lost your touch?" They shrugged and then took a sip of their tea as they waited.

She sighed. "I guess it's fine. As long as personal shit is off the table. I'm **not** dealing with anything about that this week."

"Obviously. That was the agreement. If they try to get salacious, you're done."

One less thing to worry about today. "Thanks."

"So, how are we? Feeling refreshed?"

Catra stretched and leaned back in her chair, "Ready to conquer the world."

"I know precisely how to start," DT reached into their bag and pulled out a stack of papers they plopped in front of her. "We've been gathering questions from the shareholders joining us remotely. I wanted to review them together and decide on a strategy to address them tomorrow. I've grouped them by category of topic and gravity."

Catra started flipping through the pages with a raised eyebrow. "Nothing about Catradora in here, right?"

"No," DT chuckled as they brought out another collection of papers, somehow double that of the first. " *This* is all the beloved fawning, speculation, and scolding over your love life."

"Great, let me file those," Catra took that stack and immediately dropped it in the trashcan beside her desk.

With that, they got to work reviewing everything that was actually relevant. After finishing preening the online questions, DT began roleplaying as a difficult person during the live Q&A. They *never* missed an opportunity to show off their 'acting skills,' and it really did help Catra with calming her gut reactions.

When 8:40 rolled around, she had to run to arrive on time for the meet and greet. The last thing she needed was for Darla's newest employees to think she didn't care about them. She fixed herself and put on a smile as she walked into one of HR's training rooms. Inside was at least one familiar face. Glimmer hopped up from her seat to greet her.

"How's it going, Sparkles? You know, you could've opted out of this. Pretty sure we know plenty about each other."

"I'm ready to meet *Work Catra.* I bet you're super friendly and professional."

"Jokes on you; I'm going to start this meeting by firing everyone." There were some gasps and panicked chatter behind them.

"Ms. Catra," her HR lead whispered.

"Oops, sorry," she scratched behind her head and waved with her other hand. "Hi."

Glimmer quietly laughed her whole way back to her seat. After assuring everyone that she had no intentions of firing them, the rest of the meet and greet went smoothly. Towards the end, someone inquired if everyone would be getting company nicknames like Sparkles, and she decided it was probably time to make a gracious exit.

Lonnie's debrief was short and sweet, and they spent the rest of their scheduled time together in manufacturing before the 'war room' meeting got called to order. It was already a whirlwind of a day, but Catra couldn't wipe the dumb smile off her face. She was *back* , and it felt good.

Adora spent her rideshare to the Darla Headquarters flipping through her Latin flashcards. Magistra Webb had been kind enough to spare them the first-day back quiz, but she had a big test scheduled on Wednesday. Maybe she'd ask Catra to work on grammar when she got home.

Home. That was her next agenda item after finally picking up her car. She was going to head to her apartment, gather what was left, maybe cry a little, and then go back to her new' home.' The one where everything was gorgeous, luxurious, and all she could ever want...

She was deep in her thoughts when the car stopped in front of the security gate. "Mam, I think this is as far as I can take you," the driver explained.

"No problem," Adora said, quickly throwing all her stuff back into her backpack.

Juliet escorted her in something like a high-tech golf cart, chatting about how things were going with the blind date Angella set her up on. Then she paused abruptly in front of an empty parking spot. "Um, my apologies," Juliet stopped and raised an eyebrow. "If I'm not mistaken, this was where your vehicle was, correct?"

Adora tried to think back to that frantic afternoon. She'd rushed there thinking maybe Catra would end up in the hospital or worse, and had taken the closest spot she could find and ran from there. "This seems right?"

"Hmm, it was here the last I checked," Juliet grabbed her walkie-talkie and radioed out to her team. "Did anyone approve a tow of an abandoned vehicle without my knowledge?"

After everyone came back with a negative, she frowned. "You'll need to check in with the main office. Perhaps Catra or someone else had it stored?"

"Seriously?! I can't even find my fucking car," Adora mumbled. Juliet looked shocked, and before she could make things worse for herself, Adora quickly took it back, "I'm so sorry. Just tired! Been a bit of a *day* . You know what? I should walk to the front from here. It's a beautiful day. Thank you for the help." She jumped off of the golf cart and ran without giving Juliet a chance to react.

Adora was still scolding herself when she arrived at the front desk. The person working was someone she'd never seen before. "Hi. I need to talk to someone about finding my car."

"Um," the young woman looked at her like she was an idiot. "We don't do delivery here. I can give you the number for sales--"

"That's not what I mean. My car was parked here, and now it's not, and I don't know where it is and--"

"OH! I see, let me get you in touch with our security," she picked up the phone and started dialing.

"Juliet already knows," Adora cut her off. "Can you just call Catra for me?"

"Mam, I can't just *call* Ms. Catra. She's very busy, and I'm sure she has no idea what happened to your vehicle."

Adora sighed and walked away to try her cell phone. It went straight to voicemail. "Why," Adora whined. All she wanted to do was get her stupid car to pick up the last of her stupid stuff from her stupid apartment... she was on the verge of tears while the receptionist watched on in confusion.

"Um, mam? Is there anything else I can do for you," the young woman asked cautiously.

"Adora," a familiar voice called out. "Afraid the boss is in the 'war room' if you're here to visit. Should be free in about an hour."

Adora turned to look upon her savior in coveralls. "Lonnie, thank god," she ran up to the other woman, wrapping her in a hug. "I can't find my car. Do you know where it was moved to?"

Lonnie, startled by the sudden hug, broke away and looked embarrassed. "That's on me. I forgot to put it back," she gestured toward the nearest elevator. "It's downstairs; come on."

Adora became worried when she realized they were going down to the manufacturing and engineering level. "You didn't put it in a crash test or something, did you?" Adora asked as they descended. "That would be my luck." She gave a pained laugh, and a tear broke free that she quickly wiped away before Lonnie saw.

Lonnie feigned being hurt, "Damn, what's Catra been telling you about me?"

"No, no, it's not you," Adora started panicking. How many people at Darla was she going to look unhinged to today? "I just *need* my car, Lonnie. Sure, it doesn't always run right, and sometimes it makes this sound like it's growling at me--"

Ding .

The elevator gave Lonnie a chance to interrupt Adora's breakdown. "Only moved it down here because I noticed your oil was leaking." Lonnie held the elevator door for Adora to walk out first. "Figured I'd fix that up before you stalled out on the way home."

"Oh," Adora said softly. "That's all?"

"Well, I also added some power steering fluid. Should take care of the growling."

They turned some corners, and in one of the bays was Adora's car, as beautifully awful as she had left it. It looked particularly amusing flanked by various Darla vehicles.

"Feel better now," Lonnie asked.

"Yeah," Adora said as she placed a hand on the hood. "Thanks for taking care of it."

"No problem. I put some notes in your glovebox about other things you should get fixed soon. Bring it back by when you're ready."

When Adora drove away in her car, it felt like a victory. Over what, she wasn't exactly sure, but she really needed it.

"And then, the grand FINALE," Entrapta announced from the stage. "Hit it, Emily!"

On cue, her assistant robot pressed a button on the podium, and the room exploded with music. The two were joined by her newest creation, the EKS, an upgraded version of Emily. The EKS came out doing something like a dance along to the music, much to Entrapta's amusement. The two robots joined together center stage, continuing to dance.

"Wait for it," Entrapta stage-whispered to Catra, sitting a few rows back as her one-woman audience.

Emily opened up a box on stage and held it out for EKS, who reached in and took out a small item. It then turned and appeared to scan the audience.

"Now, hold up your hand," Entrapta ordered.

Catra did as instructed, and as soon as the EKS saw her, it tossed the item precisely to her. It turned out to be a tiny plush version of Emily.

"ISN'T SHE INCREDIBLE," Entrapta said gleefully.

"You're incredible," Catra said in awe as she held up the doll. "You really think she can do that tomorrow even if this place is packed?"

Entrapta patted the back of EKS, "I've done some trial runs with volunteers and made adjustments as needed. Everything should go to plan!"

"And if she knocks someone out, we say we're training them for combat," DT said from the left of the stage.

Catra sighed. "Absolutely not."

Thoroughly rehearsed and prepped, there was nothing left to do but rest. *Everyone* kept reminding Catra of this. They assured her they were even more prepared than usual and that there was nothing to be stressed about. She wondered if they'd ever let the whole stupid fainting thing go. Probably not, she figured, but maybe it wasn't a bad thing. Thus, she heeded their warnings and left work *on time* .

When she arrived home, she found Adora busy in the kitchen, putting some things away. "Hey, Adora," she said with a grin as she wrapped her up in a hug from behind. "What's all this? Did you go shopping?"

Adora held up a can of corn she was about to put in the pantry, "About six months ago."

"Right, stuff from your old place. I forgot," Catra said as she let her go and sat at the kitchen island to watch her. "Find anything exciting?"

Adora shrugged and kept putting her things away, "Not really."

Catra's brow furrowed. That was oddly short for Adora. "How was your day," she tried cautiously.

Adora finally turned around and joined her with a slight smile. "It was fine. Had a quiz today in anatomy and physiology class, but it was easy. Then I went to Starbucks. My manager ALMOST talked me into working today, but he was such an ass I left."

"Good for you. Sorry, you had to deal with that," Catra reached across the island and held her hand, rubbing her palm with her thumb. "I know it wasn't easy for you."

Adora nodded, then quickly shifted the focus off herself. "How was work? I came by for my car, but you were in the **war room** ," she said dramatically. "Is a shareholders' meeting about world domination?"

"Practically," Catra laughed. She launched into her stories about the day and how great it had been to be back.

"Wow," Adora said at the end. "I think you *could* take over the world with robots like that."

Catra laughed, "Entrapta's not focused on stuff like that. She'd rather make a robot who can bake tiny cupcakes."

"My kind of machinery," Adora chuckled. "Sounds like you had a perfect day."

"I did get to come home to you at the end of it . " Catra tugged on Adora's hand to implore her to meet her halfway for a kiss.

After clearing out what was left of her apartment, Adora had decided she was definitely, *absolutely* , **totally** going to talk to Catra... sometime. Maybe tonight. She knew she couldn't let this keep

building inside because, clearly, it was coming to a rapid boiling point with how she'd been acting. Then Catra came home all floaty and happy. She'd had more or less the exact opposite of Adora's day. Who was Adora to take that from her? Especially when all she was going to do was whine about something she was sure other people dreamed of...

After another night of missing her pillow, she got up at the same time as Catra. The happiness she felt singing along with Catra's shockingly dorky 'get hype' morning playlist calmed the waters of her mind. Not to mention how much she enjoyed sipping coffee while helping Catra pick the right suit.

When it was time for Catra to leave, she followed her to the elevator to see her off for the big day. As much as she tried to hide it, Adora could see a lot of anxiety under her excitement. "Good luck today, boss," Adora said with a honeyed voice as she wrapped her arms around her and kissed her.

Catra leaned back to pull Adora off her feet to deepen the kiss. When she put her back down, she looked up at her with stars in her eyes, "Pretty sure I've already hit the lifetime limit on luck, but I'll take it."

"You are such a sap," Adora teased.

"Am not," Catra said impishly as she entered the elevator. She stopped the doors with her arm for a moment to call back, "I love you. Hope you have a good day."

"I love you too," Adora said as she waved goodbye. Melog came beside her to fill the void by rubbing her legs. "Aww, good morning," she said sweetly and lifted him into her arms. "Maybe I should tell you all my problems," Melog made what felt like an approving 'mrow,' and she carried him over to her nook to relax until her first class.

When Adora arrived at Anatomy and Physiology, the same group of jerks from the day before did their whole laugh-and-whisper bit. Fuck that, Adora thought. Instead of taking her usual seat, she decided to confront the situation by sitting right beside them. That shut them right up. She smiled smugly at them before she said a pleasant, "Good morning."

What a power move.

Then fifteen minutes into class, the professor announced that they would be doing a group project... groups he assigned by rows.

Fuck.

After giving them the instructions and rubric, he finished his lecture early to allow the groups to meet, exchange ideas, and make plans to meet outside class.

Adora awkwardly scooched her chair over to join the other three. She gave a small wave. "Sooo," she stretched it out as she tried to think of how to break the ice. "Are you all passionate about any body systems?"

The trio's ringleader rolled his eyes. "Anyway," he turned away from her to the other two. "Meet at my place tomorrow night?"

The other two nodded and continued talking like Adora wasn't there. They clearly didn't know who they were dealing with. Adora picked her chair up and moved to where she was sitting right in front of them. "Fine. Out with it," she whisper-yelled at them, "What is going on? I am a NICE person. I've never even SPOKEN to you before, much less know your names. Why are you being little jerks?"

"Soren," the main guy said and crossed his arms. "Guess you've BEEN playing the part, not even getting to know us, *little people* ."

Adora balked at that. "What? No, I just--"

"Cut the shit, blondie," Soren said dismissively. "We know who you are and what you're about. Showing up here to get your vanity degree while sleeping with your greedy capitalist girlfriend. The rest of us have to make good grades to graduate and get decent jobs. So excuse me if I'm not excited to have dead weight in our group."

Adora could not believe what she was hearing. Was this more online gossip she'd missed out on? She'd stayed off everything since the whole stupid TiffanyTruth debacle.

She popped back up to her feet and glared down at them. "I have ***NEVER*** made less than an A in my whole LIFE," she said as she leaned down with her hands on the table. "And, for the record, I've been POOR for most of it. I'm not going to stop now just because I live with my rich girlfriend, WHICH I DIDN'T EVEN ASK FOR, BY THE WAY. I WILL keep making A's even if I have to work with you, MR. DUMB FACE," she emphasized and then sat back at the table. "So, I repeat, do you have any body systems you're passionate about?!"

Looking a bit shellshocked, a girl in the trio stammered, "Um.. the endocrine system?"

Catra was standing backstage, trying to keep her nerves settled while counting the minutes until she was on. It wasn't the largest crowd she'd ever spoken to, but it *was* comprised solely of people that needed Darla to succeed as much as she did. And if they weren't confident in her ability to be the driving force behind that...

Three minutes to go.

Her phone vibrated. Fuck, she needed to turn that off. When she brought it out, she was happy she didn't.

Adora: [picture of her and Melog snugged up in the nook. Adora was wearing cat ears.]

Adora: We're mewing for you!

Catra : This makes even less sense than the first time. Thanks.

Catra : I love you. I'll call you when I'm done.

She turned her phone off and tucked it away. One minute.

DT came over to fix her tie and check her hair, "Alright, almost game time. Deep breaths. Eyes up. Walk out like you own the place because you **do** ."

"Thanks, coach," Catra said with a laugh.

After a few words from the MC, Catra walked out on stage to a roaring applause that became a standing ovation. "Wow," she said as she took it all in. "Did you miss me?"

She went on into her prepared speech, blending the stories of where the company was and where it was headed. Darla continued to grow and outpace every competitor by every financial metric, even as

others attempted to copy their work. Nothing was going to stop them.

Adora was studying under a tree when Catra called to check-in. "Heeey, Adora." She sounded positively giddy.

"Heeey, yourself. Someone's in a good mood."

"It was perfect," Catra said excitedly. "Maybe I'll take a three-week vacation before this thing every year."

"Not a bad plan."

"How's school been?"

Adora's heart dropped to her stomach thinking about her display in class earlier. "Fine. Studying for my Latin exam tomorrow in the arboretum."

"Good place to do it, lots of plant names are Latin based. Oh! That reminds me," there was some shuffling on the other end. "Are you up for going out to eat tonight? Somewhere new, apparently pretty fancy?"

It seemed like the right thing to do to celebrate Catra's success, even if she wasn't in the best of moods. "Sounds great."

"I'll pick you up after I'm done here. I've got to head back and make sure EKS isn't knocking people out with projectiles. I love you."

"I love you too," Adora said.

Catra was holding her breath as Entrapta reached the end of her presentation.

"This is Darla's biggest step yet to advance the futures of technology and SCIENCE," she declared from the stage. The audience began their applause, perhaps thinking that was the end. Entrapta wasted no time proving them wrong, "Hit it, Emily!"

Emily started the music, and the two robots began their attempts at dancing. Catra got even more nervous when the crowd was up on their feet dancing along. Had Entrapta controlled for this much movement? When EKS held the first plush aloft, people caught on quickly as to what would happen next. Everyone reached high up into the air, and cheers erupted from those lucky enough to receive a plush. There was something hysterical about watching adults in business attire jostling for toys. Needless to say, Entrapta's proposal was a hit.

There was a brief intermission between the presentations and the Q&A's. While Catra really would've liked to hide in her office, she stayed out amongst the crowd, chatting and shaking hands. Those invited to attend in person were chosen lottery style as opposed to giving priority to the amount invested. This led to a much more diverse crowd, and Catra was delighted to meet people who weren't your average old rich man.

When Catra was beckoned to return to the auditorium, the stage had been set up for their Q&A panel. Entrapta, Lonnie, and other key department heads were also available for questioning. They started

with the online questions they'd selected-- mostly about technical aspects of the vehicles, future plans, and the like. Nothing too heavy. Then... came the live Q&A.

The first few questions were for Entrapta; her robotics presentation really stole the show.

"This question is for Entrapta and Lonnie," a youngish man said as he took the mic. "Do you think that EKS could operate a Darla? And if so, would it be an AI-squared driving experience?" He laughed, and Catra wasn't sure if it was a joke or if he was that nervous.

Lonnie side-eyed the rest of the panel before answering, "All I can say is our cars are very user-friendly. I'll let Entrapta tell us if that includes robots."

"FASCINATING question," Entrapta said enthusiastically. "I'm not entirely sure EKS would be the best driver, but then again, Darla can drive herself so it's really a question about their compatibility..." She went on a five-minute thought experiment that no one could've anticipated, but the audience remained engaged as they tried to work it out. "In conclusion, there isn't enough data to support a solid answer, but I'm willing to do some experiments around this in the name of science."

Next up was an older, more severe-looking gentleman. "This morning, Catra, you told us that you are interested in developing a program to make Darla vehicles available to those who are, let's say, less fortunate."

Catra sat up straighter in her seat, her defenses fully up. "Safety shouldn't be a luxury," she said simply.

Some folks in the crowd applauded in affirmation, but the man wasn't dissuaded. "That is a noble answer, but we know the ***real*** motivation behind this new direction. And MY question is if your future significant others will also impact your company vision and plans? And will anyone on this panel have the courage or power to stop you?"

Boos. Gasps. All eyes on Catra. This was precisely the thing she'd been prepping for with DT yesterday, though even their fake asshole questioner character was more likable than this.

Catra breathed deeply and carefully calculated her words lest she got on the mic and said *, "Fuck you. Next question."*

"Thank you for allowing me to speak to this," Catra said calmly as she stood up from her seat. "I didn't *want* to take any attention away from our accomplishments with this baseless gossip, but now I have a reason to. You've clearly used your basic understanding of my life to draw lines between why I want what *you* have termed 'less fortunate' people to have our vehicles."

She swiped on her phone to cast an image onto the projector behind her. "Here's a 'less fortunate' family for you. The father is a math professor at his local community college. The mother is a bank teller. They make a decent amount of money, enough to keep that kid of theirs fed, happy, and safe. However, unless they put all their savings into it *and* took on considerable debt, they'd never afford our current Darla models." Catra paced on the stage as she talked, using the rhythm of her steps to ground her.

"Sir, I'm worried about your ability to draw conclusions, so let me spell it out for you. These are my parents, and I lost them shortly after this photo was taken due to a very avoidable car accident. If making our technology more accessible can save even one kid from growing up without their parents, I would call that a success. Making this fucked up world a better place has always been my vision for

our company. If that isn't compatible with yours, I suggest you find somewhere else to invest your money."

Adora spent the late afternoon transforming herself from a college student in loungewear to someone she hoped looked like she belonged on the arm of a CEO. Catra hadn't specified a dress code, but if she was picking her up straight from work, Adora at least needed to be on par with what Catra left in. Thus she decided on a suit that Netossa had fitted for her.

When she was finished, she went down to the lobby to wait. Unfortunately, that left her feeling exposed as she could see some photographers across the street, no doubt trying to catch a glimpse of her from the glass.

"Was it always like this for Catra," she said off-handly to the front desk worker.

"Hmm? Oh," they said as they looked up from the computer. They pressed a button behind the desk, which caused the blinds to lower. "There you are, Ms. Adora. My apologies; I didn't see you come down."

"Thanks," she said, feeling more relaxed. "I'm still getting used to all of this."

"I'm sure you'll get the hang of it," they said cheerfully. "Before you know it, you'll be able to tune it out like it's a normal part of your day."

Yay?

Adora practically leapt into the car as soon as Catra pulled up, hoping to avoid more attention.

"Nice form," Catra said with a smirk. "You'd make a pretty good bank robber, not to mention a hot one."

Adora buckled herself in, "Sorry, I'm just... not in the mood for all this media stuff tonight."

"Fucking same," Catra sighed. "I can't handle another interview or public appearance after today. I think I'll tell DT I'm on a PR vacation until further notice."

"I approve, boss."

Catra reached over and squeezed her hand. "Thanks. This restaurant's very exclusive as far as I know, shouldn't have anyone bothering us there. It's kind of word-of-mouth at the moment. I only heard about it from Scorpia because her girlfriend helped design it."

"Isn't she a florist," Adora asked curiously.

"Yeah. Apparently, it's an 'botanical experience,' whatever that means."

After parking at a massive stone building, they were escorted to an elevator straight to the top. Exiting found them in a hall reminiscent of an ancient marble temple covered in greenery everywhere. A man in a flowing robe with flowers braided into his hair and beard approached them.

"Greetings," he said as he bowed to the two of them. "Ms. Catra and Adora, I presume?"

They glanced at each other out of the corners of their eyes. Catra nodded, "Yes."

As though that was a 'yes' to all things, he immediately placed matching flower crowns on their heads. Adora tried to hold back her laugh at Catra's obvious dismay.

"We are so honored to have you joining us tonight," he turned and began to lead towards the golden doors at the end of the hall. "I believe even a person of your means will find this to be an experience like no other."

"You look so cute," Adora whispered.

"Shut up," Catra whispered back.

"Welcome to Plumeria," the host interrupted them dramatically as he threw open the golden doors.

Beyond was something that looked more like a forest than a restaurant. At the center was a massive, presumably fake, tree with branches that extended out over the whole space. Hanging from each were different kinds of giant bird nests decorated with vines and flowers that connected them back to the tree. Inside were diners enjoying their meals.

"We have reserved our very best table for you," the host said as he led them further into the forest. He stopped at a translucent staircase that led up to a dome-style bird's nest, hanging about ten feet off the ground. "After you."

Adora cautiously took the first step, and Catra put a hand on her waist as she followed. Inside the nest was shockingly less claustrophobic than Adora worried it would be. There were circular windows that let them look out at everything. Fairy lights were embedded into the furniture, making it all aglow.

The host left them with menus, and they were finally alone again. "I'm really sorry if we fall to our deaths tonight," Catra said as she took off the flower crown and hid it beside her.

"From this height, we probably wouldn't die," Adora noted as she looked out of the window, "Unless we hit our skulls *just right* ."

"Reassuring. Is that what you're learning in school?"

"I thought you liked heights, scaredy cat," Adora teased.

"I do when it's proven that I won't end up crashing to the floor during the second course."

"You can fall on me if you need to. My butt will cushion your fall."

"True love," Catra laughed. "Alright, let's see if they've got anything on this menu without flowers in it..."

After the first course arrived without the server tumbling down to the ground, they both felt more at ease. It was a selection of various 'common' appetizers elevated to elegance with edible flowers and designer plating.

"Mmm," Adora hummed after consuming the last of the fancy sliders, "I still prefer the ones at Chili's."

"Refined taste," Catra said without thinking about it.

"Bringing her up on our date night? Wow, Catra, that's pretty low."

Catra rolled her eyes, "Not something I'd ever do on purpose. Thank *god* no one brought her up today. I was worried it would be a fucking sea of drama during the Q&A, but I just got one asshole."

Adora started fiddling with her napkin roll, "How'd that go?"

"He was trying to call me out over wanting to make affordable Darla's, and I basically murdered him with words."

"To murder," Adora said as she held up her drink, and they clinked.

"Glad this place is private; I can imagine the conspiracy tweets about who we killed."

"As if anyone needs an excuse to talk about us." Adora kept busying her hands with playing with her napkin.

Catra watched her face drop and realized something she'd meant to do. She'd left Adora alone to process the media circus around their move-in. Sure, it was self-preservation, but it was clear how heavily it weighed on Adora. She needed to take some of that from her.

"What were they saying about the move-in?"

Adora raised her eyebrows. "Do you really want to get into that right now?"

"Not really. But if you had to hear it, I should too."

"Read that stupid Tiffany Truth article. That'll pretty much sum it up." Adora seemed genuinely annoyed, and Catra cursed herself for even bringing it up.

Catra took her phone out from her suit jacket and groaned, "Torture it is." She noticed a new text message from a number she didn't recognize. Fucking hell, did someone leak her number today?

[Unknown]: You should see this. [embed of a TikTok video]

"Someone randomly messaged me a TikTok, that's weird, right?"

"Maybe Entrapta's bots have inspired a new dance challenge?"

Curiosity killed the cat. She'd already started playing it, "Wait! It's you. Holy shit," she started laughing as she watched Adora dress down some kid in class. "This is great, why didn't you tell---"

because I live with my rich girlfriend, WHICH I DIDN'T EVEN ASK FOR, BY THE WAY.

She said it with such disdain and hurt. Maybe the media wasn't responsible for Adora's mood after all...

The video finished, and Catra's mouth hung open. She could feel her chest tightening, tears welling up in her eyes. When she met Adora's blue ones, she could see tears were already going down her cheeks.

"Catra, I'm-- that--"

This was not happening. Not now. Not today when everything had been so *perfect* .

As quickly as she could manage, Catra escaped the nest and ran, not particularly caring if she fell at this point. She managed to find her way to the restrooms and splashed water on her face. Maybe this was just a bad dream...

She wasn't in there long before Adora came in after her. "Please, Catra, it's not what you think."

"Isn't it?"

Adora sighed and rubbed her forehead, "I know. I shouldn't have gone off like that in public, but it just happened. I've been keeping all of this inside because I wanted to wait to talk after everything calmed down at work. Today was so important to you, I didn't want to ruin it."

"Just tell me how you really feel," Catra said as she leaned against one of the cool marble walls. "I'm not some fragile fucking thing, Adora. I can handle it."

The biggest bluff of her life.

"Fine, okay." Adora took a deep breath before it came tumbling out with tears and fury. "I feel *angry* . Someone packed up my *life,* and I didn't have a say. Asking me after the fact isn't really asking me. Not when someone already had to fold my underwear and pack my most private fucking stuff," she paused and exhaled heavily. When she started again, her tone was more measured, "I know you wanted it to be a big romantic gesture, and that's really sweet, but you can't make those kinds of choices for me. I'm my own person, and me having less money than you doesn't change that."

Catra bit her tongue to distract herself from the tears threatening to break free as she stared at the floor. There was no way she could meet Adora's gaze. Not when she had been the one to make Adora feel this way. How could she be so fucking self-centered, inconsiderate… so goddamn stupid?

"I'm sorry," Catra said haltingly, "I'm so sorry, Adora, I didn't… fuck, I…." The sobs broke free, and she could hardly breathe, much less talk. She was going to lose the most important thing in her life—-her wealth and business be damned, and it was all her fault.

"Catra, look at me, please," Adora put a hand under Catra's wet chin and guided her to meet her own. "I love you."

Catra shook her head. That couldn't be right. Everything was falling apart, just like the stupid tabloids and Valerie said it would.

Tears were still streaming down Adora's face, but she smiled softly at her, "I can love you and be mad at you at the same time."

"I love you too," Catra choked out before leaning forward and wrapping her arms tightly around her. "I never wanted to force anything on you, Adora. I hate that I did. I'll… I'll do whatever it takes to fix this; I'll get your old apartment back. I just want you to be happy."

Adora held her just as tightly, kissing her forehead. "I'm happy living with you. I don't want to go back. All I want is a heads up next time you want to make life-changing decisions or to hire someone to move my vibrators."

They both laughed and softened in each other's arms. "I promise," Catra said solemnly. "No surprise weddings or adoptions or whatever. Next time I mess up, can you tell me instead of bottling it up? Even if I've got a million other things going on, I'd rather know from you than fucking TikTok."

"I promise," Adora replied.

Catra went in for a kiss so desperate it ought to be reserved for the end of the world. Adora returned every bit of it in kind, pressing her tightly against the bathroom wall. They only came up for air when the door to the bathroom was swung open by some unsuspecting person, causing both of them to start shaking with laughter.

"Gotta keep up our reputation," Adora said with a smirk.

"How about we clean up and continue this conversation over whatever a bouquet of meats is?"

"Sounds perfect," Adora replied.

Chapter End Notes

I'd like to thank everyone for their continued patience with me as I update my stories. I remember when I used to apologize for updating only once or twice a month! Oh, those were the days.

I'd also like to thank everyone who has shared with me their thoughts and opinions around the whole move-in. It really helped me to get into the headspace of Adora better, and I hope this is a satisfying not 'conclusion' per se but a way to honor those feelings.

My readers and fandom friends are the best. Thank you! Hope you enjoyed.

Hard

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora try to figure out how to exist in the world after their first real fight. Old foes and new make themselves known.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Good news: Catra and Adora had their first real 'fight' of their relationship, and they walked away from it together, holding hands.

Bad news: Catra and Adora had their first real 'fight' of their relationship, and it was **all** Catra's fault.

It was times like this that she really wished her parents were still around. Given their measured approach to most things, they probably would've seen this conflict coming and talked Catra into making the *idea* a surprise, not the deed. Meanwhile all she had to teach her growing brain about love was a bunch of sappy movies, books, and shows that taught her the only thing better than a grand gesture was an even grander gesture.

Bless , as Helen might say. Maybe she should try running things by her next time…

All of this to say, Catra couldn't shake the feeling of creeping dread during the dinner. Maybe Adora was feeling the same way, and that's why they hadn't stopped holding hands since they sat back down in their "nest." When the worry became too much to bear, she squeezed Adora's hand like her life depended on it. She was met with a squeeze back just as hard.

"Want to get dessert to go," Catra asked as they were finishing up the 'meat bouquet.'

"Sure," Adora said while fiddling with a 'lily,' "Do you think it'll be a plant that we have to water until it grows a strawberry shortcake in a few years?"

"Probably," Catra rubbed her thumb in Adora's palm, tracing lines that she wished she could read. "I'll be surprised if they actually have to-go anything, but I just want to be home with you and Melog. If you want, I can help you study for your test tomorrow."

Adora stared at her adoringly and leaned over to kiss her cheek. "That sounds perfect."

The drive home was somewhere between a cozy quiet and awkward. Like, Catra laughed at Adora's terrible attempts at sing-alongs, but she didn't say much of anything. The 'fight,' if you'd call it that, was over by Adora's estimation nearly as soon as it started. But… she could tell Catra was pretending to be okay when she very clearly wasn't. Adora could relate…

"So," Catra said finally, as they were nearing their building. "I realized I don't even know what even happened in class. What was going on with those people anyway?"

Adora rolled her eyes so hard they scraped her skull. "They were complaining that I wasn't going to do anything for this dumb group project. Like I don't care about school because of my 'greedy capitalist girlfriend.'

Catra sucked in air through her teeth as she processed this. "Ouch," she said finally. "That's… *damn* . I can't judge them for saying shit like that about me, but I can't believe there's ever been a class where you weren't the biggest try-hard in the room."

Adora gasped. "Try hard!"

"Adora. Come on," Catra glanced over at her with a smirk like she was catching her in a lie. "I've seen your flashcard collection."

"I care about studying, that's all."

"You've got flashcards from high school in there."

"You never know when they might come in handy!" All that weird tension was forgotten now unlike the facts from her Biology I class seven years ago. "Anyway… You're right, but you know what? They're going to see how hard I DO, not **try** ."

Like she was possessed by a punny ghost, the dumbest joke came out of Catra's mouth without her willing it. "Hey, your hard doing is supposed to be for me only."

She was cringing at herself before she even finished. Meanwhile Adora was laughing so hard, she could barely breathe. Her eyes that were already cried out for the evening managed to squeeze out a few more.

"I think being in love is making me dumber. I'm going to have to get Entrapta to do a study on me." Catra shook her head while pulling up to the valet.

They held hands, laughing all the way to the elevator. When the doors closed, Adora composessed herself enough to attempt a sultry proposition, "You ready for some hard doing?"

"You're never going to let me live this down, are you?" Catra covered her face with her hands, hoping to god this stupid elevator didn't have sound recording.

"It might be my favorite thing you've ever said," Adora said as sincerely as she could manage between more childish giggles. "You're lucky I've sworn off Twitter this week."

"Keep laughing," Catra said, her eyes set on the floors ticking up. "When we get up there I'm going to make you conjugate every irregular verb I can think of."

Adora couldn't help herself. She slipped in front of Catra, blocking the door. "Do you think you can teach me how to conjugate," she leaned in, whispering into her ear, "To do... hard."

Catra stared up at her as she pulled away and said, deadly serious, "Quo usque tandem abutere, Adora, patientia mea?"

The elevator opened up behind Adora and Catra swerved around her after chanting whatever curse that was. "That doesn't scare me, because I have no idea what it means."

"O tempora, O mores," Catra called scornfully as she led them into the penthouse.

"I'm literally in Latin 101."

Catra just made a 'tutting' noise and was heading for the study.

"Mihi nomen es Adora," she said confidently, even triling on the 'r' of her name.

Catra looked back at her with a raised eyebrow and concerned eyes, " **Est** Adora. *Est* ."

"No, *I'm* Adora. You're Catra."

"Has the withdrawal period already passed?"

- - - -

Despite all of her shenanigans beforehand, their tutoring session was all business. Adora clearly had some deep anxiety about this test. She made up a bulletin board of everything she was worried about, and Catra helped her lower each item's unique 'threat level.' By the end, Adora was breezing her way through declensions, conjugations, and sample translations Catra pulled together for her.

"I'm ready," Adora said finally after she slammed down the last of her flashcards triumphantly.

"Of course you are, you fucking tryhard," Catra teased as she kissed the top of her head. "I know it's kind of late, but you mentioned not being able to find some of your stuff from the move?"

Adora looked like a deflated balloon. "No, Catra, it's fine. We don't have to talk about that. It wasn't anything important."

"Come on. I can't believe I forgot about this," Catra grabbed her hand and led her out of the study. They crossed the large first floor to one of the spare bedrooms. When Catra opened the door, she gestured at the packed boxes on the floor. The previous bedroom suite had been replaced with everything from Adora's.

"My furniture," Adora said as she put a hand on top of her dresser gingerly. She pulled open one of the drawers and laughed as she pointed to the exposed nails. "Old pokey! This is a ***hazard*** . I really can't believe they kept all this stuff."

"I didn't want them to leave any of you behind," Catra said and gave an awkward little smile. "I know this doesn't make the other stuff better, but…"

"I appreciate it," Adora leaned in and kissed her. Then she looked a bit shocked. "Wait, wait," she pointed back at the bed. "Is that *my* bed?" When Catra nodded, she began to blush and looked away. "Oh. Well."

"What?"

"I've…uh…" She bounced a bit on her heels. "It's an *experienced* bed. You know. From.. uh…"

"You've fucked other girls on that bed," Catra asked matter-of-factly.

"Mmhm," Adora admitted. "Is that weird? I mean. Now it's in *your* house."

"Our house, and no, it's not like I'm surprised," Catra stood staring at the 'recreated' Adora bedroom. "I'm just having a hard time imagining it." Catra went and sat down on the bed which squeaked like it needed to be oiled somehow.

"What, you don't think I have moves? I *have* moves. **Moves** that bagged me a hot billionaire."

Catra looked disinterested, playing with her cuticles. "Eh, maybe I just was ready to settle down with any nice girl."

"Seriously." Adora narrowed her eyes at her and pointed at the ground beside here. "Get up and come here, RIGHT NOW."

With shivers down her spine, Catra realized how much she was into Adora ordering her around. No witty quips came to mind. She simply stood and followed the command.

Adora cleared her throat. "Hey," she said as she slipped into character. "I had a *really* good time tonight," she reached around Catra and rested her hand on her lower back. "Kind of a shame for it to end already, don't you think?"

As Catra stared up at her in this pose, somehow Adora felt taller and more imposing. "Yeah," she managed, her voice sounding small and pathetic in her head. "I… don't have any other plans."

"Perfect," Adora said and then shrugged off her own jacket. She held out an arm for Catra's, who gave it away mindlessly. "Let me go hang these up. You make yourself comfortable. Sorry, all I've got is the bed to sit on. Moving, you know."

Catra sat down on Adora's bed and felt butterflies while waiting for her, which was *ridiculous* . This was her girlfriend. The woman she was going to be going to bed with every night for the rest of her life if she was lucky. It shouldn't feel like a first time.

But then Adora came back, and did this stupidly sexy move where she put one of her muscular arms up and leaned on the door frame. "Sorry, meant to ask if you wanted something to drink."

"Shut up and get in here," Catra demanded.

Adora looked utterly pleased with herself as she sauntered in and put a hand under Catra's chin. "You know, I don't think I'll be in the mood until you make a certain *special* request just for tonight."

"Absolutely not."

" *Do it* ."

Catra's shoulders slumped as she looked up at Adora with her best pleading eyes, "Adora."

Adora stood back up straight and crossed her arms. "Maybe I need to get to sleep. I do have a big test tomorrow."

"Fine," Catra buried her head in her hands and grumbled, "Do me hard, please."

Adora swooped back in as soon as the please was on her lips, pushing Catra flat against the bed. "Don't ever doubt my moves again," she said as she climbed on top of her.

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In contrast to her other classes, Adora was one of the last ones to finish the Latin exam. All the same, she felt decently confident. The late night studying with Catra helped more than she could've hoped for, and with her favorite pillow back under her head, she had the best night's sleep since before their

trip. Having her complicated feelings about the move out in the open didn't hurt either. Everything felt like it was back in place again. Perfect.

Well, except for the fact that she was now sitting outside of the humanities building, trying to coordinate with her anatomy group. It was so annoying that a college class had the audacity to assign a group project. Hadn't Adora done enough carrying people in high school when she wasn't paying for the privilege to do so? Reluctantly she opened the group text where little had actually been decided since a vague mention of meeting at Soren's place that afternoon.

Adora: Done with my classes for the day. When can we meet?

Soren : idk but we can't meet at mine anymore, roommate problems

Madison : ugh he's a [demon emoji]

Adora : K. I'll get us a group table at the library.

Linzee : can't

Adora raised an eyebrow at that. Had this group been so annoying that they'd been kicked out of the library?

Soren : z's ex works at the library coffee shop

Adora was about to suggest that they could go to literally any other floor in the library but the one with the coffee shop, when there was another buzz.

Soren : can we go to your place, Adora? You've got plenty of room I bet.

She resisted the urge to throw her phone. She could hear his annoying voice in her head while reading the text. Adora started to type out a 'absolutely not' style Catra reply, when Madison's came through.

Madison : rude, she probably isn't even allowed to invite people over there. Let's just meet in the commons.

This was all probably a dirty trick the trio was in on. Logically, Adora knew this. Her pride however couldn't let such a challenge go unanswered. She erased the message she was typing and quickly sent a new one.

Adora : We can meet at my place. URCS building downtown at 3. Text me when you're in the lobby and I'll come down to get you.

Linzee : cool

Soren : so sweet, see you soon [smiling emoji]

Madison : thx

Adora sighed, already dreading what she had willingly gotten herself into… and, by proxy, Catra. She tried giving her a call to warn her, but unfortunately it went straight to voicemail. *Eheu* .

- - - -

The second day of their shareholder events was much less electrifying than the first. They opened the day with a bunch of financial reports from easily the least charismatic members of the board. Thankfully they also provided enough coffee to caffeinate the whole city. After a couple of cups, Catra had already been cut off by Scorpia who gave her a whispered, kindly scolding reminder about her *condition* .

At least being boring was the only bad thing about the financial presentation. The numbers didn't lie, and *Darla* wasn't showing any sign of weakness or slowing down. Finally, the presentation was wrapping up and someone was taking the stage to direct the in person crowd.

Catra took that as her opportunity to sneak away. Maybe even steal a cup of coffee while Scorpia was out of sight. Everything was great until she turned a corner and met eyes with the last person she expected to run in to at her own business. A wicked smile played on the other woman's face as she gave a polite wave.

"Darling. It's so good to see you again," she said, as though they hadn't been smacking each other in the press for over a month now.

Catra was caught. She found herself wondering why she didn't take up Juliet's offer of having a guard with her during these events. Not that she anticipated any physical harm from this interaction...

"I can't say the same." She was glancing over Valerie's shoulder, trying to find anyone from her team. All she saw were visitors and the caterers and extra security they had hired. They were milling about, seemingly not even noticing the scene playing out nearby yet. Thus she tried to keep her composure. "What are you doing here?"

"Wow, Cat, I can't believe you're forgetting one of your earliest shareholders." She dramatically placed a hand against her heart and her impossibly tight blouse. Catra wondered how she could breathe then felt immediately gross for noticing something like that. "I couldn't believe it myself. This year… of all the times I've entered my name for the in-person lottery? Wow. Seems like fate, don't you think?"

"Some people say fate is a bitch," Catra said beneath her breath.

Valerie laughed again and reached over to pat Catra's shoulder. She reflexively pulled away, causing the other woman to glance over at some of the guided tours heading up the hall. "Don't be so jumpy. Makes you seem like you're still unwell. Then you'll be getting a lecture from that PR person of yours... what's their name again? All I know is my girl calls them double trouble, because they always one up us."

Fucking hell, she hated that she was right. Catra put on her best fake customer service voice and smile. "I'm very busy today, Ms. Harper. Do you need something?"

"From you?" Valerie flitted her eyes up and down Catra, with a smirk that probably made other people swoon. "Always," she said and threw in a wink. "I *also* wanted to check on you. That Q&A yesterday? Wow. You handled it masterfully, but I know that cruel old man must have hit you where it hurt. Between that and Barista Barbie's little blow up..."

Catra put her hand up, still smiling. "Hold that thought," Catra said pleasantly and then tried to disappear into the crowd coming by.

"Wait," Valerie grabbed her in the last moment and leaned in close to her to whisper. "I'm trying to warn you. He's trying to gather support for a vote of no confidence."

Catra stopped dead in her tracks and looked back at the other woman with sincere interest for the first time in years. "What," was all she managed to say.

"He pulled me aside yesterday and explained everything. Must have thought I'd be on his side," Valerie explained in hushed tones. "Little does he know, I'd **always** rather be with you than against you."

Catra's heart felt like it was both speeding and misfiring every other second. She was sure the thump, th-thump could be heard by everyone around her. And, of course, *now* people seemed to notice who they were walking passed. Even as her employees tried to get them back on track, the tours lingered, circling. She was suddenly surrounded by people trying to talk to her, pose for pictures, or shake her hand.

Dizzy.

Just keep smiling.

Try not to smile in an unhinged way.

Everyone has their phones out.

Breathe. Breathe. Keep breathing.

Don't pass out.

THUMP. thUMp. Thumpthumpthump.

Don't pass out.

Valerie said something that didn't quite make it through the cacophony of the crowd and her heartbeat. Then, all the sudden, her god damn savior in high heels appeared, parting the ocean of people with the grace of an angel. She'd never been more grateful to see anyone in her life.

"Excuse me, everyone," they said in a booming but ever affable voice. "I am so sorry, but I'm afraid I need to steal our CEO for a quick business meeting. Otherwise I am sure she'd stay here until midnight getting to know each and everyone of you."

With that, people began to file back into the planned tour groups, and she had the space she was desperately craving. Valerie, however, stayed put. DT narrowed their dark eyes at her and said in the kindest tone, "Ms. Harper. Why don't you run along now? I'm sure you have some gold to dig elsewhere."

"I believe Catra is interested in what I have to share with her," she countered, arms crossed.

DT looked down at Catra who still was in a daze. "I think you've shared quite enough."

Valerie rolled her eyes then directed her attention back to Catra. "You've got my number, darling. Let me know if I can help."

Then she was gone.

DT linked one of their arms with Catra's and started leading her away. "As I was saying, we need to have a quick chat."

Catra snapped out of it once they were moving. "Thanks," she mumbled.

"What was *she* –," DT started to ask and then gave a sweet movie star smile to a new group passing by. "Hello. Welcome." They nudged Catra, who then waved like she was on a pageant float.

Once they were within the sanctuary of DT's opulent office, Catra laid down on one of their couches. "Fuck," she groaned into a pillow.

DT sat down on the edge of their desk. "Alright. What is going on? It can't just be *her*. You can handle Miss Val in your sleep." Then they laughed at themself. Of course they did. "Poor wording, my apologies. Anyway, my point is you left here ruling the world yesterday. Everything is going so boringly perfect today, and I find you about to fall over before noon. Is this about that silly video of blondie?"

Catra tossed the pillow away. "No. Well. Not exactly," she sighed then looked up at them with a glare. "You know, a number I don't even know texted me that video last night, but this is the first I'm hearing about it from you. Are *you* slipping?"

DT sighed and shook their head like a teacher trying hard to be patient. "Someone sent me that yesterday afternoon, but the last statement you put out was very clear. Instead, I spun them a great narrative about everything else happening here. Gossip magazines are the only ones running on Adora's rant, and only the online ones at that. Never fear. I'm *always* on time, kitten."

Catra tilted her head at them and couldn't help but smirk as stressed as she was. "So you know all about the vote of no confidence then?"

DT stared back at her with wide eyes and an open mouth.

"Are you sure you don't need me to come over," Glimmer asked. "I'm not even busy."

Adora felt very tempted by the offer, but remained strong. "No, I can handle it. I don't need a chaperone for my stupid group project."

Glimmer sighed on the other end. "Fine. But… be careful, okay? After yesterday I wouldn't put it beyond these goblins to try to set you up for another video or to steal something for ebay!"

"I'm not going to talk about anything but the endocrine system, and I've already locked most of the doors." Adora was busying herself with preparing far too many snacks for a four person group, hoping to appease her enemies with food. "Plus, they seemed like they care about their grades."

"Who needs a degree when you can sell Catra's underwear?"

Adora was not amused.

"Come on, I'm not wrong. Bet they'd even get a buyer for a *picture* of Catra's underwear."

"Even better they can take a picture of our sex toys. I'm lucky the movers didn't."

There was a slight giggle followed by a long spell of silence. Finally, Glimmer said, "I'm glad we talked about that. I should've realized you're like the world's **worst** person to move without permission. It just seemed so romantic. Plus, I hate moving."

"Yeah," Adora said half-heartedly while trying to fancifully cut fruit.

"Anyway, I should've been a better friend instead of thinking what I would want. I'm sorry."

"Thank you. I know you guys just wanted to do something nice for me."

"Sooo," Glimmer hung the word out like a whistle. "How are things going since the talk? Are you two okay?"

Adora's strawberry rose wasn't turning out how she hoped, but she still smiled to herself. "We're good, actually. Honestly… it's weird, but now that we've had a fight, I feel better about us. Like we can get through *anything* together."

"Sickening," Glimmer teased. "I get it. Bow and I have had some…disagreements… over the years."

"And you're still *sickening* ."

They were in the middle of arguing over which couple was more pathetic when Adora got a ping on her phone.

Soren : here.

"Shit," Adora said abruptly, putting down her last fruit. "It's happening."

"Good luck," Glimmer said. "Keep me updated. I can be over there in ten, and I'm looking for an excuse to choose violence today."

"Like every day," Adora said with a laugh. "Okay. I'll text you how it's going."

With that, they said goodbye. Adora took her time washing her hands, finding Melog to squeeze, and then engaging in a staring contest with the elevator doors. God, she did **not** want to do this. Maybe she should've let them think Catra didn't allow her to have people over. Maybe she should've leaned into the *vanity degree* angle. Maybe they were on to something. Did any of her hard work matter when her girlfriend was the CEO of the highest valued car company in the world?

She pressed the button forcefully as if answering her inner monologue.

Of course it mattered.

It mattered *hard* .

Chapter End Notes

Just a little URCS update after so very long. My strategy in writing right now is going for shorter chapters. It seems to be help! I wrote this in about 24 hours (and didn't edit it a ton... sorry, I'll probably update this 1000 times to fix everything).

Thanks to friends on twitter and discord who helped me with random story points/names/etc.

Thanks to the best readers in the world who are so patient and lovely.

Let's see where this story takes us from here.

Do you think Valerie's full of bullshit or actually looking out for Catra?

Will the anatomy trio prove they're more passionate about the endocrine system than roasting Adora/her girlfriend?

Will Catra come home ready to put her own moves on Adora only to find her putting glitter letters on a posterboard with strangers?

More importantly, will Glimmer get to choose violence today?

Also, I faded to black over the spice b/c I just don't think I'm a good NSFW writer. If there's a want for my brand of literal dumb fuckery, let me know and I'll see about working back into it. haha.

Strange Bedfellows

Chapter Summary

Adora tries to rein in a goat rodeo of a group project.

Catra learns a name to a new nemesis from her forever one.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In the short ride up the elevator, Adora had aged at least forty years. Something about being around these three made her feel like an old woman on the verge of complaining about 'today's youth.' In reality she couldn't have been more than a year older than them.

"Holy fuck," Madison said as the group stepped off the elevator.

Soren surveyed the space and looked disappointed. "Not nearly as ostentatious as I was expecting."

"I can't tell if that's a good or bad thing," Adora said but kept walking, trying to hurry them along to the dining room table which she'd already stocked with various school supplies.

"A boring thing," Soren said indifferently as he dropped his stuff down on the table.

Linzee glanced up from her phone long enough to look around. "It's cute."

"Thanks," Adora said, again wondering about the implication. "Anyway. Before we get started, let me go grab some snacks. I don't know about you but I can't think when my hypothalamus is angry." No one even appreciated her perfectly relevant joke. Pearls before swine, her mother would say.

She texted Catra on the way to the kitchen, again to no reply or seen notification. Damn. For once she hoped she'd be at work late. Adora picked up the serving platter where she'd laid out the very best random snacks available. She tried to make it look nice, but there's only so much a crystal dish can do for a generous pouring of goldfish crackers. At least they also had decently fancy cheese from the farmer's market. That paired with her attempts at pretty fruit made for a good showing, she thought.

Adora placed the platter down at the center of the table, and Soren began laughing as took out his phone to snap a photo, "This is great."

Adora decided to ignore him. "Would anyone like something to drink?"

"Definitely. Where's the wine cellar," Madison asked hopefully. "Can I take a selfie with the oldest bottle? I won’t drop it, promise!"

"We don't have one. Pretty sure we have a half bottle of some white wine. I don't remember what kind it is, but I can check."

"Really," Madison looked shocked, almost like she assumed Adora was lying. "Okay, I'll take water. What kind of ice do you have?"

Adora looked at the other two to see if this was some joke she didn't understand. No such answers were found. "Regular or crushed?"

"You don't have flavored ice? You know, the kind with flowers or fruit or whatever in it?" Adora shook her head no. "Not even cute little ball ice?"

"No."

Madison frowned, then reassessed her surroundings. "How weird. Are you sure Catra's not like... secretly broke or something? Maybe she spent all her money buying this place?"

"Pretty sure she's got plenty of money even if our ice is just ice," Adora answered as politely as possible.

Linzee side-eyed her friend. "I told you. They're not wannabe rich influencers."

Soren lifted up the crystal bowl of goldfish and said sagely, "Money may trend but wealth whispers, Mads, and it lives how it likes."

Adora never really considered what it was supposed to be like being "rich," or, at least in her case, rich adjacent. What it meant for her was not worrying so much about money. When they had gone to the grocery store together, she grabbed fruit juice instead of fruit drink. She ordered what sounded good from menus. She let herself have a little more than she normally would. It didn't mean flaunting money or running up a big bill just because she could. It didn't seem like it meant that to Catra either… aside from the tipsy arcade purchase, anyway.

She cleared her throat awkwardly to redirect the group which had now launched into what they would do with all this money. "Is everybody good with water and perfectly normal ice?"

After some "ehs" and "whatevers," Adora escaped to the kitchen for one last moment alone.

Once they were properly settled with mundane iced water, some plates full of snacks, and a fleet of laptops... it was time to get to work.

"Has everyone read the rubric," Adora asked, then offered up some papers. "I printed out copies."

The others swept them up and read with varying levels of interest. "Creativity, really," Soren complained. "Why does he care if we're creative or not! If we know our shit and did the work, give us an A."

Adora laughed, despite not wanting to agree with him on anything. "Yeah, I thought the same thing, but honestly it seems like he just doesn't want everyone to make a Powerpoint."

Linzee looked up with a big grin. "I think I've got a loophole. He *didn't* say we can't use Google Slides. Easy."

"Z, that's the same thing," Madison said with a sigh, and she tapped her chin. "Okay. Endocrine system. Everybody close your eyes and feel what the vibes of the endocrine system are."

This experience was getting weirder by the second, but at least they were talking about the project. Once she saw the others were actually doing it, Adora let her eyes drift closed.

"What does the endocrine system *want* to be," Madison said in a soft voice, clicking her nails on her water glass.

"You and your ASMR," Soren complained. "Save it for your channel."

"Shut up, I like it," Linzee said.

Madison went back to clicking her nails and occasionally saying random words related to the system, "Hormones. Pituitary gland. Pancreas," and so on.

Adora kept her eyes closed, taking a couple of deep breaths in and out. Finally, she said more like a question than a declaration, "A skit?"

No one said anything at first, so she elaborated. "Since it deals with moods, interactions, things we can act out. It could be kind of fun? Can't say it's not creative."

"That's so cringe," Soren commented finally. Adora was moments from opening her eyes and kicking his ass out of her home. "I **love** it."

"How are you feeling," DT asked like it was a question Catra could actually answer.

She was feeling… put every negative emotion on a wheel, spin it, and whatever it landed on was floating around in her heart and mind. Slowly her medicine was starting to at least turn down the intensity of it all. Enough to take the edge off without making her feel like a zombie, anyway.

"Like an idiot," Catra said simply. "I should've walked away."

"On the rarest of chance that manipulative tart is telling the truth, it's a good thing you didn't," DT patted her on the shoulder.

Why was everyone fucking touching her today?

"Are you ready to do this," DT asked as they picked up their office phone.

Catra sighed. "Yeah, whatever."

With that, DT placed some calls and arranged for Valerie to join them in the office. Meanwhile Catra moved from the couch to DT's desk chair. She felt out of place sitting on the other side of DT's desk, but it did make her feel less vulnerable. To distract herself from getting more anxious about this strange affair, she was poking around at all of their snarky stationary and desk decor. Who knew you could buy sticky notes that are preprinted with the words "FUCK YOU" at the top like it was some kind of official memo title? DT had one on their monitor with her name scrawled across it in loopy handwriting with a heart at the end.

"Hey," she said as she pulled it off to show its writer, "Do we need to talk about this?"

"Oh kitten," they laughed and waved her off. "I reserve those post-its for only my highest priorities. Since this whole thing started, you've been racing to the top of that list daily. I haven't had a chance to catch my breath chasing after your image. I almost miss the days of being paid big bucks to read a trashy novel during downtime."

There was a knock at the door, and DT went to answer it. "Speaking of trashy," they said as they ushered Valerie in, nodding to Juliet as she left, "Thank you."

"Charming," she said with a roll of her eyes. "I was going to question why I had to be given a security escort, but perhaps I should feel lucky you didn't put a bag over my head as well."

"What a missed opportunity! Perhaps we can find one before you leave," DT said. They went and sat down in a chair next to Catra. "Sit and start spilling, honeybear," they tapped a pen towards the empty seat in front.

Valerie seemed to take their jabs in stride and calmly sat down. "I'm glad you're taking this seriously," she said to Catra who didn't reply. "Did mother forbid you from talking to me?" She gave a not so subtle disapproving look to DT.

"Either tell us what you know or leave," Catra said flatly. "I don't have time for your games."

"That's unfortunate, I'm very **fun** to play with," Valerie said. DT started to comment, but she got to business . "As I was telling you before you looked like you were going to vomit on my shoes, which are new by the way, that man yesterday is sounding the war horns."

"Did you get a name? I hadn't seen him before the Q&A," Catra asked.

Valerie went digging around in her handbag and pulled out a business card. "He gave me one of these. Very old school. Can't even be bothered to put a QR code on it," she flung it towards DT's waiting hand. "Howard Protos. I don't know much about him other than he is **old** money, in every sense of the word."

"Love that hard earned generational wealth," DT said after sliding the card to Catra.

Catra examined the card in her hand. The only extra bit of information other than his contacts was that he was the founder of something called Prime Inc. She had never heard of it. "And what did he want from you?"

Valerie gestured at herself. "Based on what he said that he needs a fresher, more appealing face to help him gather support."

DT twisted their face up in confusion. "Truly puzzling as to why he would come to you then. And, please know I mean this with the fullest of offense, but how can we trust you aren't stirring the pot? You love to dream up fanfiction about yourself to get attention," DT leaned forward on their elbows. "Or need we forget your stories about your passionate love affair with our CEO?"

Catra had been loving listening to DT dress the other woman down right up until that moment. Even if it was much less than Valerie made it out to be, Catra had never admitted to DT about that stupid night when they first met. God, why. Her face felt hot, and she distracted herself by pretending to make notes on the stack of post-its in front of her.

"I may have an active imagination from time to time, but I've told plenty of truth. And, more importantly," she pulled out her phone and laid it down. "I have **receipts**. I recorded the conversation once I realized what he was talking about."

"And he didn't notice," Catra asked suspiciously.

"Pretended like I was using my camera to check my lipstick. It was easy. People often underestimate me," she swiped until she found the relevant video. "Tragically I forgot to swap cameras, so all you're

going to see is my chest."

DT bent over to preview the still image, and scrunched up their nose in disgust. "Sure, titsapalooza." They turned to Catra. "Look away! This might be one big plot to seduce you."

Meanwhile Catra's head was already in her hands. "Did I have a heart attack earlier? Is this hell?"

"You two are *so* entertaining, like a little comedy duo. Precious," Valerie said with a laugh. "I hate to ruin the mood, but this is going to get ugly." She pressed play on the video.

"I haven't had enough coffee yet , babe. What exactly did you pull me in here to talk about," Valerie said over the video. "Something about wanting to solve our little Catra problem?"

The man's frustrated sigh was loud enough to be picked up on the recording. Howard began to talk so slowly it was borderline insulting, "Catra is today and has **always** been suppressing the true potential of this company. Now we know exactly why. With her background, it's quite easy to see how her *attachments* impact her policies. Running a company like it is some kind of charity organization. It's a wonder she hasn't already destroyed it."

"Mmhhm," Valerie hummed. "She has a unique style. Sometimes I think she doesn't really care about making money."

"Then you understand my point precisely." Howard said, his voice picking up in speed and passion. "If someone different were at the helm, someone more experienced, calculating… someone less emotional, Darla's success would reach beyond her shortsighted vision. Darla could be a technology empire."

"All of that sounds very promising, but how do you propose to oust her? We don't have that kind of power."

Howard said, "I am gathering support to call for a vote of no confidence. With enough of the public shareholders signing on, the board will be forced to recognize us."

"And you don't think they'd say thank you for your time and then move on to the next item? As much as I have complicated feelings about our spunky CEO, she is the **face** of Darla. A well respected one at that."

Howard scoffed. "I cannot deny that she's quite charismatic and clever, but that is the sum of her value. This whole silly situation with her girlfriend has her in a downward spiral. It's exposed her for the immature, inexperienced little girl she is. There has never been a better time to strike. *Entrapta* is the force behind the technology, and that's what sets Darla apart. She's the only one we need to keep. You saw that display this morning. The billions we could make in military contracts alone from the robotics technology would make everyone forget about Catra."

Valerie was silent for a moment then asked quietly, "What do you want me to do?"

"Simply to help me spread my message amongst the younger crowd. You have a very, let's say, *persuasive* quality, and something of a history with Catra. Or... at least, the ability to make others believe you do."

"You're not wrong about that."

"I hope then I'll have your full support. Catra is a naive, idealistic girl. If she thinks she can lower the status of Darla from a luxury vehicle to some common economy trash and *still* make the

investors happy, she is incorrect. Mark my words, if it were not me seeking to steal the reins, someone else would."

"Interesting," Valerie said. "You would be making a play for her position?"

"Of course. I am more than worthy. I believe anyone with half a mind would agree once I have laid it all out for them. And, of course, I would be very interested in lucrative brand partnerships. The clientele that deserves Darla are the same that might enjoy a higher quality of musical entertainment, don't you think?"

Valerie stopped the recording there. "You've got a big storm coming, darling."

Catra was biting her tongue so hard she was worried she'd break the skin.

"May I see that," DT held out a hand and Valerie cautiously gave it over. Catra could see them quickly airdrop the video to themself and then proceed to delete it from Valerie's phone.

When she snatched her phone back, she rolled her eyes. "This isn't amateur hour, I've already uploaded it to my cloud."

Catra leaned back in her chair and crossed her arms tight against her body. "Let me get this straight. This guy wants to force me out, somehow convince the board to hire him instead as CEO, and he needs you to, what, rally the shareholders that aren't old men? And then he'll make Refined Taste the *official bullshit radio* of Darla?"

"Pretty much," Valerie shrugged. "I don't know if I believe he could really pull it off, but Howard? He definitely does. I've never met a bigger egomaniac... well," she side-eyed DT who was furiously typing away at their computer. "Until this morning."

"Have you spoken to anyone else about this," DT asked, unbothered.

"Not a word. I brought it straight to Catra as soon as I could. Would've called her last night, but I figured she had her hands full with her reluctant roomie."

Focus, Catra.

Pushing down her emotions, she stuck to fact finding. "Were you the one that sent me the tiktok yesterday?"

"No," Valerie said quickly. "I thought about making a stitch of it with me packing to take her place, but it felt a bit gauche given your last interview. Truth be told, I was planning to let this whole thing with you go for a while. I've been so busy with RT, you understand. Then here I am, minding my own business and getting pulled into a meeting for some impromptu corporate espionage."

"Uh-huh," Catra pulled out her phone and looked at the mysterious text again. The number didn't match the one on Howard's card. She turned the phone to show it to Valerie. "Recognize this number?"

She squinted at it then typed it into her own. "No, doesn't match any of my contacts," she showed as proof. "Catra, I hope you don't think so low of me that I would actually agree to this. It might hurt my pride to say it but what you're doing here is important. No one should get to take that away from you."

"Then the best thing you can do," DT said, "Is keep your thin mouth shut and stay away. Thanks."

Valerie looked to Catra as though looking for a second opinion.

"Agreed," Catra said sharply.

"I suppose I'll take my leave then," Valerie said as she stood. "You can always call again when you realize you need me."

As soon as the door closed behind her, DT growled, "What a fucking liar."

Catra looked up at them, confused. "It didn't sound staged."

"Those shoes are from several seasons ago," DT shuddered then spun their chair to face their computer. "Okay, back to war planning. I have some particularly petty ideas, but what are your thoughts? If we're going to take the first shot, we've got to move today."

Catra slipped away from behind the desk and was pacing in the room. She felt like she was playing a "choose your own adventure" game in her mind and trying to figure out which ones didn't lead to 'somehow be fired from a company you co-founded,' 'resign in shame,' or 'go to jail for murder.'

"Overreacting plays into his hand," Catra said finally. "Who's to say he didn't bring this to Valerie knowing her dumbass would tattle immediately to try to manipulate me? If I go out there and start acting like I need to be on the defense or suddenly picking a fight with this guy, it works to his narrative either way."

DT looked over at her, clearly not impressed with the plan so far. "So, we do nothing? Saves me some work, but at what *cost* ? I've grown to almost like you over these years together."

Catra rolled her eyes. "I don't believe in going into a fight without enough information, that's all. We need to compile everything we can get on him and whatever the fuck Prime Inc is."

"Ooh, yes, that's what I'm talking about. I feel like a detective in a true crime show," DT said. "Thoughts on looping in the rest of the team?"

"Only Entrapta. The way he was talking about her… I don't like it. Makes me think he could have someone trying to work her. Other than that, it stays between us for now." Then she looked a bit sheepish. "Well. Adora–"

"Obviously, tell our blondie. If this man's into playing dirty, there's no reason to think she wouldn't be an unwitting player in his production."

"I don't know what it is, but I *really* want you right now," Adora said as she stared into the other woman's eyes, leaning over the shorter woman with one hand on the fridge.

"It's because I'm doing my part," said Soren as he popped up into the shot with a name badge that said, 'Pineal Gland.'

"You're the best wing gland," said Linzee, who was wearing a name badge that said 'Sleep.'

"Cut," Madison called as she stopped the recording. "That–"

"What the actual fuck," another voice said behind her.

"Catra," Adora shouted and then practically sprinted over to her, wrapping her arms around her. "I can explain. It's **not** what you think."

"Oh, I think it's *exactly* what I think," Catra returned the embrace, giggling as she kissed Adora on the cheek. "This is the dorkiest shit I've ever seen. If you don't get an A , burn the building down."

"She gets it," Soren said. "We're going to make that professor feel too bad to give us anything less."

Catra let go of Adora and waved at the trio. "Hi. I'm Catra, the greedy capitalist girlfriend. Hope you're enjoying our very expensive home. I need to borrow your lead for a few minutes, if everyone's okay with that." They nodded in silence. "Great. Thanks."

She took Adora's hand and stole her away to the private study. The last thing she needed was these three overhearing. As soon as the bookshelf closed behind them, it was as though her mind forgot exactly what she was doing here. All her thoughts were Adora's red cheeks highlighted by the mood lighting of the fake tavern. She slipped a hand behind Adora's neck and pulled her down into a desperate kiss.

Adora came up for air with a satisfied smile on her face and said dumbly, "*Wow*. What was that for?"

"Just need you to remember me when you're out there being courted by glands and hormones," Catra said. Then she remembered the real reason for this meeting, signing deeply, trying to figure out where to start.

Adora reached forward and pulled her close again. "It's going to be okay," she said as she held her and ran her fingers through her hair.

"You don't even know what's going on."

"Doesn't matter," Adora kissed the top of her head. "We can handle it."

With that, Catra told her everything. Adora reflexively gagged at the mention of Valerie's involvement, but had a new enemy by the end of it.

"That's all I know right now," Catra said. "I had to be out there the rest of the day, shaking hands, being friendly. All while wondering who was marking me for betrayal later. Tomorrow morning we're having a 'war room' meeting about whatever DT and Entrapta have been able to dig up on him. Apparently she has some *techniques* for finding stuff online. Not sure if it's strictly legal but I'm not asking too many questions."

"Fuck," Adora said, starting to spiral a bit as she finally processed it all. "This is so stupid. Is this… this isn't all because of me is it? If… Catra, I don–"

Catra silenced her with a quick kiss. "Absolutely not. It's because I'm not some cutthroat bastard, and I'm not going to become one just to make people like this prick richer." She grabbed Adora's hands which were nervously shaking, "Look at me."

"Gladly."

"You were right. It's going to be okay," Catra said. "I'm not going to run away from some old nepo-baby. He thinks he's going against some little girl who doesn't know what she's doing."

Adora laughed at that. "Then he seriously miscalculated, and he has *no idea* how badly he's going to lose." Her phone buzzed in her pocket. "Damn. That's the group. I've got to get back out there."

"Go, I'll be fine," Catra kissed her one last time before pulling the switch to open the door back up. "I'll make myself a drink and head upstairs. Just promise me you're not making Melog play something."

"But he's already practiced his lines," Adora said with a laugh as she started to walk away. She stopped suddenly, leaning back in, "Would you like some company? Because I happen to know someone who is free and wanting violence tonight."

"Say less."

Catra: cocktails and gossip on the roof?

Glimmer: [heart eyes emoji] is it my birthday?

Catra: sending you a car

Chapter End Notes

Look at me, writing words on the regular. What a wonder.

Hope you enjoyed! I am thrilled to write some Glimmer and Catra bonding at the top of next chapter.

Also I must admit I know almost as little about the endocrine system as I know about being rich.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!